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IAS COMPASS OF ESSAY

FOUNDATION STUDY MATERIAL
UPSC CIVIL SERVICES
MAINS EXAM



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PREFACE

Dear Aspirants,

The Essay paper of UPSC mains gives aspiring civil servant candidates with most freedom for creative expression, analysis and displaying understanding of complex topics. The constraints of word limit in the other General Studies paper are not present here.

However, this freedom also comes with its own challenges. Most aspirants have ideas, but what is the challenge is keeping the entire write-up in tune with the topic. The other aspect is about brainstorming the topic with the view to open various threads and substantiating the entire article with relevant facts and examples, interesting anecdotes and ideas. An attempt should also be made to present alternatives to the view presented or suggestions so make the write up comprehensive, cohesive and innovative. The entire focus should be on making the entire write up always stick to the topic of the essay.

The attempt in this Mains Compass on Essay is to provide necessary tools for students appearing for UPSC Civil Services Mains Exam in 2023. Various essays have been provided for reference to students to understand the art of essay writing.

The conceptual coverage in the booklet has been presented by analysing recent UPSC trends and pattern. Of late, UPSC has been asking both Philosophical and General Topics. Hence, this booklet is covering **5 major themes:-**

1) Philosophical/Ethical.
2) Democracy, Polity and Governance.
3) Inclusive Economy and Economic Justice.
4) Social Issues and Social Justice.
5) Diverse topics comprising of Environment, Science and Technology, Security and International Relations.

The above themes open up all potential areas in which UPSC frame essay topics. All in all, there are around 60 topics covered in this booklet and these are having direct relevance with the current and contemporary issues.

The write-up in the essay topics is not sacrosanct. It will only provide a common overview/insight to the reader as ready reference which can be improved by the reader in her own writing and by using her own natural flair and other suitable additions. The write-ups here are varied in size as we have tried to incorporate important facets which can be utilised by aspirants in creating their own essays on the basis of prescribed word limit.

►**DISCLAIMER:** *As the topics covered below and their content are compilation and collation by various contributors so the opinions expressed are those of the contributors only. On our part, we have tried to neutralise the language and tried to put non offensive opinions so as to prevent any kind of offence to the reader. Seriously, our intention is not to hurt anyone's feelings.*

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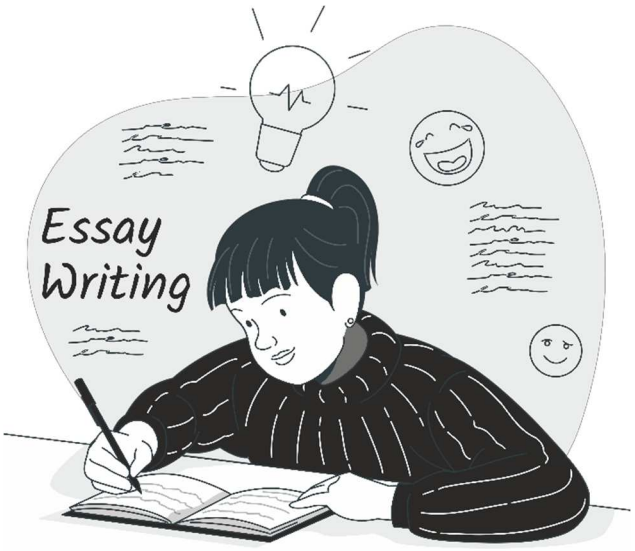
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Part-I General Inputs

▶What is an Essay?



- An essay is a **"formal, analytical and creative piece of writing, dealing with a single theme".**
- It is a written conversation giving a **clear and concise expression to one's own personal ideas or opinions** on a given topic.
- An essay is not a plain collection of facts, events or phenomenon, but an **assessment of points and counterpoints on them with reasoning, causation and way forward**.
- Further, essay is a **comprehensive knowledge and it requires understanding of broad issues**. There is **no single source to master it.** The task of the student is to connect the dots of knowledge from multiple sources and that can be school textbooks, newspapers, guidelines and practice provided by the mentors, audio and visual media, movies, documentaries etc.

▶Why focus on the Essay Paper?

- The significance of the essay paper for the civil services aspirants can be gauged from the fact that it has been assigned **compulsory status** by the UPSC and **designated as Paper I**.
- From the **selection point of view**, the essay paper of 250 marks consists of enough weightage to determine the final outcome/selection and ranking of the candidates.
- **Average marks** in an essay paper is in the range of 115-125 out of 250 marks (and highest being 176 marks) whereas in General Studies the average range is 95-100 marks.
- **Benchmark of exam preparedness** as it reflects command on General Studies, Current Affairs, Observational, Experiential and related knowledge.
- Provides **opportunity to a student** to explore in-depth, plan and present herself as a well organised and knowledgeable candidate.
- **Reflects analytical and problem solving mindset** on issues of common concern faced by humanity.
- Reflects **policy making approach** of candidates.
- Measure of **Job Fitness**.

▶What is the common trend of UPSC Essays?

Essay writing is a very important part of the civil services mains exam. UPSC has given this paper immense importance by making it a full paper of 250 marks. In this situation when the aspirants are preparing for the exam then they should understand the parameters that the UPSC has laid for this paper.

According to the UPSC:

*"**Essay:** Candidates may be required to write **essays on multiple topics**. They will be expected to **keep closely to the subject** of the essay to **arrange their ideas in orderly fashion**, and to **write concisely**. Credit will be given for **effective and exact expression**."*

So, these are the parameters that on which the essay that we write are going to be evaluated. Let's understand them a little more so that we understand how to get maximum marks when we write our essays.

a) Essays on multiple topics: The essay paper has multiple topics which are divided into two sections. You are expected to write two essays, one from each section. While choosing the right essay for yourself, pay attention to the topics on which you have a comprehensive understanding. You should

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choose topic in which you will be able to express yourself fully and not what you think will fetch more marks as nothing can replace great knowledge and expression.

b) Keep closely to the subject: At times, we have ideas which are very far and wide and the UPSC has clearly explained that we need to be stay as close to the topic as possible. One of the reasons for this suggestion may be that the UPSC gives preference to objective parameters when awarding marks to each candidate. To maintain this process as objective as possible, it is needed to stay close to the subject.

c) Arrange ideas in an orderly fashion: Flow of thought is a very important feature of the essay expected by the UPSC. As highlighted above, it will help the UPSC to evaluate the essay in an objective fashion. Moreover, flow of thoughts also indicates how you see situations, observe them, develop understanding and based on that make your mind/opinion. These are important qualities that the UPSC is looking in the future civil servants.

d) Write concisely: You are expected to write each essay in about 1000-1200 words and hence, brevity is an important feature if you want to showcase comprehensive understanding of the subject/issue. This is something that you need to do so that you may attempt both the essays within the specific timeline of three hours.

e) Effective and exact expression: UPSC has highlighted that it will give credit to effective and exact expression. Now effective expression is a combination of all the above stated requirements plus good language, decent grammar and legibility. The way you express makes a lasting impression in the mind of the examiner and if you have done all this in exact expression (expression according to the need of the subject/theme) then the examiner may give you credit for this as well. So, it is a mechanism to get extra marks over the content of the essay.

In the form of topics, UPSC presents a set of problems from different thematic areas to aspirants. The purpose is to identify an aware citizen who knows about the existence of the problem, reasons for its prevalence and also the possible solution for improving the situation.

With civil servants acting as positive catalysts, the overall desire is to create a productive, progressive and safe society. Hence on such consideration, the usual thematic areas on which the topics are asked are given hereunder:

Development of Society; Actualising Demographic Dividend; Education; Ethics and Behaviour Modification; Inclusive Economy and Livelihoods; Social Justice; Governance topics connecting Political Party & Electoral Reforms, Civil Service, Police, Judiciary, Non-State actors' participation; Corporate Social Responsibility; Role of Media; Security; Environment etc. and their interconnections.

Manner of asking the topics: Of late, the above thematic areas are bifurcated in the form of Philosophical/Ethics and General Topics in the Essay Paper. On this note, refer to the topics of 2020, 2019 and 2018 given below:

▶2022

Section-A: Write any one of the following essay in 1000-1200 words.

1. Forests are the best case studies for economic excellence. *(#Inclusive Economy and Economic Justice)*
2. Poets are the unacknowledged legislators of the world

   (#Democracy, Polity and Governance)
3. History is a series of victories won by the scientific man over the romantic man *(#Philosophical/ Ethical Topics)*
4. A ship in harbour is safe, but that is not what ship is for *(#Philosophical/ Ethical Topics)*

Section-B: Write any one of the following essay in 1000-1200 words.

5. The time to repair the roof is when the sun is shining

   (#Philosophical/ Ethical Topics)
6. You cannot step twice in the same river

   (#Philosophical/ Ethical Topics)
7. A smile is the chosen vehicle for all ambiguities

   (#Philosophical/ Ethical Topics)
8. Just because you have a choice, it does not mean that any of them has to be right.

   (#Philosophical/ Ethical Topics)

▶2021

Section-A: Write any one of the following essay in 1000-1200 words.

1. The process of self-discovery has now been technologically outsourced. *(#Philosophical)*

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2. Your perception of me is a reflection of you; my reaction to you is an awareness of me. *(#Philosophical)*
3. Philosophy of wantlessness is Utopian, while materialism is a chimera. *(#Philosophical)*
4. The real is rational and the rational is real. *(#Philosophical)*

Section-B: Write any one of the following essay in 1000-1200 words.

5. Hand that rocks the cradle rules the world. *(# Philosophical)*
6. What is research, but a blind date with knowledge! *(# Technology)*
7. History repeats itself, first as a tragedy, second as a farce. *(#Philosophical)*
8. There are better practices to "best practices". *(#Philosophical)*

▶2020

Section-A: Write any one of the following essay in 1000-1200 words.

1. Life is long journey between human being and being humane. *(#Philosophical)*
2. Mindful manifesto is the catalyst to a tranquil self. *(#Philosophical)*
3. Ships do not sink because of water around them; ships sink because of water that gets into them. *(#Philosophical)*
4. Simplicity is the ultimate sophistication. *(#Philosophical)*

Section-B: Write any one of the following essay in 1000-1200 words.

5. Culture is what we are, civilization is what we have. *(# Philosophical)*
6. There can be no social justice without economic prosperity but economic prosperity without social justice is meaningless. *(# Social Justice # Economic Justice)*
7. Patriarchy is the least noticed yet the most significant structure of social inequality. *(# Social Justice)*
8. Technology as the silent factor in international relations. *(# Technology # International Relations)*

▶2019

Section-A: Write any one of the following essay in 1000-1200 words.

1. Wisdom finds truth. *(#Philosophical)*
2. Values are not what humanity is, but what humanity ought to be. *(#Ethics)*
3. Best for an individual is not necessarily best for the society. *(#Ethics)*
4. Courage to accept and dedication to improve are two keys to success. *(#Ethics)*

Section-B: Write any one of the following essay in 1000-1200 words.

5. South Asian societies are woven not around the state, but around their plural cultures and plural identities. *(#History and Culture)*
6. Neglect of primary health care and education in India are reasons for its backwardness. *(#Education #Health)*
7. Biased media is a real threat to Indian democracy. *(#Media and Governance)*
8. Rise of Artificial intelligence: the threat of jobless future or better job opportunities through reskilling and upskilling. *(#Science and Economy)*

▶2018

Section-A: Write any one of the following essay in 1000-1200 words.

1. Alternative technologies for a climate change resilient India. *(# Environment #S&T)*
2. A good life is one inspired by love and guided by knowledge. *(#Ethics and Morality)*
3. Poverty anywhere is a threat to prosperity everywhere. *(# P&G #Social # Economic #Ethics)*
4. Management of Indian border dispute- a complex task. *(#India and its Neighbourhood)*

Section-B: Write any one of the following essay in 1000-1200 words.

5. Customary morality cannot be a guide to modern life. *(# Culture (#Ethics and Morality)*
6. The past is a permanent dimension of human consciousness and values. *(#History # Ethics)*
7. A people that values its privileges above its principles loses both. *(# Culture (#Ethics and Morality)*
8. Reality does not confirm to the ideal, but confirms it. *(#Philosophical)*

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▶How to choose a suitable topic?

Answer: This is the first major decision that a candidate faces in the essay paper. The choice is easy if the candidate has excellent command, background and factual recollections on one topic vis-à-vis the remaining options. But it becomes trickier and more daunting if no single topic appears favourable from the outset.

- **Comparative analysis:** The candidate has to make estimations of her knowledge base for different segments and viewpoints of the essay topics in question and finally undertake a rational comparison between the topics to select the one she feels most strongly in command of.
- **Safer bet:** Choosing **regular and non-controversial topic** over the more opinionated/philosophical topic is a safer bet. But such topic will be chosen by many, hence to stand out and to score more, the differentiating factor is the originality in presentation.
- **Three M's:** Correct choice of topic can also be made by using the principle of **three M's: Motive, Method and Message**. These not only define the essay but also help in achieving the communication goals in the appropriate language and writing style.
- **Philosophical/Opinionated Essays:** In case of opinionated statement based essays for e.g. *Customary morality cannot be a guide to modern life,* the most important aspect is decoding the most apt meaning of the topic, convert the statement into applied writing by choosing most apt examples from the current society to explain it further. In case of any doubt in decoding the meaning of such essays then skip them and move towards more regular and non- controversial topics.

▶What should be the structure of an essay?

The structure comprises of **Introduction**, **Main body** and **Conclusion**. For 1200 words essay, the introduction should be on 100-120 words, main body in 1000 words and conclusion in remaining in 100-120 words.

- A good essay is one which induces the reader to get immersed and engrossed in reading the entire text. For right inducement, attractive **(Introduction) of the essay** is extremely important. It should be like an attractive movie trailer which gives a hint/glimpse on the things to explore while reading further. So, the best way of introduction is picking a (live example) related with the topic asked. This helps in connecting with the topic instantly and the examiner also knows that the student understands the topic, and also knows what is happening currently with respect to the topic.
- This part should comprise of analysing the factors impacting the topic. The factors can be: - *Historical/cultural, Political/Legal, Economic, Geographical/Environmental, Psychological, Behavioural etc.* So it is expected to decode right factors according to their weightage w.r.t. the topic, analyse the gaps resulting from these factors and then suggesting logical solutions, and the opinions should be backed by authentic sources.
- **Conclusion** should always be optimistic, providing a silver lining and benefiting the entire society.

▶How much time should a student allocate in the exam towards essay writing?

1 Essay in 90 minutes: In Essay paper, 3 hours are allotted for writing two essays. The equation is 1 Essay in 90 minutes.

Effective time management: Because students have got a tendency to write on the topic in which they are most comfortable and they tend to lose their time track and breach the limit of 90 minutes and thus they fail to do justice with the second topic, and resultantly they lose marks. The outcome of lack of time management is given below:

- Even the examiner now knows that the aspirant is not a good time manager and thus lacks a key element of job fitness i.e. effective time management.
- Further, it will easily reflect that student had more inclination towards safer topic only from the comfort zone. This will again bring negative impression as it would portray that the student wants to confine herself in the comfort zone and play safe and if moves outside the zone then she is found wanting and perplexed.

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▶How can a student get started in writing an effective essay?

To get started: There is a difference between reply and response. Reply is instinctive which is mostly not balanced but response is properly planned balanced reply. So, **UPSC checks planned response** of a student.

To do this, first 10 minutes out of 90 minutes should be utilised in collecting random points with respect to topic, note them on the rough space, and then arrange them in the serial order in the manner they should be aligned in the write up. This will show coherent flow and reflect that the writer believes in proper planning and then responding.

▶What is the significance of language in essay writing?

- **Simple but effective:** Xth standard English is more than sufficient to put thoughts effectively. Queen's English is not required. Attractiveness of writing is not due to difficult words but it depends on the **art of presentation**.
- **Communication test:** This is not an English test but it is a communication test. Whatever the student is writing should be understood by any reader, and this is a work place requirement. For e.g. everything moves on files in govt. and whatever is noted on file should be understood by subordinates, peers, seniors etc.

▶What are the features of a good essay?

Foremost, the candidate should keep in his/her mind that the essay will lead the examiner through his/her organized thoughts on a single topic. The essentials of essay writing would be the format (framework, structure), information (content, substance), language (expression, presentation), and logic (analysis and information).

- **Definite purpose**: An essay must materialise itself as **topic-centred, all pervasive and unified**, developing one theme with a definite purpose.
- **Coherence:** The composition of an essay should be **treated in an orderly manner**. It should follow a certain ordered line of thought pertaining to the topic under treatment and come to a definite conclusion. Before writing an essay on any subject, it is a primary necessity to plan out a coherent line of thought on all relevant aspects of the subject.
- **Brevity and compactness** is the beauty of an essay. The whole exercise of essay writing should be to lay, treat and expound your ideas or opinion on the given subject concisely, clearly and well within the set time limit.
- **Lucidity:** The language and the construction of sentences should be **simple, direct, natural and interactive**. **Clear thinking** is a natural prerequisite for clear writing. Clear understanding of the subject under treatment springs out relevant thoughts which automatically transform themselves to words on paper before you.
- **Originality:** The essay must **bear your personal touch**. It should reflect your personal feelings and opinions on the subject. It should have your individuality in it. As already discussed above, an essay is a written composition giving expression to one's personal ideas or opinions on the subject concerned. So, never be afraid to express your **verifiable views** in your essay.

▶What is remarkable about candidates scoring 150+in the Essay Paper?

- The remarkable features of their essays comprise of planned response; easy targeted, reader friendly communication; usage of authentic examples both from the past and current scenario; logical analysis; originality in approach; reflecting the desire to deal with problems; and always ending with silver lining benefitting all.
- In short, able to display their **policy making mindsets**.

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Part-II Quotations for Essay Writing

Quotations on Women

a. A woman with a voice is, by definition, a strong woman. (By Melinda Gates).

b. To empower a woman is to empower her children, her family and her community. The smartest investment we can make is in women. Women must have the freedom and the possibility to decide who they are. (By Barbara Bush)

c. When women thrive all of society benefits and succeeding generations are given a better start in life. (By Kofi Annan)

d. Wives should not be dolls and objects of indulgence but should be treated as honored comrades in common service.

e. Woman is the companion of man, gifted with equal mental capacity. (By Mahatma Gandhi)

f. I measure the progress of a community by the degree of progress which women have achieved. (By Ambedkar)

g. Patriarchy is so ingrained in our psyche, that most of us propagate it in small ways even without realizing it.

h. Each time a woman stands up for herself, without knowing it possibly, without claiming it, she stands up for all women. (By Maya Angelou)

i. Life is not a competition between man and woman. It is a collaboration. (By David Fearnhead)

j. Teach her that the idea of 'gender roles' is absolute nonsense. Do not ever tell her that she should or should not do something because she is a girl. 'Because you are a girl' is never reason for anything. Ever.

k. Human rights are women's rights, and women's rights are human rights. (By Hillary Clinton)

l. Gender equality is more than a goal in itself. It is a precondition for meeting the challenge of reducing poverty, promoting sustainable development and building good governance.

Quotations on Environment and Sustainable Development

a. We don't have time to sit on our hands as our planet burns. For young people, climate change is bigger than election or re-election. It's life or death.

b. By polluting the oceans, not mitigating CO2 emissions and destroying our biodiversity, we are killing our planet. Let us face it, there is not planet B. (by Emmanuel Macron, President of France)

c. We are the first generation to feel the effect of climate change and the last generation who can do something about it. (By Barack Obama, Former President of USA)

d. Climate change knows no borders. It will not stop before the Pacific Islands and the whole of the international community here has to shoulder a responsibility to bring about sustainable development. (By Angela Merkel, Former Chancellor of Germany)

e. The world is not ours to keep. We hold it in trust for future generations by Kofi Annan.

f. Earth provides enough to satisfy every man's needs, but not every man's greed." by Mahatma Gandhi.

g. The future depends on what we do in the present." by Mahatma Gandhi

h. Thousands have lived without love, not one without water. W. H Auden.

i. Pure Water is the world's first and foremost medicine.

j. On climate change, we often don't fully appreciate that it is a problem. We think it is a problem waiting to happen. (By Kofi Annan)

k. Saving our planet, lifting people out of poverty, advancing economic growth...these are one and the same fight. (By Ban Ki Moon)

Quotations on Agriculture

a. Most things, except agriculture can wait. (By Jawahar Lal Nehru)

b. If the farmer is rich, then so is the nation.

c. A farmer is magician who produces money from the mud.

d. If agriculture goes wrong, nothing else will have a chance to go right in the country.

Quotations on Education

a. Knowledge is power. Information is liberating. Education is the premise of progress, in every society, in every family. By Kofi Annan.

b. One you stop learning, you start dying" by Einstein.

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c. The highest education is that which does not merely give us information but make our life in harmony with all existence. Tagore.

d. Technology will not replace great teachers but technology in the hands of great teachers can be transformational.

e. Don't confuse schooling with education. (By Elon Musk)

f. Share your knowledge. It is a way to achieve immortality. (By Dalai Lama)

g. Education is the most powerful weapon which you can use to change the world. (By Nelson Mandela)

h. If you are planning for a year, sow rice; if you are planning for a decade, plant trees; if you are planning for a lifetime, educate people. (A Chinese proverb)

I. An investment in knowledge pays the best interest. (Benjamin Franklin)

j. The beautiful thing about learning is that no one can take it away from you.

k. Education is simply the soul of society as it passes from one generation to another.

l. Literacy is a bridge from misery to hope. (By Kofi Annan)

Quotations on Health

a. Of all the forms of inequality, injustice in health care is the most shocking and inhumane. (By Martin Luther King Jr.)

b. He who has health has hope; and he who has hope, has everything. (By Thomas Carlyle)

c. It is health that is real wealth and not pieces of gold and silver. (By Mahatma Gandhi)

d. Health is the greatest of human blessings.

e. Every human being is the author of his own health or disease. (By Gautama Buddha)

Quotations on Ideas and Imagination

a. Imagination is more important than knowledge. Knowledge is limited, imagination encircles the world. (By Einstein)

b. India conquered and dominated China culturally for 20 centuries without ever having to send a single soldier across her border. (Hu Shih, Former Ambassador of China to USA).

Quotations on Leadership

a. I have always believed that on important issues, the leaders must lead. Where the leaders fail to lead, and people are really concerned about it, the people will take the lead and make the leaders follow. (By Kofi Annan, Former Secretary General of United Nations)

b. A leader is best when people barely know he exists, when his work is done, his aim fulfilled, they will say: we did it ourselves. (By Lao Tzu)

c. Where there is no vision, the people perish.

d. Before you are a leader, success is all about growing yourself. When you become a leader, success is all about growing others. (By Jack Welch)

e. Leadership is lifting a person's vision to high sights, the raising of a person's performance to a higher standard, the building of a personality beyond its normal limitations. (By Peter Drucker)

Quotes on Democracy

a. Man's capacity for justice make democracy possible, but man's inclination to injustice makes democracy necessary. (By Reinhold Niebuhr)

b. The ignorance of one voter in a democracy impairs the security of all. (By John F Kennedy)

c. Democracy is the worst form of government, except for all the others". (By Winston Churchill)

d. Democracy is not a form of government, but a form of social organization. (By Dr. Ambedkar)

e. Democracy is the government of the people, by the people, for the people. (By Abraham Lincoln, Former American President)

f. No famine has ever taken place in the history of the world in a functioning democracy. (Amartya Sen)

Quotations on Happiness

a. Happiness is when what you think, what you say, and what you do are in harmony." (By Mahatma Gandhi)

b. Happiness is not something readymade. It comes from your own actions. (By Dalai Lama)

c. The goal is not to be better than the other man, but your previous self. (By Dalai Lama)

Quotations on Patriotism

a. My patriotism is not an exclusive thing. It is all embracing and I should reject that patriotism which sought to mount upon the distress or exploitation of other nationalities." (By Mahatma Gandhi)

b. We are Indians, firstly and lastly". (By Ambedkar)

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c. I want all people to be Indian first, Indian last and nothing else but Indians. (By Ambedkar)

Quotations on India

a. India is the one land that all men desire to see, and having seen once, even a glimpse, would not give that glimpse for all the shows of all the rest of the globe combined. (By Mark Twain)

b. In there is one place on the face of this Earth where all the dreams of living men have found a home from the very earliest days when man began the dream of existence, it is India. (By Romain Rolland)

c. There is no book in the world, that is so thrilling, stirring and inspiring as the Upanishads. (By Max Muller)

d. Perhaps in return for arrogance and spoilation, India will teach us the gentleness of a mind, the quiet content of the uninquisitive soul, and a pacifying love for all the living things. (By Will Durant)

e. India is the cradle of the human race, the birthplace of human speech, the mother of history, the grandmother of legend, and the great grandmother of tradition. Our most valuable & most constructive materials in the history of man are treasured up in India only. (By Mark Twain)

Quotations on Peace & Globalisation

a. Violence in the last refuge of the incompetent.

b. Peace starts within and radiates out into society.

c. It has been said that arguing against globalisation is like arguing against the laws of gravity. (By Kofi Annan)

Quotations on Love

a. Power is of two kinds. One is obtained by the fear of punishment and the other by acts of love. Power based on love is a thousand times more effective and permanent then the one derived from fear of punishment. (By Mahatma Gandhi)

b. Love is composed of single soul inhabiting two bodies. (By Aristotle)

Quotations on Science and Scientific Temper and Technology

a. Cultivation of mind should be the ultimate aim of human existence.

b. Technology is best when it brings people together.

c. Technology is a useful servant but a dangerous master.

d. Technology is nothing. What's important is that you have faith in people, that they are basically good and smart, and if you give them tools, they will do wonderful things with them." (By Steve Jobs)

e. Engineering is the closest thing to magic that exists in the world." (By Elon Musk)

f. Machine intelligence is the last invention that humanity will ever need to make.

g. That which can be asserted without evidence, can be dismissed without evidence." (By Christopher Hitchens)

h. Nothing in life is to be feared, it is only to be understood. Now is the time to understand more, so that we may fear less." (By Marie Curie)

i. Science knows no country, because knowledge belongs to humanity, and is the torch which illuminates the world." (By Louis Pasteur)

Quotations on Individual's ability, Hope, Self-improvement and Character

a. If you believe in living a respectable life, you believe in self-help which is best help. (By Ambedkar)

b. If you think you are too small to make a difference, try sleeping with a mosquito. (By Dalai Lama)

c. Character is like a tree and reputation is like a shadow. The shadow is what we think of it, the tree is the real thing. (By Abraham Lincoln)

d. Good character is not formed in a week or a month. It is created little by little, day by day. Protracted and patient effort is needed to develop good character. (By Heraclitus, Ancient Greek Scholar).

e. There is a higher court than courts of justice, and that is the court of conscience. It supersedes all other courts. (Mahatma Gandhi)

Quotes on Character

Character is the quality of being determined and able to deal with difficult situations. It reflects moral excellence and firmness of a person.

a. We are what we repeatedly do. Excellence, then, is not an act, but a habit. (By Aristotle)

b. Character may almost be called the most effective means of persuasion. (By Aristotle)

c. Good moral character is not something that we can achieve on our own. We need a culture that supports the conditions under which self-love and friendship flourish. (By Aristotle)

d. Courage is the most important of all the virtues because without courage, you cannot practice any other virtue consistently.

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Quotes on Wisdom

Wisdom is defined as the ability to make good judgements based on what you have learned from your experience, or the knowledge and understanding that gives you this ability.

a. We don't receive wisdom, we must discover it for ourselves after a journey that no one can take for us or spare us. (By Marcel Proust)
b. Science is organized knowledge. Wisdom is organized life. (By Immanuel Kant)

Quotations on Values, Morals and Ethics

a. Try not to become a man of success, but rather try to become a man of value. Einstein.
b. The mind is everything. What you think you become. (By Buddha)

Quotations on Kindness, Compassion, Love and Tolerance

a. Be kind whenever possible. It is always possible. (By Dalai Lama)
b. Our prime purpose is this life is to help others. If you cannot help them, at least don't hurt them. (By Dalai Lama).
c. If you want others to be happy, practice compassion. If you want to be happy, practice compassion. (By Dalai Lama)
d. In order to have faith in one's own path, we do not have to prove that someone else's path is wrong. (By Paulo Coelho)
e. I do not like what you say but I will defend to the death your right to say it. (By Voltaire) (Also can be used in Free Speech & Liberty)
f. Anger and intolerance are the enemies of correct understanding. Mahatma Gandhi
g. The highest result of education is tolerance. (By Helen Keller)
h. Tolerance becomes a crime when applied to evil.
i. Tolerance of intolerance is cowardice.

Quotations on Free Speech, Liberty & Freedom

a. What is freedom of expression? Without the freedom to offend, it ceases to exist.
b. If one is going to err, one should err on the side of liberty and freedom. (By Kofi Annan)
c. The success of a society is to be evaluated primarily by the freedoms that members of the society enjoy. (By Amartya Sen)

Quotations of Mahatma Gandhi

a. An eye for eye only ends up making the whole world blind.
b. Where there is love, there is life.
c. Hate the sin, love the sinner.
d. The weak can never forgive. Forgiveness is the attribute of the strong.

Quotations on Simplicity

a. Simplicity is the ultimate sophistication. Leonardo da Vinci.
b. A complex system that works is invariably found to have evolved from a simple system that worked." Gall's Law.

Quotations in superstitions, fake news

a. Beware of false knowledge; it is more dangerous than ignorance.

Quotations on Poverty & Inequality

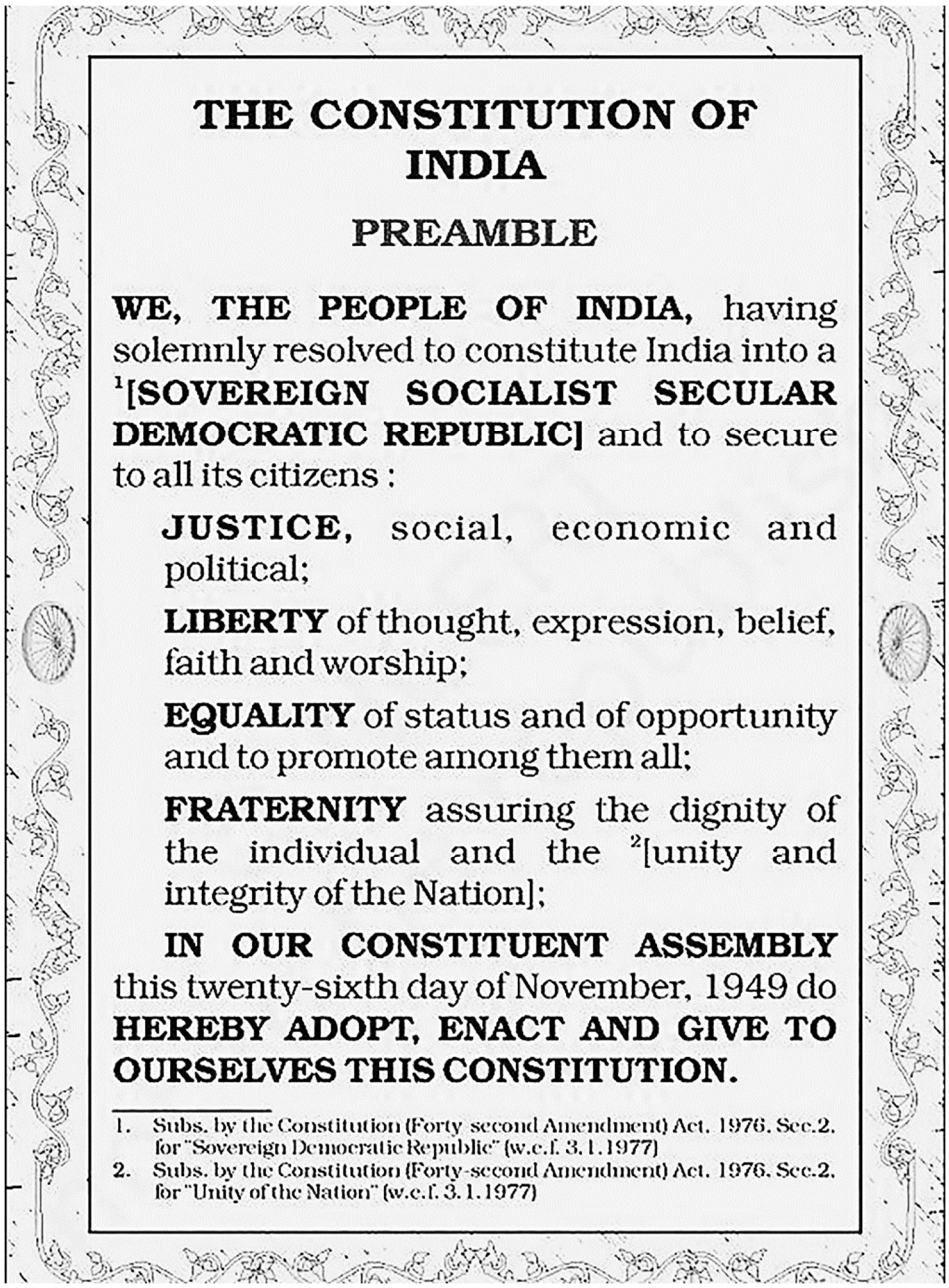
a. Poverty is not just a lack of money; it is not having the capability to realize one's full potential as a human being. (By Amartya Sen)
b. Overcoming poverty is not a gesture of charity. It is an act of justice. (By Nelson Mandela)
c. No society can surely be flourishing and happy, of which the far greater part of the members are poor and miserable. (By Adam Smith)
d. Poverty is the worst form of violence. (By Mahatma Gandhi)
e. There are people in the world so hungry that God cannot appear to them except in the form of bread. (By Mahatma Gandhi)
f. Extreme poverty is a threat to human security everywhere. (By Kofi Annan)
g. Poverty is the parent of revolution and crime. (By Aristotle)
h. An imbalance between rich and poor is the oldest and most fatal ailment of all republics.

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Part-III Essay Topics

All UPSC essay topics are related with the issues and problems faced by the society for which it requires logical solutions, way forward and thus benefiting the entire society. The overall aim is to prepare and develop the society on the basis of vision, goals and constitutional morality reflected in the 'Preamble of the Constitution' as given below:



THE CONSTITUTION OF INDIA

PREAMBLE

WE, THE PEOPLE OF INDIA, having solemnly resolved to constitute India into a [1]**[SOVEREIGN SOCIALIST SECULAR DEMOCRATIC REPUBLIC]** and to secure to all its citizens :

JUSTICE, social, economic and political;

LIBERTY of thought, expression, belief, faith and worship;

EQUALITY of status and of opportunity and to promote among them all;

FRATERNITY assuring the dignity of the individual and the [2][unity and integrity of the Nation];

IN OUR CONSTITUENT ASSEMBLY this twenty-sixth day of November, 1949 do **HEREBY ADOPT, ENACT AND GIVE TO OURSELVES THIS CONSTITUTION.**

1. Subs. by the Constitution (Forty-second Amendment) Act, 1976, Sec.2, for "Sovereign Democratic Republic" (w.e.f. 3.1.1977)
2. Subs. by the Constitution (Forty-second Amendment) Act, 1976, Sec.2, for "Unity of the Nation" (w.e.f. 3.1.1977)

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1 THEME PHILOSOPHICAL/ ETHICAL TOPICS

UPSC tends to asks topics which are philosophical and ethical.
These are in the form of experiential quotes of philosophers, political and social reformers.
There are topics linked with Political, Economic, Social and Environmental Ethics.
Individual and collective behaviours and responsibilities.

►IN THE MIDST OF GREAT ADVERSITY, LIES GREAT OPPORTUNITY

#PHILOSOPHICAL

In 2019, the world was hit by an adversity of the worst sort, the COVID-19 pandemic. An extremely virulent form of virus, the coronavirus, spread across the world, affecting every country. To counter the pandemic, many countries had to resort to extreme measures - such as suspension of air travel and putting their citizens into a lockdown, termed the 'Great Lockdown'. Needless to say, this caused huge economic and even political upheavals across the globe.

To address this adversity, the world stepped up to put their minds. The global scientific and medical community clocked extra hours to save as many lives as they could. Global collaboration through initiatives like COVAX was set up. Research to make a vaccine went on at a global level, and vaccines were created in record time. Capacities were amped up to deliver these vaccines to developing and underdeveloped countries, with India too playing a significant role.

Today, because of the efforts of scientists and medical practitioners all over the world, the world is much better equipped to deal with future pandemics that may arise in future. With the know-how gained for fast-track development of vaccines, better technology and creation of delivery systems to develop herd immunity. Thus, what has been a great adversity, has also created a great opportunity for amping up of healthcare, delivery across the world and increasing global collaboration.

The pandemic, though, is not the first time when humanity has faced a great adversity and has converted that adversity into an opportunity. Our very own nation, India on the eve of Independence, was faced with a political disaster the worst kind, the Partition. Besides that, we were plagued with the problems of extreme poverty and illiteracy. There was social turmoil and amidst this, we were faced with the challenge of deciding the future of our nation, through creation of Constitution.

The Great Depression of 1930 was another such adversity. Various economies of Europe and North America faced extremely high rates of unemployment and hunger. Europe faced a similar situation post-World War II too.

If we go a little further back in time, the smallpox epidemic of the late 18th century has decimated almost one-third of the population of Europe. The Indian city of Surat too, in the late 1980s faced a severe plague scare, mainly due to unhygienic and dirty living conditions in the city.

Similarly, another great adversity for India and other countries was the Indian Ocean Tsunami of 2006, when thousands of people died and lakhs were displaced. The Indian Ocean had, before this, never faced a natural calamity of this magnitude. Hence, people in the coastal regions of India and the littoral had little warning and experience on responding and managing their lives and property. The consequence was unprecedented devastation.

However, in all the great adversities mentioned above, humanity rose to the occasion and great opportunities for our future were created. The Indian leaders, on the eve of Independence, made a 'tryst with destiny'. India created a strong democratic constitution for itself, which despite the turmoil of Partition and communalistic pressures of the time, opted for secularism as its ideal. We worked extra hard to improve our economic conditions and make us self-dependent. Strong institutions like the Election Commission and an independent judiciary were created in these times. Post-Independent consolidation and re-organisation was undertaken to

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tackle the social turmoil and create a united India. The results are there for all to see.

Today, India stands tall as the world's largest democracy. Our Election Commission and judiciary are regarded as one of the most powerful institutions of the world. We are one of the fastest growing economies and have made great strides in reducing poverty and provide universal basic education to all. Thus, what was seen as a great adversity plaguing our nation, was turned into a great opportunity towards making India a great nation.

Similar developments were seen during the time of the Great Depression, which provided opportunity for the birth of Keynesian economics and thus welfare economics, where governments activity contribute towards enhancing welfare of their citizens. Post-World War-II, economic turmoil led to the birth of Bretton Woods institutions i.e., World Bank and International Monetary Fund (IMF), contributing greatly to global financial stability. This created an opportunity for the world to prevent such incidents in the future.

The small-pox epidemic, though being one of the most tragic events in history, also created an opportunity for an important scientific breakthrough, the creation of the world's first vaccine by Edward Jenner. This led to creation of vaccines for many more diseases, enhancing global health apart from saving many lives.

Similarly, it was after the Surat plague, that policymakers realised the importance of cleanliness and hygiene in preventing diseases. Today, Surat is one of the cleanest cities in India and a model for other cities throughout the country.

The 2006 Tsunami led to the installation of state-of-the-art early warning systems in the India Ocean region for the very first time. Today, advance warning can be given for, not just tsunamis, but even disasters like tropical cyclones, greatly enhancing India's disaster resilience.

Thus, it would not be wrong to say that in the midst of great adversity, lies a great opportunity willing to be seized.

However, does this also mean that opportunities can be seized, created and realised only in the times of great crises. Do we need to wait for calamities, when there is a great loss of life and property, to occur for humanity to come up with novel transformational ideas? Shouldn't opportunities instead, be used in advance to prevent adversity in the first place?

As wise man have said, 'prevention is always better than care', hence we should 'make hay while the sun shines'. We as humans have been born with a unique capacity for self-reflection and analysis. Hence, we should use this ability to predict and prevent adversities from occurring, at an individual, social, economic, political and environmental level.

An example of this is the current climate crisis. As described by IPCC (Intergovernmental Panel for Climate Change) in its various reports, if we act now, we can prevent severe climate disaster in the future and save millions of lives. Hence, herein also lies an opportunity to be seized, which can actually prevent adversity ex-ante.

A similar example for the importance of preparation can be understood using previous examples. India became a great nation, not only because of our extraordinary response to great adversity, but because, a vision for future of India had already been created in advance by our leaders during the long freedom struggle (A vision for the future Indian republic had been created as early as 1915).

Similarly, past research, institutions and mechanisms (like WHO, advances in biotechnology and DNA) played a huge role in tackling the COVID-19 pandemic. Had these institutions, mechanisms and technologies not existed, the effect of the pandemic could have been much more disastrous.

Whether politically, economically, socially or environmentally, the world around us is constantly changing. Thus, adversities may still arise even with our efforts to prevent them. What is more important here, though, is to constantly strive for prevention of such adversities, and also, not to be dejected in the face of calamity, rather seize the opportunity hidden within it. As Napoleon Bonaparte once said, 'Courage isn't having the strength to go on, it is going on when you don't have strength'.

►TREAT THE PEOPLE AS ENDS IN THEMSELVES, NEVER AS A MEANS TO AN END

#PHILOSOPHICAL

Once a very unusual case reached a British court. The case pertained to a grotesque act of cannibalism. The three accused in the case were said to have consumed the flesh of a young boy who was travelling with them on a boat journey in the sea. The three men even conceded of having done so, but the argument given

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by them was that, had they not done so, they all would have died due to scarcity of not having food. Moreover, they said, they boy was unwell due to consumption of salty sea water and would have died anyway. So, they killed him and could sustain themselves on the journey. The death of a boy saved the life of three others.

Now these arguments, raise a very fundamental question, with which the philosophers have been grappling since ages. Can people be used as a means to an end or should they be an end in themselves?

In the case of cannibalism, described above, the utilitarian would argue that it is totally justified to kill one person to save the maxim of greatest good of greatest number. On the other hand, consequentialist or teleological scholars would argue to put ends above means. According to consequentialists, if the end is good, the means can be and should be compromised. So, if using someone as a means serves a larger purpose, so be it. For ex. For consequentialists actions like theft are justified if it is done in dire circumstances, let's say to avoid starvation.

As opposed to these two lines of arguments comes the deontological perspective of Immanuel Kant. Kant puts the means above ends. Kantian view emphasises on human dignity and advocates it as a categorical imperative. According to Kant, if a person is used as a means to an end, his/her dignity is violated, human dignity being inviolable in any circumstances.

In every sphere of life right from ancient ages till today, we have seen people being used as a means towards a larger, sometimes not so noble objectives. From the times of ancient Greece to American Revolution, we witness slavery being practiced on a huge scale all over the world. The imperial powers like Britain, France made it legitimate to trade human slaves as if they were objects. Southern States of USA even went to pursue a civil war against the liberal North to continue with their right to continue with slavery. There can be no better example of a society collectively using human beings as a means than this.

Slaves from Africa and South Asia were used as indentured labourers in fields, industries and plantations under pathetic living conditions to fulfil the needs of erstwhile imperial empires. Some ancient philosophers, like Aristotle, even defended slavery as a functional necessity of society. They rationalised slavery on the grounds that this practice was even in the interest of slaves, as they lacked mental faculties to lead an independent life.

Even though, not slavery in its true sense, but the plight of Indigo cultivators, poor peasants and tribals was similar during the British rule. Their labour was used as a means towards the end of colonisation.

In the modern times, there was promulgation of liberal ideology by scholars like John Locke, Thomas Hobbes etc. It was aimed to give maximum possible liberty to an individual, to enable them to pursue their creative best. But as time passed, humanity has again slowly descended into a similar predicament. This time it was invisible slavery in capitalism. The workers were made to work their heart out for the success of industrial revolution in Western countries. Criticising the capitalist mode of production, where workers were used as a means towards the objective of accumulation of wealth in a few hands, Karl Marx laid down the theory of alienation. Rut of capitalistic labour, reduced humans to a cog in the wheel as he got alienated not only from the product of his labour but also from society and self.

With the rise of consciousness of nationhood, there was emergence of nation states after the Treaty of Westphalia in 1648. Even though the history of wars is as old as mankind itself, now wars were fought in the name of larger objective of national interest. Hundreds of thousands of innocent civilians and duty-bound soldiers died during the two world wars for protecting their national interest, which to a large extent was a construct of the leaders of those times, lakhs of people were sacrificed at the altar of protecting their country. It may even be a result of inflated ego of politicians that led to them use their countrymen as a means on the pretext of national interest.

Politicians and politics do not treat people as means only for war, but also during routine politics. People are approached by politicians just before the elections to fetch their votes and be forgotten altogether later, once their utility as voters is over. Politics has got mixed with criminalisation, corruption due to the unsatiable greed of money and lust for power for which no means is considered as unscrupulous.

Gandhiji said that politics without ethics is a death trap. He advocated for priority for means over ends, which can be a source of guiding light for contemporary politics to not reduce voters only as a

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means of grabbing power. They have to be nurtured, goodwill has to be earned through arduous efforts rather than taking refuge in money and muscle power.

Politics as they say is a mirror image of society, in which it is situated. In society, we witness varied instances when people are treated as a means for an end. People engage in theft, deceit, lies, half-truths, scams etc. where someone is being used as a means to further someone else's cause. All such activities are not only rampant but have also become normalised. There is no strong sense of revulsion for them in our society. As Hannah Arendt puts it, the evil has become banal.

Economic realm is also an important constituent of society. We have seen the use of personal data being used deceitfully to make gains for companies. This has given rise to widespread concerns of privacy and data theft. It can also be seen as company using its clients and their personal information as an illegitimate means to further their business prospects. It violates the right to privacy which is now a fundamental right under Article 21 of Constitution.

During the COVID-19 pandemic, we saw hundreds of vaccines being manufactured all over the world by companies. Due to the gravity of the crisis, clinical trials were conducted in a hasty manner. We saw several reports of vulnerable and poor people being used to act as agents to these trials by giving them wrong information, and at times, by offering them huge sum of money. The question here arises whether, the financial condition of poor being used to push them to a life-threatening trial, even if it intends to serve a larger purpose is justified. Even if he/she might be financially poor, but his/her dignity should be respected at all costs.

Thus, sometimes it becomes a necessity to use others as a means for pursuing a larger good, although it must be kept in mind that utmost care and empathy for the person concerned should be the duty of the society for whose benefit, he is being used as a means.

Although, Kantian view is the most appealing to any humane soul, but one should not be absolutist in such subjective assumptions and conclusions as situation might differ and demand different approaches suitable in a particular context.

►IF YOU CAN DREAM IT, YOU CAN DO IT.

#PHILOSOPHICAL

"A dream is not the vision you see in your sleep; it is the thing that doesn't let you sleep." These golden words of Dr. APJ Abdul Kalam have inspired generation upon generation. Dreams are the beautiful and heartening wishes we harbor that inspires us to make reality just as amazing and mesmerizing. To even wish for and dream of wonderful things requires great creativity, hope and intelligence. A person capable of dreaming is also a person capable of turning dreams to reality, with their unique vision and skills. Walt Disney rightly said, "If you can dream it, you can do it."

The difference between dreaming and doing lies in our perception. Seeing our wishes as mere desires keeps them in the realm of imagination seeing our wishes as directives for a brighter future helps us realize them and manifest them.

If one hopes and dreams for a moving cause with enough intensity, he can find enough strength and intelligence within himself to fulfill such a cause. Times old and new show us through individuals and institutions alike how great resolve, determination, dedication and achievable targets can make all dreams come true.

Dreaming a glorious dream

A dream is not simply a hope filled thought one can think and desire. Thoughts are impulses of the mind tempered with reality and constrained by the limits of the world. On the other hand, a dream is an impulse of the soul free from the sounds of the "norm", free to create a reality of its own.

The plan to visit a neighbouring city is a thought. The plan to fly to a city in a world without airplanes is a dream. A dream is not what is moulded by reality. It is that which on realization molds reality.

George Bernard Shaw rightly said, "The reasonable man adapts himself to the world, the unreasonable man transforms the world." The Wright Brothers in 1903 made an unrealistic dream reality with the first successful airplane flight. On an institutional level, Savitribai and Jyotiba Phule and their associates made history by establishing a school for girls in India in 1848. Pushing the boundaries of what is "acceptable, probable, realistic" is the hallmark of a revolutionary dream. It is perhaps the only dream that is ever

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realized fully. Without the motivation to make the unthinkable happen, dreams can be lost to compromise.

Making dreams come true

Making dreams come true requires determination and dedication. Painstaking efforts, relentless pursuit and single–minded focus is key for such an achievement. During the Covid–19 pandemic, everyone dreamt of a miraculous invention to save humanity.

Only, a few turned that dream into reality. Since 2020, leading pharmaceutical companies and their visionary and enthusiastic scientists attempted to create a lifesaving corona preventing vaccine. From March to November 2020 leading companies like Pfizer AstraZeneca, Moderna faced numerous difficulties in their vaccine trials. However, after numerous failed trials, all efforts came to fruition. The vaccines developed have an efficacy rate of more than 90% and have indeed saved million of lives and enabled the world to return to normalcy.

On an individual level, we can learn from the inspiring journey of genius inventor Thomas Edison. Edison had a dream of living in an efficient, developed world powered by electricity. He failed ten thousand times. Yet, he counted each time as a unique lesson. The Culmination of all those lessons was the lightbulb.

Turning a vision into a tangible reality requires us to be skilled and knowledgeable about our intentions. As Wilbur Wright said, "it is possible to fly without motors, but not without knowledge and skill." Dr. Vikram Sarabhai was the one with a glorious vision of India's indigenous space program, for which he conceptualized the academic and physical rigor befitting of India's finest space scientists. ISRO's Academic centers and Research centers have arisen out of this awareness of importance of skills and clarity play in the realization of any dream.

Prioritization is the less spoken secret for realizing one's dreams. We must prize our objectives over distractions, judgements and the price at which our objectives will be realized. On the path to become world champion, boxer Mary Kom had to make sacrifices, forego the comfort of family and continuously practice. Sacrificing comfort, early gratification, and our own fears are some examples.

During the freedom struggle, both Moderates and Extremists were intensely devoted to the cause of India's freedom. So much so, that they decided to sacrifice their affiliation with the Congress, to unfetteredly pursue their dream for freedom.

Defending our dreams

In a world, where many never experience the joy having a dream, and many more lose hope of living such a dream, disappointment runs rife. It is only natural that the "dreamer doers" draws scorn and judgement of those bereft of dreams.

Martin Luther King Jr. whose most famous speech is called "I have a dream," is a shining sample of someone who fought to uphold his dreams until the very end. Despite the racial segregation laws, racist attacks, and resistance from his own family, King strove to work for his dream and find more allies who shared his dream. Thus, it is essential for the voices cheering us to drown out the voices attacking us.

Our dreams can undergo can evolve while travelling from our minds to our world. Therefore, it is essential for us to have an open mind and see dreams as tangible yet polymorphous. Dr. APJ Abdul Kalam had a dream of serving his nation and crafting her destiny. For this, he tried to join the Indian Airforce 7 times, and got rejected each time. However, he knew that dreams could change form while retaining their soul. He worked tirelessly and became the Missile man of India, inspiring many more to go after their dreams.

Living the dream

All the difficulties, triumph and losses associated with pursuing our dreams makes us value every effort to live such a dream. Thus, when such a dream becomes a reality. We fight tooth and nail to maintain and preserve it. India, in its varied history, has been witness to many uncomfortable events such as the loss of her freedom, and the mistreatment of her people. For centuries, brave men and women fought for India's freedom. When it was finally realized, we became even more aware of the immense value of our dream. Today India is the world's largest thriving democracy and boasts of one of the strongest armies of the world.

Living such a dream is only possible if we dare to see a dream, plan for it meticulously, stay open to its many possibilities and defend it with everything we have. Realizing our dreams motivates us to dream higher dreams with larger goals and gives us the confidence to realize them.

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►POETS ARE THE UNACKNOWLEDGED LEGISLATORS OF THE WORLD

PHILOSOPHICAL

It was late 1950s. An American poet and renowned nature lover received a letter from her friend. It spoke of the miserable death of birds, probably due to a pesticide. Four years later the poet, penned a masterpiece – "The Silent Spring." This book unveiled the adverse effects of DDT on the environment. DDT was at that time being indiscriminately promoted by the governments to improve agricultural productivity post second world war.

This poet, Rachel Carson became the pioneer of modern environmental movement in the USA. Despite criticisms, especially from the chemical industry, she succeeded. The sentiment for the nature found resonance with many nature lovers leading to protests, and demand for 'conservation.' This forced government to bring about regulations and motivated chemists to develop 'Green Chemistry.' "How can someone write about the sea but leave out poetry?" she would say. Today, behind international conventions, COPs and agendas for climate change, she stands, least remembered!

Poets have remained unelected representatives of the people, shaping ideas of humanity since time immemorial. This essay would delve into those unrecognized legislators and how their contribution in making the present world the place it is today.

Human behaviour stems from attitude. Attitudes in turn are formed by cognition, reinforced by affective component. Poets provide the information, facts or realities with a very strong emotional component. This makes the readers to ponder, question and act or react. Perhaps, Shelly was true when he wrote: "Our sweetest songs are those that tell of the saddest thoughts."

Great revolutions of the world attribute part of their success to thinkers and poets. Random popular emotions were given proper morphology by them. The story of French Revolution is incomplete without the fire kindled by Voltaire, Rousseau, Montesquieu and the story of American War of independence would be incomplete without the contribution of Thomas Jefferson.

When 19th century Europe was under the grips of consumerism and materialistic greed, Romanticism emerged as a movement in literature to provide solace and vision for a future to the masses. It began as a reaction to industrial revolution. William Wordsworth, John Keats, Shelly are ground-breaking poets of this era. They revived the aesthetic flavor of human lives.

Quran and sayings of Prophet Mohammed form the foundation of Islamic thought and philosophy. These ideas were often misinterpreted by corrupt Ulemas and multiple factions for personal gains and force warfare. Later, Sufi poets like Sadi and Rumi brought back humanism, love, grace and tolerance to Islam.

Poets have voiced the woes of the world. This has been true from the very earliest times when poetry began to be written to this day. Tony Morrison in her works brought out the dark shades of racism in USA. Through his book "Inglorious Empire," Shashi Tharoor demanded reparations from Britain for the illegal occupation of India and usurpation of vast wealth from India. This sparked debate on the nature of colonialism and fixing of responsibility of colonizing powers to apologize for their historical actions. Colonized countries were surprised to know that history schools of Britain never taught colonial history and the extent of exploitation Britain conducted on its subjects.

India in its long history witnessed the reigns of mighty and public minded kings who emphasized on welfare-oriented policies. These benevolent kings were adviced by great scholars and court poets, like Kalidas for Chandragupta II and Krishnadevaraya had Ashtadiggajas – Council of Eight – men of words, who guided his actions.

During the ancient times, the metaphysical ideas spread out in the Vedas, Upanishads, poetry of Sangam age form the fountainhead of knowledge and wisdom which continues to be relevant to the present day. Upanishads emphasize esoteric learning and metaphysics, on were literary councils organized by Pandya rulers during ancient times in Tamil Nadu. Here the best literary works were awarded, and moral works were incorporated into school education. Today, these Sangam writings are a storehouse of ethos of the age and provide a window into the polity, economy, society and cultural links of the times.

Poets of medieval age have even accompanied the kings in their expeditions. Alberuni's Kitab-ul-Hind was penned during Ghori's invasion. Coincidentally, it can be noticed that a flourishing rule brought prosperous literature or vice versa! Abul Fazl's Akbar Nana.

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During the freedom struggle, the task of kindling the spirit of nationalism and oneness among Indian masses was the principal goal of freedom fighters. How could the idea "nationhood" be rooted in a land, where there was hardly any commonality, in terms of common language and culture, but common exploitation at the hands of British? Poets were however at the forefront of drawing the national imagery. Bankim's "Vande Mataram" and Tagore's "Jana Gana Mana" were sung and celebrated during the Swadeshi movement and became the rallying spirit of millions wanting freedom and self-rule.

The goals of Indian National Movement were not limited to only Civil & Political liberties but also had a cultural project of developing a national culture. Social reformers like Raja Ram Mohan Roy vehemently opposed the social evils, questioned Brahmanical hegemony and superstitions, fought for the rights of the marginalized like women, Dalits and tribals. Powerful writings, for example by Derozio from Young Bengal movement, assaulted the veil of ignorance and called for scientific temper and rationalism. Sri Narayana Guru in his bhajans and bhakti called for "One caste, One religion, One God" for mankind. Revolutionaries like Ashfaq Ullah Khan who were willing to die for the sake of India's freedom rallied around songs and slogans that motivated them like Inqilab Zindabad.

Poets come from different levels of society and strive for a better society based on inclusivity. Their compassionate and kind lens allows them to imbibe positive virtues like equality, justice, fraternity even before they found echo in modern constitutions, like the Preamble of the Constitution. For ex. Poets and Saints of Bhakti Movement came from diverse backgrounds – Kabir (weaver), Ravidas (cobbler), Mirabai (Rajput Princess) etc. and preached against dogmatism, caste and social barriers and gave message of oneness and love for right conduct and god. Poets speak for rights of women, transgender, homosexuals as famous line by William Wallace on motherhood "The Hand that rocks the cradle rules the world."

Democracy is founded upon the bedrock of freedom of speech and expression. Like legislators, poets accept reality and approach it with rationality. The Nightingale of India, Sarojini Naidu wrote about "palanquin bearers" and 'Coromandel fishers.' Rudyard Kipling called ideal legislators "To walk among the kings, Yet not to lose the common touch."

Dreams and ideals are the life force for poets. They in their writings are often concerned about ideals, ethics and morals. These timeless ideals which are powerfully communicated continue to motivate leaders and masses for generation. Thirukkural by Tiruvallur inspired Tolstoy to write "Kingdom of God is within you." Both motivated Gandhi to launch Satyagraha and bring the greatest empire in history on its toes. When Robert Frost wrote:

"The woods are lovely, dark & deep

But I have promises to keep,

And miles to go before I Sleep"

Who can inhibit the urge to introspect?!

Despite accolades, the contributions of poets have remained unacknowledged. Often, they are seen as cynical and rejected as impractical. Some have criticized their dogma as "poets are doubly cut off from reality." Much later, the distance shrank, recognizing them as novel, ardent champions of mankind.

Poets have served as "causative agents and ideologues' behind a large transformation of human society. However, the effort is brought about by more pragmatic personalities who bring these images to fruition, and later celebrated as leaders. Not surprisingly, it is Gandhi and not Tolstoy, who was harbinger of Satyagraha! The intention of poets, to a major extent, ceases with expression of events or ideas. It is upon readers, on how they work these ideas which decides the future.

Poets blunt out blatant truths which are hard enough to be assimilated by amateur minds. The tale of Salman Rushdie hints that twenty first century is still an era where writers and poets should flee for their lives. However, unacceptable at first but it often dawns that the radical ideas that poets lay are true and often the voice of the voiceless. As Voltaire's often quoted saying goes, "I may not agree with what you say but I will defend to death you right to say it." It is essential to creatively engage with radical ideas and not banish them.

The pen has always been mightier than a sword. Both poets and legislators have wielded it meticulously, sculpting progress in the sands of time. Today, the mode of expression has changed. But the idea to read, write, speak, feel, think and act has not. Doves and pigeons carrying messages have been replaced by the blue bird (Twitter). There are anonymous writers and poets, who are analyzing state policy,

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disseminating objectivity, addressing insanity, accommodating diversity and fostering fraternity. Societies too are becoming liberal day by day, moving towards common goal to realize.

"When the mind is without fear and head is held high

Where the world is NOT BROKEN up into fragments by narrow domestic walls

Where dear stream of reason has NOT LOST its way into the dreary desert sand of dead habitat

Into that heaven of freedom.

My father, let my country awake"

- Tagore (Gitanjali)

►YOU CAN NEVER CROSS THE OCEAN UNTIL YOU HAVE THE COURAGE TO LOSE SIGHT OF THE SHORE

#PHILOSOPHICAL

During its formative years post-independence, India was gradually consolidating itself both in terms of its economic strength as well as foreign cooperation. Meanwhile the ethnically related East Pakistan was facing atrocities from West Pakistan. Further, India had a two front threat from Pakistan's East and West territory. With its economic development at stake and essential foreign cooperation at risk, India. Decided to help in Bangladesh liberation. This needed immense courage from leaders like Mrs. Indira Gandhi and Major. Sam Manekshaw but to cross the ocean of security threat from Pakistan and liberation of Bangladeshis, it was essential. Eventually India was able to cross the ocean by losing sight of the comfort of its slow economic & geopolitical growth. For this risk taking attitude and courage was necessary.

But what is courage? It is a cardinal virtue as propounded by Plato. It is the attribute of an individual to face adversities and work through them.

It is very important to be courageous and increase one's risk appetite. Having courage to take risks enables individual to explore new things and possibilities. It helps us to leave our comfort zones and work hard to face the adversities. It is said that human minds work more efficiently on the face of adversities, as it creates a compulsion for us to discard laziness and enhance our abilities. But more than anything else having courage and taking risks, gives oneself a moral boost and confidence.

Historically, we have seen during the invasion of Alexander. While the ruler of Taxilla, surrendered to Alexander to save himself, King Porus had the courage to confront despite being aware of the might of Alexander's army. Eventually, King Porus was remembered for his bravery and honourably got his kingdom back.

Fast forward to the freedom struggle against British power, the courage of Indian leaders to move out of their comfort zones for national independence gained results. Had they not tried, perhaps India's independence would have been delayed further.

Even in the International arena, India took the risk of not siding any party during the cold war period. This could have resulted in India being sidelined by both blocks in future. But India was able to cross the ocean and today it is not only a partner of both rival blocs, but is also able to respectfully pursue its national interests.

Coming to the economic progress, a fast growth often requires, some risks to be taken be it individuals at stock market or the nation's growth as whole. India was able to capitalise on the reforms of liberalisation, privatisation and globalisation by risking domestic growth. Today India is the 6th largest economy of the world.

The biggest relevance of risks and its necessity for growth is in businesses and entrepreneurship in particular. Developing a startup involves numerous risks like capital, human resource, consumer trust, competitive market etc. But to be successful, one needs to take risk. The audio device manufacturer company "Boat" is a case in point. It gained market prominence alongside Sony, Bose etc.

Even in technological progress, India's Pokhran experiments risked global backlash. But a courageous risk taken then has made India a nuclear power today and external security.

Public Administration too calls for courage, to take risk and lose sight of the shore, with the likes of Satyendra Dubey, who risked life to expose financial irregularity, Ashok Khemka, who sacrificed his comfort owing to transfers due to whistle-blowing.

It is essential to have the courage, to take risk to succeed. But sometimes it is essential too to not loose sight of the shore under the hood of courage. It is said that courage is a mean value of fearfulness and foolishness. It is equally essential for us to not be foolish in our pursuit.

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In the contemporary times, we can see that Taiwan's provocation to China by highlighting the visit of USA's speaker Nancy Pelosi did not augur well with China. It is essential for Taiwan to first exhaust all diplomatic solutions.

Similarly in facilitating technological advancements, we often risk the likes of privacy, security etc. while it is important to promote blockchain technology, governments must not promote unregulated use of cryptocurrency, as it can lead to failure of flat currency, crime financing etc.

Even in disaster management, we calibrate our approach towards disaster risk reduction we should focus on essential development like dams, coastal infrastructure etc. but at the same time, we must reduce our risks.

Society in general calls for women empowerment and boosting individual liberty, but at the same time, we must strengthen the institutions like police, judiciary etc. to protect the liberty.

By now, we are convinced that we must raise our risk appetite and also our ability to withstand the consequences. And this is what needs courage and efficient risk management. But there also lies challenges in doing so.

It is very difficult to find such courageous people. PayPal co-founder said, "Courage is in further short supply than geniuses". This shortage can be attributed to the social upbringing in our society that naturally makes a person risk aversive. Like every parent aspires their child be a doctor, engineer for secure & paying jobs. Further limitations like financial weakness, stops a person from taking risks. Further there is an inertia at individual level to move out of comfort zone and take the chances of failure.

In this regard, we must first try to become psychologically stronger. We should remember that, even if we are not able to cross the ocean, we would be prod of ourselves to have atleast tried. This gives us moral boost-further there is a need for positive attitude to handle failure like Edison said, "He did not fail, rather he discovered 10000 ways that do not work". Beyond being able to handle failure, we must keep hope as "Luck favours the brave". At the society level, risk taking attitude must be encouraged and role models be presented. Government initiatives to promote Indian unicorns in social media is a step in right direction.

To conclude, we must not fear taking risks to achieve something but at the same time, we must also focus on scoping and preparing ourselves for the consequences. This can help us sail through the oceans easily.

►REALITY DOES NOT CONFIRM TO THE IDEAL, BUT CONFIRMS IT

#PHILOSOPHICAL

The year 2020 will be remembered in the times to come, for all the negative reasons. There was large scale mortality, people's sufferings, job losses, economic recession etc. were the hallmarks of the year 2020. All of this was because of the COVID-19 virus induced worldwide pandemic.

Coronavirus induced pandemic has exposed the reality to the world. It has exposed the deep-rooted inequalities, defects in global and national health governance, excessive dependence on any one country, and lack of cooperation and collaboration among nations. The reality is far from ideal state. In the ideal world, the pandemic would not have been thought of, let alone its spread and resulting negative consequences.

In this essay, we will discuss the current face of society, reasons behind the importance of ideal society, source of ideal in the Indian and global context and some suggestions on how to bridge the divide between reality and ideal.

Let us see some examples from history to understand the importance of ideals. Ashoka was said to have killed his 99 brothers in order to become a king. Even after getting the throne, he pursued the policy of annexation. In the famous battle of Kalinga, he got enlightenment and understood that war and aggression cannot be the ideal state. Thereafter, he pursued the policy of Dhamma to win the hearts of people. For him, the source of ideal was Dhamma. Throughout his life, he propagated the ideal of Dhamma by erecting stone pillars and appointing officials to propagate his message to the masses. Similarly, ideal life for Aryans was to follow Rigveda and its principles. They used to do yajnas and recite appropriate mantras mentioned in the Vedas.

What are the ideals of modern-day India? The ideals of modern India are mentioned in the Preamble of the Constitution – which call for establish a society which is rooted in the ideals of democracy, is secular in

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nature, has socialistic aspirations, where justice, liberty and equality are ensured for each and where the spirit of fraternity informs inter-personal and community relations. Our forefathers have visualized a modern-day Indian state in which every person has the liberty of thought, expression, belief and worship.

There have been specific and elaborate directions to achieve the ideal state in the form of Directive Principle of State Policy.

Now after understanding the ideals of India, let us discuss the current realities by some specific instances. As per Article 39(b) and 39(c), the state should take steps to ensure that wealth is not concentrated in the hands of few and the benefits of growth and development is equitably distributed.

However, the reality is far from the ideal. As per Oxfam Report, 70% of the wealth is concentrated in the hands of top 1% of the Indian population. Moreover, in 2018, the unemployment rate reached 6.1% (NSSO data), which was highest in the last 45 years. Clearly, the reality depicts joblessness and non-inclusive growth. Therefore, the Indian lived reality does not confirm to ideals enunciated in Indian constitution. The reality of this unsustainable growth clearly justifies the importance of economic justice mentioned in the Preamble. Thus, reality confirms the importance of ideal.

The growing criminalization of politics is another grim reality. Nearly 43% of members of Parliament in the 17th Lok Sabha are facing criminal charges against them. This depicts a sad situation in which criminals have better chances of winning an election and have come to dominate public life. Consequently, there has been a decline in the quality of parliamentary proceedings and members often indulge in unethical practices like defecting due to influence of money. The ideal state (Political Justice) demands the highest – ethical behavior from the elected representative. The ideal demands good governance from the government which will bring a mammoth socio-economic transformation in the country.

Clearly the reality is far from ideal, but the ideal highlights the need to check the growing criminalization of politics, to reach the ideal state. Therefore, in a sense, ideals are the goals or values that guides and inspires the human behavior. They give a sense of purpose to life which brings satisfaction to the humans.

However, not all ideals are static. Some ideals keep on evolving as the society evolves. In ancient India, the king who upheld the social order was considered just. This essentially meant to uphold the Chatur Verma (4 Varna System). In modern day India, this may look regressive and unjust and against our ideals (social justice and equality).

India is on a path of transformation. We have conceptualized our ideals in the dream of New India. In the past, we have taken several steps to reach and accomplish our dream of ideal Indian society which includes, Right to Education Act, MGNREGA, Right to Information, LPG reforms among others. We have brought a significant change from the past and modified the reality to the positive. Some examples include Swachh Bharat Abhiyan which have made India open defecation free, JAM trinity to reduce leakages and corruption to name a few.

Ideals have the power to change reality. This requires an earnest resolve of all the stakeholders to work in synergy. The government should invest in capacity building of the people by improving education and health. Moreover, there is a need to bring behavioural and attitudinal change to bring a sustainable and long-term change.

Any change will come only with active participation of both state and non-state actors. The state should articulate a clear goal and act as a facilitator, while the non-state actors should identify the issues, make suitable suggestions and ensure citizen's participation in order to create a New India based on the foundation of social, economic and political justice. Although the goal may seem utopian, we should take the inspiration from following words of wisdom – **"ARISE, AWAKE AND STOP NOT UNTIL THE GOAL IS REACHED" - SWAMI VIVEKANANDA.**

►THOSE WHO HAVE A 'WHY' TO LIVE, CAN BEAR WITH ALMOST ANY 'HOW'

#PHILOSOPHICAL

On the night of 7th June 1893, when there was nobody on the railway station on a dark and cold night, something very remarkable happened which changed course of humanity. From nowhere a train approached its station in Pretoria, South Africa. As soon as the train stopped, a young lawyer named M K Gandhi was thrown off the train. Fraught with anger, humiliation and fear, he recounted what happened to him. Despite having a ticket to travel in the first-class

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compartment, he was thrown out of the train, just because he was brown in his skin. This incident gave him his reason 'why', he needs to stand against injustice. For the next 21 years and later, he fought against injustice through satyagraha and non-violence, which made the 'father of the nation'.

The above case highlights the importance of having a purpose (why) which motivates one to bear with the hardships in achieving the goal (how).

There are three essential attributes of 'why', which is crucial for anyone to bear with almost any 'how'. The first is values one holds. Values are beliefs/qualities that are important to us. They give us purpose to guide our actions. For instance, Mother Teresa valued 'service to the needy', so much that she even said that she was not a firm believer in God. She saw service to needy as the best way to salvation and realise Godliness.

Second, is attitude. Attitudes are learnt predispositions to act favourably or unfavourably towards an attitude object. Right attitude is important as it serves as the inner motivation to do things, which one aspires for. For instance, Abdul Kalam despite facing obstacles and rejections he faced in his missile program continued to pursue his goals with perseverance and dedication due to the positive attitude of completing the task at his hand.

Third is Aptitude. Aptitude is the innate ability to do things quickly. This requires hardwork, motivation and interest. For instance, Dr. Ambedkar in his quest to ensure social justice, worked hard and developed interest in all disciplines of social sciences -- politics, economics, sociology, law etc. It is because of his vast interest, learning and aptitude, that India has of the longest living constitutions of the world. Having seen the significance of 'why' in equipping one with values, attitude and aptitude, we will see how it is related to developed.

The purpose or 'why' is crucial for social, political and economic development. In the sphere of social development, we can see that individuals committed to public service (why) help large number of people leaving their comfort zone. For instance, Baba Amte committed to the well-being of leprosy patients.

In civil society, we can see case of organisations like Save The Child movement under Kailash Satyarthi saving thousands of children forced to bonded labour. Government in order to end social injustice and exploitation of peasants, abolished the zamindari system right after independence and distributed land to peasants.

In the political sphere, one can see how individuals committed to values of individual liberty, freedom and human dignity, fight rigid hierarchical social structure. Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar, Raja Ram Mohun Roy and their efforts in eliminating social evils like Sati, female infanticide are well known. Governments also have to bear with consequences of people's frustration, when they had to take strict measures like lockdown, Sec 144 to enforce lockdowns during COVID pandemic to save lives. We heard of civil society organisations like PUCL, PETA etc. fighting in courts to ensure human rights and animal rights respectively.

Even in economic realm, we have come across stories of entrepreneurs, who have fructified business ideas into viable massive businesses. They had to face issues of shortage of capital, human resources and technology. Despite these difficulties, they strived hard to make their companies a success. High drive of these individuals could only motivate them to make massive efforts. India has more than 100 such unicorns, 100 different stories of struggle and grit.

The successful Kudumbashree scheme which runs on the idea of empowerment through entrepreneurship has ensured women empowerment in Kerala. In the pursuing the necessity of economic growth and infrastructure development, sometimes government has to face opposition and wrath of the people. For ex. Irrigation projects like Narmada River project was completed despite protests.

However, not always 'why' leads to positive developments. There are negatives as well. For ex. Some individuals like Ramalinga Raju, in their quest for wealth indulged in unethical business practices and accounting frauds, leading downfall of Satyam Computers. These and other similar stories of greed reflect, that the quality of motivation is also important. Usually, the narrow goals of enriching themselves by any means and at the cost of others leads to their downfall. For some others like Hitler, their goal was to pursue power at the cost of others and pursue their hateful and divisive agenda. For ex. Misguided terrorists want to pursue power, even if it leads to killing innocent people.

So, the question arises, how to address the problem of negative 'why' i.e., negative emotions or motivations. The answer is simple. The root cause of the problem is their wrong conception of their 'why' to live. If this is addressed at an early stage in people

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live, then it will benefit not only them but also the larger humankind as well. Thus, we need to explore measures for inculcating the right conception of 'why'?

First and foremost, is right socialisation. The conception of one's ideas and character start from childhood and is shaped in families, neighbourhoods and schools. Children's self is like a clean slate. Thus, it is important that these institutions proper environment to inculcate proper values. The next is educational institutions which incorporates the values and philosophy of our constitution, culture, art etc. in the tender children. Education should focus on holistic development of children with emphasis on moral character development. Methods like role playing, visiting old age homes, museums etc. can be used in schools.

Thirdly, we need to focus on awareness generation of public about the moral thinkers and society. Indian ethos are a culmination of several centuries and great individuals like Swami Vivekananda, Raja Ram Mohan Roy, Ambedkar and Gandhi etc. Their contribution to the society is not known to the people. So, awareness generation is very important to provide a moral guide and motivation to citizens.

Finally, ethics in public life needs to be emphasised. Politicians, elites and other important influencers in public life have a moral responsibility upon them to ensure social trust in society. They should put on exemplary behaviour and act like guiding light for others to emulate. These measure, to some extent, can help address the negative 'whys' which brings out evil in humanity.

Purpose (Why) is the seed which when watered, nurtured can mature into a large tree even in face of immense challenges. Just as Gandhiji observed, divine resides in the soul. If we properly channelised the potential of these divine soul by giving the right 'whys' and could facilitate them through their journey, we can definitely make Earth the heaven, we have dreamt of.

►THE TEST OF TOLERANCE COMES WHEN WE ARE IN MAJORITY; THE TEST OF COURAGE COMES WHEN WE ARE IN A MINORITY.

#PHILOSOPHICAL

When in the majority, we often tend to take decisions which serve our interests but may prove to be detrimental to the interest of others. 'Tolerance' doesn't imply abandoning our thought process; it means making room for others' freedom of expression. As Voltaire rightly said, 'I disapprove of what you say but I will defend to the death your right to say it'.

On the other hand, according to Plato's cardinal virtues, courage refers to the ability to do justice. When in minority, we fear the outcomes and the repercussions that follow the actions.

The test of tolerance and courage stand on the premises of impartiality and integrity respectively. The group conformity effect is a challenge to both tests. When we are in majority – be it power or strength in numbers, we are inclined to use our powerful position to exploit situations to our advantage. E.g., when bills are passed through voice votes by the Parliament, without taking into consideration the views of the minority. It is perceived that the ruling party was intolerant of the views of others. Similarly, the test of courage calls for commitment towards intellectual integrity.

Minorities are easier to oppress by the majority members. People tend to conform to the demands of the latter and forego their thoughts. For instance, IES officer Satyendra Dubey relentlessly raised his voice against the corruption collusion in the Golden Quadrilateral project. Despite being one of the very few persons to protest against the wrong, no number of threats could deter him from his goal.

On turning the pages of history, we see the remarkable example of the Mughal ruler – Akbar. His values of religious tolerance are relevant to date. He abolished the pilgrimage tax of Hindus and the Jizya tax. He believed that such taxation demeaned the stature of other religions. His principle of 'Sulah-i-Kul', harmonious relationships among all, upheld the values of tolerance and fraternity. Although he had all the powers, he stood the test of tolerance with grace and dignity.

Further, the beginning of the Indian freedom struggle reminds us about the test of courage when we stand

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in minority. The awareness among the masses about British exploitation was brought in by the few educated Indians. They showed courage to speak against oppressive colonial rule through the press and pamphlets. Defying their rule, the fighters did not beg down under the pressure.

Similarly, the social reformers stood firm on their ground to reverse the historical evils prevailing in society. Raja Rammohun Roy was the only one to revolt against the exploitation of women under the garb of the 'Sati' system. Despite being alone, the protests by the orthodox Brahmanical society could not stop him from repealing the law. The passing of such a test of courage proves our loyalty towards our constitution.

Now, if we look into the political dimension, we see many cases of intolerance that have cropped up in yester years. The misuse of section 124A of the Indian Penal Code to gag the voices of protest by a section of politicians has raised concern nationwide. Moreover, states like Tamil Nādu and West Bengal are facing a tussle between the Governor and the Chief Minister. Parochialism in the outlook is raising questions on the sustainability of cooperative federalism.

This happens mainly because most powers are with the Central Government and the Governor is seen as an agent of the Centre by the state. Although it's not true, sadly the level of tolerance among both comes down and ego play comes in between, hampering the federal structure, we need seamless patience, respect and willingness to consider bridging the increasing gap of intolerance.

Furthermore, in the sphere of international relations, India has shown the courage to stand apart even when no major power supported her. During the cold war era, India along with Egypt, Indonesia, Ghana and Yugoslavia formed the Non-aligned Movement, declaring its independent stand from any power bloc. Its principles remained intact irrespective of any international pressure.

Presently, in the context of the Russia – Ukraine war, India abstained from voting against Russia. Despite pressures from Europe and USA, her display of valour on an international platform has awarded her a unique position in global politics. Replying to the Western criticism, S. Jai Shankar has said, 'I am not sitting on the fence just because I don't agree with you. It means I am sitting on my ground.'

On a different note, when we glance through our society, we see declining tolerance for women. This has become evident through the increasing number of serious crimes against women, unequal work pays, refusal to grant maternity leaves, etc. Patriarchy is strengthening its roots in the form of selective sex abortion, domestic violence and so on. At this juncture, the test of tolerance is required on the part of men so that women get equal access to benefits. Women require to excel in the test of courage. So that they can use the law and get justice through constitutional means.

However, such prejudice and stereotypes are not restricted to women alone. With the abrogation of section 377 in the Navtej Singh Johar case, the rights of the LGBT community have come to light. The narrow outlook towards this community has been conclusively proven by the rampant discrimination against them. To establish an inclusive society, we need to be more tolerant and cooperative towards such minority and vulnerable sections of our society.

Moreover, the ruthless use of the environment has posed a challenge to the sustenance of humanity. Human beings have outnumbered the rest of living beings and are dominating the globe with technology and the exploitation of resources. Our rising intolerant attitude towards our ecosystem has increased the intensity of disaster and augmented the process of climate change.

Thus, from the above, we can say that an amicable attitude is required to stand true to the tests of courage and tolerance. Such values need to be inculcated through value education in schools and colleges. We should have an empathetic attitude towards the minority section and honesty to speak against the injustice caused by people in the majority. This will help us to reach our targets of inclusivity and collective growth.

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►BEST FOR AN INDIVIDUAL IS NOT NECESSARILY BEST FOR SOCIETY

#ETHICS #SOCIETY

As emperor Ashoka stood on the grounds of Kalinga post the war, he was a victorious man – The emperor of everything the eyes could see; North-South-East-West. Around him lay thousands and thousands of slaughtered men, their wailing families, their orphaned children. The destruction soured his taste of victory and he came at an impasse.

Often in life we as individuals find ourselves standing at similar crossroads where we get choices that we need to make. Some are not good for individuals, some are good while others might turn out to be the best. But is it necessary that choices- Best for an Individual turn out to be the best for the society as well?

Lets explore this in the following paragraphs.

Historically, the Indian Society promoted **community living**. There were only 'Jana'; no 'Janpads' Problems and meals were shared alike. This ideal society started to change as soon as individualistic thinking entered. in ancient period, the lust for power by a few led to the oppression of the weaker sections and degradation of the society as a whole. Further, the invasions of Mahmud of Ghazni, Mohammad Ghazi, Nadir Shah just for the display of their strength destroyed the peace of Indians.

Most significant here is the Battle of Plassey between the Nawab of Bengal and the Britishers, aided by defectors like Mir Jatar. The latter did it for their own economic future; opening roads for a crippled Indian Economy and subjugation of its people for a long time to come. All the thinking for individual best never fared out good for the others.

Furthermore, politically, India is a democracy that provides for collective decisions and collective answerability. The constitution has provided for equal rights and protection for all **– Art. 15 & 16, Schedule V, Schedule VI, etc**. providing for upliftment of a certain sections of the society which are at a greater disadvantage. But these mechanisms fail when individualistic thinking seeps in. Defections by sitting MLA and MP for self gain topple the elected governments, bringing a state for uncertainty. Forced coalitions just for power often lead to more ideological clashes than work. Corruption by the bureaucrats and politicians may fill their bags with money, but deny the large rural community a speciality hospital.

Globally, we are more integrated today than before. All the economies are interconnected with global manufacturing and supply chains. An effect in one area is felt all over. The cold war between USSR and US divided the whole world into groups. Though directly they did not fight a war, but the quest for upmanship led to proxy wars like one in Vietnam. Similarly, the current US-China issues for super power upmanship has lead to sanctions and withdrawing investments – threatening livelihood of the common masses. The abandoned diplomatic talks between India and Pakistan have made multilateral engagement institutions like SAARC defunct. The negative outlook on cross border trade has deeply disturbed the involved traders.

Moreover, the **biggest disaster of this parochial attitude has been on the environment**. Even though the institutions like UNFCCC or UNEP are at work, the denial of the developed nations to cooperate with the developing world hurt the cause. The recent withdrawal of US from the Paris agreement unilaterally may be beneficial for its economy in the short run but harms the future of least developed island nations and coastal cities like Haiti, Cuba, Madagascar. The luxurious lifestyles of the rich 1% leads to more severe heatwaves, droughts, rains whose repucussions are felt most of the poor. The COP25 at Spain ended without concrete steps because the leaders were occupied in getting a fair deal just for themselves.

The partisan thinking prevalent in the society has led to further issues. The corporate want to shirk their corporate social responsibilities to gain extra profits. Hindus and Muslims want to have an upmanship over the others. Karnataka and Goa fight over the waters of Mahadayi river. There are snatchings, robberies, murder, deceit – all for personal gains. All these leads to the degradation of the society – culturally, economically and morally. Parochial individuals lead to segregated societies. In the long run, its difficult to survive in such a selfish word. Here, the following steps can be taken as a start.

From time immemorial, India has given various philosophies to the word. The philosophy of **Vasudev Kutumbakam** – engraved at the enterance halls of

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the Parliament. It emphasizes 'the world is one family'. The **'Panchsheel'** signed between India and China repeatedly focused on mutual peace and well being and peaceful existence. India has always thought of the Indian subcontinent as its extended part – supporting its neighbouring countries in disaster and development alike – examples being 'Operation Vanilla' and developing Bangladesh's first nuclear power plant. Such philosophies need to be revived at the World level so that others can watch, learn and adapt them.

We have some great example of personalities who practiced community thinking. Mahatma Gandhi not only taught for himself but for the society as a whole when he faced discrimination. He ran programme for the Dalit upliftment, included women and men arise in the freedom movement – left none behind. Mother Teresa sacrificed a comfortable life to serve in Bengal – dedicating herself to the care of the poor. The peace keeping forces, Doctors without borders – serve in hostile areas like Syria, south Sudan etc. without caring about their lives. Popularising these stories will inspire others to lead similar lives. Moreover, the current heroes like Kailash Satyarthi need to be recognized and rewarded – encouraging others.

There would hardly be any people who are not touched by religion today. Propagating the basic proponents of Mutual coexistence and self giving preached by the religions can be an effective strategy. The Boddhisatvas help others achieve Nirvana, even if their own is delayed. The Prophet did not keep to himself the revelations he received from Gabriel. Jesus got crucified to atone for the sins of the mankind. All these instances can easily be impressioned in the minds of the people.

The biggest learning has been the current Covid -19 pandemic. The world right now has integrated its efforts to fight as one unit. A drug research in US or an effective drug in India are instantly exchanged. The police, the paramedic, the scientists, the people volunteering for vaccine trial as well as the recovered patients donating their plasma – are all effective spokes in the wheel of the coronavirus fight. If one dismantles, the system topples. Had these people thought about their own well being before that of the world, there would have been utter chaos.

Ultimately, it's we humans who need to realise that one's welfare too, is entwined with those of the others. Thinking for our own good, sidelining the welfare of the society might give lucrative short term gains but will fizzle out in the long run. A polluting industry has to live on the some earth. A CSR shirking company has to coexist and depend on the same society for its perpetvity. Thus, it's we who have to choose now. Do we want what is best for society – Maximum good for maximum people? Or stick to what is good for us as an individual, ultimately leading to no good for any people.

►LENDING HANDS TO SOMEONE IS BETTER THAN GIVING A DOLE

#ETHICS #SOCIETY

It has been nearly 4 months and Balbir, auto-rickshaw driver in Jaipur has not earned anything. The lockdown was imposed due to Covid-19 to protect the lives of people but Balbir feels that he has been pushed to mere existence living without any savings to augment the future. The government does provide food for which he has to stand in long queues, still the quantity is not enough. He feels that the government could have used his services to supply essential commodities thereby helping him to cope up in this hour of crisis. Thousands of workers like Balbir have either lost their job or are on the verge of giving up and staring at an uncertain future. The food provided for free under PM Garib Kalyan Yojana doesn't satisfy their self-confidence which comes from earning and then feeding. Dole doesn't satisfy him.

Dole refers a kind of benefit either monetary or non-monetary paid by the government to the unemployed. While it is given so as to help them in hour of crisis, the background often has a different story to tell. Mostly doles are given by government when it focuses on short term rather than long term solutions for economy.

Most of the time the state just looks over the inequality aspect and shreds its responsibility. This is because setting the root cause of inequality from where the need arises to roll out the doles often are time consuming and may even fail. In that case a shadow of doubt will be casted on the government and of course, nobody wants to face failure. Doles also form a part of larger vote bank politics thereby undermining the freedom of choice as the votes are indirectly purchased. The vicious circle of dependence never ends.

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Lending a hand on the other side provides an opportunity to create self-reliance. This is based on the basic yet fundamental premise that people will always not be there for you, that is why you need to learn to handle things on your own. Helping people to be self-reliant would have a ripple effect. From the individuals side, there will be a sense of self independence and pride for contributing towards the economy. It will enhance their decision making power of how to earn and on what to spend. This will lead to increase in the productivity in the society thereby leading to improvement in living condition. This will be followed by inclusive development. The community as a whole will benefit from the improved access of products and services. Increase in earning capacity of people will be channelized to improving healthcare and educational outcomes. Crime rates would decline and will help in building a cohesive society. From the political angle, there would be a demand for welfare oriented and accountable leaders. Self-reliant individuals would no longer be lured by doles and this will help in cleansing of politics thereby improving the outcomes.

It is truly said that freedom comes from strength and self-reliance but the breakup of Indian economy where 90% of the workforce is in informal sector and about ¾th of population unskilled, self-reliance would require tackling the problem from grass-root with a multi-faceted approach. It is well known that India is an agrarian economy and still majority of our population lives in villages. It is therefore necessary to diversity the earning from agriculture by skilling farmers in sericulture, apiculture, horticulture, energy generation and conservation, livestock rearing etc. The surplus labour should be utilized effectively in cottage industries and MSMEs for which effective implementation of schemes like stand-up India, Start-Up India, ASPIRE scheme and Make-in-India is required.

Agriculture is a subject in state list and therefore, the state governments while evaluating the ground realities should be effective in implementation. Waiving off farm loans and providing free electricity for irrigation causes more harm than good. These lead to not just wastage of our precious resources but hinder innovation and growth. Furthermore, the majority of semi- skilled and unskilled workers can be trained in government facilities to augment our seriously lacking manpower in education-teachers; health care auxiliary workers; nurses, doctors; tourism industry-guides, cab-drivers; hospitality; delivery of government services – by acting as correspondents, carrying out social audit, direct link between implementing authority and target population.

Advantage of demographic dividend can be effectively utilized in construction and manufacturing sector. National Highways in India are only 4% in length and about 80% of the movement happens on them. Workers can be effectively employed in setting up infrastructure → industrial and agricultural corridors, building of highways and roads, social infrastructure (schools, hospitals, training centres), mandis in villages, they can also be used in restoration works. Finances can be effectively pulled in from government's budget commitments, corporate social responsibility expenditure and if need arises by setting up viability Gap funding mechanisms.

Government should be commented for already taking a step in right direction by introducing schemes and programmes. E-governance initiative of government has simplified the procedures for setting up business through Spice + platform under Ministry of Corporate Affairs, further DBT transfers and linking of bank accounts to Aadhaar have helped in more targeted implementation. Van Dhan Yojana by Ministry of Tribal Affairs under nodal agency TRIFED is a novel step in training tribals in better marketing and price discovery of their products. Furthermore, schemes such as Hunar Haats and Seekho aur Kamao are really innovative and helpful. Formation of self-help groups and encouraging them by providing institutional credit has brought thousands of family out of poverty. Since most of the groups are run by women – their growth has led to a gender balanced and inclusive growth.

Poverty breeds lack of self-reliance. India has been commended all over the world for significantly lowering the poverty and uplifting millions out mere existential living. These steps if implemented in a right direction would be stepping stones to achieve dream of $5 trillion economy and doubling of farmer's income.

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▶QUICK BUT STEADY WINS THE RACE

#PERSEVERANCE #SOCIETY

The 21st century is the age of the internet, driven by **Industrial Revolution 4.0**. In the story of the rabbit and the tortoise, the rabbit, after gaining a considerable lead, proceeds to rest and allows the tortoise to win due to his complacency.

Today, however, life is fast, and people have big ambitions. Those who are in the lead want to extend it, and those who are behind in the race are running faster than ever before. Sky is the limit today, and nobody can afford a moment to take a pause.

The age-old proverb – "Slow and steady wins the race" has been modified for the 21st century – "Quick and steady wins the race".

In this context, let us analyse whether the phrase still holds true for the world today, or has it lost relevance.

Historical Perspective – The Portuguese were the first Europeans to arrive in India. The Dutch and the British took more than a century to arrive after them. Despite having such a vast experience of India, how did the Portuguese lose ground in India?

Similarly, after the second Carnatic War, the French were in firm control of Hyderabad and Arcot. But, within a few years, they lost all the advantages to the Britishers. If we analyse carefully, the British supremacy over their fellow Europeans was due to their quick decision-making abilities. The likes of Robert Clive provided the leadership which the others could not muster.

The importance of swift action and foresightedness can be seen throughout history – from Industrial Revolution till WWII, and later during the Cold War.

It thus becomes important to observe how the contemporary world is the outcome of rapid, but careful, decision-making, and quick implementation.

Contemporary World: Faster than ever before –

During the 1980s, few professors in an academic institution in USA, were working for a project sanctioned by the US military. They gave birth to the **"World Wide Web",** which was later declassified, and the internet was born.

The internet revolution required hardware that people could use to access the vast information on the virtual world. Three men in a garage started a company that built smart hardware solutions. The company was Apple, and it captured the imagination of the time. To run the hardware, many software companies were born which included the likes of Microsoft, Cisco Systems.

Similarly, using all above mentioned technologies, Mark Zuckerberg built Facebook and connected people with each other. It is not difficult to identify the theme. The US raced ahead of the world in terms of technology and maintained and strengthened its position as the world superpower.

Let us look at another case study – China. China's economy was in shatters post failed experiments of the Great Leap Forward and Cultural Revolution initiated by Mao Zedong. Deng Xiaoping introduced several changes in the Communist economy of China. He allowed private ownership of land and industries, modernised agriculture, strengthened defence forces and encouraged science and technology. With consistent policies and quick actions, China became the manufacturing hub of the world within two to three decades. The standard of living improved and the faltering economy became one of the largest in the world.

What do we find common in USA and China? Both these revolutions have taken place in the last 30 years, with results being witnessed within a decade of proper implementation. Long-standing vision, quick decision-making, effective implementation, and adequate support are the key ingredients in their success.

Let us now turn our attention towards India. What have been our achievements and efforts in this regard, and where does India stand in a fast-changing and complex world.

The story of India –

India has seen major progress on many indicators, and especially socio-economic ones, in the last few decades. India is among the fastest growing economies in the world, it has pulled a minimum of 273 million people out of poverty since 2005-2015 as per UNDP and the world is looking at India with a sense of hope and opportunities.

However, India has had its share of struggles.

During the 90s, India faced a major economic crisis. With less than a week's import cover left, India had to accept the conditional support of IMF and change its

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economic structure. In the same decade, India faced political instability and the world blockade led by the US post the Pokhran tests. India also had to fight a war with its hostile neighbour in probably the most challenging terrain of the world. Despite all the hurdles India sailed through the waves of uncertainty.

With the leadership of PM Narsimha Rao and the ambitious vision of Manmohan Singh, Indian economy transformed from being government dictated to being facilitated and enabled by the government.

Indian democracy proved its mettle time and again during the 90s to always being represented by the popular wishes of the public.

India successfully conducted operation SHAKTI under the able leadership of PM A. B. Vajpayee and APJ Abdul Kalam. India also won the war against Pakistan and till date controls the highest battlefield in the world – the Siachen Glacier.

All these incidents and achievements were possible due to visionary leadership and quick action under immense pressure.

However, instead of learning from its recent past, India has somehow managed to lay behind in many arenas – India was extremely late in adopting 4G and seems to be missing the bus in the race for 5G implementation. Similar issues like the late boom of start-up industry in India, the slow decision-making on future of sick PSUs such as BSNL and Air India and the late adoption of Crypto Currency etc. call for attention.

What can be the solution to these challenges? How should India tackle the challenges?

India: Looking forward to sea of opportunities –

Many problems can be associated to slow decision-making capacity of the political and permanent executive due to risk-averse nature and red-tapeism. The 21st century requires a 21st century bureaucracy – an entrepreneurial bureaucracy. It is also important for the political executives to back the officers in driving the change and create a healthy atmosphere for bureaucracy to make a difference.

India has worked on these aspects in the recent years. The most remarkable being the immediate announcement of Chandrayaan – 2 after heart-breaking fate of Chandrayaan – 1. This decision was fully backed by PM Narendra Modi who congratulated ISRO and Chairman K. Sivan and encouraged them for their endeavours.

Similarly, the recent strategic disinvestment policy announced in the Budget 2021-22, growth of IT and services sector in India, the rise of urbanisation from 11% in 1901 to estimated 42% in 2021, introduction of PM Jan Dhan Yojana, UPI, Bharat Net and adoption of the progressive National Education Policy 2020 are signs of positive attitude towards firm and quick policy decision-making.

However, at the same time, it is extremely important to not lose moral values and ethics in the zeal of taking fast decisions and quick implementation.

We have discussed the historical aspect of quick decision-making followed by two recent case studies of US and China. We then moved on to the specific case of India, looking at the challenges and how to tackle the decision-making paralysis.

21st century is often said to be the Asian century dominated by the dragon and the elephant.

While China is on its way to make this a reality, India still has a lot of catching up to do. However, India has shown a lot of courage and determination, especially in the fight against climate change, Covid-19 pandemic where it chose to save lives in the short term and livelihood in the medium term.

The world today recognises the strength of India. With demographic dividend on its side, India will realise the dream of becoming a super-power with quick decision-making and effective implementation.

▶JOY IS THE SIMPLEST FORM OF GRATITUDE

#ETHICS #SOCIETY

A child readily accepts a new toy and expresses her happiness by clapping and laughing. A farmer desperately waiting for rainfall on his parched land, after a few good showers looks up in the sky with tears in his eyes to thank the almighty. A homeless person accepts a blanket on a chilly winter night and expresses his gratitude by folding hands and a thankful smile. Similarly, dog drinks milk served to him and returns the act of kindness by being loyal and protective for the owner. He is happy to feel belonged and being cared for.

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Gratitude is a state of being thankful for what has been bestowed upon us while at the same time being willing to return the act of kindness having given an opportunity to do so. Like in above examples, an individual can be grateful in a hundred ways but the simplest form will be being joyful (happy) about being blessed. It is said that happiness is contagious. A person being in a blissful state of mind is bound to give happiness to others and thereby, the vicious cycle of being grateful can be churned. Mother Teresa, Nelson Mandela, Mahatma Gandhi, Gautam Buddha to name a few were the ones who harness this power of gratitude.

Being grateful for what has been bestowed upon us was reflected very evidently by early human civilizations. People of Indus Valley Civilization, were thankful for the abundance of resources at their disposal and therefore the trend is so evident back then as a form of gratitude. The civilization was peaceful and joyful thereby setting example ever after centuries of their existence about how egalitarian society leads to prosperity and longevity for all. Similarly, Aryans were grateful for having discovered fertile pastures after coming from Central Asia, so were Babur and Akbar in India – a land of diversity, love and kindness. Even Buddhism has its teaching reflecting the joy in acceptance when it says a person should practice 'Mudita' (joy over others success); 'Upeksha' (mind at peace); Karuna (Compassion). Gautam Buddha always taught his disciples to happily accept what is being given to them.

But as our society progressed, simple things were replaced by complex things, man grew to be greedier than his need. The definition of joy changed drastically and humans became ungrateful for most of the things. Today, everyone is competing for power be it inside a country or around the world. Politicians inside the country are often happy only after amassing wealth and having great power at their dispersal; paying least regard to the toppling social order inside the country. The great geo-political game running in the world and the race to become a super-power by eliminating and threatening others is now giving joy to the world leaders. Unmindful exploitation of resources specially natural resources for economic gains without being grateful in the first place for having them is pushing the entire universe to extinction.

The society that we live in today has more jealousy than joy. The millennium generation getting the advantage of internet are now searching their happiness by measuring the number of likes on a particular post on major social media platforms. Similarly, an entrepreneur today is not happy by influencing a number of lives or by giving hope to the budding talents that dreams can be achieved instead she runs behind the profits and materialistic gains on the balance sheet. This negative competition and the feeling of finding joy only after pushing the other down is being ingrained in the society for too long. No wonder, our colleges produce mere machines than thinking individuals because they have been never appreciated for their uniqueness but instead have been exposed to comparisons. Nobody is given a moment to pause and introspect how far they have come and to express gratitude for the journey that made them today.

Such toxic environment where individuals are perpetually unsatisfied breads unhappiness and leads to mental health problems. Leaders of such country which are themselves product of this environment turn to extremist methods and often their nationalism does more harm than good. In such a society inequality leads to deterioration of status of women increasing crimes and domestic abuse. Such a country can never progress in this world for they have forgotten to distinguish between how much is too much.

However, it is not at all difficult to inculcate these fundamental emotions to help citizens of a country to be grateful for what they have. The leaders of the country should take the first step in this direction by indulging in less power games and working towards making society more just. Sustainable development goals can be made more applicable here. **Goal 4** – Quality education by teaching students about how small things are those that really matter. Japanese school inculcate value of cleanliness right from the beginning in students. Japanese citizens who went to watch football match stunned the entire world when they cleaned the stands after match. The players did the same when they left their dressing room and accommodation while at the same time leaving a note

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that they were grateful for the hospitality. In India, Delhi schools are running happiness curriculum to help children find peace and joy and realize that they have been blessed. **Goal 16** – Peace, Justice and Strong Institutions can have far reaching effects on humanity. As they would provide the basic framework for functioning. **Goal 12** – Responsible production and consumption would help us limit our greed.

We the people of India should be grateful for the preamble that is as given to us by our forefathers. The least we can do is to understand the intricate balance between Justice, Liberty, Equality and Fraternity to bring about unity and live peacefully in this nation. Lastly, we should not forget being happy to be part of World's largest democracy and the most vibrant too.

▶THE TEST OF TOLERANCE COMES WHEN WE ARE IN MAJORITY; THE TEST OF COURAGE COMES WHEN WE ARE IN A MINORITY.

#PHILOSOPHICAL

When in the majority, we often tend to take decisions which serve our interests but may prove to be detrimental to the interest of others. 'Tolerance' doesn't imply abandoning our thought process; it means making room for others' freedom of expression. As Voltaire rightly said, 'I disapprove of what you say but I will defend to the death your right to say it'.

On the other hand, according to Plato's cardinal virtues, courage refers to the ability to do justice. When in minority, we fear the outcomes and the repercussions that follow the actions.

The test of tolerance and courage stand on the premises of impartiality and integrity respectively. The group conformity effect is a challenge to both tests. When we are in majority – be it power or strength in numbers, we are inclined to use our powerful position to exploit situations to our advantage. E.g., when bills are passed through voice votes by the Parliament, without taking into consideration the views of the minority. It is perceived that the ruling party was intolerant of the views of others. Similarly, the test of courage calls for commitment towards intellectual integrity.

Minorities are easier to oppress by the majority members. People tend to conform to the demands of the latter and forego their thoughts. For instance, IES officer Satyendra Dubey relentlessly raised his voice against the corruption collusion in the Golden Quadrilateral project. Despite being one of the very few persons to protest against the wrong, no number of threats could deter him from his goal.

On turning the pages of history, we see the remarkable example of the Mughal ruler – Akbar. His values of religious tolerance are relevant to date. He abolished the pilgrimage tax of Hindus and the Jizya tax. He believed that such taxation demeaned the stature of other religions. His principle of 'Sulah-i-Kul', harmonious relationships among all, upheld the values of tolerance and fraternity. Although he had all the powers, he stood the test of tolerance with grace and dignity.

Further, the beginning of the Indian freedom struggle reminds us about the test of courage when we stand in minority. The awareness among the masses about British exploitation was brought in by the few educated Indians. They showed courage to speak against oppressive colonial rule through the press and pamphlets. Defying their rule, the fighters did not beg down under the pressure.

Similarly, the social reformers stood firm on their ground to reverse the historical evils prevailing in society. Raja Rammohun Roy was the only one to revolt against the exploitation of women under the garb of the 'Sati' system. Despite being alone, the protests by the orthodox Brahmanical society could not stop him from repealing the law. The passing of such a test of courage proves our loyalty towards our constitution.

Now, if we look into the political dimension, we see many cases of intolerance that have cropped up in yester years. The misuse of section 124A of the Indian Penal Code to gag the voices of protest by a section of politicians has raised concern nationwide. Moreover, states like Tamil Nādu and West Bengal are facing a tussle between the Governor and the Chief Minister. Parochialism in the outlook is raising questions on the sustainability of cooperative federalism.

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Furthermore, in the sphere of international relations, India has shown the courage to stand apart even when no major power supported her. During the cold war era, India along with Egypt, Indonesia, Ghana and Yugoslavia formed the Non-aligned Movement, declaring its independent stand from any power bloc. Its principles remained intact irrespective of any international pressure.

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On a different note, when we glance through our society, we see declining tolerance for women. This has become evident through the increasing number of serious crimes against women, unequal work pays, refusal to grant maternity leaves, etc. Patriarchy is strengthening its roots in the form of selective sex abortion, domestic violence and so on. At this juncture, the test of tolerance is required on the part of men so that women get equal access to benefits. Women require to excel in the test of courage. So that they can use the law and get justice through constitutional means.

However, such prejudice and stereotypes are not restricted to women alone. With the abrogation of section 377 in the Navtej Singh Johar case, the rights of the LGBT community have come to light. The narrow outlook towards this community has been conclusively proven by the rampant discrimination against them. To establish an inclusive society, we need to be more tolerant and cooperative towards such minority and vulnerable sections of our society.

Moreover, the ruthless use of the environment has posed a challenge to the sustenance of humanity. Human beings have outnumbered the rest of living beings and are dominating the globe with technology and the exploitation of resources. Our rising intolerant attitude towards our ecosystem has increased the intensity of disaster and augmented the process of climate change.

Thus, from the above, we can say that an amicable attitude is required to stand true to the tests of courage and tolerance. Such values need to be inculcated through value education in schools and colleges. We should have an empathetic attitude towards the minority section and honesty to speak against the injustice caused by people in the majority. This will help us to reach our targets of inclusivity and collective growth.

►WHEN THE WINDS OF CHANGE BLOW, SOME PEOPLE BUILD WALLS, WHILE OTHERS BUILD WINDMILLS

PHILOSOPHICAL

In a left-wing extremism-affected backward district of Chhattisgarh, two officers namely, Raj and Aman, were on an emergency deputation for stopping protests and strikes of local villagers against the state government for acquiring tribal land for a proposed road project.

Raj in his village took coercive measures & deployed local police & instructed them to take punitive actions against any indiscipline. On the other hand, Aman calmly analysed the situation and persuaded the locals that the proposed project will provide various benefits like job opportunities, better health & education facilities and transportation will improve.

Aman's persuasion completely changed the narrative and outlook of locals & they pro-actively helped the workers in the construction of the road project. While in the former case, the protest turned violent. Thus, the above story highlights that walls are not always the best solution, rather using one's emotional intelligence & realizing the demand of the situation leads to a rational decision which is beneficial for the larger good of society.

Change always brings a new direction to society; however, it depends on oneself whether to adopt

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oneself to make it work in one's favour or stand against and deny change which may turn out to be adverse. This is evident from the following:

The advent of Aryans brought a new dynamism to Indian society (iron age). However, gradually orthodoxy crept in & later discriminatory tendencies started developing in society. The Caste system became rigid and exploitative. Reactionary forces began to rise against Brahmanical orthodoxy and caste system. However, it was only under Buddha & Mahavira that considerable success could be won against the caste system. Both did not fight any wars but tried to educate and enlighten society. Rather than listing the demerits of the caste system, they focused on developing a new ethic with its roots in reason, logic & prayers rather than rituals, sacrifices and superiority of birth.

Teachings of Buddha & Mahavira were wheels to society which drove everyone on the path of salvation. Buddha's idea of the Middle Path or Ashtanga Marg still holds its importance in promoting social equality and cohesive bonding in society.

During the Indian freedom struggle, the Britishers imposed various irrational and exploitative policies. They racially discriminated against Indians which led to the birth of Indian opposition in the form of revolutionaries & Gandhian ideology. Revolutionaries employed violence & coercive struggle against the British. They believed in the philosophy of the bomb. For example, Bhagat Singh bombed the Central Assembly in opposition to certain legislations being pushed over Indians, however, the Britishers easily suppressed them.

On the other hand, Gandhiji brought a revolution in society and widened the social base of national movements. Gandhiji's call for Non-Cooperation Movement, Civil Disobedience Movement and Quit India Movement was supported by everyone including women, tribals and other marginalised communities. Gandhi's emphasis on Satyagraha (Struggle for Truth) put the Britishers in dilemma regarding a method to counter it.

The references from great personalities highlight that though walls or rigid action may bring a short-term benefit, it is only by regulating one's thoughts and efforts to make the best of any situation that leads to the most optimal outcome.

Even in modern times, several instances indicate that adaptive transformation yields a beneficial result if one realizes its true potential. The story of LPG Reforms pursued by India in 1991 is one such story of courage. India's 1991 LPG reforms were a watershed in India's history which completely upended India's economic setup. The ideals of privatisation, liberalization & globalization gave a push and new energy to India's entrepreneurial class whose energies were unshackled from the rigid regulations. Utilizing this opportunity, people from rural areas started migrating to urban areas to get jobs & women entered agricultural fields (feminisation of agriculture) which played a significant role in women's empowerment. Those who opposed it failed to reap its benefits.

Even during the COVID-19 pandemic, the need to tap into opportunity during the crisis was evident. The pandemic shut down transportation networks, people were stuck in their homes, economic activity plunged due to lockdowns and a severe depression hit most of the world. However, India launched the Atma-nirbhar Bharat Mission which not only promoted indigenous industries but also reduced the current account deficit & India emerged as a global hub of skilled manpower which in turn contributed to India's growth & GDP.

Willingness to adapt and adopt innovative technologies emerged as a booster for India's sustenance. India used open-source platforms to develop apps for contact tracing, and vaccine rollout (COWIN), and zoom was used for conducting meetings and keeping education going. The psychological barrier that technology is not reliable was broken for good. Today, google pay, e-commerce purchasing, e-governance etc have made service delivery efficient & quicker.

But can we say that evolution & change always leads to a fruitful result? Should it never be opposed? Modern technologies such as internal combustion engines and urbanization have markedly improved the quality of life of humans. But at the same time, these technologies and their production systems have led to a marked increase in greenhouse gas emissions to the point that climate change is threatening the entire existence of life on Earth as we know it. International agencies like UNFCCC, UNCBD, UNEP etc. have been advocating for rapid decarbonisation of economic activity and the pursuit of sustainable production and livelihood based on renewable energy.

Also, forces of globalization, westernization or modernization have increased disparities in society between the haves and have-nots and between rural

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and urban areas. Increasing inequality, as highlighted by a recent OXFAM report, is not good for society at large. (According to the Oxfam report, the top 10% of India's people hold 80% of the wealth, so opposition by them against these changes is natural & justifiable. Modern Technologies such as AI, ML, Internet of things, robotics and supercomputers have been increasing unemployment, particularly for the most vulnerable. Technology has given birth to the atomic bomb, the bombing of Hiroshima and Nagasaki being surely the most horrific incident in human history.

All the above examples suggest that change brings hope, light, innovation, and excitement and opens the door to new possibilities. But there exist some people who will be alienated from these benefits, so the question arises what should be done?

Change is the law of nature; nothing remains stagnant, according to Charles Darwin, natural relation & evolution is a universal rule which cannot be violated, so the mitigation lies in expanding the advantages of change to every man, species & environment & biodiversity.

According to Plato, "we must live like cells of an organism where the health of one affects the health of all" i.e., inter-dependence & socialization are inherent in everyone's character so an effort should be made towards inclusive & cooperative growth, the seeds of which benefit everyone.

Also, efforts should be made to inculcate values of reasoning, emotional intelligence, cognition and most importantly following the Ashtanga Marg of Buddha that helps to change even the most adverse & worst situation in one's favour & develop a sense of interconnectedness with others to cherish the chare of benefit with the humanity at large.

►CUSTOMARY MORALITY CANNOT BE A GUIDE TO MODERN LIFE

#MORALITY #SOCIETY

The concept of life has always intrigued humans. Even the Rig Veda, considered to be one of the first books written in the **Nasadiya Sukta**. The Nasadiya Sukta is the first section of Rigveda, and contains nothing but questions – questions about the origin of life. The meaning of life, the creator, the purpose of life etc. In the ancient Greek City States, great thinkers like Socrates. Plato and Aristotle also tried to delve upon what constitutes a good life, and how life should be conducted. Subsequently many philosophers also tried to answer these existential questions about life.

Initially, before the advent of civilisation, human lived in small groups called tribal societies. Gradually with newer discoveries and intentions, humans began setting down in larger societies. There were always a quest for a stable life for humans. This quest, in past, gave birth to religion and customs. They consisted of rules, doctrines and regulations to organize the social order in a particular manner. So as to make life more predictable, orderly and productive. Religion and customs had the concept of morality in them. Morality of a society distinguishes the good from the bad, the right from the wrong and the divine from the evil. Each society developed its own set of customary morals and organised their society accordingly. For example, it was the **Dharamshastra** and **Manusmriti** for India in the 5th-6th century A.D. the **Sharia law** in the Islamic World (8th century AD onwards) and the **law of the Bible** for the Christian World in the Middle Ages.

However, with the passage of time, these customary laws got entrenched and petrified, and failed to evolve with changing circumstances. Many regressive practices took root in these customs, and got the sanctity of religion. For example, it was considered morally right, to practise untouchability, Sati, female infanticide, etc. in Hindu law; to practise stone pelting and chopping off heads of thieves in Sharia law and putting to death anyone who questioned the authority of the Church in Christian Law. There was no scope for humanism and reasoning. Those in positions of power dictated morality as per their convenience to maintain the status quo. The result was immense social inequalities, political instability and a regressive decaying society, especially during the **Dark Age in Europe (500-1200 A.D.)**

A break in this time with the advent of a phenomenon, known as renaissance. It was sort of a rebirth of rationality and reasoning, which was the feature of the Roman & Greek society in the pre-Christian era. Renaissance was speech headed by scientists and thinkers like Machiavelli, Galileo, Newton etc. This was the advent of Modernity. Modernity is characterised by the spirit of humanism and individual liberty. Individual is considered to be an end in itself. Modernity favours rational thinking, and a scientific approach towards solving problem. It advocated separation of the Church from the state, thus

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confining religion to the private sphere of an individual. With the growth of intentional trade, colonialism and imperialism, these modern ideas gradually proliferated to different parts of the world, including India. In India, great thinkers like Raja Ram Mohan Roy. Rabindranath Tagore, B. R. Ambedkar, Jawahar Lal Nehru etc. were flag bearers of modern thought.

However, the spread of modern thought and ideas was not without backlash from conservations, who favoured traditions and customary morality to modern, rational thinking. This clash is evident and very much visible in our societies even today in multiple spheres, be it social, political, economic or even intentional.

It is the **social sphere** where the clash between customary morality and modern rationality is most evident. For example, in India, conservatives, consider practices of untouchability, caste disability, female infanticide, Sati, Patriarchy, and many more regressive practices to be morally justified, as it is sanctioned by customary law. However, there is no doubt today that these practises are irrational, regressive, inhuman, degenerate and against individual liberty. This is also vindicated by the Indian Constitution through Right to equality, Article 21 (Right to life), Article 17 (Against untouchability), etc. The Indian constitution even advocates discrimination and use of affirmative action, to undo the historical injustice inflicted upon certain sections of the society due to the so called "customary morality", and also to enforce the modern ideal of substantive equality.

In the **political sphere**, use of customary morality is the agenda of the ultra-conservatives and the ultra-right wing. Nazism and Fascism are examples of political ideologies that were based on customary morality and false cultural Chauvinism. These ideas took such a toxic form and culminated in heinous, cruel, inhuman and unthinkable acts which led to the holocaust. Even today, these ideas present themselves in some form or the others, and are a great threat to the modern ideas of equality, liberty and fraternity which have been achieved after a long period of struggle. In the Indian context, our constitution and polity provide for various safeguards against the subversion of democracy, and also gives many rights and protections to minorities to safeguard their interests.

If we were to follow customary morality, in the economic sphere, then Vasco de Gama couldn't have crossed to oceans to come to India, or Indians like M.K. Gandhi, B. R. Ambedkar, etc. couldn't have gone to England to acquire Western Education. This is because both in Christian and Hindu law, it was forbidden to cross the sea. Such as irrational notion goes against individual freedom and does not foster the spirit of adventure, enterprise and curiosity. Another example could be the clash between the Catholics and the Protestants, where the latter considered work to be worship, and were instrumental in the growth of capitalism. Hence, if it were not for the modern thoughts of innovation and spirit of adventure. The human race could not have progressed economically and there would have been no industrial revolution.

Customary morality cannot be a guide to international relations and foreign policy either. The international order, post WWII, was guided by the spirit of humanism and rationality, with emphasis on the need to report human rights, the will of the people and progressive notions of liberty, equality and fraternity. The birth of the United Nations Organisation is testimony to this. Whenever regressive customary morality has taken primacy, it has only led to chaos and death intentionally. The best example of this is the growth of Fundamentalism internationally. The only thing that this ideology has achieved is the loss of millions of innocent lives in different parts of the world. On the other hand, it is the modern democratic countries based on ideas of humanism and empathy that come forward to offer humanitarian assistance in face of disasters, both natural and man-made.

A well-known phrase goes – **"The only thing permanent in this world is change."** It is a very apt saying, when seen in light of the clash between customary ideas and modern ones. All customary and traditional ideas are not bad or regressive. Rather it is on the foundation of them that we build on new ideas. However, what becomes important is to examine if the morality of the post holds any significance in the modern period, or serve any purpose at all. If not, it is very imperative that they are reformed to suit the times. Evolution is the fundamental law of nature, and it holds well in the spheres of morality as well. Therefore, if we are to take the human race forward, then customary morality cannot be our guide in that journey towards on evolving social consciousness.

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►LESSONS LEARNT FROM HISTORY MAKE OUR PRESENT AND FUTURE SAFE

#HISTORY #ETHICS

History is the key to our present and those who can't learn from the history can never progress. As it's said that **'History repeats itself'**, but the outcome can always be moulded by the teachings of the history. Thus a bright present can enlighten the future to make it safe for the mankind. Humans are the social civilized animals with the ability of processing thoughts. What different would be if we couldn't use our gifts?

As old as the humanity goes, there has been evolution in every field that has touched us. History is the package of time that has wrapped in it many aspects of life that guide the evolution of species.

In the realm of society, Indus valley civilization can be taken as the best example: -Where the town planning, trade, division of society into lower and upper town yet all equal in residence, the belief in life after death had evolved from the scattered lifestyle of a hunter-gatherer and led to kingdoms to flourish. Presently the sectoral town planning, like of Chandigarh, can be seen. Futuristic perspective lies in the building of smart cities which will have all the facilities.

Culture has evolved as an integral part of the society. Dance, music, arts were once the means of connecting to one's supernatural powers evolved and now has become the identity of the traditions. Vedas were not rigid in the beginning, but had some relevance for that time, while some had scientific backing. Understanding the value, as of Yoga has led to a better life, with the classical arts that has been demanding utmost concentration and fitness in the growing pollution and changing lifestyle, has become a style statement and the professional way to earn a livelihood.

Historically, the civilization that lived in sync with their environment has flourished for long. The tribes like Sentinalese of the Nicobar Islands are the second last untouched yet an old tribe, who have worshipped the nature such that the small island is their complete world. The idea of worshipping nature Gods like Agni, Vayu, rendering Dharti as Mata are all the symbols how important the environment is. With recent unplanned sprawl of industrialization, it is high time to protect the environment; else it won't take a long time to perish. It is the environment as a whole which has and will continue to provide for the food, clothing, housing, energy and means for livelihood. This is the basis behind the sustainable development Goals, so as to make the future safe.

The **World War I led to formation of the League of Nations, the failure of which has been the founding strength behind the United Nation Organisation**, the regional cooperation summits and inter-country MoUs so as to maintain peace and harmony for the future. Thus, evolution of relation has come a long but hard way.

The economy is an offshoot of the political system. From the oppressive monarchy to autocracy to imperialism it has led to the freedom struggles throughout the world to establish democracy. E.g. India, where first the barter system led to coin currency, the token currency replaced it to be maintained against a common standard (US. $), this has made a global village of opportunities. The various systems like communism, socialism and capitalism have also led to a welfare approach for some. The best combination can only led to a safe future.

Science and Technology has been saving mankind from perils. From inventing fire, wheels, clothing, sustainable energy, housing machinery for all the work, it has been impacting our lives since the beginning. The medicine system has been impacted where the age old traditions of Unani, Ayurveda and Homeopathy, and folk treatments have been treating the incurables for the modern medical science. The Charak Samhita has described such advanced surgical methods. What was fiction for the time are now becoming the reality to improve the lifestyle and living standards.

Thus, it is not wrong to say that history holds the answers to all our questions for countries to come. It has been adapting and evolving, while some aspects have gone missing in the due course of time. It is for the benefit of the generations to filter out the root causes of disharmony like the caste system and the blind religious beliefs, towards an advanced society in making.

►EDUCATION WITHOUT MORALS IS LIKE A SHIP WITHOUT A COMPASS, MERELY WANDERING NOWHERE

PHILOSOPHICAL

The East India Company, in its time, had one of the most educated workforces. However, collectively they inflicted multiple harms on people, worldwide, and

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especially India. Indians were treated as second class citizens, suffered multiple famines that led to death in billions and gave India a legacy of corruption. Only because they lacked morality.

It is necessary to impart intellect and energy to make a productive human being. Thus, education has become a perquisite for quality of any person's life. However, how that education is used is also an important avenue for discussion.

Morals are values that guide an entity in deciding right or wrong. It is essentially a compass for individuals that direct them towards an ethically correct choice. Without them, a person, a society, organisation of nation might make choices which are neither utilitarian nor beneficial in long run.

Warren Buffet has said 'three important factors for selecting a person are intellect, energy and integrity, but if he lacks the third despite having the first two, reject him'. It highlights the importance of education with morality.

In recent times, education has advanced technology, reachability and influence to such an extent, that it could be both optimised and mis-utilized. Through this essay, let's explore how education without morality is a ship without compass how it can be used to provide direction towards a positive path.

Education provides a person with skillsets could be utilized to improve their standard of living, improved understanding of the world and themselves and opportunity to improve their self-esteem. However, if such skillsets are used only to live life as it goes, without any goal; it is a wasted potential.

Many highly educated individuals in India prepare for government exam, with single purpose of status and income. They have flexible moral compass where the inevitability of corruption has been internalised. As a result, they focus on self-promotion as public servant rather than serving public. Here they lack direction of utilizing their potential for their duty of public service.

Also, a ship without a compass leads to wrong path in majority of cases. Similarly, education without morals lead people towards wrong direction.

Nowadays, there are technologically apt individuals who could obtain job for minimal amount say, Rs 20000 to 30000 and live honest lives. But few of them use their skills to commit fraud and dupe naive people who lose their hard earned income. Such people are educated but they lack empathy and integrity and cause degradation of society.

Educated people are highly respected in the society. People look upto them, seek their advice and follow them as role models. However, just like a ship without a compass can make other ships lose their way, educated people without morality can misguide others.

Continuing previous causes, a highly influential corrupt officer gives a message to society that only people with low moral fabric achieve success in governance. A scamster earning double than an honest worker can misguide her to resort to frauds to become richer sooner. In term, it leads to a society where people low moral fabric, evils in society against vulnerable sections are frequent and total social chaos is expected.

Further, how long a ship without compass will go on wandering. Someday it will have to dock, else it will sink with extinguished supplies. Similarly an educated person without morals may dupe and fulfil their self-interest but only till their misdeeds sink them finally.

Harshad Mehta, an influential name in financial markets had made big money and fame. However, his malpractice finally caught upto him and he was convicted for frauds worth crore of rupees. Similarly, Satyam's creative accounting was caught and its executives were punished.

However, sometimes education without morality also has direction, but the direction is the one causing havoc and disaster. It is not about individuals who have lost their direction and resorted to misdoing.

But it is about use of education in direction that suits their morality.

Adolf Hitler was one of the most intelligent people of his time, with ability to influence the public with his speeches. He used it to create feeling of distrust against Jesus and implemented one of the largest and most heart wrenching genocide in the history of the world, only because of his own prejudice United States of America dropped two atomic bombs in Japan with justification to stop the war. Here education was used to destroy the generations of an enemy country and justified on moral grounds. However, use of such weapons to destroy any life is against any kind of morality.

Thus, education is important but it should be guided in the right direction. Only then it will be most fruitful to the individual, society and nation, in addition to world as a whole. Rabindranath Tagore had said 'The highest form of education is not which gives us most

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information, but which teaches us to live in harmony with all forms of lives.

Thus, moral education should become a serious part of the curriculum. Unfortunately it is not given due importance is education of children as compared to other subjects. In addition to theoretical explanation, there is need to encourage practical morality in children. Here, they are appreciated for practicing honesty, integrity and empathy at personal level.

Practical morality since childhood would serve as compass in day to decision of such adults and even influence their next generation. It can also encouraged through role plays, role models and case studies to make children aware of real life situations where morals can be compromised and how to resolve such situation.

Many institution mention code of ethics, but still resort to embezzlement and corruption. Thus, initiatives to transform code of ethics from mere lip service to organisational culture is important.

Along with job-oriented aptitude, moral aptitude of a person should also be analysed. Induction trainings should involve morality and related group activities that are engaging and participative. Involvement in ethical activities should not be seen as a compulsion but interests and participation should be with entitlement and interest.

Lastly, Chanakya had said poverty leads to corruption and rebellion, thus state should provide enough food and income to people. Productive employment is sine qua non for educated youth of today's time underemployment. Unemployment and disguised unemployment cause people to become desperate and hopeless and they lose their moral compass.

In such case, government should provide assistance to people by providing income support and support to search opportunities. Their skillsets should be aligned with market and new job opportunities should be created.

Thus, morality of the people needs to preserved, nurtured and developed so that their education can be used in avenues of research, social development, economic growth and environmental conservation. It will help in development of humanity and world as a whole.

►INTROSPECTION AND PERSEVERANCE IN HARD WORK ARE KEYS TO SUCCESS

#PHILOSOPHICAL

Dr. APJ Abdul Kalam was rightly said the people's president. He used to participate in events and communicate with people in general and youngsters in particular. In one such event in Chennai, a small boy asked him in 2002 that how can India become great again, as it used to be in the past? Dr. APJ Abdul Kalam replied that it is the people like you, with ignited minds, who will make the nation great.

Another student asked as to what we should do to make the nation great. Dr. Kalam gave the four-point formula – First, there should be a great vision. Second, you should continuously acquire knowledge. Third, you should work hard. Fourth, you should display perseverance. This is the mantra of success, he said.

In this essay, we will try to understand the message of Dr. Kalam, how introspection and perseverance can lead to success. After that, we will apply these abstract ideas to demonstrate the present situation and ultimately how we can make the nation great again.

Introspection and Perseverance: A civilizational idea

Introspection refers to be aware of oneself. It means evaluating oneself and assessing our actions. At the same time, perseverance is our ability to display persistence and handle setbacks.

Since ancient times, India was a land of great scholars and rishis. They became great not because of some supernatural boon but by constant introspection and perseverance in hard work.

A case in point can be Gautama Buddha. He had a thoughtful mind since childhood. He left home at the age of 29 and spent the next seven years introspecting and finding the truth. He got many setbacks in the process, but he displayed great perseverance and, at the age of 36, attained success by getting enlightenment.

Similar to Gautam Buddha, Ashoka, in the war of Kalinga, introspected that it is wrong to kill so many people for territorial conquest. After the war, he adopted the policy of Dhamma and spread his message by using stone pillars. Despite the enormous moral baggage of the past, he continued to do hard work, which ultimately led to an informed citizenry and good governance (a success for any king).

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Moreover, the practice of meditation and the rich text of Aranyaka (books written in the forest) is a clear indication of the importance of constant introspection in living a happy life.

The power of perseverance can be seen in the recurrent incursions and large-scale loot by Turkish invaders. In 1000-1025 A. D., Mahmud of Ghazni invaded India 17 times. Temples were destroyed, treasuries looted, and villages burnt. It was a testing time for India. In 1033 A. D. Sohail Deopasi, a ruler of Bharuch in Central UP defeated a large army led by a nephew of Mahmud. This sent a clear message that India is not weak and can respond. Interestingly, no foreign invasion happened after the battle of Bharuch, and there was a period of peace for the next 150 years.

Introspection and Perseverance – Success stories in Recent times

After getting Independence in 1947 from colonial rule, we have started our collective journey to make the nation great again.

At the time of Independence, India was a developing country characterized by shortages of food, medicine, and other essential things. Five-year Plans gave the vision and committed leadership, along with the people of India, have worked hard despite so many obstacles.

Constant introspection of our weaknesses led to GREEN REVOLUTION, which made India self-sufficient in terms of food grains. Similarly, we have achieved great strides in nuclear technology, space science, and other sectors. This was possible only because we were determined to do hard work despite the constraints of resources.

Building on this tradition, the government of India has brought several economic reforms like GST, IBC, RERA, Jam trinity, MPC, etc. These reforms are a step in the direction of India becoming a $5 trillion economy. These reforms would not have been possible if it were not for proper introspection and perseverance. Inefficient fund delivery led to the introduction of JAM. Shortcomings in SARFAESI Act led to the introduction of IBC etc.

The government of India is working hard to build upon these reforms and amending them wherever required constantly.

After understanding the role of introspection and perseverance in hard work, let us now look into some of the renewed challenges faced by our nation.

Renewed Challenges – Need for Introspection and Hard wok

India needs to enhance its discussions on critical topics if we want to become a great nation. Today majority of our people are young. How to use these people as a demographic dividend by proper skilling and investment in health care? We should work hard on there reforms as there is a limited window of opportunity.

India is a water-scarce nation. This water crisis is going to be aggravated in the coming years. How can we shift to less water-consuming lifestyles? What policies should the government adopt? Can we learn from other similarly situated nations? These are the key questions that need to be introspected.

It is rightly said that success often requires breaking our habits. We need to move from this business as usual attitude. We cannot continue to waste food when there are so many hungry people in our country.

Thus, after acknowledging that many issues need to be resolved, a start can be made by setting up and bringing sensible reforms in our institutions like Election Commission, Judiciary, and Parliament. Strong institutions are not only drivers of economic growth but also protectors of democracy.

We need constant introspection in every field and learn from others. E.g., we should introspect why we cannot attract businesses that are moving out of China, why we are importing 80% of our toys from China, despite so much potential. Similarly, we should learn from Singapore, which has become a great transshipment hub just under 30 years of Independence.

No doubt, we have great potential and a rich heritage. If properly utilized, we can dominate the world landscape. Coherent vision has been set up in the form of New India and Aatmanirbhara Bharat. Now we should build upon this and follow the mantra of success given by our people's president. We should become the ignited minds and fulfill the trust that has been put upon us by Dr. APJ Abdul Kalam by making the nation great again within our lifetime.

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2 THEME DIVERSE TOPICS

ABOUT THE THEME:

UPSC tends to asks topics which are philosophical and ethical. Besides these, it also asks mix nature of topics belonging to different themes like issues of Environment, International relations, Science and Technology, Security etc. Considering the above, the topics in this section have been incorporated to highlight contemporary issues which can be helpful in answering diverse nature of topics.

►WHAT GETS MEASURED, GETS MANAGED

MISCELLANEOUS

There are no problems and only solutions if it solutions are arrived after taking into considerations all the consequences of that solution. This is only possible when the solution is not an outcome of forced situation.

It was afternoon time on Saturday, suddenly our doorbell rang, Nisha went to open the door and found few people were standing outside with pen and papers in hand. They came to collect household and population data under Census exercise conducted every ten years by government. Nisha was still in her childhood, asked her father about the details collected by team. She was curious of why team is so dedicated to collect data in this hot summer. Her father explained her that it is a pre-requisite to manage the affairs of government that it should collect population details from time to time.

Her father further explained her about how data collection helps in resource management in different fields of public policy like education, health, social welfare, security, disaster management etc. Nisha became more curious to know about different ways of measuring things, what if we do not measure? She further questioned can we still manage without measurement? In upcoming paragraphs will discuss about importance and methods of measurement and importance of measurement for effective management.

Management can be understood as science of judicious use of available resources be it material or human. Management improves the efficiency of system. In today's life management is taught in business schools where management of smallest to biggest things (time to human resource management) is given importance.

Measurement is pre-requisite to management. Without availability of data of resources management will not be effective. For only, when we know what we have at our hand, what is the demand on those resources can be build effective solutions that meet aspirations.

With emergence of information technology revolution, measurement has become comparatively easier task by use of computer, internet of things, internet and there is reduction in time taken to measure details. For example, census 2021 will be conducted by electronic devices which will help in collecting data easily. The era of pen and paper is about to go and tablet and computers has taken place to share and collect data. Thus, there is immense focus on information collection or measurement.

Kautilya, principal mind behind the well-functioning Mauryan State in Ancient India, has mentioned about measurement of enemy and kings own power before indulging into war in his magnum opus 'Arthasastra'. The quest for measurement has driven the development of an entire discipline of mathematics.

Let's discuss how measurement helps in management in different arenas.

In the field of social welfare, government collects details of people living below poverty, their economic status, which helps government to rationalise schemes for a particular section of people. It helps in reducing financial burden on government. Example PM-Jan Dhan Yojana, food security act 2013, MGNREGs etc.

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In the field of environment management, there are efforts on both domestic and international levels to measure and respond to climate crisis. At international level, efforts by bodies like IPCC (Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change), UNEP, WMO, UNCLOS etc. has mapped devastating impacts of industrialisation and climate change. IPCC reports on climate change which raised concern of global warming had put countries under pressure to go for 'net-zero goals'.

At domestic level, National Green Tribunal, NGOs and Environment Ministry are working together to manage the negative impacts of environment pollution and environment degradation by collecting data from time to time. The rising consciousness about water security is because of mapping of water resources and underground water.

In legal affairs, data of criminal cases, civil case, disputes among states guide our society to manage the civil affairs. It is the measurement of rising land disputes that led government to launch schemes like SVAMITRA which proposes to use of drones in mapping land, use of computers in land records management is modern way of land management.

Data collection helps in mapping the topography and atmosphere of the country. Different disasters can be predicted by modern technology e.g., super computers predict weather & cyclones. It is by use of seismograph we can calculate earthquake impact and by long time evaluation, it has been helpful in managing the impact of earthquakes. By use of satellites, we can manage the prediction of wildfires, cyclones, draught, floods which helps in large resource management be if human of physical. For example, we can predict the onset, path of cyclones in Bay of Bengal & Arabian Sea. Prediction of monsoon has been easy because of data collection by Indian Metrological Department.

In the sphere of international relations, reports of SIPRI institute which tracks nuclear stocks of major powers helps in managing the nuclear warfare around globe. It became easy to measure power of enemy states by measuring his economical, army, naval powers. Satellites data has been used to spy on foreign nations to secure national interest United Nations & World Food Program has used data measurement to fight global poverty and were somewhat successful in managing global poverty. Example – World Food Program in poor African nations and Afghanistan.

Data measurement has helped in securing national security e.g., NCRB holds data of criminals and terrorist, national data grid etc. Important data on drug trades, money laundering, fake currency notes, human trafficking helps in managing security of country in better way.

After the end of Second World War and emergence of new nation has led to immense growth on data collection of political systems in these countries. By studying these data sets, we could predict the electoral behaviours. We see how data is used in predicting election results before result e.g., Exit Polls, as we have discussed the importance of data collection, can we imagine our self in a situation where there is no measurement has ever taken place?

Imagine if we do not have data of our population, crimes, schools, national bodies, weather system, and judicial system? What if at the end of semester, a higher education institute denies students certificate on behalf of no data on attendance? The whole society will be in chaos. We can relate the idea of justice with measurement. Justice is essential for happiness and satisfied life. Human body itself a great source for data. What if we forget, what we have done yesterday? Our life be a nightmare. What will happen, if we fail to recognise our near ones because of lack of data in our brain? What will happen if our watches stop today and suddenly, we forget the day, year and era?

Everything mentioned above is possible if we stop measuring data and information. It will be near impossible to manage without data. It will be a situation of 'no light at the end of tunnel'. There will be no future because the idea of future depends on past and present. If we do not measure past and present, how we could have a better future? Everything is relatable in this universe.

Let's take example of COVID-19 pandemic. During the pandemic, total number of infections, and R number which indicated the rate of increase of infections were widely tracked. Was it possible to vaccinate if we did not have predicted the number of vaccines required? It is because of all the measurement of past and present and efficient data systems that we could achieve the vaccination of 135 crore people.

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However, there are abstract things which are difficult to measure. Love, passion, emotion, justice are few things which are difficult to measure and can only be felt. It does not mean we cannot manage the immeasurable things. We can manage these by emotional intelligence. It is in benefit of society to manage the non-measureable things. It also helps in maintaining order in society. By managing these abstract ideas, we could also reduce burden on data collection. Example – By inculcating ideas we can reduce crime in society which will reduce burden on NCRB like institutes.

We have discussed the importance of measuring things, to same up we must focus on both measurable and immeasurable ideas of life. Measurement is just a one dimension of management. Merely collecting data and measurement will not help in effective management. We need to develop capability to manage beyond just collecting data. E.g., Our judiciary is clogged with thousands of pending cases, which are duly tracked by national judicial data grid. The measurement is there the response should be not more data and management but solutions like increase the strength of judges and improving court management processes. We need to keep on filtering the data to store the relevant data and discard the irrelevant. Therefore, just measuring everything will not get managed by itself measuring and managing are two difficult fields which are inter-dependent without management, measurement is of no use and without measurement, management will be tricky process.

So, it is not only measurement but what we measure and how we measure in effective way and the effective response in line with that data that is more important in today's life. We need to keep evolving our methods of measurement, so when Nisha becomes young, she could herself feel the benefits of measuring and managing things. These are many children like Nisha in our country which are taking benefit of government programs because of effective data management by our agencies. Example – Mid-Day Meal Scheme.

Our focus should be on quality of measurement and management. Our quality of measurement will help us in achieving in managing the demographic dividend and achieving the goals of $5 trillion economy in near future.

►INNOVATION IS KEY DETERMINANT OF ECONOMIC GROWTH AND SOCIAL WELFARE

#SCIENCE #SOCIETY

The entire human history can be viewed as history of human innovation. The early humans innovated to control fire and invented the wheel. In later times, humans innovated stone tools and later metallic tools. Thus, the progress of humans as a race is closely linked to the innovations that humans did to make themselves fittest in evolutionary struggle.

Coming to modern age, this age is characterized by innovations of industrial revolution. These innovations has led to tremendous economic growth as well as social welfare.

For instance, economy has transmitted from mainly agricultural nature to mainly industries led by modern technologies in modern age. Further, Social welfare has also increased manifold in modern age vis-à-vis pre-industrial age. In terms of education, we today study scientific education rather than traditional religious education. The same goes with healthcare which shifted from unscientific to scientific nature.

Additionally, social welfare should also be seen in the shift in values that innovation brought. In modern age, we have democratic values which oppose orthodox discriminations.

Thus, we can see that innovation is key determinant of economic growth and social welfare.

In this essay, we will first explore the meaning of economic growth and social welfare. Then we will understand how innovation leads to economic growth and social welfare. Further, we will analyse the challenges India face in sphere of innovation and how can we overcome those challenges.

Explainer: Economic Growth and Social Welfare

Starting with economic growth, it can, in its most rudimentary form, considered as GDP growth (Gross Domestic Product). But for true economic growth, GDP growth needs to be sustained and made more inclusive. In times of climate change and threats it can pose to economy, sustainability is an important aspect.

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At the same time, economic growth needs to be inclusive as economy is not sum of incomes of few elites but that of the masses. But how do we ensure that economy becomes inclusive? The answer to this is by ensuring social welfare. Social welfare is improvement in standard of living of the masses. This includes education, health, housing, food, internet etc.

Thus, we can see that economic growth and social welfare in their true form are not mutually exclusive but are interlinked. This aspect is captured by concept of development which can be measured by Human Development Index and Multi-dimensional Poverty Index.

Now, after understanding economic growth and social welfare. Let us understand how innovation leads to them.

Innovation – an expressway for economic growth and social welfare

Innovation is essentially a process of problem solving in a more efficient manner under the constraints of resource availability. Thus, it is natural for innovation to be the expressway for economic growth and social welfare.

More specifically, innovations like green technology, and circular economy's technology will promote sustainability of economic growth. Examples of innovation in solar energy, wind energy, Biofuels and atomic energy are case in point for green technology. On the other side, recycling innovations and waste to energy technology are examples of innovations leading to circular economy.

Apart from promoting sustainability, innovation in field of social welfare will not just promote social welfare but also promote inclusiveness of economic growth. **For instance**, in education sector, innovations like **Tele-education and Massive open online courses (MOOC)** and other tools of on-line education are promoting accessibility of education to the masses and democratisation of education.

Further, in health sector, innovations have direct bearing on lives saved. Two of the most important innovations in health sector are vaccination that prevent diseases and health insurance which is financial innovation making health care affordable.

The same is the case with food where green revolution has prevented famines in India since 1970s. Thus, we can see that innovation is an expressway to economic growth and social welfare i.e. development of humans.

Now, let us analyse the challenges that India faces in sphere of Innovation.

Innovation in India: potholes on express way

For any vibrant innovation ecosystem, we need 4 things – man power, funds, industry-academia link and patent infrastructure. India faces challenges in all 4 of these categories.

Starting from manpower, India has demographic advantage, however, this advantage is not getting fully utilized. This advantage gets eroded starting from the childhood as 40% Indian children are stunted and 20% wasted. This impares growth of healthy mind. To add to difficulties to manpower, education in India is characterized by rote learning. ASER report by NGO Pratham points out that around 50% of students don't achieve documentary levels of learning outcomes.

Now coming to funding of innovation, the R & D expenditure of government is <1% of GDP. To increase the scarcity of funds, private sector R & D expenditure is virtually non-existant. Even this meager amount of funds are not getting utilized in best way because of dysfunctioned industry-academia link. To highlight the gravity of situation, research in India is often mocked as resume – research.

Finally, in the patent infrastructure, Indian patent laws are of good quality. However, implementation of these laws is not up to the mark. For instance, it takes 18 months to get a patent in India as compared 1–4 months in Singapore.

Thus, these are the 4 major potholes on innovation expressway and India needs to urgently repair them.

Innovation in India: repairing the potholes

Starting with manpower, to reap the demographic advantage, India needs to provide health care and education to its children. In healthcare, government has various schemes to ensure nourishment of children for example, Prime Minister Matru Jandhan Yojana covers infants less than 6 months old, ICDS

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and midday meal covers nourishment of children older than 2 years to 14 years. Thus, the gap between 6 months to 2 years needs to be filled as the Kasturirangan Committee pointed out that major mental development happens in 1st 1000 days.

After ensuring proper development of brain, the brain needs to be trained by quality education. There is need to shift towards a curriculum that promotes critical thinking and activity based learning. Also comprehensive continuous examination should be introduced to remove role learning for exam mentality.

Moving forward, the government should increase budgetary support for R & D to at least 1% of GDP. Also, private sector needs to be motivated to increase its R & D spending. This can be done by providing tax incentives for R & D expenditure. Also, coorporates situated in tech parks should be mandated, by law, to invest a threshold of their profits in R & D.

Additionally, to sustain the ecosystem of innovation, profitability of R & D expenditure needs to increase. This will happen when industry – academia link is strong. For this, joint research and sponsored research should be promoted.

On top of this, entrepreneurship in universities should be increased so that university students can take R & D from Labs to market.

Finally, patent infrastructure need to be strengthened. This requires reducing Turn around time for patents to less than 4 months from current 18 months. For this to happen, we also need patent drafting professionals which make the process more robust.

Lastly, patent enforcement should be improved. This can happen by have special judges with expertise in patent laws to adjudicate patent infringement cases.

Thus, implementation of these reforms will repair India's innovation expressway which will set India on a path of economic growth and social welfare.

To conclude, innovation is indeed key determinant of economic growth and social welfare. However, innovation should not be taken for granted as it needs vibrant innovation ecosystem.

►SOMETIMES IT TAKES A NATURAL DISASTER TO REVEAL A SOCIAL DISASTER

#DISASTER #SOCIETY

Disaster is a phenomenon which leads to a large-scale destruction of life and property. It has a huge impact on the social and economic factors of the country. For instance, the super-cyclone "Amphan" in West Bengal caused havoc and lead to destruction of thousands of crores. Apart from physiographical disaster such as earthquakes, cyclones or heat waves, biological disaster such as viral pandemics have also emerged as a threat to human existence.

The world has witnessed global pandemics such as the Spanish influence in 1918 or the SARS in 2004. Recently, Covid-19 (SARS – Cov2) has brought the entire world to a standstill. It is believed to have emerged in the Wuhan Province of China and then spread across the globe. This has led to the entire world to come in a lockdown, halting all the economic activities worldwide. This has further lead to widespread unemployment. Thus, this natural disaster has revealed a social disaster which the world is staring at.

A social disaster can be defined as a situation in which majority of the masses find themselves devoid of any work i.e., unemployment, which further leads to poverty, poor and sub-standard living. The following figure describes social disaster:

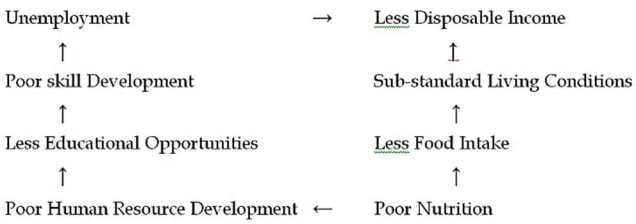


Fig: CHARACTERISTICS OF A SOCIAL DISASTER

Further, this social disaster affects various sectors of the society in varying degrees. The most vulnerable to the adverse impacts of the social disaster are:

1. Workers in the informal sector
2. Women
3. Farmers

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Impact on the Workers: The workers, especially those working in the informal sector find themselves on the receiving end wherever any disaster hits the country. Their vulnerability was exposed in the Covid-19 pandemic. Nor did they only lose their jobs but also found themselves without any means of survival post the lockdown. In the absence of any government help, they were forced to walk-back to their home states. This has led to deaths of some workers.

Moreover, workers in the informal economy have to fight at two fronts whenever any disaster hits them; first, as they are the bread-earners of the house they have to work irrespective of the dangerous conditions prevailing outside. This need to earn exposes them more to the disaster, in this case the Corona – Viruses. On the other end people employed in the formal sector have the facility of work-from-home. This reduces their exposure to such deadly viruses. Moreover, people in informal sector are not covered under any social security measures, hence increasing their vulnerability. All these factors push these workers into a perpetual cycle of poverty.

Impact on Women: The role of the women in the 21st century has changed drastically. Today, women have to fight at two fronts; first they have to manage the household tasks and second they also have to manage their jobs. This increased responsibility has made them more vulnerable to the impacts of disaster. This is because it is the women who face the threat of unemployment the most. Further, in case of poor living conditions it is always the women who go to bed with a hungry stomach. This further leads to conditions such as anaemia or under nourishment.

Further, domestic violence is another impact of a disaster as was evident during the recent Covid-19 pandemic. Due to the imposed lockdown the cases of domestic violence reached its peak during this period as highlighted by an international study.

Impact on Farmers: Agriculture is dependent on nature and any calamity by the nature has adverse impact on the agriculture and thereby on the farming community. In 2019, heavy rainfall caused floods in Maharashtra. These floods washed away all the Sharif crops thus causing a huge loss to the farmers. The impact was so severe that the farmers could not even get back the principal amount that they had invested, leave aside the profits.

Such losses push the farming community into a vicious cycle of poverty which often ends with the farmers committing suicide. Furthermore, the lack of penetration of institutional sources of credit in some rural areas makes the farmers vulnerable to the local money lenders. This vulnerability leads to instances such as forced labour which are still prevalent in certain remote areas of India.

All these issues have bought into light the idea of welfare state that the Constitution of India states. 70 years post-independence some sections of the population find themselves the most vulnerable whereas some enjoy the perks of being born into a high class society. The policies and approaches have widened the gap between the haves and the have not's. Further, it seems that the idea of socialism has taken a back-seat and capitalism has been placed in the driver's seat.

Thus, it has become the need of the hour to re-design our policies and construct our framework so that the difficulties of the vulnerable section are addressed.

In pursuit to achieve this, the **first step** can be to have a bottom-up approach of governance. Such an approach shall frame policies by focusing on the needs of vulnerable section rather than addressing the aspirations of the capitalist class. NITI AAYOG's Aspirational District Programme is an example in this direction. **Second,** there is a dire need to ramp up primary and secondary health and wellness centres and increase their penetration in the remote areas. Further, it has to be ensured that quality medicines are available at affordable costs.

Moreover, India needs to increase its expenditure on health to at least 2.5% of GDP. All these measures will ensure a healthy population and thereby enable India to reap the maximum benefit of its demographic dividend.

Third step in this direction is to bring the informal workforce under some social security scheme. According to the Economic Survey 2018-19, almost 90% of the workforce is employed in the informal sector.

Fourth, India needs to provide employment to its vast workforce. Currently, unemployment in India stands at 6.1%, which is at a 45 year high. The solution to this issue is setting up of more labour-intensive industries and simultaneously codification of the labour laws.

Fifth, there is a dire need for India to diversify its agricultural basket. Such diversification will have a dual benefit; first it will rectify the skewed cropping pattern and thereby ensure income to the farmers and second it will give a boost to the nutritional intake.

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Also boost must be given to the Model Agricultural producer and Livestock Marketing Act to help farmers better realizes the value of their products.

All these above measures will surely aid in minimizing the gap between the haves and the have not's. Further, it shall decrease the vulnerabilities of the lower sections of the society thereby giving an impetus to the idea of welfarism.

►WATER SCARCITY MAY LEAD TO WATER WARS

#ENVIRONMENT #CONSERVATION

Problems are huge as precious evolutionary living resources, natural infrastructure, are going extinct. While we thoughtlessly build artificial infrastructure, we forget that this kills natural infrastructure which took evolution aeons to create and cannot be engineered. We are missing the essential point that this is our lifeline on the planet. Forests, rivers, mountains, aquifers and soil are being lost at an alarming rate. Today, India is in the midst of a suicidal water crisis as urban and rural landscapes go thirsty.

Over the years, we have seen activists, scientists and experts from across India working on bottom-up schemes to revive and rejuvenate lakes, wetlands, streams and other small water bodies. While these movements have brought about a significant change at the local level, the scale of our water problems is much larger.

Here we have two intractable issues. **First**, cities today are vast agglomerations that continue to spread, with bursting populations of tens of millions. They are huge parasites on water, food, energy and all other resources. High densities of our cities do not allow for water harvesting filling the gap. Until now, invasive schemes like dams to service these large cities and the huge needs of agriculture have caused extreme ecological devastation.

Second, in our global market economies, the products and services that are derived from natural infrastructure have often led to the terminal loss of the source itself. The global free market, and with it the scale of human intervention, now exceeds the scale of the planet. These resources (forests, mountains, floodplains and rivers) are often lost to the greed of governments, institutions, corporations and individuals. This is long-term loss for short- term gain. Natural resources are living evolutionary resources that are constantly renewed by natural cycles. Therefore, they provide us perennial value as long as we use them with natural wisdom and not kill them with exploitation — which is the order of the day.

Groundwater plays an important role in our lives and India's economy, but it is disappearing fast. There is mounting evidence that we are extracting more than can be naturally replenished. In the hard-rock aquifers of peninsular India, drilling 800 ft. or deeper is becoming the norm. Groundwater-dependent towns and villages spend an increasing fraction of their budgets chasing the water table. Stories abound of farmers spending their life savings or taking loans to drill a borewell, but failing to find water. If we "run out" of groundwater, millions of people will be left without any means to sustain themselves.

Scientific evidence also points to over-exploitation. The Central Ground Water Board classifies all blocks in India based on the fraction of recharge that is extracted and trends in long-term groundwater levels. Since 2004, almost a third of blocks have been classified "over-exploited" or "semi-critical". If we understand the problem and if the consequences are so severe, why are we unable to address it? The answer lies partly in politics, partly in the invisible nature of groundwater, and partly in our reliance on simple techno-economic fixes.

Flawed regulatory structure: Electricity is supplied to farmers free of cost. This policy made sense when groundwater was abundant in the 1980s. Indeed, it helped millions of farmers escape poverty. But today, where groundwater levels have fallen hundreds of feet below the ground, the subsidy is actually only utilised by the richest farmers who can afford to drill deep. And even so, not all are lucky enough to strike water. Access to groundwater in hard-rock regions has almost become a lottery. Yet in the absence of alternative water sources, charging farmers for electricity is seen as political suicide.

Groundwater is inherently difficult to monitor and control, in part because of its invisibility, which also perpetuates the illusion that each well is independent. The myth is enshrined in Indian groundwater law that allows landowners to extract as much as they want. In reality, not only is groundwater within an aquifer interconnected, but aquifers and rivers are also interconnected. So depleting groundwater means drying rivers. Despite this,

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groundwater and rivers are regulated by different agencies that do not properly account for the linkages between them, often double counting the quantum of the resource.

Much of the current action on the ground is through techno-economic fixes. These have clear benefits in terms of reducing pumping costs and using local aquifers instead of building big, expensive dams. But what they do not do is create "new" water.

Solution can be **floodplain.** Research has shown that floodplains of rivers are exceptional aquifers where any withdrawal is compensated by gravity flow from a large surrounding area and can be used as a source of providing water to cities. Floodplains are formed over millions of years by the flooding of rivers with deposition of sand on riverbanks. Some floodplains, such as those of Himalayan rivers, contain up to 20 times more water than the virgin flow in rivers in a year. Since recharge is by rainfall and during late floods, the water quality is good. If we conserve and use the floodplain, it can be a self-sustaining aquifer wherein every year, the river and floodplain are preserved in the same healthy condition as the year before.

The Delhi Palla floodplain project on the Yamuna is an example of this. By utilising 20 sq.km of the river length and running at half its capacity, it provides water to almost a million people daily. Piezometers and a control system have been installed to monitor water levels and other parameters through the year, to ensure sustainable withdrawal. Besides, it provides huge revenue to the Delhi Jal Board.

Preserving the floodplain in a pristine condition is essential for this scheme to work. Land on the floodplains can be leased from farmers in return for a fixed income from the water sold to cities. The farmers can be encouraged to grow orchards/food forests to secure and restore the ecological balance of the river ecosystem.

Currently, mineral water is brought from faraway mountain springs, putting huge pressure on the mountains. It is packaged and consumed in plastic bottles that end up in landfills. Forested hills are a result of evolution over millions of years. They are not polluted and sit on a treasure of **underground aquifers** that contain natural mineral water comparable to that found in a mountain spring. This is because the rain falls on the forest and seeps through the various layers of humus and cracked rock pathways, picking up nutrients and minerals and flows into underground mineral water aquifers.

Research shows that the water in these aquifers is comparable to several international natural spring mineral waters. It also shows that if a scheme of 'conserve and use' is applied correctly, it would allow a forest (like Asola Bhatti in Delhi) to be sustained as a mineral water sanctuary. About 30 sq.km of the forest could then provide enough natural mineral water to 5 million people in the city. The Aravalli forested hills can provide mineral water to all major towns of Rajasthan. This water can substantially improve the health of citizens and preserve forests at the same time. The marvel is that we can provide quality natural mineral water for all from a local forest tract for 20 times less than the market price and yet reap great economic returns.

Such non-invasive, local, large-scale 'conserve and use' projects till now have not been part of our living scheme. They change the relationship between nature, water and cities. They differ in scale from the small, community-driven projects of check dams, water harvesting and lakes and can service large populations. Unlike large-scale dams, these projects work with nature rather than against it. They can be used around the globe. If we were to recognise the true value of our natural infrastructure and 'conserve and use' our evolutionary resources with the help of science, it would secure the future for humanity and the natural world.

Further, boosting recharge through **rainwater harvesting structures** such as small check dams is a popular measure. Another technological solution is to improve efficiency through subsidised drip irrigation or energy-saving pumps.

The way forward is **comprehensive water budgeting**, simultaneously in each watershed and the river basin as a whole. Water budgets at the watershed level will inform communities about how much water they have, so it can be equitably shared within communities. Water budgets for the river basin will inform communities how much must be left for downstream users, ensuring that water resources are allocated between communities fairly and transparently.

Given the zero-sum nature of the game and the impossibility of creating "new" water, it is likely that we cannot restore the water balance in severely depleted regions without painful cuts in water use. However, there are some glimmers of hope. Water users everywhere are worried about the disappearing resource and willing to engage. The trick lies in combining technology (low-water-use crops,

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xeriscaping) and economic incentives that reduce actual water use ("cash-for-blue" schemes) without reducing productivity or quality of life. This needs a strong water governance system based on awareness building, science and a commitment to fairness and sustainability.

►CONVERTING WASTE MENACE INTO A WINDOW OF OPPORTUNITY

#ENVIRONMENT #POLLUTION

Waste management rules in India are based on the principles of "sustainable development", "precaution" and "polluter pays". These principles mandate municipalities and commercial establishments to act in an environmentally accountable and responsible manner—restoring balance, if their actions disrupt it. The increase in waste generation as a by-product of economic development has led to various subordinate legislations for regulating the manner of disposal and dealing with generated waste are made under the umbrella law of Environment Protection Act, 1986 (EPA). Specific forms of waste are the subject matter of separate rules and require separate compliances, mostly in the nature of authorisations, maintenance of records and adequate disposal mechanisms.

With rapid urbanisation, the country is facing massive waste management challenge. Barely a quarter of the 1.43 lakh MT of garbage generated every day in Indian cities gets processed. The remaining three-quarters are dumped in the open. Solid Waste Management (SWM) is one among the basic essential services provided by municipal authorities in the country to keep urban centres clean. However, almost all municipal authorities deposit solid waste at a dump yard within or outside the city haphazardly. Experts believe that India is following a flawed system of waste disposal and management.

Health and safety and environmental risks are a major concern. The workers as well as the waste pickers are not provided with proper health and safety equipment like boots and gloves. The working conditions are unhygienic, the chance of transfer of infection is high and because of this if a worker gets sick he loses his wages. The workers are also not provided with medical insurance. The environmental risk is also high because the landfill sites are not maintained properly and the leachate gets leaked into the underground water.

Sources and types of solid waste: Residential:-the residence might be single family or multiple family dwellers the types of waste they produce are paper, food wastes , cardboard , leather, yard wastes, textiles, glass, special wastes, metals, plastics , ashes, wood and household hazardous wastes.

Industrial: – industries produce ashes, food wastes, packaging, special wastes, housekeeping wastes, construction and demolition materials and hazardous wastes.

Commercial & Institutional: – they produce wood, metals, cardboard, glass, special wastes, Paper, food wastes, hazardous wastes.

Municipal services: – landscape and tree trimmings, Street sweepings, general wastes from beaches, parks, and other recreational areas, sludge.

The key to efficient waste management is to ensure proper **segregation of waste at source** and to ensure that the waste goes through different streams of recycling and resource recovery. Then reduced final residue is then deposited scientifically in sanitary landfills. Sanitary landfills are the ultimate means of disposal for unutilised municipal solid waste from waste processing facilities and other types of inorganic waste that cannot be reused or recycled. Major limitation of this method is the costly transportation of MSW to far away landfill sites.

A noteworthy first step was propelling sanitation to the top of the policy agenda under the flagship Swachh Bharat Abhiyan programme. The Clean India Dashboard tracks programme achievements, 24x7. Almost 90 megawatts (MW) of energy is generated from waste-to-energy (WTE) projects. Nevertheless, the disproportionate focus of the programme on toilet construction and eliminating open defecation deflects attention from colossal failures in waste management systems.

There has been technological advancement for processing, treatment and disposal of solid waste. **Energy-from-waste** is a crucial element of SWM because it reduces the volume of waste from disposal also helps in converting the waste into renewable energy and organic manure. Ideally, it falls in the flow chart after segregation, collection, recycling and before getting to the land fill. But many waste to energy plants in India are not operating to their full potential.

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Installation of **waste-to-compost and bio-methanation plants** would reduce the load of landfill sites. The biodegradable component of India's solid waste is currently estimated at a little over 50 per cent. Bio-methanation is a solution for processing biodegradable waste which is also remains underexploited. It is believed that if we segregate biodegradable waste from the rest, it could reduce the challenges by half. E-waste components contain toxic materials and are non-biodegradable which present both occupational and environmental health threats including toxic smoke from recycling processes and leaching from e-waste in landfill into local water tables.

The concept of **common waste treatment facility** is being widely promoted and accepted as it uses waste as a resource by either using it as a co-fuel or co-raw material in manufacturing processes. This has led to rise of Public Private Partnership (PPP) models in waste management which has open doors for doing business in waste management.

Bio-medical waste (management and handling) rules, 1998 prescribe that there should be a **Common Biomedical Waste Treatment Facility (CBWTF)** at every 150 kms in the country. CBWTFs have been set up and are functioning in cities and towns. However, establishment of functional CBWTF throughout the country must be ensured. Integrated common hazardous waste management facilities combine secured landfill facility, solidification/stabilisation and incineration to treat hazardous wastes generated by various industrial units. They contribute about 97.8 per cent of total landfill waste and 88 per cent of total incinerable hazardous waste generated in the country, as per an environment ministry report.

Focus on 3 R's-Reduce, Reuse, Recycle with collaborative participation of State and Non-state actors: It is the only way to save the environment from getting deteriorated. We are quickly running out of space and now it is important that all of us learn the three R's of the environment and put it into practice.

Reducing the amount of waste produced is the best way to help the environment. For instance buying products with minimum packaging, borrowing things which we do not use often, starting a compost bin, saving energy and water by turning are ways to reduce. To reduce the environment damage caused by cars, increase use of carpooling with friends, walking, taking the bus, or riding your bike instead of driving are the necessary steps to be taken. Same way salvage does for the environment. It helps to reduce the waste by sorting out articles of use.

Instead of throwing away articles try to find various efficient ways to reuse it. For instance, replacing few things in our day to day life like using cloth sacks in place of plastic bags, re-useable lunch bags without creating waste. Donating old clothes, toys and furniture to the needy and poor. Use writing paper on both sides etc.

The process of changing the waste and non-useable materials into potentially useful materials. It is the key component of modern waste reduction procedure. There are some ISO standards related to recycling such as ISO 15270:2008 for plastics waste and ISO 14001:2004 for environmental management control of recycling practice. Recycling reduces the consumption of raw materials and energy usage. It also reduces air and water pollution by reducing the need of conventional waste disposal. Usage of recycled materials will help the environment to be green again.

Around 100 cities are set to be developed as smart cities. Civic bodies have to redraw long term vision in solid waste management and rework their strategies as per changing lifestyles. They should reinvent garbage management in cities so that we can process waste and not landfill it (with adequate provisioning in processing and recycling).To do this, households and institutions must segregate their waste at source so that it could be managed as a resource. The Centre aims to do away with landfill sites in 20 major cities. There is no spare land for dumping garbage; the existing ones are in a critical state. It is reported that almost 80 per cent of the waste at Delhi landfill sites could be recycled provided civic bodies start allowing waste managers to segregate waste at source and recycle it. Compost pits should be constructed in every locality to process organic waste. Community participation has a direct bearing on efficient waste management. Recovery of e-waste is abysmally low; we need to encourage recycling of e-waste on a very large scale level so that problem of e-waste disposal is contained.

►CAN TECHNOLOGY REPLACE MANPOWER?

#SCIENCE #LIVELIHOODS

Jobs – this is the catchword of today's domestic as well as international politics across the globe. The present

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scenario of unemployment appears pretty grim, with joblessness touching record levels in many countries, including India. A large part of the problem of unemployment is because of the paradigm shift that we are witnessing in technology. Experts believe that the fourth Industrial Revolution has brought with itself technologies that have total disrupted the manufacturing processes. Today's machines are smarter and efficient than ever and have replaced manufacturing jobs to a large extent – especially in advanced economies of the West and China. A certain backlash against machines replacing humans in jobs has brought forth a natural question – **"Can technology replace Manpower?"**

In context of answering this question, it would be informative to look at a brief history of technology itself.

One can argue that technology is as old as manpower itself. The highly developed cognitive and analytical capacities of the human brain allowed humans to develop tools and processes which would aid in better survival. Rubbing stones to generate fire, while using wooden logs as wheels were all technologies of the Palaeolithic Age. Microliths were technological Innovations of the Neolithic Age. With time, the technologies got more and more complex and functionally efficient. Evolution of agricultural technologies and warfare technologies was the next big step. However, the industrial Revolution of the 18th and 19th century is by far the biggest leap in technology that mankind has taken. Lately electricity, computers and most recently Artificial intelligence, Big Data, Blockchain are the new technologies.

From the above historical description, it is clear that humans evolved technologies for themselves. Technology has always had a functional role. Technology reduced human effort and made tasks more efficient. It left humans more time in leisure, which helped in innovation and creative thinking. This furthered technological development and the cycle kept reinforcing itself. Using technology, man was also able to solve problems and build things which are seemingly beyond the limits of manpower. For example, deep sea mining, crushing of stones, communicating with romance far away – are all beyond man's physical capabilities, but technology makes it all possible. Technology has had an impact not only in the economic sphere, but also in the social, political and cultural spheres. Today's technology allows us to socialize with friends who are in a different city, influence political opinions remotely, and keen about different cultures while sitting in our rooms. Therefore, it would not be wrong to say that technology has aided in making our lives easier are the course of history.

When we compare technology with manpower, we see that both are pretty different. Manpower can be divided into two physical and mental. Physical manpower entails doing work with our bodies – like pushing a rock, packaging stuff, assembling parts; while mental manpower involves brain functioning – analysis comprehension, innovation and understanding. It can be observed that for a large part of history, the role of technology was to supplement physical manpower and reduce drudgery – the invention of cars, steam engines, mining equipment, use of electricity for mechanical operations etc. The progress has been such that physical labour today has lost its value as the same work can be done by a machine efficiently and tirelessly. On the other hand mental labour today holds more relevance than ever, partly because technology of today cannot match levels of human intelligence and partly because today we live in an age of knowledge economy.

The above trends therefore, again point to the relevance of manpower in face of todays advanced technology. It however is important to know that this debate is not a new one. It has existed ever since the spinning Jenny – the first machine of the industrial Revolution, replaced jobs of English workers. Those sceptics of machine power were known as luddites. Similarly, modern thinkers like Gandhi were also not for replacement of manpower by technology. He advocated that every person performed bread-labour and wanted production by the masses, not mass production. In the same way, neo-luddites of today call for banning of new technologies which have led to joblessness.

A historical analysis would suggest that technology cannot replace manpower. At most, it can alter the nature in which manpower is employed, but it cannot certainly replace it. This is because human manpower is too complex to be emulated by a machine precisely. Although technology today performs more tasks of humans than ever, but those are tasks that can be programmed through logic functions. One cannot possibly programme man's natural decision making, cognitive and emotional qualities into a machine.

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Therefore, technology, while closing some jobs, opens up new ones which are of a different nature. Manpower can never go out of vogue, because it is manpower itself that makes technology, not the other way round. Also, present fears of technology replacing manpower are pretty far-fetched, as more than 70% of the World lives in developing countries where people do not have access to ever basic agricultural technologies like farming tools. In the future of technology evolves and becomes smarter, it is bound to have a social, political and economic backlash so as to keep the balance.

In a world where Amazon uses robots to find inventory, Ford uses robotic arms to manufacture cars, and legal firms use Artificial Intelligence to fight case, apprehensions of technology replacing manpower are valid. However, one must wait and give this disruption some time, as job markets lag when it comes to reacting to disruptions. Technology never was, and can never be a substitute of manpower. Technology is a tool and efforts must be made to set it remain that way. It is because of the combination of manpower and technology that the human race has progressed so much. Creative Solutions are the need of the hour so that both are balanced. Technology cannot replace manpower, but supplement it better.

►INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS ARE ALL ABOUT ECONOMIC INTERESTS AND LOCAL POLITICAL GAINS

#INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

International relations are based on national interests of a nation which include economic interests and local political gains. No country in the world is self-sufficient to meet every need from the domestic resources. Neither does any country remain isolated from the world today. There comes in the role of international relations and foreign policy. The main objective of the foreign policy of a country is to further its domestic interests.

Foreign Policy of a nation is meticulously designed as an Instrument to further its national interests which include economic interests. Nations engage in trade to meet the needs of the people as well as maintain a favorable balance of payment. When international trade results into unfavorable balance of payments, nations indulge in trade wars by imposing tariffs. US-China trade war is an example of centrality of favorable balance of trade in the international relations. Colonization of India was accompanied by the systematic destruction of Indian handicrafts by the British through one-way free trade and other measures. Favorable balance of trade was a major objective of the colonization of India by the British.

Nations need energy security as energy is vital for economic development. Ever since oil industry boom in the Middle East, the USA has tried to increase its geopolitical influence in the region. Energy security was at the heart of US intervention in Iraq. India has carefully balanced its relationship with competing powers such as Saudi Arabia, Iran, and Israel in the Middle East, primarily influenced by its large dependence on oil and gas from the region.

An economic interest of a nation is dependent on availability of essential raw materials for manufacturing products for exports and domestic consumption. Countries seek to ensure uninterrupted supplies of raw materials such as iron ore, coal, rare earth metals, etc. China controls nearly 95% of the world's rare-earth metals production. It has used it as a diplomatic lever.

One of the key objectives of international relations among countries is to increase investments. Countries design their foreign policies in a way to attract investments from abroad as well as opportunities for domestic investors abroad. India's foreign policy is formulated with a view to improve foreign direct investments and foreign institutional investments.

Foreign policy is used by leaders for local political gains as well. Boris Johnson's campaign for Brexit made him PM of the UK and brought again to power in recently conducted elections. Donald Trump's campaign to "make America great again" appealed people and brought him to power. His subsequent measures, after coming to power, such as withdrawal from Paris Climate Deal, trade war against China, seeking funds for wall along Mexican border, more stringent visa rules, etc. have all been to fulfill his electoral promises.

Similarly, India's foreign policy with respect to Sri Lanka has always been influenced by the sentiments of Tamil people in India. India has been unable to resolve the issue of Teesta River with Bangladesh. Domestic political compulsions from the state of

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Bengal have made the Union government hesitant to proceed on the issue. Indian government's decision of not joining Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP) was influenced by its impact on farmers, which comprises of a large section of voters. Pakistan's Kashmir rhetoric is influenced by its domestic political compulsion, which led it to adopt the policy of fomenting terrorism in India.

International Relations go beyond just economic interests and local political gains. National interests determine foreign policy decisions. There is ideological dimension too in framing a country's foreign policy. International relations in Cold War era were heavily influenced by the conflict between two mutually opposed ideologies of Capitalism and Communism. NAM originated in this context and Indian foreign policy was based on this non-alignment principle.

Another factor which determines international relations among nations is based on battle for supremacy. US Pivot of Asia policy is based on the thought of containing the rising economic and military power of China, which is a threat to the supremacy of USA in the world today. Alignment of different nations to form block is to maintain the balance of power among nations. Formation of power blocks among nations to maintain balance of power can be seen during the first and second world wars, cold war period and even in post-cold war international relations among different nations.

Ethical, moral, and legal dimensions also influence in formulation of foreign policy of a nation. International relations are based on the principles such UN Charter, Panchsheel, Right to Protect, etc. Another important issue which influences a country's international relations is its defence. India's relationship with Russia and Israel is built primarily on the India's defence needs. NATO was formed for collective security of the countries following the Capitalist system under the leadership of USA.

Global commons and shared responsibility demand nations to design appropriate foreign policy. Examples include activities of UNFCCC for climate change, Convention on Biological Diversity, UNCLOS, etc.

Technology is an indispensable factor in international trade and relations. India's need for nuclear technology helped strengthen conclude Civil Nuclear Deal with USA and helped strengthen relationship with USA. India collaborates with countries such as USA, Israel, France, Russia, and Ukraine in the field of space.

Diaspora is an influencing factor for international relations among nations in the world. India's policy in the Middle East is also influenced by the presence of large diaspora in the region. Nations use soft power in relations with other countries. Cultural heritage, philosophical ideas such as those of Gandhi, yoga and meditation, films, sports, etc. too are being given increased importance in the power matrix shaping the foreign policy.

In designing foreign policy of a country, it is important to keep in mind its history and legacy. Foreign policy is evolved from history with suitable changes to address the dynamics of the geopolitical reality taking into account the national interest including the economic and strategic interests. Foreign policy of the countries reality cannot be a sudden break from the past. Despite India's increasing closeness with USA, NAM still continues to have a great influence on Indian foreign policy.

Economic interests and domestic political compulsions are important factors determining the foreign policy of a country. However, foreign policy goes beyond these two factors. Ideological leaning, defence needs, commonly accepted international principles and rules, etc. to play a great role in shaping the foreign policy of a country.

A country's foreign policy is determined by its national interest. National interest of a country takes into account dynamic internal and external environment, domestic and international political compulsions and other significant inputs. It is a high-level decision-making process involved by the head of the state, ministry of external affairs, career diplomats and other experts. Most important objective is to safeguard the national interest of the nation. In order to define the determinants of national interest of a nation, it is indispensable for the policy makers to factor complex and dynamic domestic and international political milieu. In the context of globalization and transnational activities, nations have to constantly interact with other nations, international organizations and non-state actors bilaterally and multilaterally. Foreign policy of a country is designed taking into account both internal or domestic factors and international determinants. It

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goes beyond economic interests and local political gains.

►THINK GLOBAL - ACT LOCAL

#GLOBALISATION

In 1893, a conference of religious delegations was organized in Chicago. Everyone had their share of time to address the conference. Then came a man with a modest attire. He started his address with "My brothers and sisters" and conveyed the world as one family. This address captured the imagination of the audience like none of the speakers. This was Swami Vivekanand whose thoughts and vision were global in nature yet rooted in India's psyche and teachings.

Despite having a global perspective, he always chose to act locally starting from himself as an individual and then on the Indian Society to remove social ills plaguing India. His approach to life to think globally and acting locally ultimately made him a globally revered personality. The same approach can be extrapolated to a nations' outlook towards growth, the guiding force behind scientific endeavors, etc.

So here it is prudent to analyze, why is it important to think global? If so, why should we act locally? What challenges we face in this approach? And is it all we need to do?

Thinking global refers to rising above oneself and one's surroundings to gain perspective of the whole world and humanity at large. It helps us understand human nature. Thinking global is a means to understand the impacts of our actions on the whole world and its reactions. This way we can regulate our actions and emotions and positively cooperate with others.

Even in ancient times, there was global engagement in great civilizations in the world. This is evident in not just the close trade relations between Indus Valley Civilization and Mesopotamia but also between the close trade relations between Sangam Age kingdoms and Rome. This exchange for sure was not just limited to the realm of materiality but also influenced ideas and outlooks.

This is even evident by the Non-alignment policy and Strategic Autonomy pursued by India in India's foreign policy. India engaged and wanted to gain from USA and USSR. Both camps, despite being engaged in Cold War, contributed to the development of large integrated steel mills and development of IITs in India.

Thinking global helped India to raise the issue of Pakistan's State sponsorship to terrorism at global forums. India was able to convey and persuade world opinion on action against terrorism. Similarly, India's global leadership on raising injustice towards developing countries by developed world has made it a natural leader of the developing and least developed nations.

In the economic sphere, thinking global helps us calibrate our economy by analyzing global threats and prospects. We can see this has helped India to have a very low currency depreciation in comparison to other economies. Also, India was able to take proactive measures and escaped the worst effects of Global Financial Crisis.

India's global outlook, motivated India to develop a low cost, efficient and indigenous commercial space program. ISRO has allowed India to have various developmental gains.

After having so many benefits of thinking globally, we should analyze the challenges that thinking globally brings.

Sometimes leaders who are supposed to be visionary, bend towards protectionism and hindering think globally too like. For example, during the presidentship of Donald Trump. Further, enmity and confrontations, hinder global perspectives, like USA-China trade war has kept them from realizing the potential of cooperation.

Now that we realize the potential of thinking globally, we must also refer special importance to act locally. Acting local means starting with a change an individual level first without delay and procrastination. Acting locally often yields better results as it provides a small domain which is easy to start with. It often happens that, when we act locally, others tend to follow us on our success. This is what ideally a leader is supposed to do. Hence, it is essential that we act local.

During the national struggle, Gandhi used to clean his own toilets and members of the Congress to do the same with a vision to spread the message of cleanliness. His thoughts were shaped by global and scientific consciousness for clean environment and prevention of discrimination. However, instead of lecturing others he himself decided to act locally and become a living inspiration for others to emulate.

In the international fora too, India not only thinks of global peace and prosperity. But it also goes one step

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further and acts locally by starting dialogue with adversaries and neighbors like back-channel diplomacy with Pakistan, border dialogue with China.

Thinking globally helped India to be aware of the global economic slowdown, but then it did not rest idle. The RBI's accommodative stance, government's jobs proposal were actions taken at local level that averted worst effects of economic slowdown.

Even in the technology sector, India gives due regards to data and privacy concerns. This has been an approach of other nations too, most prominently that of the European Union with their GDPR regulations, but what makes India stand out is its works on data protection through data protection bill, data localization rules by RBI etc.

But as in earlier case, here too there are challenges in acting locally.

Acting local is often ineffective in the long run due to its local & limited impact. As we have seen in Climate action, India's local actions cannot stop climate change, which needs collective action across all stakeholders. Similarly, tax evasion by companies and trade are areas that are beyond local actions.

Further, capability and economic constraints of poor and developing nations stops them from acting locally and have significant impact. As during Covid, African nations were not able to develop vaccines. It needed nations like India to think global and extend support.

So, what should we do to think global and act local? It is important to think global and act local. But it is equally important to sometimes think locally and cater to local needs like poverty and inequality in India. At the same time, we must not stop ourselves at acting locally and strive to act globally, when needed. Like India's efforts to bring global consensus on framework against terrorism.

It is essential for everyone to remember the words of Immanuel Kant that "we must act assuming, everyone around acts ethically". This idea can motivate each nation to think globally with open mind without enmity and distrust. The cooperation hence forged will surpass all limitations of capability.

To conclude, we as Individuals must build our perspective for the whole world and start acting first on ourselves and then our society. As a nation, we should keep global good in mind and act at the local level first. In this line, government initiatives like Atma-nirbhar Bharat, Vocal for Local can help. The mantra for everyone must be collective growth and prosperity with initiative at local level. This can help us achieve global cooperation and act thinking the whole world as our family (Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam).

►RELEVANCE OF SOFT POWER IN INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

Ruchika is a fourteen-year-old girl who lives an ordinary life in sub-urban Mumbai. She goes to school, plays with her friends and spends time with her family. The only thing that sets her apart from others in that she speaks five languages – English, Hindi, Marathi, Korean and Japanese.

When she was young, she watched a lot of Japanese cartoons (Anime) and asked her parents to enroll her in Japanese classes. In her late adolescence her peer group began listening to Korean music (k-pop). Her interests changed and her parents, both software professionals, encouraged her to pursue languages.

This story is not just about a young servant but of globalization and soft power diplomacy. Japan and Korea are economic power – houses that are using them influence in culture to secure contacts abroad.

This essay will evaluate the role of soft power in international relations. It will evaluate its impact, stakeholders and critically explore its efficacy and evaluation. But first, let us see what is soft power?

Soft Power: Nation Branding and Influencing

The concept of soft power is hard to quantify but easy to understand. In simple terms, it is the ability to coopt rather than to coerce.

According to Joseph Nye, it is the use of cultural capital and economic power to influence other countries.

Soft power is the opposite of hard power which is the use of military and economic sanctions to gain desired objections. When economic influence is used for aid or disaster assistance it becomes soft po9wer. For example, the blocking of Russian companies and economic sanctions are hard power policies of the US. The promotion of Vaccine Maitri and lines of credit to Nepal (after the 2015 earthquake) by India is soft power.

Nation branding is an essential part of soft power. For example, Switzerland is associated with neutrality after World War II. It has fast emerged as the center of financial institutions which park undisclosed assets for clients. Similarly, America is associated with freedom and liberty. This helps its Multinational

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Corporations advertise their products with the same zeal.

India is closely associated with spiritualism and philosophical growth. It has also emerged as a bastion of religious tolerance and the oneness of humanity. After the Hippie Era, the Beatles even came to India for seeking universal learning in India. This has formed India's image as a cure against western capitalism. Off late, this spiritual exceptionalism has taken the form of Yoga. When India celebrates The World Yoga Day on the 21st of June; the world pays attention. Let's take the example of yoga to evaluate the relevance of soft power as a strategy for successful engagements with the world arena.

Soft Power Yoga: Case Study

An evolved foreign policy has different sectors which operate in unison. This results in various levels of diplomacy – Tier I (government to government) and Tier 2 (non-government to non-government). Non-government organizations include businesses and civil society representatives.

India's Yoga diplomacy encourages governments to interact with wellness corporations, fitness professionals and even the medicine sector (pharmacy and service) from India. For example, advocacy of Yoga by India enables corporates like Patanjali to increase their presence in other countries. This has a good impact on public relations, diaspora engagement and advocacy of India's interests.

Firstly, the Yoga soft power strategy, encourages association – advertising for India, "Think Yoga and Wellness". "Think India". This encourages the medical – tourism and wellness vacation sector in India. Secondly, it enables creation of brands like Patanjali and Baba Ramdev as the ambassador of India Inc. and Incredible India. Thirdly, it spreads the idea of India's spiritual wellness, Vasudeva Kutumbakam and openness to heal – which invites FDI and promotes goodwill among nations. Lastly, by building a sound public relations exercise, Indian migration of skilled labour for remittances and the services sector is seen in a good light. This can ultimately pave the way for furthering India's interests in other countries. Hence, Soft power diplomacy is very important in international relations. However, despite its relevance, some issues remain let's assess them.

Efficacy of Soft power: From Security to Strategy

In 2013, a notable Bollywood actor called Nepal "India's little sister". This caused a stir in Kathmandu and clashes in front of the Indian Embassy. The problem with overleveraging soft powers is two folds – First, governments do not have control over the non-governmental representatives but face the music for their actions. Second, Soft power works in a context. Despite providing an annual support of Rs 1200 crore to Nepal, India has been seen as a big brother. Many nationalist and communist parties object to India's presence in Nepal and this has culminated in the Kalapani issue between India and Nepal.

Furthermore, Soft power can never work without a security strategy. For example, despite 'Aman Ki Aasha', the nuclear deterrent is essential for avoiding a hot war against Pakistan. The opening of the Kartapur Corridor has been appreciated but India's outstanding issues of terror financing are never addressed by Islamabad. Even healthy bilateral trade has not decreased hostility along the India – China border.

This begs many to ask if soft power has an impact on the black bon of International negotiations and decision making? Does Bollywood help in Free trade Agreement negotiations? Can yoga and technology transfer and Intellectual Property Rights (IPR) waivers? The impact of soft power is very hard to quantify.

Recently, Scholars have even begun to highlight the concept of 'Sharp Power'- Which is the use of misinformation and propaganda to highlight an adversaries faults. This acts as a means of manipulation to undercut the influence of a country at the international level. Hence, the debate on soft power is dynamic and requires a careful pursuit of sound security policy in addition to soft power policies.

Conclusion: Relevant but Reform is Needed.

This essay argued that there is no doubt that soft power – which the outcome of careful nation branding – is relevant for international relations. However, soft power can never work in isolation and needs sound security policy as an insurance.

Ruchika's story surely suggest one important fact that if international relations become people's relation India's 1.2 billion diplomats can spread enough good will to charm even the grumpiest of dictators. Yet, reform and caution are essential. India, as a civilization state has much to share with the world. Soft power can be a vital tool in building relations which become resilient supply chains. Who knows, may be some day Asaki from Tokyo will speak Marathi and Hindi.

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3 THEME DEMOCRACY, POLITY AND GOVERNANCE

ABOUT THE THEME:

UPSC topics related with Democracy, Polity and Governance are based on the requirement to convert our democracy into a fully functional and vibrant democracy. A vibrant democracy should reflect the vision of the Preamble i.e. Justice, Equality, Liberty and Fraternity. In this regards, the topics in this theme are based on the following thought process:-

"India has been a democracy for over seven decades. Now, it is the apt time to evaluate the current state of democracy by analysing its performance so far and in this context also evaluate recent and contemporary issues which require deeper analysis to give our nation a hugely efficient democracy in near future".

Considering the above, the topics in this theme have been incorporated to highlight important issues which can be helpful in understanding the nuances of a vibrant democracy.

►IS TOO MUCH DEMOCRACY HAMPERING ITS INDIA'S NATIONAL INTEREST?

#POLITY & GOVERNANCE

"Democracy is two wolves and a lamb deciding what to have for lunch." This quote succinctly but uncharitably highlights the peculiar problems associated with the democratic form of government, and the way it often acts to the detriment of both the individual and the whole.

However, the fact that this quote comes from Benjamin Franklin, one of the founding fathers of the oldest democracy in the world reveals that this story is only one side of the coin, and thus merits a closer look into the multi-faceted interaction between a democratic government and the concept of national interest, especially in the context of the largest democracy in the world -- India – its past, present and future.

An Examination of 'Democracy'

A Democracy is often described as government of the people, by the people and for the people. This implies that the government is chosen from among the people themselves, by their mandate, to serve their larger interests. In India, this facet of democracy is reflected in universal adult franchise guaranteed under Article 326 of the constitution which forms the foundation of our 'Representative Democracy'.

However, apart from this political concept of democracy, there are other aspects of a democracy that often do not get adequate attention. A true democracy guarantees not just political participation but also social and economic democracy, implying that an Indian must not only be part of the process of choosing the men who lead the country, but also have a reasonable stake in the social and economic systems that move the country forward.

Indeed, India's aspirations towards social and economic democracy is writ large in the Directive Principles of State Policy which prescribes a policy framework to attain a truly democratic vision of the nation. It is with this holistic vision of democracy that we must evaluate the level of democracy in India and what 'National Interest' truly means.

Democracy of National Interest

If a nation is a community of people with shared interests, cultures, geography and other social characteristics, and a democracy is an aggregation of the will of those very people, it seems natural that the goals of the nation will be automatically served by the expression of democracy.

However, wider political discourse and current events disprove such simplistic a hypothesis, raising the seemingly oxymoronic question of 'how much democracy is too much democracy?" Why does this question arise?"

The concept of natural interest is a malleable one, where different sections of society having different priorities, driven by their unique circumstances, have

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different conceptions of what is in the interest of the nation at large.

For instance, grassroots democracy and protection of human rights may be considered as being in national interest for a resident of Kashmir, whereas suspension of the same due to perceived threat to territorial integrity and national security may be the best way to serve national interest, to others.

In a similar vein, individual voters may not be able to assess adequately the complexities involved in prioritizing and formulating national policy, fending themselves at odds with measures taken in their best interest. This narrative is relevant in the governments' justification of the farm laws.

An even more fundamental problem lies in the minds of the true guardians of democracy itself – the voter. Winston Churchill famously remarked that the greatest argument against democracy is a conversation with the average voter. This may hold true in India as well, with voters uninformed of political issues, easily swayed away by parochial interest of caste of religion and motivated by promises of doles, subsidies and freebies rather than by true national interest.

In all these cases, where the expression of democracy, appears to act to the detriment of natural interest as assessed by the democratically elected government, it is often considered an overreach of democracy. The response is often to curtail the expression of democracy in the name of national interest.

Thus, it seems a rationale exists to argue that democracy must be curbed at times to enable the singular pursuit of national interest, manifesting as a prosperity to curtail protests, reduce consultative governance and curb crushing voices of dissent, consultative decision making and restrict transparency, over centralize and even occasionally suspend democracy through acts like AFSPA.

Too little democracy – an alternative perspective

However, before drastic measures are taken, an alternative perspective must be considered. Considering the holistic perspective of democracy as an economic, social and political framework, does the Indian system at present have democracy in excess or is there in fact a dearth of it.

The same incidents we have already discussed can be re-assessed through this lens.

The problems of Kashmir are not just a question of territorial integrity but also one of deprivation of political participation, meaningful economic participation and opportunities and prevailing social tensions along communal lines. In summary, there is no democracy, political, economic or social.

Similarly, farmers in Punjab & Haryana faced a threat to their livelihoods from an act of legislation that was passed with little political consultation or participation. Regardless of whether the acts are effective in their stated intent or not is undercut by the perceived lack of a democratic attitude which prompted the protests in the first place.

Apart from these instances, where democracy itself seems to be lacking, the lack of quality in certain facets of Indian democracy are also a result of shortcomings in our understanding of democracy. Vote bank politics and freebies reflect the lack of social and economic democracy in India. Social inequities and the lack of meaningful economic participation thus also have a deleterious effect on political democracy.

This re-assessment thus opens the window to a new outlook. That perhaps is not an excess of democracy but a shortage of it that must be remedied. But to truly judge which of these outlooks to rely on, we must look to the past with an eye on the future.

A vision for India extracted from its past

Perhaps there are none better to judge the value and extent of democracy India requires and what it means for national interest – than the men and women who fought and bled for creating the modern Indian nations.

Bal Gangadhar Tilak famously proclaimed that Swaraj was his 'birthright', signaling not just a cry for sovereignty but also for democracy. The singular vision of the Congress as a movement was aimed at introducing responsible government and expanding franchise to create a representative government.

Mahatma Gandhi himself advocated for an extreme version of a decentralized democracy envisioned as an oceanic circle.

The ultimate vision of National Movement and its understanding of the National interest is also writ large in the Preamble of the Constitution where it guarantees justice, equality and liberty to all Indians.

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Thus, national interest lies in serving the interests of the people and in that respect, the question of overreach of democracy does not arise.

The glorious vision for a democratic India thus requires a deepening of democracy, where every citizen is informed, educated and socially and economically equipped to handle the responsibility of political democracy. Suspension and restriction of democratic tendencies are counterproductive to a vibrant democracy and is reflected in the poor performance of our country in indices which highlight the quality of our democracy such as the 'Freedom in the world' Report which describes the largest democracy in the world as 'Partly Free' and other reports which refer to India as a 'electoral autocracy'.

It is said that human being's capacity for justice makes democracy possible, but their inclination for injustice makes it necessary. In keeping with the vision of our founding fathers and the aspirations of our people, it is only reasonable to conclude that this justice is the ultimate national interest, and deepening democracy is thus not just possible but necessary.

►SOCIAL MEDIA AMPLIFIES HUMAN INTENT – BOTH GOOD AND BAD.

#SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY

As per latest reports, India is home to 833 million internet users and 600 million smart phone users. India is also seen as the fastest growing market for e-commerce and digital media sites. All major social media giants have penetrated deep into India's customer base, including people from ultra-rich background to lower-middle class and working classes. Indians have their WhatsApp, Facebook, and Instagram accounts. Social media has become the fastest means for social communication, information (or misinformation) dissemination, and social interaction.

India has witnessed the power of social media platforms in amplifying news, rumors, or any social issue. This has had both positive and negative outcomes. In early 2010s, when the social media platforms were new, (and yet saw booming user-base) India witnessed some of the watershed events like – Anti-corruption movement and Muzzafarnagar riots (2013). Both the above mentioned events were opposite in character (good and bad), however they had one similarity – role of social media in amplifying emotions and mobilizing masses: where social media was used as a platform to call for support against the evil of corruption and on the other hand social media was used to spread rumors to amplify the evil of communal riots.

Social Media & its Features

Social Media can be considered as the latest leg of the fourth pillar of Democracy, i.e., Media. Social Media is a special platform for communication, information, dissemination, education of the users, with the use of the internet and smartphone. Social Media platforms like WhatsApp are conversation platforms, whereas platforms like Instagram are more of community interaction platforms. Some features of social media –

- Fastest communication – with a click of the button.
- Anonymous – Fake IDs can be created and very difficult to establish.
- Global in nature: We can communicate across national boundaries at ease.
- Algorithm based: Leads to radicalization of the customer who is exposed to propagandas (say – leftist or rightest) owing to their personal interests.
- Amplifying human emotions – social media amplifies human intent – both good and bad. If a user wants, he/she can spread correct and useful information through stories or can spread 'one-sided and biased' articles/posts. Hence, the use of social media inherently depends upon the intent of the user.
- Internet based: Prone to cyber – breaches – Barrack Obama's Facebook account was hacked.
- Privacy breach – Social media giants gather, process and sell personal information.

Positive impacts of social media

Social Media has started playing a vital role in the lives of the people, where friends can stay connected from long distances, Government can educate the masses about schemes, corporate houses can show 'targeted advertisements' to the customers, and individuals can raise their voices against injustices. Social media has had a positive and constructive impact when viewed from the prism of society, economy, culture (History),

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Politics, Environment and overall development of the people.

Historical – Cultural impact: Various influencers on social media produce Info-videos on hidden treasures of India like puppetry (a dying Art form), secrets of Indian temples or unique creatures of Tribal India. This helps in educating the youth and instilling a sense of pride for the country.

Social Impact: Social media on several occasions have proved to be a platform to raise voices against injustices highlight issues and pressurize the Government to act. Example –social media was used to amplify the need for stricter laws against rape, after Nirbhaya case. This ultimately led to passage of 'Nirbhaya Kanoon' against rape. Arab Spring that led to the democratization of many Arabian countries was not possible without the power of social media. Social media has given voice to the voice-less and made privilege to air one's view widely, once possible for only few to many.

Economic Impact: social media and its algo-based marketing technique has helped many budding entrepreneurs to grow their business. Example – Shop via Instagram. The entire thrift shopping revolution is based on the social media websites.

Political Impact: Better and more diverse interaction between citizens and political parties/Government/ Ministries. Social Media allows easier two-way communication, which can be acknowledged by the people in power.

Environmental Impact: Amplifying the issues of Climate change, educating the masses and getting support for protection movements and fundraisers.

Impact on overall development of the people: social media has played a constructive role in the development of the weaker and vulnerable sections of the society. Examples – Reducing Vaccine Hesitancy using influencers in social media, giving a platform for talent (Ranu Mandal), Platform to raise funds (Baba Ka dhaba from Delhi).

Hence, social media has positively changed the way we interact and communicate. However, just like any other Technological tool, social media has also been misused for negative outcomes!

Negative impacts of social media

The features of Social Media platforms like anonymity, speed and mass-reach, at times proves to be a cause of concern. When social media is used with the bad intent, the misinformation spreads like wildfire, which does not give proper time for stakeholders to think rationally before they tend to react under negative emotions. Social Media has been used to spread rumors, malinformation, and propagandas.

"Man is what he knoweth" –Plato. Hence, if wrong or altered information is provided to the people, it tends to lead to negative outcomes like radicalization of the youth (ISIS terror recruitments via social media), increased communal differences leading to communal clashes (Kawardha communal riots due to propagandas via WhatsApp messaging), hate speech (Bulli-Bai case) etc.

Extreme ideologies (Right-wing news pages or left-wing news pages in social media), Wrong information (due to issue of fact-check), Cyber-bullying and body shaming (just because the person who comments feel that he/she is anonymous, sitting hundreds of kilometers away).

Reforming the social media

Social media has now become a part of our lives, which cannot and should not be taken away. Social Media is a powerful tool for right to freedom of speech and expression (A 19), which is inherent to a democracy. However, the need of the hour is to reduce the negative impact of social media on the society.

A step in this regard is the Digital Media (Ethics) Rules, 2021. These rules address issues such as social media platforms liable for mis-information, grievance redressal of users, and self-regulation, loose regulatory bodies to ensure compliance by social media giants, government backed fact check sites on the lines of Yahoo – check, bringing – in laws for hate speech as a separate criminal offence under IPC, Anti-Cyber bullying policies, and of course, passage of Data Protection Bill for data privacy.

In the arguments for and against the use of social media it must be now clear that the use depends on the 'intent of humans'. Social Media is a blessing for people to raise their voices, and hence the stakeholders – Government, Social Media Companies, Civil Society, and the citizens, must work towards

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promoting the positives of the social media, and at the same time regulating the negatives through legal and innovative measures.

►TECHNOLOGY AS SILENT FACTOR IN INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

#INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

Technological revolution arrived after the arrival of Renaissance in mediaeval Europe. It has been a major turning point in human history. Technology has not just enhanced the living conditions in a limited area but its ripples were felt all around the world. This development brought many like-minded as well as enemy nations to common consensus of mutual relation and collaboration integrated with ideology. The advancement has also led to saying " there are no permanent enemies or friends in international relations but only permanent interest".

We would understand in this essay, how have international relations in the world transformed from one of isolation to one of integration and mutual goodwill. Also, how has been this transformation in international relations been interest based, a major driver of which has been technology and its evolution.

Technology is derived from the word technique, which means a way to get a particular task accomplished. Thus, technology is a mechanism which transforms theoretical knowledge into workable techniques which are reliable, robust, repeatable and efficient. Technology enhances human productivity and makes tougher tasks easier. This technological revolution started in Britain with the industrial revolution and scientific revolution and has gradually impacted the whole world.

During the early years of 18th century, at the peak of Renaissance, many disciplines like science, economics, etc flourished, leading to many innovations. These innovations not just affected economy, society but it also has transformed the relations of nations with other nations. The age of imperialism and colonialism could not have been successful without superior technological capability of the Western European countries. The technological innovation gradually transformed international relations from economics oriented to ideological oriented. We shall look into this transformation of international relations with every new technological paradigm.

How international relation began to gain importance and turn interest based?

With the invention of Spinning Jenny, textile industries saw a boon in Britain. This innovation led to increase in consumption of cotton which was imported from America and Asia. This revolution led to increase in production of clothes and thus the size of market fell short to the production.

The new explored lands started to become the new market and source of raw materials for these industries. The economic gains out of the textile innovation helped Britain to invest in developing factory systems in first half of eighteenth century. Gradually, this factory system started to flourish in other European countries as well as the British colonies. This greatly enhanced the power of Britain in the 18th century. Many rival nations realised the superiority of British and made peace with them by entering into matrimonial alliances. Thus, began the new era for European dominance of world economics and politics. But, this dominance of Europe came at the cost of people in Asia and Americas.

The society in Asia started declining due to the end of old feudal lords and rise of new trader and merchant class. The agricultural labour divided between farm labour and industrial worker. But this development did not bring about change in living standard of labourers and workers. The misery of the third estate has been studied and reflected upon by many scholars from sociology, philosophy, etc., giving rise to the ideas of capitalism and Marxism. The world started dividing between capitalist and communist ideas.

The innovations in late eighteenth and first half of nineteenth century were focussed on improving military might and communication revolution.

The Innovation of Telegraph and typewriter changed the way the world communicated. Initially, the use of typewriters had been in the government systems for the purpose of documentation. Posts and letters were the only way to communicate for a country during the times of war and administrative affairs. But soon, posts and letters, began to lose their importance and Telegraph became central.

The telegraph soon became an important mode of communication as normal means such as letters and posts would take too long a time to transmit

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messages. This improved connectivity and communication among people across different parts of the world. But the telegraph innovation soon had to be supported by robust means of transportation for transporting goods and people.

Mining of iron ore and steel increased for supporting building of railroads and steam engines. These steam engines and railroads played an important role in the system of imperialism. While the early years of 19th century saw steam engine revolutionise steam ships and travel on the sea route, the latter half of nineteenth century saw the steam engine revolutionise travel on land by way of railroads. This transport revolution supported capitalist countries by making it easy and quick to transport raw materials and manufactured goods. This also improved the movement of people and military in and outside countries.

This invention helped Britain and allied partners to fight against rival imperial powers like Russia and Japan. The goal of having an upper edge over rivals led to constant innovations and evolution of arms and aminations. The urge to capture more territory led to a military technology revolution in the early twentieth century with the invention of artillery tanks, which played important role during the World War I.

World War I saw widespread loss of life and destruction of property. It was realised that peace was a valuable goal. For the first time an arrangement in the form of League of Nations was established to bring enduring peace after World War I. The League of Nations informed the United Nations which was established after World War II.

Despite the League of Nations working for peace and tranquillity, war returned to Europe and the World soon. The period after World War I saw the rise of dictators and authoritative regimes across Europe. The rise of leaders like Hitler in Germany, Mussolini in Italy and others openly professed racism, bloodshed and war as a means for the political ends. World War 2 was the result of their insatiable urge for power. The war initially confined to Europe became a total war and reached various corners of the world. World War II saw the use of fighter aeroplanes and use of submarines for the first time. These technologies were reasons for early success of Germany under Hitler. However, the American intervention and bombing of Hiroshima and Nagasaki using the nuclear weapons quickly ended the war. However, the nuclear bombs killed lakhs of people in these cities and reflected the cruel use of nuclear technology.

Bretton Woods conference and rise of New International Relation.

The period after World War II, saw the need for developing and rebuilding the world. This period saw the formation of new institutions such as Bretton Woods institutions (IMF, World Bank and GATT) which aimed to create a world order which was rules based orderly and peaceful in the long run. They extended financial assistance to nations and supported rebuilding of their infrastructure. However, despite the USSR and USA fighting the together in the World War II, USA's insecurity against communism led to the onset of Cold War in the world. The world was divided into two blocks. A nuclear armed race started in the world as countries felt that nuclear bombs were essential for guarantee of security.

International Treaty and agreement to stop the nuclear race

Countries one after another began developing their nuclear weapons and testing them. Post nuclear weapon testing by India under 'Operation Smiling Buddha', there was felt the need for "nuclear non-proliferation treaty".

Thus, technology has become the single most important factor in the world affairs. The rise of computers and age of internet has brought world further closer to each other. Computers and Internet based technologies have revolutionised the world by making it possible to communicate between two persons in real time. These technologies have had profound effect from global to individual level, paving way for a flatter planet i.e., globalisation.

At the same time, computers made computations faster and more efficient, they helped design better machines and manufacturing systems. This has given a big boost to automobile industries by introduction of assembly lines for manufacturing, production process, etc. However, this internet-based technologies have given rise to new challenges of cyber-crime, hacking, snooping and other cyber-security issues.

Internet and Artificial Intelligence

The era of robotics with artificial intelligence has been vulnerable to digital attacks. The Budapest convention, Five Eyes Nation, intelligence sharing, etc had been part of global effort to tackle these issues. The rising threats have made countries Technology based assets at high risk of Rival attack costing

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millions of dollars loss and even may affect the economy.

Biology and biotechnology have been at the frontier of technological advancement in the last century. Genetic engineering of crops like Bt-brinjal, etc have been effective in addressing problems of pest, disease, etc and improved crop productivity. They have been crucial in many parts of the world in ensuring food security and addressing malnutrition.

Various interventions in the form better medicines, vaccines and treatment protocols have been developed to counter life threatening diseases improving quality of life of people. Thus, developments in biology and biotechnology have been a boon for humanity.

Thus, technology has played crucial role in determining the contours of international relations at every point in time. Each new invention and innovations make humanity empowered, leads to ease of living, towards intermixing of varied cultures and evolving a common consensus. It is not the technology as such however the intention with which it is used that leads to challenges for humanity and international relations. For example, nuclear technology can be used for both nuclear weapons and nuclear power. Thus, the need is ethics and ethical management and use of technology.

The focus of international relations has been traditionally on power, narrow national interest rather than benefit of humanity as a whole. Thus, in the new era, the upcoming generation needs to be collaborative and deliver for humanity as a whole.

►DEMOCRACY IS NOT ONLY ABOUT ELECTIONS, BUT IT IS GOOD GOVERNANCE AFTER ELECTIONS

GOVERNANCE

The objective of democracy is putting in place a government to govern after the elections. Conducting elections is inevitable for exercising universal adult suffrage in a democracy, but it is only a means to an end, but not an end in itself. Democracy loses its substantial energy in party politicking, leadership tussles, elections and power games. Democracy is a form of government in which people exercise the decision-making power either directly or through their representatives. In a representative form of the government, the rulers are elected by the people. Thus, free and fair elections form the bedrock of any vibrant democracy. The government formed must function in accordance with the commonly agreed principles of governance by the people in the form of the constitution. It is elected to implement the objectives such as justice, equality, liberty and fraternity outlined in the Preamble to the constitution as well as Directive Principles of State Policy (DPSP). As John Kay explains, "The people who own the country ought to govern it."

Fernando Cardoso is right: "Democracy is not just a question of having a vote. It consists of strengthening each citizen's possibility and capacity to participate in the deliberations involved in life in society." Indian masses have reposed their faith in elections as a mode of choosing their rulers and find wider social acceptance in the political culture of India.

The constitution of India provides the direction to the elected government in the form of the preamble to the constitution and DPSPs. DPSPs outline the goals set by the constituent assembly for future governments and aspirations of the people that the elected governments should work for. Today, the important issues of governance include a range of subjects such as realizing economic growth potential of 8% and above for the country, modernizing agriculture and making it a profitable and desirable profession, making India a manufacturing hub, realising service sector growth potential and making India a knowledge economy, arresting the problem of mounting unemployment and harnessing the demographic dividend, providing robust infrastructure, inclusive growth, access to universal health and education and addressing malnutrition, gender equality and issues of vulnerable groups. Governance must put in place proper legal, judicial and police reforms, Civil Services Reforms. The government must undertake balanced regional development, especially for Northeast region.

Too much focus on elections as symbol of democracy is doing disservice to the entire range and concept of democracy. Corrupt electoral practices become the fountainhead of all evils in the governance and administration. It has created a system where everyone from a voter to those holding the ministerial positions poses himself/herself as a victim of corruption. The cycle of corruption starts from bribing voters in different forms and ultimately ends in the poor governance and delivery of services affecting the

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voters itself. Freebies are announced without taking into due consideration their impact on financial management. Politics has become highly competitive. Winning elections by announcing freebies is preferred over sound fiscal management. Winning ability in elections is often not based on good leadership. Many criminals who break laws contest elections and become law makers. The combinations of money and muscle power, along with social acceptance enable candidates with criminal backgrounds high wining ability.

Association of Democratic Reforms (ADR) statistics show that due to weaknesses of criminal justice system and putting aside of ideals by the political parties, a high percentage of representatives in India have criminal cases pending against them. They further undermine the law and order machinery and ultimately governance suffers. First Past The Post (FPTP) system fails in giving due representation to minority voices, which get muzzled. Issues of sections such as women, children, tribal, physically disabled or old people get low priority. It is one of the fallouts of the FPTP. Governance issues related to them get neglected as they are considered less important from electoral perspective.

Gandhiji visualized, "I understand democracy as something that gives the weak the same chance as the strong." Formulation of policies and laws must be the prime concern of the people's representatives. However, focus gets shifted to waive agriculture loans and free power for irrigation, etc., rather than improving productivity and sustainable agriculture. The core development issues are neglected. Policies related to Uniform Civil Code, etc. take precedence over socio-economic development and welfare measures.

The issue is how to reduce the centrality of the elections and bring governance to the forefront in Indian democracy. Auditing of the election promises of political parties must be built into the political culture. Political parties and leaders must be made accountable. Rational Media has a great role to play. People friendly media platforms can be used for political debates on citizen centric governance. Civil society organizations can perform the auditing to put a rigorous accountability framework and analysis of political parties work before the people. Cleansing the electoral funding is a must. State funding of elections, as suggested by the Indrajit Gupta committee report, must be implemented. Political parties must be put under RTI. Reducing frequency of elections to 2-3 during the cycle of five years can be tried. Further, statutory backing to Model code of conduct can play a significant role. Disqualification of MLAs and MPs, and debarring of candidates from contesting in elections against whom charges of serious criminal offences have been framed must be implemented. Empowering election commission is a must to make it fully independent and immune from political pressure and biases. There must be introduction of a collegium system for the appointment of CEC and other election commissioners. Making its expenditure charged upon the Consolidated Fund of India. Same protection must be provided to other election commissioners as given to CEC.

Conclusion: Most modern democracies are based on representative form of the government. Elections play an indispensable part in a representative democracy. However, elections are just a tool to achieve the wider aim of good governance and realizing the aspirations of the people. The power, prestige and money associated with political offices have made elections the prime focus of democracy. Capturing political power has become the central concern. The centrality of governance in democracy can be restored through long-pending electoral reforms and putting the electoral promises of the political parties from past election to a rigorous test before next elections. Only then the democracy will become "the government of the people, by the people and for the people," instead of a government by the politicians, of the politicians and for the politicians.

►AATMANIRBHAR BHARAT

#SELF-RELIANCE

"You have to dream before your dreams can come true" - Dr. APJ Abdul Kalaam

It's self-evident that the above line aptly captures the true essence of performing the act of dreaming and envisioning about one's ambitions. It's a time-tested principle – man started dreaming right from the age he kick-started the civilisation process. Since times immemorial to this date, contexts have changed, but the significance of dreams in every success story hasn't diminished, and that it's testimonized by the very fact that dreams form a quintessential ingredient of every fable that talks of people conquering unfathomable heights.

Also it's a fact well established that the goods and dreams of the nation, itself is shaped and carved by

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the individuals it comprises of: after all, individuals are the basic unit of a society and an aggregation of societies collaborates to be called together as a nation. Undoubtedly, and quite similarly though, India has its own set of aspirations, as diverse and as holistic as its vast geographical presence and myriad cultural colours, as profound as its spiritual richness, as passionate as its population and as great as its historical riches. There are 'visions' and not dreams of creating the foundation of a new India, as dreams might become feeble over time, but its visions that are concertised by the virtue of sheer commitments and efficient, meticulous planning. There are visions of creating a new order, visions of creating 'Aatmanirbhar Bharat'.

Such were the visions envisaged by the founding fathers of the country, where they clearly laid down ever cherished principles for the future generations to be attained, in order to create the India that stands out from the rest. The holy book of the religion of nationalism, the Constitution of India, itself serves as a torch-bearer for the mandarins and citizens of the country to realize these socio-economic-political aspirations. The **Preamble of the Constitution**, itself, clearly presents the core values of Aatmanirbhar Bharat, in an explicit fashion.

> We, The PEOPLE OF INDIA, having solemnly resolved to constitute India into a SOVEREIGN, SOCIALIST, SECULAR, DEMOCRATIC, REPUBLIC and to guarantee to all its citizens.
>
> **Justice,** social, economic and political;
>
> **Liberty** of thought, expression, belief, faith and Worship;
>
> **Equality** of status and opportunity; and to promote among them all;
>
> **Fraternity**, assuring dignity of individuals and unity and integrity of the Nation;
>
> IN OUR CONSTITUENT ASSEMBLY, this 26th day of November 1949, do HEREBY ADOPT, ENACT and GIVE TO OURSELVES THIS CONSTITUTION.

To decipher the meaning of the highlighted terms of the Preamble, is a no lawyer's paradise only. It has been meant for every citizen of the country. These goals had already been identified by our forefathers, who shaped the destiny of the country. To continue being a sovereign and a truly independent nation, promoting welfare measures for the masses, paying equal respect and tolerance for a mutual and harmonious co-existence of all religions, valuing democracy to its core and recognising the powers of the citizens in forming the government – are some of the fundamental and rock-hard aspiration of India as a country.

Citizens have always been the 'MAGNA CARTA' of India's aspiration. Thus, guaranteeing precious political virtues as inalienable as justice, liberty, equality, fundamental rights and promotion of fraternity, has been given a top-notch priority to the Dream-List of the Country.

However, linking the dots with prudence and pragmatism, it's high-time that India looks forward to revolutionise its existing approaches and targets, in all spheres and realms. We are in the 21st century, one of the radical periods of all times, witnessing fast-paced growth and a huge bag filled with challenges and opportunities alike. It is in these circumstances that we have to establish India as a world leader; and thus, it's in this context that it's imperative to revise our goals, which requires sheer resoluteness and a firm vision in our hearts and mind.

From a social angle, we need to **cater to the masses.** Critiques say over population is a humongous challenge for the country, but optimists declare the same as a prospective opportunity. Thus, with such a mammoth population, it's urgent to plan and implement strategies that works the best towards this direction and plays an integral role in maximising the potential of our human capital, which stands under-utilised till date. This requires a robust growth in the social infrastructure set up, mechanisms to ensure a well-educated and a healthy life to all. Improvisations in availability, accessibility and feasibility of health care facilities and educational services form the core of the same. Allied factors as clean drinking water and a sound situation of sanitation, also plays a critical role. The government's plan of National Health Protection Scheme and the flagship programmes like Swachh Bharat Abhiyaan, are adequate steps in the same direction. It's prudent to recognise the fact that health and education are the basic prerequisites for development of the human capabilities and enlarging their progress – hence, needless to mention, these areas will always be prioritised over the rest.

Talking about social setups and access to resources, one of the key beneficiaries that needs urgent attention, but unfortunately, faces utter neglect – are the WOMEN, the FEMALE FORCE. Though we have been successful in accelerating our growth rates, we have still not managed to cope up with our parochial outlook and let women go out of their traditional

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roles, thus limiting their exposure to and participation in the development and decision making process. Achieving greater gender equity and restoring gender imbalances, with an equal emphasis on providing equitable opportunities to women, ensuring their security stands as an unquestionable target to be achieved by India, in the coming direction.

As we kick-start our voyage towards becoming an influential global force, it's high time that we gradually move from traditional 'Roti, Kapda, Makaan, Paani, Bijli' rhetoric. As a nation that intends to develop as a global power, we need to empower the citizens, both economically and socially. We need to move from **'SUSTENANCE TO SUSTAINABILITY'**. Our economic agenda must be in consonance with our geo-political ambitions, and thus needs to reflect the same commitment. There has to be a gradual transition from India being an agrarian economy to an industrial power, a thriving centre for employment opportunities, a hub for entrepreneurship, innovation and intellect, an economy synergising sustainability with efficiency in the most optimum fashion, A country committing to Zero Defect (Professional Competency Efficiency) + Zero Effect (Environment Sustainability).

Coming back to the real world, there is an urgent need to fill the chasm between the primary and the secondary sectors for preventing escalation in the existing 'BHARAT-INDIA' divide. In such context, agrarian reforms are requiring dynamic immediacy. Saying adherence to our former PM, Lal Bahadur Shastri, wherein he saluted the hardships of the farmers by winning 'Jai Jawan, Jai Kisan' we need to introduce sustainable agricultural reforms that ensure food security along with securing the producer efficiently. Also, it's the need of hour to link science with agriculture and thus focussing on aggravating the potential of the production process as well as doubling the farmer's income.

Economy has to be revitalised with technology and the e-conversion of existing economic schemes and provisions, will certainly yield a positive impact on the country as a whole. Pressing for greater digitalisation and cashless transactions, is a suitable measure to check leakages and discrepancies in the process, thus saving the drainage of millions of resources from the national exchequer. Strengthening of banking system by introducing various measures as recapitalisation, Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, DBT (Direct Banking Transfers) to farmer is a satisfactory action towards the same. Ultimately, all of it has to be equitable in nature, thus increasing the necessity of emphasizing upon 'Financial Inclusion' as a critical element in the entire process of economic rejuvenation.

Entering the global leadership can't be attained without achieving strides in the realm of **scientific innovation and technology.** Technological upgradation, sustainable automation and Research and Development in Science and Allied fields have to be some of the key indicators to track India's progress in the field. It's crucial to link science with the masses in order to get the best out of it. Scientific intervention in medicines for finding cure of deadly health problems and technological betterment in areas of disaster forecasting, telecommunications etc., require sustained actions. Also, the emphasis will be on 'Maximum innovation with minimum destruction', thereby making unconventional energy usage important for development. It's a need to shift from gaining 'Nuclear Capabilities to Human Capabilities' with Science, so as to establish an ideal society that uses its technology as a tool for human betterment and progress.

Curbing corruption, enhancing accountability and transparency, promoting female participation in politics and decision-making, checking red-tapeism, fastening speedy judicial system and an efficient policing mechanism are some of the existing goals in our list that need immediate attention and action for the development of the public-political order in the country.

Standing at the threshold of being 'DEVELOPED' from a 'DEVELOPING' nation, it becomes imperative to contextualise our visions for NEW INDIA, from the perspective of the international angle. Strategic leadership and strengthening of diplomatic ties with game changer nations, has to have a definite place in our list. This has to be done for seeking international cooperation and attempting to be an influential force in terms of tackling global issues as terrorism, cybercrimes, climate change and health epidemics. This would also mean a firm step towards attempting to attain a permanent seat in the UN Security Council, and thus attaining a permanent membership and legitimate authority and responsibility to shape the new international order.

However, aspirations are to be seen with open eyes. It has to be different from fantasies, and grounded in the idea of reality. It has to be supported by actions

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and truly unshakable determination to achieve the same.

Our ancient scriptures also reiterate the same*: (It takes sweat and actions to realise aspirations and not merely dreams, just like the way a sleeping lion can't get a deer right away near him, only because he dreams it.)*

Ours', being a nation, guided by our rich, enlightening past, it becomes essential on our part to lay down clear plans to fulfil our vision and turn it into reality. This will require tapping the potentialities of the youth and channelising it towards constructive forces and a resolute commitment by all people, from all strata of the society. We need to evolve a coherent and firm partnership among all stakeholders to accelerate our development pace. Narrow prejudices need to be kept aside before national interest.

Finally, **'Nation first, Self-Last'** has to be the over-arching principle and ever-green mantra before kick-starting this mammoth exercise. There has to be a leap, a giant leap to acquire 'AATMANIRBHAR' status. We, as Indians, need to dream of such visions that don't let us sleep and rest, we need to be awake to set an example for the world to follow, we, as Indians need to prove our mettle.

As earlier at the cusp of independence, while the world was sleeping, our forefathers were awake at the stroke of the midnight hour on 15th August, 1947 to make a 'Tryst with Destiny'. A similar episode has to repeat itself where we, as 135 crore Indians, make a 'tryst with Excellence' where we stand unified as a global democratic leader, achieving incomparable strides through our massive human potential, coupled with cultural and social solidarity of thought to attain the status of Aatmanirbhar Bharat.

►DEMOCRACY IS NOT JUST A QUESTION OF HAVING A VOTE

#DEMOCRACY, POLITY AND GOVERNANCE

The objective of democracy is putting in place a government to govern after the elections. Conducting elections is inevitable for exercising universal adult suffrage in a democracy, but it is only a means to an end, but not an end in itself. Democracy loses its substantial energy in party politicking, leadership tussles, elections and power games. Democracy is a form of government in which people exercise the decision-making power either directly or through their representatives. In a representative form of the government, the rulers are elected by the people. Thus, free and fair elections form the bedrock of any vibrant democracy. The government formed must function in accordance with the commonly agreed principles of governance by the people in the form of the constitution. It is elected to implement the objectives such as justice, equality, liberty and fraternity outlined in the Preamble to the constitution as well as Directive Principles of State Policy (DPSP). **As John Kay explains, "The people who own the country ought to govern it."**

Fernando Cardoso is right: **"Democracy is not just a question of having a vote. It consists of strengthening each citizen's possibility and capacity to participate in the deliberations involved in life in society."** Indian masses have reposed their faith in elections as a mode of choosing their rulers and find wider social acceptance in the political culture of India.

The constitution of India provides the direction to the elected government in the form of the Preamble to the constitution and DPSPs. DPSPs outline the goals set by the constituent assembly for future governments and aspirations of the people that the elected governments should work for. Today, the important issues of governance include a range of subjects such as realising economic growth potential of 8% and above for the country, modernising agriculture and making it a profitable and desirable profession, making India a manufacturing hub, realising service sector growth potential and making India a knowledge economy, arresting the problem of mounting unemployment and harnessing the demographic dividend, providing robust infrastructure, inclusive growth, access to universal health and education and addressing malnutrition, gender equality and issues of vulnerable groups. Governance must put in place proper legal, judicial and police reforms, Civil Services Reforms. The government must undertake balanced regional development, especially for Northeast region.

Too much focus on elections as symbol of democracy is doing disservice to the entire range and concept of democracy. Corrupt electoral practices become the fountainhead of all evils in the governance and administration. It has created a system where everyone from a voter to those holding the ministerial positions poses himself/herself as a victim of corruption. The cycle of corruption starts from bribing voters in different forms and ultimately ends in the poor governance and delivery of services affecting the

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voters itself. Freebies are announced without taking into due consideration their impact on financial management. Politics has become highly competitive. Winning elections by announcing freebies is preferred over sound fiscal management. Winning ability in elections is often not based on good leadership. Many criminals who break laws contest elections and become law makers. The combinations of money and muscle power, along with social acceptance enable candidates with criminal backgrounds high wining ability.

Association of Democratic Reforms (ADR) statistics show that due to weaknesses of criminal justice system and putting aside of ideals by the political parties, a high percentage of representatives in India have criminal cases pending against them. They further undermine the law and order machinery and ultimately governance suffers. First Past The Post (FPTP) system fails in giving due representation to minority voices, which get muzzled. Issues of sections such as women, children, tribal, physically disabled or old people get low priority. It is one of the fallouts of the FPTP. Governance issues related to them get neglected as they are considered less important from electoral perspective.

Gandhi visualized, "I understand democracy as something that gives the weak the same chance as the strong." Formulation of policies and laws must be the prime concern of the people's representatives. However, focus gets shifted to waive agriculture loans and free power for irrigation, etc., rather than improving productivity and sustainable agriculture. The core development issues are neglected. Policies related to Uniform Civil Code, etc. take precedence over socio-economic development and welfare measures.

The issue is how to reduce the centrality of the elections and bring governance to the forefront in Indian democracy. Auditing of the election promises of political parties must be built into the political culture. Political parties and leaders must be made accountable. Rational Media has a great role to play. People friendly media platforms can be used for political debates on citizen centric governance. Civil society organizations can perform the auditing to put a rigorous accountability framework and analysis of political parties work before the people. Cleansing the electoral funding is a must. State funding of elections, as suggested by the Indrajit Gupta committee report, must be implemented. Political parties must be put under RTI. Reducing frequency of elections to 2-3 during the cycle of five years can be tried. Further, statutory backing to Model code of conduct can play a significant role. Disqualification of MLAs and MPs, and debarring of candidates from contesting in elections against whom charges of serious criminal offences have been framed must be implemented. Empowering election commission is a must to make it fully independent and immune from political pressure and biases. There must be introduction of a collegium system for the appointment of CEC and other election commissioners. Making its expenditure charged upon the Consolidated Fund of India. Same protection must be provided to other election commissioners as given to CEC.

Most modern democracies are based on representative form of the government. Elections play an indispensable part in a representative democracy. However, elections are just a tool to achieve the wider aim of good governance and realizing the aspirations of the people. The power, prestige and money associated with political offices have made elections the prime focus of democracy. Capturing political power has become the central concern. The centrality of governance in democracy can be restored through long-pending electoral reforms and putting the electoral promises of the political parties from past election to a rigorous test before next elections. Only then the democracy will become "the government of the people, by the people and for the people," instead of a government by the politicians, of the politicians and for the politicians.

►COOPERATIVE FEDERALISM: MYTH OR REALITY

#CENTRE-STATE RELATIONS

Conditions of India at the time of independence in 1947 were the guiding factor behind the shape and design of Indian constitution. One of the biggest element of Indian constitution was to make India a cooperative federal state. In contrast to unitary state, India, being extremely diverse country not just geographically but also culturally, chose federal model. But, India was not exactly one identity at the time of independence. It suffered from separatism, regional inequalities and most importantly inadequate nation building. Thus, rather than adopting US–type dual federalism, India adopter centrally tilting cooperative federalism.

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However, we should realize that our forefathers, being humans, took their decision with colonial experience in their mind. Therefore, rather than stability, India preferred representiveness and accountability. Thus, despite being federal state, India adopted Parliament system.

Thus, Party Politics of India is able to distort Indian federalism. For example, Article 356 misuse and activism by Governor only happens in states where opposition party is ruling. Moreover, inter state issues like inter state water issues gets political hype only when different political parties are ruling in different states.

Therefore, a rational conclusion is that cooperative federalism in India as envisioned by constitution remains a myth. However, this essay will focus on how to make cooperative federalism a reality in India. But, first let us look at the depth of distortion that party politics bring in federalism of India.

Tribhang of Indian Federalism:

As explained before, Indian federalism gets distorted by political party system of India. This distortion is most noticeable in political sphere but as politics is Athashastra, the distorting effect is also felt in economic sphere.

Starting with political sphere, the distorting causes crisis of nation building. Regional political parties make sure that regional identity remains strong. However, national political parties try to focus on unity in uniformity. This tension leads to nation building crisis.

Moreover, the distortion distorts the constitutional post of governor. He was made head of the state to emphasise on unity of India and he was made only a nominal head to make Indian unity compatible with diversity. However, in practice Governor is agent of political ruling at center. Thus, in states where opposition party is ruling, becomes very activist. For example, Lt. Governor and Administrator of Delhi and Pondicherry are very active. Plus, during the time of political instability in states like Rajasthan, Maharashtra and Karnataka, Governor's activism is tilted towards centre.

Further, the distortion has made mockery of Article 356. As per Architect of Constitution**, B. R. Ambedkar Article 356 was to be a dead letter.** Yet, political history of India speaks loudly that Article 356 only barks at opposition ruled states.

Moving on, in economic sphere, central government through Finance Commission and Planning Commission (now not existant) was expected to reduce developmental imbalance in India. Instead of this, economic policies of center has always benifited states where its party rules. This becomes evident by looking at North-South imbalance in distribution of tax revenue. Also, the neglect of North East States has to, a lot of extent, do with low seat share of North East in Parliament.

Thus, Cooperative Federalism in India is definitely a myth. However, it can become a reality if India is willing to take difficult but doable reforms.

Making Cooperative Federalism a Reality: To highlight the crux of the matter, we should remember M. N. Venkat Challiyah Commissions observation that no political reforms will be successful if political party are not reformed. Therefore, the first step to make cooperative federalism a reality is to make **Indian Political Parties democratic**. Only when party leaders are elected by party members, then the state leaders will actually become free from remote control of national leaders. This freedom will provide foundation to cooperative federalism where states will gaim significant autonomy from center.

However, still centre retains governor-route to mingle with state's decision making. Therefore, logical next step should be to **reform post of governor**. On this **Sarkaria Commission** has suggested to retain all provisions of governor in the constitution as they currently are. However, Sarkaria Commission has suggested methods to realise constitutional morality of Governor. The Commission suggests to codify conventions regarding governor's appointment, removal and functioning.

For example, the code should provide for consultation with Chief Minister while appointing Governor. Further, the code should direct that Governor should be non-political person and outsider of the state he is going to be nominated.

Moving on to the **Third step**, we need to ensure that dispute resolution between federal units happen with the spirit of cooperative federalism. This requires consultation on regular basis for resolving day to day federal issues. For this, institution of Zonal Councils should be revived.

However, the real disputes between federal units are on major policy issue. Honoring the foresight of constitutional makers, we can use **Article 263 inter-state councils** to get consensus among federal units so that policy reflects cooperative federalism. The example of GST council and 101st Constitutional Amendment Act is a case in point.

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Further, for dealing with inter-state river water disputes, we need to promote bottom-up political negotiations rather than top-down tribunal arbitration. The recent amendment to inter-state water disputes Act is welcomed on this ground. Therefore, the political will for implementing it is need of hour.

Lastly, as politics is arthashastra, institution of Finance Commission needs reforms similar to the reforms that made Planning Commission into Niti Aayog. Therefore, Team India is also needed to decide on the members and terms of reference of Finance Commission.

Thus, we can ensure that polity of India reflects cooperative federalism. But, how will the status-quo change? Why people benefiting from the status quo agree to change it? The answer to this is simple "No! they will not agree to change." Thus, we the people of India needs to force change. Therefore, the civil society needs to come out and go to people's room and educate them on the benefits of cooperative federalism. Citizens need to be educated that their problems are divided between different federal units and therefore, only cooperative federalism could provide them meaningful resolution.

Thus, the making of cooperative federalism as real fact in Indian political system is going to be protracted conflict. But, the democracy of India can ensure everyone that if the people of India have made up their mind to live in harmonious political system, then no one can stop the change.

Therefore, remember Gandhi "Be the change you want to see" and go out, join civil society, contribute and make history.

►DECENTRALISATION OF POWER AND IMPORTANCE OF PANCHAYATS

#PANCHAYATI RAJ INSTITUTIONS

The essence of democracy is decentralisation of power and allowing governance to reach the grass roots for the welfare of people. Local government elected by the people thus imbibes democratic functioning of the society involving residents of the area. The concept of local government has been in India ever since the dawn of civilisation in various forms including that of Sabhas and Samitis at the village level. It was in the **year 1882 when Lord Ripon** issued a resolution on **Local Self Government**. Objections were raised by the bureaucracy of those days against any extension of the powers of local bodies and giving them a democratic character. It was a comprehensive resolution which dealt with administrative areas, the constitution of local bodies, their functions, finances and powers. This was an important landmark in the evolution of local self-government in India. This led to the strengthening of local institution over a period of time leading to its incorporation in **PART IV** of the Indian Constitution.

Article 40 of the Constitution provides for organisation of village panchayats and also endows them with such powers and authority to enable them to function as units of self-government. But Article 40 being part of **Directive Principles of State Policy** could not be judicially imposed. Consequently, Government of India constituted various committees for the proper functioning and devolution power at the ground level. The government accepted the recommendations of **Balwant Rai Mehta Committee** which proposed to set up a three tier structure of panchayats in India having **Gram Panchayats** at the village level, **Panchayat Samiti** at the block level and **Zilla Parishad** at the district level. It was also considered that there is an imperative need to enshrine in the Constitution certain basic and essential features of Panchayati Raj Institutions to impart strength, certainty and continuity to it. Thus, accordingly the Constitution (Seventy-Third Amendment) Act, 1992 and Constitution (Seventy-Fourth Amendment) Act, 1992 were enacted by the government.

PART IX and IXA were added to the Constitution after the amendment. It provides for constitution of **Panchayat** at the village, intermediate and district level; **Gram Sabha** at the village level consisting of persons registered in the electoral rolls of the village; **Reservation of seats** for Scheduled Caste, Scheduled Tribes, women; constitution of **Finance Commission** to review financial position of Panchayats and make suitable recommendations for devolution of funds to panchayats; elections to be conducted for panchayats by State Election Commission.

PART IXA provides for the constitution and composition of **Municipalities; Ward Committees**; power to impose tax by municipalities; **Finance Commission** to review financial position of municipalities and allocate taxes; election to municipalities; **District Planning Committee** and **Metropolitan planning Committee**.

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On the basis of above, the Panchayati Raj Institutions have been in existence for a long time, the participation of people at the grass root level has become more of a bureaucratic and mechanical exercise. There have been various instances in the past where approval from Gram Sabha has been either forced or forged for acquisition of land for various commercial purposes including mining. Even the local bureaucracy has not helped much in nurturing the institution to grow and sustain at ground level. Merely by making panchayats a part of the Constitution will not solve the case of grass root democracy unless its limbs are empowered. Thus, the core issues of local self- governance involve the '**principle of subsidiarity'** which means that what can best be done at the lower levels of government should not be centralised at higher levels; a clear delineation of functions entrusted to the local bodies; effective devolution of financial powers and functions and convergence of services for the citizens as well as citizens centric governance structures.

The Second Administrative Reform Commission (2nd ARC) on **'Local Governance'** has suggested various measures to address these core issues. For example:-

Constitutional status to panchayats and municipalities aimed at a fundamental shift in the nature of governance. However, experience of the past suggests that creating structures of elected local governments and ensuring regular elections do not necessarily guarantee effective local empowerment. While Panchayats, Nagarpalikas and Municipalities have come into existence and elections are being held, this has not always translated into real decentralisation of power because the Constitution left the issue of degree of empowerment and devolution to the State Legislature. State Governments and their bureaucracy are not always in favour to effectively empower local governments because they view it as diminishing of their power and hold. Even mandatory provisions like the constitution of District Planning Committees and Metropolitan Planning Committees have been ignored in many States. Thus, compulsory empowerment of panchayats and municipalities by the state having a dedicated bureaucracy at ground level is necessary for effective local empowerment.

Under **Article 243G**, while framing laws on Panchayats, State Legislatures should endow these institutions 'with such power and authority as may be necessary to enable them to function as institutions of self-government'. Thus, Panchayats are 'governments at their own level' and have autonomous jurisdiction of their own. However, the problem arises when we find government functioning at various levels thereby creating overlapping jurisdiction and autonomy. In such a case, autonomy of one may rub against autonomy of another in similar jurisdictions. Thus, providing autonomy to panchayats will also mean withdrawal of certain activities or functions from the State Government and transferring them to local bodies. This will give panchayats a true independent and autonomous identity independent from the state government to perform their power and functions.

Powers to panchayats and municipalities have been provided to enable them to function as institutions of self- governance under **Article 243 (G) and 243(W)** respectively. For this, they may also be empowered to prepare local plans for economic development and social justice and to implement schemes and perform functions including those listed in the **Eleventh** and **Twelfth Schedules**. However, the past experience suggests that progress of devolution of powers and responsibilities to local governments at various levels have been poor and uneven. The implementation space at local levels is thus occupied by a multiplicity of governmental agencies leading to confusion, unnecessary duplication and wastage of funds. Thus, there should be clear delineation of functions for each level of local government. It has to be done continuously by restructuring organisations and framing subject-matter laws so as to avoid overlapping of functions. 2nd ARC has suggested adding subjects on education, public health including community health centres/area hospitals, traffic management and civic policing activities, urban environment management and heritage and land management including registration in the 12th Schedule.

The local bodies rely heavily on their respective state governments for **financial inflows**. The major sources of income for local governments like property tax are not properly collected due to lack of a proper mechanism of levying and collection of such tax. This makes the coffers of local bodies extremely inadequate to meet their operational needs. Responsibility to provide civic amenities falls short of expectation due to inadequacy of funds. Thus, the local governments have to stay at the mercy of their state government for allocation of funds through grants to meet their needs including salary of the staff. In this respect, **Article 243H** and **243X** make it

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obligatory for the state government to authorise the local bodies by law to impose taxes, duties etc. and assign to the local bodies such taxes/duties levied and collected by the state government.

State Finance Commission (SFC) under Article 243I and 243Y recommends principles for distribution of funds between the urban local bodies and different panchayats. Thus, the role of State Finance Commission becomes important regarding devolution of financial resources for panchayats and municipalities. However, devolution of finance to local bodies depends upon the revenue generated by each state which is never same. While some states have followed the concept of pooling of all revenues and then sharing, others follow different percentages of devolution for different taxes. Thus, apart from principles of devolution of taxes, even fiscal administration of every state needs to be improved as it involves levy and collection of taxes at local level. State governments generally take a long time to implement the report of SFCs which further delay the process of devolution of funds.

The crucial issue of **capacity building** in urban and rural local bodies remains a largely neglected area in decentralised self-governance. Lack of training of personnel has resulted in capacity deficit within the Panchayat and Municipal Institutions. Thus, a proper exercise needs to be taken for capacity building which includes individual development along with organisational development through various schemes. Individual development involves the development of human resources including enhancement of an individual's knowledge, skills and access to information. It enables them to improve their performance and that of their organisation. State government should encourage holistic training programmes involving expertise in different fields. This can be best achieved by 'networking' of institutions concerned with various subjects such as financial management, rural development, disaster management and general management etc.

Empowering local bodies at ground level is very important as it involves people at local level which helps in strengthening democratic decentralisation. However, for the local bodies to function efficiently, they must be provided autonomy in their functioning. Local bodies having administrative, legislative and financial autonomy with a dedicated bureaucracy at the lower level will help in realizing the dream of Mahatma Gandhi.

"In this structure composed of innumerable villages, there will be ever widening, never ascending, circles. Life will not be a pyramid with the apex sustained by the bottom. But, it will be an oceanic circle, whose centre will be the individual, always ready to perish for the village, the latter ready to perish for the circle of the villages, till at last the whole becomes one life composed of individuals, never aggressive in their arrogance, but ever humble, sharing the majesty of the oceanic circle of which they are integrated units. Therefore, the outermost circumference will not wield power to crush the inner circle, but will give strength to all within and will derive its own strength from it." – **Mahatma Gandhi**

►WHEN FREE SPEECH IS TRULY FREE

#FREEDOM OF SPEECH AND EXPRESSION

Freedom is a theme which is going to come up again and again for creating a vibrant democracy. It is a term, like truth, that has globally become extremely important today. But it is not an easy concept to understand, especially in a public political discourse. First of all, there are many kinds of freedom: freedom to speak, to write, to think, to imagine, to live our lives, to eat what we want, and so on. Since this term is invoked so quickly and so easily — witness little children saying they want their freedom to have ice cream! — It is important that we understand its diverse meanings in our everyday use of this term. Hence, let us understand what one of the most important expressions of freedom, free speech, could mean. Freedom to hold forth?

People often tend to think that among the main elements of democracy are the holding of elections and a free media. Both elections and free media are important because they stand, among other things, for the notions of free speech and free expression. Casting a vote anonymously, of one's own free will, is an example of free expression and is broader than just 'free speech'. Similarly, when the media has the freedom to air all kinds of views, it is seen to be an example of free speech. But is free speech really the essence of democracy? Is it really so important for an effective democracy?

Paradoxically, there is an inherent tension between free speech and democracy. If free speech is understood merely as the freedom to say what one wants, then that is obviously not conducive to meaningful social behaviour. For example, one can spread falsehood about another in the name of free

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speech. One can insult, lie, create harm and hatred through free speech. In these cases, free speech should rightfully be called rumour and gossip. Rumour, gossip, fake news and deliberate lying can be hidden under the guise of free speech. It is speech with an ulterior motive. To call these as free speech is a mistake.

The answer to the problem of defining what really constitutes free speech lies in **understanding the meaning of 'free' in free speech**. **What is really free in free speech?** The freedom to say what one wants? We can't really say what we want all the time since all speech is constrained. We are constrained by language, words, concepts and grammar, and even by the physical contours of our mouth. We are constrained by the biological and cognitive structures related to thought and its expression through language. Socially, we are not fully free to say what we want. We cannot make certain utterances in certain places. A commentator, commenting on a game of cricket, cannot suddenly give a lecture on philosophy saying that he is protected by free speech!

In addition to constraints, all speech also has a cost. When we utter something, good or bad, there is a price to pay. Even in personal relations with family and friends, we cannot say what we want. If we do so — that is, if we are honest and outspoken — there is a price to pay. Relationships get broken, wars are declared between people because somebody spoke 'freely'. Thus, the essence of free speech is not really about the freedom to say what we want. It is more about speech which is free, which **comes with no cost**. Free speech is actually speech for which you don't pay a price.

The freedom of speech and expression under **Article 19(1)(a)** must take shape from the goals set out in the Preamble and must be read in the light of the principles mentioned therein. The Preamble seeks to promote "Fraternity assuring the dignity of the individual and the unity and integrity of the Nation". In its widest meaning and amplitude, fraternity is understood as a common feeling of brotherhood. While justice, liberty and equality have been made justiciable rights under the Constitution, the idea of fraternity has been used to interpret rights, especially horizontal application of rights.

The Preamble consciously chooses to assure the dignity of the individual, in the context of fraternity, before it establishes the link between **fraternity, unity and integrity of India**. The rights enshrined in Part III have to be exercised by individuals against the backdrop of the ideal of fraternity, and viewed in this light, Article 19(2) incorporates the vision of fraternity. Hence, the restriction imposed by the statutory provision (section 499 Indian Penal Code) satisfies the content of constitutional fraternity.

The fraternal ideal finds resonance also in **Part IVA of the Constitution**. **Article 51A** of the Constitution, which deals with the fundamental duties of a citizen, makes it a duty "to promote harmony and the spirit of common brotherhood amongst all the people of India transcending religious, linguistic and regional or sectional diversities; to renounce practices derogatory to the dignity of women". In fact, the Supreme Court has held that Part IVA could be used as an interpretative tool while assessing the constitutional validity of laws, especially in the context of restrictions imposed on rights.

But paying a price is not in the hands of the speaker. When we say or write something, we do not know who will take offence at it. People get upset and take offence very easily these days! Free speech is nothing but the conditions under which the hearer is not allowed to take offence and intimidate the speaker.

The real freedom in 'free speech' lies not in the freedom of the speaker to say what she wants but in the constraint on hearers to allow the speaker to say what she wants. Thus, when we demand the right to free speech, we are essentially demanding the right to stop others from not letting us speak. The most important consequence of the idea of free speech is that it **shifts the responsibility of free speech from the speaker to the hearer**. But does this mean that anybody can say what they want? Can they slander a person through falsehood in the name of free speech? Is slandering a person the same as criticising the government or the nation? After all, our governments, independent of which party is in power, have effectively used the charge of sedition to stop certain utterances in public.

Criticism as a duty: It is not free speech to purposefully slander a person. But criticising the government or nation is not the same as slandering an individual. Such criticism is not just a right, it is more a duty of democratic societies. In a true democracy, there is nothing that can be considered as slandering the government, even if a criticism may be wrong and unjustified. That is because free speech is a tool to make democracy workable and it is not really about the individual freedom to say what one wants.

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Democracy is about governance for others and on behalf of others. It is a social and public system of responsibility of governance. The very foundation of democracy is collective action and the real freedom in a democracy is the freedom of choosing who will govern on our behalf. The ideal of democracy is that we are all potential rulers — any one of us can be the Prime Minister of our country. When we elect somebody, we are only putting a group of people to govern on behalf of us. Free speech is the mechanism to make sure that they govern correctly and on our behalf. It is only free speech, defined in this manner that makes democracy workable.

The true power of free speech lies in its capacity to make those in power accountable to those who do not have power. It is a means to control those in power and is not really about freedom of individuals. The price we demand for making somebody govern on our behalf (the elected leaders) is to allow us to say what we want about them, not as individuals but as political leaders.

Thus, true free speech covers only those acts of speech which speak against power, and keep those in power accountable. It thus safeguards the most cherished democratic principle. Free speech by itself is not the essence of democracy but is the means by which any democracy can be sustained. Anybody who doesn't like to hear criticism of government or government representatives is being undemocratic. We dilute the importance of free speech when we use it to derive personal benefit or cause harm or do so in situations which are not about power. Speech, in the task of keeping check on power, has to be subsidised and made free by those in power.

►COMMITMENT TOWARDS SECULARISM ENABLES FRATERNITY IN SOCIETY

#SECULARISM

India's success as a multi-religious, multilingual, multiracial, multicultural society will depend on how successful it is in working its secularism. No society can prosper or be at peace with itself if one-fourths of its population feels neglected, deprived and unwanted. It is disconcerting to see that, in recent times, serious questions are being raised about India's secularism.

It is for the first time since Independence that the majoritarian ideology is being talked about so openly, defiantly and persistently. The Supreme Court itself has expressed apprehensions in this regard: "India till now is a secular country... we do not know for how long it will remain a secular country."

Secularism — Constitutional Precepts and Reality: It was the 42nd Amendment which amended Preamble and changed the description of India from "sovereign democratic republic" to a "sovereign, socialist secular democratic republic", and also changed the words "unity of the nation" to "unity and integrity of the nation". A series of articles in the Constitution underline the precepts of secularism. The reality is, however, quite disappointing. The majority community as also the minorities are totally disillusioned with the working of secularism. Instead of being the cementing force, secularism has led to alienation of all communities.

In a secular state, religion is expected to be a purely personal and private matter and is not supposed to have anything to do with the governance of the country. The Supreme Court had observed in the Bommai case that if religion is not separated from politics, the religion of the ruling party tends to become the state religion. This seems to be coming true.

Operationalising Secularism: India's future is intrinsically tied up with secularism. To make a real success of it, action on a number of important points is necessary. The **first** is to **define the word "secular".** Since secularism has been declared as a part of the basic structure of the Constitution, governments must be made accountable for implementing it. But how can they be held accountable unless the meaning of the term "secular" is clear? The **second** is to **define the word "minority**". The concept of secularism is based on recognition and protection of minorities. The two cannot be separated. One would have, therefore, expected that the founding fathers of the Constitution would first define the term minorities. Unfortunately, this was never done.

The **third,** and most critical, is the setting up of a **commission on secularism** for ensuring adherence to the constitutional mandate on secularism. To be effective, such a commission must be appointed by an amendment of the Constitution and should be presided over by a former chief justice of India.

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The **fourth** is the **separation of religion from politics**. It is of such urgency that no time should be wasted in bringing this about. The Constituent Assembly (Legislative) had passed an explicit resolution on the subject as far back in 1948. The first prime minister of India had welcomed the resolution and assured that the government wished to do everything in their power to achieve the objective which lies behind this resolution but action on resolution was non-existent. Even later, the governments did not sufficiently act proactively on the resolution. It was only after the demolition of the Babri Masjid, when the secular credentials were being seriously questioned in India and abroad, and hence the GoI brought the **Constitution (Eightieth Amendment) Bill** and a bill for amendment of the Representation of the People Act before Parliament in 1993 to bring about separation of religion from politics. However, the bills failed to receive adequate support and had to be withdrawn.

Unless this issue is addressed so as to carry through a suitable Constitution amendment, it will be futile to talk about India as a secular nation. On the basis of past experience and to meet the concerns expressed by some political parties during the debate on the Constitution (Eightieth Amendment) Bill in 1993 regarding the likely misuse of such an enactment, the suggestion is that the amendment bill should be confined only to deregistration of a political party which has religious links and restraining such political party from contesting elections at any level in the country.

The **fifth** item for action pertains to the **right to propagation of religion**. There are a number of decisions of the high courts and the Supreme Court according to which the **right to propagation is not a right to conversion**. This problem has to be nipped in the bud by **amending Article 25** to delete the word "propagation".

The **sixth** action pertains to doing away with the protection to minority educational institutions. There was considerable opposition to this article in the Constituent Assembly. There is no justification to continue this right.

Finally, serious thought needs to be given to deleting the provision for prohibition of cow slaughter. Article 48, though a part of the directive principles, has now been elevated in public discourse to the level of a fundamental right. The basic question is whether a total ban on slaughter of cows and their progeny is justified on any grounds at all except that of the religious sentiments of Hindus. But even in regard to them, there is no universal demand for a total ban by all Hindus. Most importantly, such a ban is not in keeping with secularism. Particularly in the drought-hit areas in a number of states such as Maharashtra, it is causing large-scale distress to farmers. The Indian Constitution is a mix of several compromises, particularly insofar as it's proclaimed secular ideology is concerned.

Two basic electoral reforms are imperative if secularism is to be strengthened. The first is increasing participation of voters by investing in mass awareness programs so that voters choose the most apt candidates by overlooking divide and rule politics. The second is providing NOTA with the power of rejection so as to gradually pressurise political parties to field better candidates and forcing them to look beyond divisive politics. A lesser divided legislature on religious issues and more focused on inclusive democracy can become the harbinger of secular ideals but great deal remains to be done if secularism is to become a way of life in India.

►IS OUR PARLIAMENTARY DEMOCRACY SHOWING PRESIDENTIAL TRAITS?

#DEMOCRACY, POLITY AND GOVERNANCE

This debate is academic. A switchover to the presidential system is not possible under our present constitutional scheme because of the **'basic structure' doctrine** propounded by the Supreme Court in 1973 which has been accepted by the political class without reservation, except for an abortive attempt during the Emergency to have it overturned. The Constituent Assembly had made an informed choice after considering both the British model and the American model and after Dr. B.R. Ambedkar had drawn up a balance sheet of their merits and demerits.

A presidential system centralises power in one individual unlike the parliamentary system, where the Prime Minister is the first among equals. The surrender to the authority of one individual, as in the presidential system, is dangerous for democracy. The

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over-centralisation of power in one individual is something we have to guard against. Those who argue in favour of a presidential system often state that the safeguards and checks are in place: that a powerful President can be stalled by a powerful legislature. But if the legislature is dominated by the same party to which the President belongs, a charismatic President or a "strong President" may prevent any move from the legislature. On the other hand, if the legislature is dominated by a party opposed to the President's party and decides to checkmate him, it could lead to a stalemate in governance because both the President and the legislature would have democratic legitimacy.

A diverse country like India cannot function without consensus-building. This "winner takes it all" approach, which is a necessary consequence of the presidential system, is likely to lead to a situation where the views of an individual can ride roughshod over the interests of different segments.

The other argument, that it is easier to bring talent to governance in a presidential system, is specious. You can get 'outside' talent in a parliamentary system too. Right from C.D. Deshmukh to T.A. Pai to Manmohan Singh to M.G.K. Menon, talent has been coming into the parliamentary system with the added safeguard of democratic accountability, because the 'outsiders' have to get elected after assuming office. On the other hand, bringing 'outside' talent in a presidential system without people being democratically elected would deter people from giving independent advice to the chief executive because they owe their appointment to him/her.

Those who speak in favour of a presidential system have only the Centre in mind. They have not thought of the logical consequence, which is that we will have to move simultaneously to a "gubernatorial" form in the States. A switch at the Centre will also require a change in the States. Are we ready for that?

On the other side, our parliamentary system it is to vote for a legislature in order to form the executive. It has created a unique breed of legislator, largely unqualified to legislate, who has sought election only in order to wield executive power. There is no genuine separation of powers: the legislature cannot truly hold the executive accountable since the government wields the majority in the House. The parliamentary system does not permit the existence of a legislature distinct from the executive, applying its collective mind freely to the nation's laws.

In our system, coalition governments have been obliged to focus more on politics than on policy or performance. It has forced governments to concentrate less on governing than on staying in office, and obliged them to cater to the lowest common denominator of their coalitions, since withdrawal of support can bring governments down. The parliamentary system has distorted the voting preferences of an electorate that knows which individuals it wants but not necessarily which parties or policies.

India's many challenges require political arrangements that permit decisive action, whereas ours increasingly promote drift and indecision. We must have a system of government whose leaders can focus on governance rather than on staying in power.

A system of directly elected chief executives at all levels – panchayat chiefs, town mayors, Chief Ministers (or Governors) and a national President – elected for a fixed term of office, invulnerable to the whims of the legislature, and with clearly defined authority in their respective domains – would permit India to deal more efficiently with its critical economic and social challenges.

Cabinet posts would not be limited to those who are electable rather than those who are able. At the end of a fixed period of time — say the same five years we currently accord to our Lok Sabha — the public would be able to judge the individual on performance in improving the lives of Indians, rather than on political skill at keeping a government in office.

The fear that an elected President could become a Caesar is ill-founded since the President's power would be balanced by directly elected chief executives in the States. In any case, the Emergency demonstrated that even a parliamentary system can be distorted to permit autocratic rule. Dictatorship is not the result of a particular type of governmental system.

Indeed, the President would have to work with Parliament to get his budget through or to pass specific Bills. India's fragmented polity, with dozens of political parties in the fray, makes a U.S.-style two-party gridlock in Parliament impossible. An Indian presidency, instead of facing a monolithic opposition, would have the opportunity to build issue-based coalitions on different issues, mobilising different temporary alliances of different smaller parties from one policy to the next – the opposite of the dictatorial

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steamroller some fear a presidential system could produce.

Any politician with aspirations to rule India as President will have to win the support of people beyond his or her home turf; he or she will have to reach out to different groups, interests, and minorities. And since the directly elected President will not have coalition partners to blame for his or her inaction, a presidential term will have to be justified in terms of results, and accountability will be direct and personal.

Democracy is vital for India's survival: we are right to be proud of it. But few Indians are proud of the kind of politics our democracy has inflicted upon us. With the needs and challenges of one-sixth of humanity before our leaders, we must have a democracy that delivers progress to our people. Changing to a presidential system can be a way of ensuring a democracy that works.

On the desirability aspect, which presidential system are we talking about when we pit the American presidential system against the Westminster model? In the American system, the President appoints his officers; they have limited tenure and their offices are confirmed by the Senate (Upper House). Then, we have the Latin American model, where some Constitutions give Presidents a term often amounting to life tenure like in Cuba. There are plenty of models to choose from and there are arguments against each. So, which system is being argued for when the votaries of change seek a shift to the presidential system?

Our Rajya Sabha cannot be compared to the U.S. Senate where each state has its own Constitution and has the power to change it. The relationship between the states and the federal government is extraordinary; as is the status of their courts and the manner of appointment of judges. I do not think people have thought about it. Merely stating that a change to the presidential system is needed does not mean much. The Indian debate currently is not focussed on the kind of presidential system envisaged. What is the term we are seeking for the President? Should he/she be re-elected? If so, for how many terms? Then, who decides the change? Parliament? All this requires a massive amendment to the 'basic structure' of the Constitution. The Supreme Court has spelt its view on the 'basic structure' of the Constitution.

Giving an opinion is one thing. A judgment is a more carefully considered conclusion. Those who support the presidential system should do their homework when they argue against the parliamentary system. There is also the matter of separation of powers. In the U.S., the President, who is also the Supreme Commander, has the power to veto the Congress. Does India need this? The manner of removing the U.S. President through impeachment is a very complex process. There is also the possibility of aggregating more powers to the President.

Before embarking for a new set-up, it will definitely be more feasible to improve the current system so why not reform thoroughly and cleanse the electoral processes to get better representatives. There are ideas going around about reforming the electoral processes to make democracy more robust. From limiting expenditure of political parties and deciding the ceiling on the expenditure, declaring the results for a combination of booths instead of constituencies. It is advisable to debate this and ensure that the gaping loopholes in the electoral processes are speedily plugged. The present parliamentary system has been tried and tested for 70 years. Rather than change the system, why not reform thoroughly and cleanse the electoral processes?

►ACTIVE AND ENLIGHTENED OPPOSITION NURTURES A SOUND DEMOCRACY

#DEMOCRACY, POLITY AND GOVERNANCE

Indian Parliamentary democracy is getting a bad name due to repeated suspension of work in Parliament. Despite important Bills pending in the Parliament, ruling party and opposition are at loggerheads on various issues. This result in wastage of important time on baseless discussions and the decisions demanding immediate attention are lost in the noise, chaos and clamour. The role of the opposition is not to oppose anything presented for discussion but to look at the issues which can be discussed for the betterment of the things proposed. Opposition for the sake of opposition is diverging from the roles and responsibility of a constructive opposition.

Some forms of ruling systems cannot tolerate opposition, and root it out wherever it arises. Other forms not only tolerate it, but make room for it within the institutions of government. This feature of

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'internalised opposition' has sometimes been taken as a mark of limited, as opposed to absolute, government, and also as the mark of politics, as opposed to coercion. It is hard to imagine the feature without extremely complex institutions and constitutional devices: it is one of the principal problems of political thought to discover what makes such opposition possible.

Considering the above, what is the role of opposition in a democracy? The use of the term 'opposition', to denote forces within political institutions that resist the ruling officers or party, is comparatively recent. J. Cam Hobhouse, speaking in the House of Commons in 1826, remarked that it was said to be very hard on His Majesty's ministers to raise objections to some proposition. For his own part, he thought it was harder on His Majesty's opposition to compel them to take this course. Hansard records laughter at the phrase **"His Majesty's opposition".**

Although the term 'opposition' was used as far back as the eighteenth century to refer to a party or a caucus within an assembly, the suggestion of an established opposition is relatively new. It is now, however, quite normal to refer to a 'loyal opposition', and to imply that the interests of the State are as well served by the opposition as by the government itself.

The 'opposition' in the modern UK Parliament consists not merely of opposition parties or factions, but principally of a **'shadow formation'**. The offices of government are imitated within the opposition, which thereby forms itself into a body prepared to substitute for all the occupants of those offices at any time. The opposition has its leader, its base organisation and committees, and usually responds to every move of the government with counterproposals, representing, in theory, what it would do if it were in office.

Even in states with high levels of repression it is rare to find no trace of opposition. In single-party systems, the opposition may exist as an underground movement as in the former Union of Soviet Socialist Republics where no formal opposition to the Communist Party of the Soviet Union was permitted but dissidents like Boris Yeltsin continued to exist. Or an opposition may engage in armed struggle as in El Salvador. Undue repression of the opposition often results in bloodshed and even change of government through violent means.

Recently in Belarus, there have been huge mass protests by the opposition against President Alexander Lukashenko (considered as the last remaining dictator in Europe).

In democratic systems, the opposition is officially permitted and recognised. Even the leader of opposition is given an honourable place in the system. In Britain, the position of the leader of Her Majesty's opposition is formalised in statute and he or she has certain rights, such as the right of reply to prime ministerial broadcasts. In India, too, the opposition leader has been given certain rights and privileges on par with a cabinet minister if he/she commands the support of the required number of Parliament members.

The concept of opposition in the modern democratic state is closely connected with the idea of the political party. A political party is a more or less organised group of citizens who act together as a political unit, have distinctive aims and opinions on the leading political issues and problems in the state, and who, by acting together as a political unit, seek to obtain control of the government. The party that is out of the government at a given point of time is called the opposition party. The number of the opposition party/parties may be one or more depending on whether there is a dual-party or multiparty system.

The most prominent question that may strike one's mind is: **Why does democracy demand the existence of opposition?** An opposition party always looks for an opportunity to replace the party-in-government, and implement its own policies and programmes. As a result, it serves two purposes. **One**, the government of the day eschews being arbitrary in its actions and negligent of the interests of the people in general; and **second,** the people of a democratic country are offered an alternative in governance of the country in their interests.

The opposition parties **also enable men and women** who think alike on public questions to unite in support of a common body of principles and policies and to work together to see that those principles and policies are adopted and implemented by the government. Without organisation, the people can neither formulate principles easily nor agree on policy. The opposition makes articulate the inarticulate desires of sections of the masses and gives expression to their pent-up feelings. This goes a long way in checking violence and political crimes which are, in reality, fatal for the healthy survival of democracy.

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Out of the innumerable problems which call for solution in a state, the opposition is expected to select those which are comparatively urgent, study them, think out solutions and present them to the people and to the government. And, thus, it **acts as a "broker of ideas"**. It preserves a sense of continuity in public policy, organises and educates the electorate, and helps to carry on and necessitate regular elections. It also dramatises politics and keeps the nation politically alive. It keeps the government on its toes.

The opposition, like the judiciary, is an **agent for safeguarding the Constitution** in case the government wittingly or unwittingly does something to violate it. The opposition also necessitates periodic interpretation, reinterpretation and amendment of the Constitution to suit changes in times, circumstances and priorities. In most democracies, the opposition's views have to be taken into consideration in **legislating on socially-sensitive matters**. The opposition has the capacity to instil in the government the confidence and ability to deal with national crises. Here, the opposition's support means that the entire country is behind the government in the hour of crisis. Not many would have forgotten the thundering speech and support given by Atal Behari Vajpayee in the Parliament (1971) when the Government of India led by Indira Gandhi had to withstand the Pakistani aggression. In the absence of the opposition, the government cannot be sure of the entire population's support. Moreover, the opposition also gives credence and authenticity to any measures of the government taken in the interests of the people and the state. The parties outside power extend support to certain measures as they cannot afford to be regarded as anti-people or anti-nation as they, too, have ultimately to face the praise or wrath of the public. Thus, the opposition does not always have to oppose the government.

Sometimes the parties in opposition oppose the government measures merely for the sake of opposition. This delays even the progressive steps of the government and results in waste of time, money and material. It also misleads the masses. Not infrequently, the leaders in opposition resort to demagogy which is harmful for the nation's health. Howsoever politically ignorant the people may be, they cannot forgive such irresponsible and delinquent behaviour on the part of an opposition party.

In a democracy, the modus operandi of the opposition involve going to the people and criticising the government, giving press-statements, debating and discussing issues in Parliament, arousing public opinion, both national and international, and placing no-confidence motions against the government. In India, submitting a memorandum to the President is also a common practice. All these are commensurate with the democratic norms and contribute to the consolidation and stabilisation of democracy in the social and political system.

To sum up, the opposition fulfils certain necessary functions—so necessary, indeed, that many competent thinkers consider it essential to the working of representative government. Of course, the opposition sometimes delays the proceedings and the implementation of vital legislation. But the balance tilts towards its beneficial impact rather than the baneful. If democracy has come to stay, it is not because it is the perfect form of self-government. Unlike dictatorship or totalitarian systems, it does not believe in self-evident principles. No plan or policy can benefit the people if we look only at its 'pros' and deny the 'cons'. Only the opposition can provide those 'cons'. Above all, it is the opposition that puts a rein on the power of the government and checks it from becoming absolute.

►INDEPENDENCE OF JUDICIARY STRENGTHENS THE EDIFICE OF DEMOCRACY

#JUDICIAL REFORMS

For the past couple of years, judiciary is regularly in limelight, sometimes due to decisive decision making such as on 'Privacy' but also due to wrong impression and mistrust it is has created by showing partisan attitude. This partisan approach was even questioned by four senior-most judges of the collegium by conducting an unprecedented open press conference.

Like all institutions of governance, the judiciary too requires a periodic dose of institutional reforms to keep pace with the societal demands. Over the years, the higher judiciary had been proactive in trying to improve and strengthen the judicial process and justice delivery system to make them more accessible, cost effective and less time consuming. The Government has also taken steps to improve the

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working of the judiciary keeping in mind the needs of litigants, particularly, those belonging to the poorer sections.

Accelerated Justice is an essential component of an effective judicial system. And speedy delivery of justice also reduces the cost to a litigant, thus making it affordable. In this context, the problem of pendency of cases in lower courts, and in some cases even in High Courts and Supreme Court, requires urgent attention. Speedy justice is an assurance extended to a citizen under the ambit of `right to life' guaranteed under **Article 21** of our Constitution. **Speedy justice** can renew our people's faith in the administration of justice and in the `rule of law'. These constitute the bedrock of our democracy. The framers of the Indian Constitution provided for an independent and strong judiciary which would work within the framework of the supremacy of the constitution and a parliamentary form of democracy in India.

There are three crore cases pending in courts. The arrears seem to be increasing every year as disposal of cases is less than the institution of new cases.

Computerisation can help enhance the productivity of judicial work. It can create an accessible data base to help both judges and lawyers; it can help case management and courtroom management; it can speed up judicial work by removing the need for paper based transactions. Recognising the utility of this tool, the Government has approved a proposal for the computerization of district and subordinate courts. An E-committee set up, on the advice of the Chief Justice of India, to monitor implementation of computerization of the judiciary has also submitted its report on the National Policy and Action Plan for the Implementation of Information & Communication Technology in the Indian Judiciary.

In the era of globalisation, liberalisation, privatisation, a growing integration of economics and societies around the world has certainly influenced many aspects of individual's lives and institutional character. Yet the basic aim of every society remains the same that is to secure a just and humane society. Therefore, the system has to be suitably amended/ reformed to meet the demands and emerging pressure from the society and to forward this cause transparency and accountability in the judicial system must be adhered to. Otherwise the day is not far when the masses may raise defiant voice against the performance of the judiciary.

As an institution, the Indian judiciary has always commanded a great respect from the people of this country. The roots of this high regard lie in the impartiality, and independence of the members of the judiciary. The deeper aim of a good society is to respect the judiciary with morality. As Chanakaya said "law and morality sustain the world." But morality comes from ethical values. The societal perception of judges as being detached and impartial referee is the greatest strength of the judiciary. The real source of strengths of the judiciary lies in public confidence in the institutions.

The judiciary is one of the three basic organs of the state. The other two are the legislative and the executive. It has a significant role in the smooth functioning of the states and in a democracy; it is based on rule of law. Since time immemorial, law and judiciary have played a vital role in Indian Polity. The constitution accords a high place of pride to the judiciary by conferring the power of judicial review of legislature and administrative activities and entrusting it with the task of enforcement of the fundamental rights guaranteed under the constitution.

In a democratic polity, the Supreme Power of the state is shared among its three main organs as constitutional functionaries. Each one of these is independent and supreme within its allotted spheres and none is superior to the other. Justice has to be administered through the courts and such administration would relate to social, economic and political aspects of justice as stipulated in the preamble of the constitution of the judiciary. Therefore, becoming the most prominent and outstanding organ of the constitutional system for fulfilling the mandate of the constitution. The judiciary has to take up positive & creative functions in securing socio-economic justice to the people.

The constitutional task assigned to the judiciary is to adjudicate disputes between the individuals, between individuals and the state, between the states and between the union and the states and while to adjudicating, the court may be required to interpret the provisions on the constitution and the law and the interpretation given by the Supreme Court becomes the law honoured by all courts of the land. There is no appeal against the judgement of the Supreme Court. It remains the law of the land unless its interpretation is reviewed on reversed by the Supreme Court of self or the law or the constitution is suitably amended by parliament. Therefore, it is no way less than that of the other two functionaries— legislature and executive. It is the role of the judiciary to carry out the constitutional message and it is its responsibility to

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keep a vigilant waters over the functioning of democracy is accordance with the dictates, directives and imperatives— commands of the constitution by checking excessive authority of the other constitutional functions beyond the limit of the constitution.

The issue of judicial reform has been raised by judges of Supreme Court, experts, academicians, and common people of this country. This alarming situations call for speedy remedial measures.

The following are some of the reforms that need to be implemented in our age old judiciary system. Non-delay and the credibility of the system is the first and foremost factor in judicial reforms. Justice delayed is justice denied. It is a vital aspect of judicial reform. The lack of speedy dispute resolution system has a direct impact on the level of lawlessness in every society. Therefore, if the system does not evoke confidence, it would become dysfunctional and fit to be scrapped. It can be possible to deliver a speedy justice mainly by computerisation of the whole judicial administration and reduce the delayed justice to the ordinary citizens and also can manage the work and time of the Supreme Court and high courts better.

Rural courts are needed for speedy justice as a lot of cases are pending for jurisdiction. It is quite necessary to reform the constitution of rural courts for speedy justice. If it is need to be a substantial increase in the number of judges of the local level giving access to the ordinary people, and the procedures of these local courts showed be made simple and uncomplicated giving room for sufficient flexibility to render justice. These courts should use only the local language and they should be empowered to visit the villages and hear the cases and record evidences locally. And deliver the verdict within the specified timeframe.

Revision of judicial procedure is equally needed. The civil and criminal procedures codes and the laws of evidence have to be substantially revised to meet the requirements of modern judicial administration. Although certain principles and procedures are still relevant yet several procedures have become cumbersome, and often counter-productive. There should be time limits prescribed for adjudication and the stages and endless adjournments should be stopped— except in exceptional circumstances for reasons specifically recorded in writing.

There is a need for a judicial commission to oversee judges' accountability. It is high time to set up a **judicial commission** and its members should be drawn from the judiciary, executive and the legislative and their recommendation is made binding on the president in all appointments to the higher judiciary. Similarly the provision for removal of a judge of Supreme Court and High Courts under Article 154 (clause 4) has become inoperative in practice. The Indian parliament has lost the capacity to act as a Court in such impeachment trials.

There are several administrative reform commissions which examine the entire administration fabric and advised a number of measures. But on the judiciary front, so far there is not any such comprehensive examination of the issues of reform. Thus, there is an urgent need to set up a commission to go into the entire gamut of judicial administration to ensure that judicial reforms in all its segments are comprehensively worked out and implemented to provide speedy justice of a minimal cost with efficiency, economy and accountability.

The Supreme Court jurisdiction should be limited only to matters involving interpretation of the constitution or disputes between two states or union and states in effect, the Supreme Court should function only as a constitutional court and federal court with high esteem. The High Court should not have the power to interpret the constitution except in matters involving the state legislation. The appellate power of High Courts should be restricted in order to reduce the case-loads.

Another point is that there is a need for a crime investigation force. The present system of police force has combination of several functions, including crime investigation, riot control, intelligence gathering, and security of state properties, protection of important citizens. All in a single police force has had a devastating effect on the criminal justice system. The police force has become inefficient and increasingly partisan. The crime investigation machinery has also become an instrument of partisan policies, mainly due to pressure from the government to the legal authority to drop criminal charges against the accused.

Due to delay and overburden of the judiciary, it's high time that the Indian judicial service should be created as an All India Service **under Article 312** of the constitution. All the officers of the district and session judges should be held by persons recruited to such a service after adequate training and exposure. Only such a meritocratic service with a competitive recruitment, high quality uniform training and assured standards of probity and efficiency would be able to ensure speedy and impartial justice. A fair

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proportion of the High Court could be drawn from the Indian Judicial Service.

Judicial activism and judicial restraint are two sides of the same coin. It is, therefore, essential to remember that judicial respect in the exercise of its functions is of equal importance for the judiciary while discharging its judicial obligation under the constitution. The judicial action should not become 'judicial adventurism'. The judge should not deliver his own notion of justice by ignoring the links of the law, the bounds of the jurisdiction and the binding precedents, the court must act with proper restraints and self-discipline.

There are four pillars of a democracy- the legislature, executive, judiciary and the fourth estate. The judiciary in our democracy has been sinking in the morass of inefficiency and delays. Charges of corruption in judiciary is undermining judicial system, denying citizen's access to justice and the basic human right to a fair and impartial trial, sometimes even to a trial at all. Petty bribery and political influence in the judiciary erodes social cohesion which reflects one system for the rich and another for the poor, fractured communities.

Comprehensive judicial reform would entail envisaging the whole spectrum of more judges, fast track courts, and the issue of capability and professionalism of those within the judicial system, to deploying new information technology systems, as something that needs to be quickly institutionalised. The current situation is such that the Supreme Court itself has said the nation "seems unconcerned" by the issue of delayed justice, and recently the Law Commission also raised the issue of the lack of professionalism among judges and lawyers in India as one of the ills that plagues the system.

A sound judicial system isn't just about delivering justice — it also affects economic interests as an effective legal system can mitigate some aspects of political instability, including security and law and order issues. But the basic issue is that any society with deep flaws in its justice delivery system wrecks citizens' faith in the processes and institutions of the state. Delivering justice, thus, is a foundational principle of a nation state — and on that front, it won't be unfair to state that India continues to face a crisis.

There is an urgent requirement to reform our judiciary, before we lose all our trust in judicial system and move towards anarchy. The reform has to begin, with the higher judiciary and from this very point we have to go further to other reforms.

►RIGHT CONDUCT OF A CIVIL SERVANT IS AN ENABLER FOR GOOD GOVERNANCE

#CIVIL SERVICES REFORMS

A peaceful and productive society is based on effective state institutions. Good governance in this sense means effective and efficient structures which provide optimal support to citizens in leading a safe and productive life in line with their desires and opportunities. Essentially, this involves a combination of democracy, the social welfare state and the rule of law. For this, an efficient and productive civil administration is a panacea for any form of governance as an interface between the government and the governed.

In the modern context, a civil servant takes care of the orders of the government and their implementation. It is the duty of the civil servant to make sure that the decisions taken at the top are actually observed at the ground. All around the world such universality is applied to every nation. India too has such a hierarchy of civil administrators engaged in carrying out the political decisions of the elected representatives. For this to happen, the conduct of the civil servant gains eminence in delivering the goods.

In this regard and to promote it, Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) has even included a paper in the civil servant recruitment process to test and guide the conduct of a civil servant. Let us now visualize the apt conduct of a civil servant given the pulls and pressures in which s/he operates his/her tasks.

The Civil services in India have a rich legacy. One of the first political thinkers in India, Kautilya, in his treaties; Arthashastra, brought the essence of a good civil administration which should work for the betterment of people. From the reign of efficient rulers such as Chandragupta Maurya, Ashoka, and Akbar, the civil administration followed a hierarchical approach carrying out emperor's orders. The fundamentals of modern day civil administration were laid during colonial period in India. However, the administration was inclined and tuned to further the British interests and had no real touch with the masses. Consequently, India after independence decided to reform the civil services and the task was carried over by Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel. Unfortunately, he could not get sufficient time to reform the services and what followed was an Indian administration though working for the people but with a tinge of colonial legacy.

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The welfare approach of Indian government post-independence was hindered by colonial mindsets of civil servants. People could not feel a sense of belongingness by the attitude of civil servants. There was poor ground level implementation, harassment of people, political non-neutrality, corruption and abuse of power. The mentioned causes led to the idea of good governance in early 1990s in India concomitant with global concerns on the subject. With India opening up to globalization, the weakness of public service delivery in India got further highlighted. Continuous economic growth and increasing competition has brought multitude of challenges to a civil servant. It is in this context that a legitimate question arises; how should a civil servant conduct himself/herself? How should it be possible to keep a civil servant politically neutral? How can an effective public service delivery be set up?

The concept of an efficient civil administrator got a fillip during early 1990s with the publishing of a World Bank report which analysed the causes of poor response of public initiatives in developing countries. It highlighted how ineffective and poor civil administration hindered programme implementation. It was in this context that 'Nolan Committee' in United Kingdom came out with seven cardinal principles of a civil servant. These are-- selflessness, integrity, accountability, openness, leadership, objective and honesty.

Selflessness refers to the feeling of serving others without thinking of oneself, **integrity** refers to the absence of any outside influence from the organization in decision making; **accountability** refers to answerability of the civil servant to the public; **openness** refers to transparency in decision making and facilitating flow of information; **leadership** infers that a civil servant should lead by example by following all the principles; **objectivity** refers to the principle of merit where selections would not be based on other considerations; **honesty** refers to the act of civil servant in such a way so as to avoid conflict of interest. In addition to these fundamental principles an ideal civil servant should have empathy i.e. compassion for the people. S/he should be politically neutral and should have courage to withstand undue pressures. In addition, s/he should have temperance in order to be patient enough to take decisions. S/he should use public funds prudently and is the best of the interest of public.

Apart from such virtues, a civil servant must possess **intellectual capability to take decisions**. S/he acts as an interface between the people and government; needs to follow the decisions taken at the top and respect hierarchy; needs to work within the four walls of the law; and if conditions arise that there might be violation of law in carrying out any instructions from top then it should be clearly brought out to the notice of seniors. If still insisted on to carry out such instructions, then it should be carried out only through written orders and not through mere oral orders. It should be mentioned that illegal orders which hinder one's authority to exercise powers or is against any statute should be ignored. A civil servant only needs to act according to the law even if s/he finds it unfair or unjust. The best s/he can do is to put forth his/her reasons about its drawbacks.

In addition, a civil servant should never criticize government policies in public discussions. S/he is a part of the government and such act reduces the credibility of the government as well as his /her own merit. A civil servant should never hesitate to put forth his/her views even if it goes against the advice of ministers, and the views should be coupled with logical reasons and lucid presentations. Similarly, a civil servant should be open to any new suggestions, open to accept new challenges at work, try to develop innovative approaches to implement orders, should not hesitate to take tough decisions and should try to make a note in writing of all his/her actions in order to be transparent.

One of the toughest jobs for a civil servant is to **maintain balance in his/her personal and professional life.** There are numerous challenges to a civil servant when there is pressure of family members and close friends. S/he should be able to maintain such space so as not to allow any influence which hinders improvement in governance and transparency.

Should try to **include civil society in decision making** so as to make governance more participatory. Should to take along with himself/herself private as well public institutions. Should maintain transparency in dealing with private sector and should avoid favouritism. Should not blindly follow any law but implement it considering all dimensions. The nature of today's administration is more people centric. S/he should be able to judge repercussions of allowing more competition or giving space to private entities on poor sections. This should be clearly brought out at policy discussions. This needs more of assessing ground level realities which requires open public discussions and bottom up governance.

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The globalised world of today makes the task of civil servant more difficult. The increasing role of private sector, decreasing social sector public investment, high competitiveness, increasing marginalization of lower sections of society, increased awareness of the citizenry, requirement of flexibility and broad knowledge network has made it necessary for a civil servant to come out from a narrow outlook and update himself/herself according to changing needs. S/he needs to be more communicative by developing good inter-personal skills in dealing with multinational companies. S/he should be well versed with the power of information technology and make its sufficient use to broaden his/her knowledge and improve service delivery.

The **principle of utilitarianism** suggests benefit of majority is superior to minority loss. However, this approach violates the principle of equal justice where each member of the society should be able to enjoy his/her rights. In such cases, rights based approach that follows non-violation of anyone's universal rights needs to be followed. However, such ethical dilemma needs to be sorted out at the individual level according to one's discretion. Clearly such decisions need critical analysis and in-depth knowledge in order to be able to take effective decisions which a civil servant should possess.

The high work pressure and expectations often stresses a civil servant. In such cases, careful handling of situations is required. A civil servant should be equipped with the ability to maintain his/her cool and calm façade and follow laid out rules and regulations for maximum effect. S/he should try to include all stakeholders in decision making and should stand up against illegal directions. It may hamper one's career growth but in the longer run a civil servant is respected for his/her uprightness and strong commitment. His/Her attitude must be reflected in the behaviour which requires strong conscience. For this, s/he needs to have clear objectives, feedbacks from stakeholders, patient listening and articulation of right thoughts. S/he needs to ensure responsibility for his/her work and should be ready to accept accountability in case of failures.

Thus an efficient and upright civil servant ensures public service delivery to the best of his/her ability. It leads to a shift from responsive to proactive administration. A well-managed public administration strikes to achieve an egalitarian and just society. It removes inequality and marginalization and makes economic growth inclusive. India, with high demographic dividend needs to take up the challenge to utilize this dividend. This needs proper imparting of skills, medical and education infrastructure and right legislations. Clearly, the role of civil servant is preeminent in the facilitation of such national objectives as it would help in elimination of social and economic injustice, improve standards of living and make India economically developed.

However, inspite of such importance, civil service today is not what an aspiring nation like India would want. It is marred with inefficiency, corruption, lack of accountability and transparency, apathy towards public. India has continuously been rated lower in international indexes such as corruption index, world competitiveness index, social index, education and health indexes, and ease of doing business index etc. However, it is not that government is not acquainted about such issues as it has taken numerous steps to make civil servants more accountable, and responsive initiatives such as e-governance, social audits, right to information and mandating citizen charter have also been instituted to make it more impactful.

However, more needs to be done. As pointed out by Santhanam Committee way back in 1960s, one of the reasons for mismanagement/corruption is discretion of civil servant. Hence, the Second Administrative Reforms Commission (SARC) in its report has brought out the need of an ethical code of conduct to reduce personal discretion. It should be strictly implemented and civil servants should be penalized for not adhering to it. It is however not possible to frame all possible situations and have a code of conduct for them. It would ultimately depend on civil servant's attitude and capability.

Hence only a change in mindsets, where a civil servant should not think himself/herself as a ruler but a provider of government service, and where public acts as a customer of these services is the key. A shift to the approach where 'Customer is king' is echoed in public administration, is required. This needs proper sensitization of civil servants and effective training and skill enhancement initiatives. Every civil servant should remember Gandhi's Talisman before taking decision- "Whenever you are in doubt to take decisions follow this approach. Recall the face of the poorest man you have ever seen and ask yourself, if the step you contemplate is going to be of any use to him/her. Will s/he gain anything?"

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4 THEME INCLUSIVE ECONOMY AND ECONOMIC JUSTICE

ABOUT THE THEME:

UPSC topics related with Economy are based on the requirement to convert our economic growth into an inclusive growth so as to cater to entire demographic dividend and to the different skill levels present in our work force.

Inclusive Growth acts as an enabler for promoting Economic Justice.

Without an inclusive economy, we cannot convert our society into a productive society and there will be lesser peace and more deprivation.

In this regards, the topics in this theme are based on the above thought process.

Economic justice is the idea that the economy will be more successful if it is fairer. The goal is to create opportunities for all to thrive and that prosperity and justice go hand-in-hand rather than in opposition to one another.

►'PROGRESS IS MORE PLAUSIBLY JUDGED BY THE REDUCTION OF DEPRIVATION THAN BY THE FURTHER ENRICHMENT OF THE WEALTH'

#INCLUSIVE GROWTH

Human progress and well-being are the central goals of social policy in a welfare state. Directive Principles in our Constitution obligate the Indian state for general welfare and progress of the population at large. While there is no doubt that there has been general well-being and development in our country since we have gained independence, however, we find that this growth and development has not been fair, equitable and humane. Some seem to have acquired larger proportion of this wealth at the cost of vast majority of population who continue to live a life of penury and destitution.

This essay is a reflection on this contentious path to development. There have been wide ranging discussions in academic circles on the path to the development and progress. Some argue that economic freedom and free enterprise with limited state intervention will create situations of general economic growth and affluence, first for the rich which will gradually trickle down to the large population at the proper time. Thus, these scholars believe that economic growth is the ultimate constraint on development and that successful growth will at the right time eliminate poverty and other social problems.

This view was pushed by the Washington Consensus, advocated by IMF and World Bank. They emphasised on the role of free markets as efficient mechanisms for promoting economic growth and advocated reforms like withdrawal of state, market deregulation.

The result of pursuit of market led development policies across the world resulted in problems of growing inequality where the rich became more richer, there was widespread damage to global environment threatening world's biodiversity and climate change, there was increasing consumerism, individualisation and commodification leading to loss of community feeling. The markets have appeared to be often sub-optimal as they are open to manipulation and irrationality. Also, rich often seem to be rich not due to their efforts but often due to luck and chance.

The incomes and wealth of world's top 1% have increased at an increasing pace in the last three decades. Back home, Indian income inequality was extremely high under British colonial rule, with a top 10% income share around 50%. After independence, socialist-inspired five-year plans contributed to reducing this share to 35-40%. Since the mid1980s, deregulation and liberalization policies have led to one of the most extreme increases in income and wealth inequality observed in the world. While the top 1% has largely benefited from economic reforms,

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growth among low- and middle-income groups has been relatively slow, and poverty persists.

Oxfam in its recent report 'Inequality Kills' reveals some staggering data on wealth inequality. The wealth of the ten richest billionaires in India would be enough to fund the schooling and higher education of India's children for more than 25 years. According to the report, despite the pandemic the number of billionaires increased in India from 102 to 142. Collective wealth of India's 100 richest people hit a record high of USD 775 billion. In the same year, the share of the bottom 50% of the population in national wealth was a mere 6%.

On the other hand, scholars of the human development school have taken a different path. They have advocated for a rights-based approach and have oriented towards enhancing human development rather than economic growth. Enabling everyone in society to achieve their minimum basic needs and over time, with rising prosperity to the raise the minimum level. For them, economic growth is just the means to the end of human development.

Poverty is hunger and fatigue. Poverty is being sick and not being able to see a doctor. Poverty is not being able to go to school and not knowing how to read. Poverty is not having a job. Poverty is fear for the future, having food once in a day. Poverty is losing a child to illness, brought about by unclear water. Poverty is powerlessness, lack of representation and freedom. Thus, poverty is real or relative of many deprivations which result in outcomes which result in unfulfilled life for the individuals. Some of the outcomes of poverty are:

1. **Deprivations compromises human capability:** Without access to basic services of healthcare, education, housing, and sanitation the capabilities of individuals will continue to remain underutilised. This is a loss to humanity.
2. **Vicious cycle of deprivation:** Malnutrition leads to lower educational and learning outcomes, lower healthcare leads to lower physical ability, these combined lead to lower earning and income outcomes in adult life. This in turn means lower opportunities for the children born in these households. Inter-generational continuity of poverty.
3. **Poverty leads to social conflicts:** Poverty leads to ghettoization and proliferation of slums in cities. The uneducated people are often vulnerable to be exploited by religious and extremist thoughts. No wonder that the poor are breeding ground for resentment against the state and prone to crime and revolutions.
4. **Culture of Poverty:** Poverty forces the poor the poor to develop certain behavioural enabling them to survive the sordid conditions of poverty. This pattern has been termed 'Culture of Poverty.' The poor develop a subculture of their own, tend to be socially isolated and have narrow outlooks. The individual who grows up in this culture has strong feelings of fatalism, helplessness, dependence, and inferiority. Their orientation is to live in present, they hardly think of the future.

There is thus a need to take a more nuanced approach to human development and progress. The first focus should be measurement and identification of poor. With the increased focus on addressing the multiple deprivations nature of poverty, measures of poverty have also evolved from a merely income level and calorie-based poverty line measures to much more nuanced multi-dimensional poverty index (MPI) developed by UNDP and Oxford University. The MPI focuses on ten parameters of nutrition, child mortality, years of schooling, school attendance, access to cooking fuel, sanitation, drinking water, electricity, housing and other assets. Thus, it does not take income for measurement of poverty. It believes that if a person is able to satisfy these basic needs, he is not poor.

Now, coming to designing policies which create a more equitable just and fair society, where basic needs of everyone is fulfilled. Scholars have suggested following policy options:

1. Taxing the rich and progressive taxation system
2. Interventions to improve public health and education.
3. Provision for universal basic income
4. Increasing the minimum wages and increasing income security for workers
5. Ensuring greater work participation of women
6. Boosting agricultural incomes.
7. Humanising globalisation

In this line, UN has come out with comprehensive Sustainable Development Goals which are collection of 17 goals for a more sustainable, equitable, fair and just world.

At the end we should remember that human progress should be as a collective enterprise where all of humanity benefits along with sustainability. Mahatma

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Gandhi's Talisman of helping the last and most destitute person should always guide our moral compass.

►CONSERVATION IS A STATE OF HARMONY BETWEEN MEN AND LAND

#ENVIRONMENT #SUSTAINABLE DEVELOPMENT

It was a very hot morning of 2031. Riya, a small kid was studying environment and ecology for the very first time. While studying she went through various strange words like forests, tiger, lion, leopard, etc. The curious kid, Riya, wanted to know more about these words so she went to her father and requested him that she wants to see these creatures. Her father was very helpless as there were no forest left. Tiger, lion, leopard, etc. were extinct. Her had no other option, but to show her the images by downloading it from internet. Riya was not satisfied by looking only at the image. She went back to her room thinking "what had happened that these creatures were extinct?"

Riya and many other kids will go through this scenario if we do not leave our earth as it is. It is high time that we realize the importance of our earth, environment and ecology and take steps to conserve it for sustainable development as well for our coming generation.

Conservation simply implies protection of flora and fauna from being extinct due to human activity. Article 48 and 48A (DPSP) and Article 51A (g) of our Indian constitution deals with protection of animals, environment including forest, lakes, etc.

Animals live in the environment by maintaining harmony with human. They do not try to encroach upon the area of man nor do they go and stay in man's house. Even if they encroach in the area outside forests, it is because they do not find forest where they can live.

Earlier, humans used to worship the environment. From the evidence of ancient history, it can be proven that they were living in with harmony nature. For example, edicts of Ashoka's pillar, Kautilya's Arthsashtra etc. mention about protecting the environment. But modern human beings are completely opposite of their ancestors. They are greedy and treat earth not as their home but a resource pool that can be exploited endlessly. This culture of greed and human want has brutally destroyed earth to the point that human existence itself is in doubt.

"There is enough for human needs but not enough for human greed." This phrase by Mahatma Gandhi resembles the present scenario of man. In order to fulfill their greed, humans are continuously exploiting Earth without thinking of its consequences.

Modern men are exploiting the nature for a number of reasons. Our wish to have air conditions, leather clothes, synthetic material, plastics, fuel and furniture is root for this exploitative attitude.

From harmony to disharmony: Harmony means peaceful coexistence. Harmony is already inbuilt in nature. Man is a part of nature not apart from it. Man was meant for living by using natural food, natural material (just as build their nests). However, human started modifying the natural course for his/her benefit. Thus, humans are going towards disharmony.

Manifestation of Harmony:

Primary Sector: Agriculture being the primary sector of economy. Agriculture sector aims to produce food to meet the nutritional needs to human beings. However, increasing use of unnatural means to produce food has led to disharmonisation. Use of chemical fertilizer, pesticides, etc. are hampering with the natural cycle. This leads to killing of various organisms which directly or indirectly helps me in maintaining the balance in the nature. For example, if the complete population of honey bees gets extinct then a large variety of crops and vegetable will also extinct.

Secondary Sector: Secondary sectors deals with the manufacturing industries. In order to manufacture the products, humans are causing pollution in the environment, resource depletion especially of fuels and minerals. For example, in industries, untreated water is released into water bodies such as rivers and lakes, leading to water pollution. The smoke which is released from industries and vehicles leads to air pollution.

Tertiary Sector: Tertiary sector deals with the service sector of the economy. Disharmony with nature is the nature of the tertiary sector. For example, once the mobile or electronic items get old it leads to the creation of e-waste generation. Radiation released from these e-waste is very harmful for both the humans and nature.

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The Reasons for increasing disharmony between human's needs and what nature can offer are the following.

Blind craving for wealth: Man in order to earn more and more money, is destroying the environment. Best example is killing animals for leather shoes, clothes, bags. Men want to earn huge amounts of money by selling these products.

Infrastructure Development: Humans are clearing the forests for development of infrastructure without even thinking twice. Many industries are built by removing forest and of course how can we forget urbanization. People are shifting towards urban areas from rural areas. Due to urbanization, population has increased in the urban areas. To cater to the increasing population of urban areas, sprawl of cities is increasing, resulting in deforestation of surrounding areas.

Dangers associated with disharmony

With the increase in disharmonisation, the balance between nature and humans has disturbed to a very large extent. With disharmony, many dangers are associated which will make human realize their mistakes.

Natural disaster: As per the IPCC 6th annual report, by 2100 most of the coastal cities will be submerged due to sea level rise. Many cities are facing situation of flood, drought, cyclones, desertification, etc.

Longer life, weaker body – Man by using various drugs and medication is successful in living a longer life but they live with weaker body. There is increasing incidence of lifestyle diseases such as diabetes, hypertension and cancer. Many of these diseases is the result of sedentary lifestyle and unsustainable consumption.

Viruses & diseases: The recent outbreak of covid 19 pandemic was a direct result of disharmonisation with nature. Increasing incidence of zoonotic diseases is the result of increasing exploitation of human beings on animal lives. For ex. Many of these novel viral diseases have been brought into human beings by their consumption of animals such as bats, pangolins etc.

Is disharmony that bad?

The answer of this question is that, disharmony is not bad provided man uses the nature in judicial and sustainable manner. For example: by using public-transport instead of private vehicle and by planting more and more trees.

In modern times, men cannot live without industries. So, to protect the environment and fulfilling their demands, men can manufacture products but in a sustainable and least harming and polluting techniques. For ex. Use of renewable energy in industrial sector, treating of wastewater generated from industries etc.

Smart Solutions:

Primary Sector: Instead of using chemical fertilizers and pesticides, farmers can use organic farming techniques to promote the growth of agriculture, deal with pests and to solve other problems associated with agriculture. Some organic method could be Zero Budget Natural Farming, System of Rice Intensification, Zero tillage farming, happy seeder, etc.

Secondary Sector: This sector can be made more environment friendly. For example, relying less on fossil fuels and more on sustainable fuels such as solar energy, wind energy and bio-energy. Before discharging untreated water and air in the environment, it must be treated very efficiently.

Tertiary Sector: Companies should invest more in increasing the life of product especially electronic materials so that less e-waste is generated when the e-waste is generated it should be disposed properly. Reuse, recycle and circular economy-based strategies should be promoted.

Policy interventions: Many countries have signed international agreements to protect environment such as Montreal Protocol, Kyoto Protocol, Paris agreement etc. India has come up with various initiatives for protecting the environment, such as carbon tax, clean Ganga program, clean energy mission, National Clean Air Program, Green Skill Development Program etc.

Conclusion:

Humans must see the relationship between human and nature as a mutually complementary relationship. Real & sustainable growth occurs, economic growth does not lead to irreparable damage to nature. Humans should not grow by damaging nature. Humans should always keep in mind that they are a part of nature and not apart from it. A proper harmony between nature and human will lead to the prosperous development of both man and nature and man will also achieve Sustainable

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Development Goals. Hence, conservation, judicial and sustainable use of nature is a state of harmony between men and land.

►WATER CRISIS: NOT JUST METEOROLOGY, BUT MISMANAGEMENT

#ENVIRONMENTAL

Pushpa lives in the arid region of Rajasthan. She must walk through the hot sands to fetch water to meet her and her family's needs. However, the distance she walked to get water has been increasing each passing year. As she recollects how in her childhood days, they just needed to walk to the Kund near the village to get water. But during the present times, the Kund has no water and is no longer used.

On the other hand, there is another story playing in stakes like Karnataka, Tamil Nādu, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana. Endowed with a perennial river Cauvery, and Dakshin Ganga, Godavari. These states are usually at horns over the sharing of water resources of these rivers which acts as lifeline for supply of freshwater in the region. Despite directions from Supreme Court of India and Awards by Tribunals formed to adjudicate different river water sharing dispute matters, they politics around sharing of river water tends to be never ending. For example. Even after award of Cauvery Tribunal, the recent dispute over Karnataka's Mekedatu dam on Cauvery has kept issue in public discourse.

It appears that the statement of Mark Twain that 'Whiskey is to drink, water is to fight' is actually true. On one hand, states like Rajasthan face water deficit (due to curse of metereology), but it is the mismanagement of water (Ex. inter-state disputes) that makes matter worse.

In this essay, we will analyse, various aspects related to water crisis. We will first deconstruct meaning of water crisis, and then investigate metereology and mismanagement as its causes followed by a brief look at's impact, and steps by the government.

About the water crisis

Water Crisis can be defined as the deficiency of water. It is a situation that involves acute shortage or scarcity of water for possible uses. This can be in three different forms. Agricultural water deficiency (drought) occurs when water scarcity adversely impacts agricultural productivity. Hydrological water deficiency entails water scarcity for human and natural world. Whereas a meteorological deficiency occurs when it is the meteorological or natural factors that causes the scarcity.

Native's Fury – The Meteorological Factors

The meteorological factors result in water deficiency across the world. Let us look at these.

Firstly, in case of India it is the Monsoons. Monsoon winds have an erratic pattern and do not cause equivalent rainfall across Indian subcontinents, rains are concentrated in four months in most parts of Indian peninsula. Due to orographic reasons, inner peninsula, Western Rajasthan and Gujarat and Tamil Nādu do not receive heavy rainfalls.

Another factor in case of India is the natural inability of water to percolate through hard rocks. This is witnessed in Himalayas where groundwater level is vein poor due to lack of water percolation. Recent studies by IMD have even pointed to dust storms in Middle east as influencing Monsoons. Lack of such storms leads to poor presence of condensation nuclei, which then leads to poor rainfall.

Now let us take a global reason for water crisis. Desert regions like Gobi Desert and Central Asia have natural water crisis where due to distance from sea, the rainfall is scanty. Similarly, Sub-tropical High-Pressure Belt around 25-35 latitude is major factor for scanty rainfall and desert like conditions especially in Middle Eastern Regions.

Another widely known factor is the El Nino phenomenon which is due to reversal of wind patterns and sea surface temperatures in the Pacific Ocean. El Nino causes drought like conditions in the Western Pacific including Australia, Southeast Asia & even India.

Lastly, Global warming induced climate change has deepened the water crisis even further. As highlighted in the recent report by Ministry of Earth Sciences, Climate change will increase the occurrence of droughts across India. Also, there is anticipation that climate change will result in thinning and eventual thawing of glaciers in the Himalayas which are the source of perennial rivers of the sub-continent. The drying of these rivers will adversely affect millions. Similarly, global agencies like WMO and IPCC paint a grim picture for water availability especially considering climate change. They warn of us

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increased frequency of adverse weather phenomenon such as draughts and floods.

However, to entirely blame weather, climate change and meteorological factors for the water crisis is not entirely story. Water management i.e., proper management and development of limited water resources is necessary to meet water needs of millions of Indians. Let us look how have we failed at managing our water resources properly.

Water Mismanagement – Who is at Fault?

It is said that 'we do not inherit this Earth from our ancestors, rather we borrow it from our successors.' The reasons for water mismanagement thus largely relates to how it is the human induced faults that has aggravated the water crisis.

Agricultural sector accounts for about 90% of fresh water use in India. Indian agriculture has the highest groundwater utilization in the world. Water use efficiency of Indian agriculture is extremely low. Several factors contribute to this. The rice-wheat system in water scarce states, irrigation subsidy by government, bund irrigation, rice as major commodity of export (export of virtual water), and eutrophication due to fertilizers, are some among many.

In the industrial sector, water utilization is primarily as a coolant. However, the largest threat of water and water bodies from the industrial sector is due to the discharge of untreated water in rivers and ponds leading to water pollution. Sewage treatment plants are inadequate leading to poor rates of water recycling, there is open waste dumping. This makes water inhospitable for marine species and deadly for consumption.

The household sector also is to blame for the water crisis. Household use water for variety of uses that leads to water wastage such washing of car, tap leaks, watering plants, usage of showers, wasting water from RO system. There is lack of regard to conserve and save water in the general population.

Even in the public and international arena water issues are not given adequate attention. Despite being home to largest rivers, South Asia still faces water scarcity partly due to heavy population in the region. Lack of trust, lack of regional cooperation framework for water issues and competition among the countries and near death of SAARC are few factors that have made regional inter-state cooperation on water issues near impossible.

At the national level too, various disputes mire the water crisis. Lack of active role played by Central Government. politicization by states over water issues and not following orders of the water tribunals, role of SC, have aggravated the mismanagement of water. India has 16% of world population and 4% of world freshwater resources and acute water scarcity. This demands a spirit of cooperation and priority to water issues. However, political grandstanding, bureaucratic red-tapism, apathy to water issues in public policy and poor policies such as excessive concretization which have blocked seepage to ground water have made the water crisis only deeper.

Thus, India faces a peculiar scenario when at the same time some parts of the country are suffering with drought while others rile under floods. For this not one is at fault, it is the collective fault of all of us and its consequences.

Water Crisis: Unintended Consequences

The grave economic impact India will have to bear to due to unsustainable water policies. World Bank projections say that India will lose 6% of its GDP by 2050 due to water crisis. Thus, unemployment, poverty, and food crisis would be a blot on Indian developmental journey. The impacts of the water crisis will fall disproportionately on the poorest living in remote regions. They will suffer for no fault of theirs as they continue to lead lives in accordance with nature.

Water crisis will increase polarisation, regionalism and fissiparous tendencies. The doctrine of son of the soil will gain ground. States instead of cooperation would use vote bank politics which will worsen the situation.

World Bank mentions that 60% of districts in India will reach critical ground water depletion level over next 20 years. Thus, vulnerable sections like women and tribals would be worse hit. This will be accompanied by poor health consequences, as India stands 120 in water quality index.

Environmentally, water crisis will lead to loss of Biodiversity, frequent droughts changes in ecosystem and loss of agriculture productivity.

Thus, we can see that the consequences of ignoring water issues will rather be disastrous.

Efforts Taken to Address the critical water situation

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Firstly, National Ganga Action Plan which aims to 'nirmalta and aviralta' of Ganga, conserve biodiversity and and reduce pollution in the mainstem and its tributaries. This program has support from the highest political level with the PM heading the National Ganga Council.

Secondly, water harvesting campaign by Ministry of Jal Shakti – Catch the Rain. It aims to revive traditional water harvesting techniques and kunds, and a rooftop water harvesting across districts.

Other steps include emphasis on river interlinking (Ken and Betwa links), increasing MSP for Millets and less water-intensive crops, advocating and subsidising Micro–irrigation systems to make agriculture water efficient and proposed amendments to river disputes act. Emphasis on greywater usage, water recycling and reuse. However, there is still a long way to go.

What more needs to be done for water-secure future

Firstly, India must take lead at the regional level via SAARC, and BIMSTEC, to adopt a regional guideline to address water scarcity and sharing of water. Secondly, amending National legislation inter-state water disputes act to expedite setting of tribunal, and not appealing the decision to SC. Thirdly, for the agriculture sector, states must take lead to "incentivize micro irrigation, IEC to reduce bund irrigation, and increase millet procurement. In the industrial sector too, changes are needed. Clear and concise water filtration guideline, regular surprise checks to analyse their efforts and mandating CSR for water conservation.

At individual level, there needs to be involvement of NGOs, and housing societies for rooftop water harvesting, using recycled water and ensuring desiltation of local water conservation sites.

Thus, there is a need for holistic and multidimensional response to the present water crisis. Water is a necessity for the existence of biosphere. Thus, we must avoid and prevent any form of its mismanagement.

It is only by collective efforts that we can prevent the grave impact of water crisis. And thus, we must ensure its conservation. For this a collective resolve by onboarding everyone, a social contract for water is needed.

►FARMING HAS LOST THE ABILITY TO BE A SOURCE OF SUBSISTENCE FOR THE MAJORITY OF FARMERS IN INDIA

#AGRICULTURE #ECONOMY

Agriculture has always been vital to India. Agriculture with its allied sectors is the largest source of livelihood in India. 70% of the rural households still directly depend on agriculture. India has been blessed with a varied climate structure and a wide variety of soils. Land is naturally suitable for cultivating a number of crops to add diversity to our food basket. Yet this sector suffers from both structural and implementation problems, which have deterred it as a source of profitable employment. In India, 82% of farmers are small and marginal farmers (1-2 hectares of landholding). Their heavy dependence on rainfall (seasonal), indirect credit, and dependence on intermediaries for foodgrain procurement make it a complex mix. A further problem of high input costs, lack of availability of technology, less diversification, heavy dependence on pesticides and fertilizers make the industry unsustainable. The distress can be seen in the number of farmer suicides witnessed in India. According to NCRB 2019 data, farming is the cause of 7% of suicidal deaths in the country. On average, 28 farmers end their lives every day in India.

The problem of making agriculture from a mere subsistence model to a revenue-generating one requires a multi-prolonged strategy—issues from procurement of seeds and inputs to the final selling. **'Ashok Dalwai's report on Doubling of Farmer's income** laid a major emphasis on input cost reduction. Along with this, sustained credit support from the formal sector and effective implementation of schemes with timely disbursements are necessary.

India has been bestowed with a variety of climates. The first step towards making farming sustainable should be to adopt agro-climatic condition-based farming. The majority of farmers take a decision to sow the crop depending on the Minimum Support Price (MSP) announced by the government and prevailing market conditions. To induce farmers to adopt sustainable agricultural practices, the government should increase procurement of other crops on MSP. Climate suitable crops should be adopted by increased MSP as incentive for such crops. A positive step in this direction has been taken by Haryana Government, where they will pay ₹ 7000 per hectare for non-paddy crops. Ensuring a supply of

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superior quality seeds locally, extending formal farm-based credit, insurance coverage at low premium rates (micro-insurance), and certainty of procurement by the government on MSP (crops other than rice) will boost the confidence of farmers to shift their pattern. Adopting agriculture suitable to climate will help us reduce resource exploitation, improve our soil condition and crop diversity, ultimately improving the nutritional intake, especially by pulses.

Majority of farmers being small and marginal, they can be organized in the Joint Liability Group (JLG). The concept is similar to that of self-help groups, where like-minded people come together to progress together. Such JLGs would enhance the credit procurement power of the group, machines lent can be used effectively, and ultimately it will help in better bargaining power while selling in the market. Collective sharing of the loans and the liability to pay will keep all members accountable and reduce the excessive burden on one. The timely repayment of loans will lead to better credit trust among the banks and farmers. There has been a rise of 38% NPAs in agricultural loans; this problem will be effectively tackled. Further, once JLGs are successfully operating, they can be formally registered with State Governments and upgraded to farmer producer groups or companies.

A major cause of distress among the farmers is the repayment of loans taken from informal sources. Farmer's land in a debt trap due to no document availability and spiraling interest rate. There are only 48,000 rural bank branches for 6 lakh plus villages in India. Further, the branches are skewed-greater presence in green revolution success areas. To make formal credit accessible, bank branches, especially of Small Finance Banks (SFBs) should be opened. SFBs have a 75% priority lending commitment to agriculture. Furthermore, microfinance institutions and post office banks should be encouraged. In areas that are far off, mobile banking should be adopted. This will also benefit farmers who cannot visit the branches often. PMGDISHA is a scheme of government by which it aims to train members from rural households to use the internet, including basic banking features. To enhance the coverage, bank applications should have regional language options. Further, the group of youth in the villages can be trained as Bank Mitras and act as a linking pin in the model. This will enhance rural employment generation as well.

Further, research and development by agricultural universities in terms of seeds, practices, and crop protection should be encouraged. A gradual shift to organic inputs like biopesticides and biofertilizers should be encouraged. Under the Soil Health Card Scheme of the government, at least twice a year, testing of soil should be done. Farmers should be explained about the condition of their soil and ways to enhance production. Continuous research in the development of superior quality seeds will help to make agriculture a more sustainable option. In West Bengal, 'Muktoshri' arsenic-resistant variety of paddy was grown. This will help to tackle bioaccumulation. Such seeds should be available to farmers efficiently and effectively. For this community, seed banks can be set up. Such banks can be maintained at Panchayat Level, and agro-climatic suitable crop seeds can be made available. Women SHGs can be roped to take charge. Further pooling of good-quality seeds by farmers can also be a solution.

Agriculture in India accounts for maximum use of water, accounting for 75% of water used, both from underground and surface water. Further, the subsidized electricity and diesel pump sets worsen the exploitation. Subsidy of the government here is a huge burden on the exchequer as well. For this, a community partnership for managing water resources, especially by raving traditional sources-baolis, tanks, ponds, should be undertaken. MGNREGA has reaped success stories in various pockets of the country to make villages sustainable in water consumption by building infrastructure. Rainwater harvesting, agroforestry (Har Medh Par Ped) and sustaining water use is the effective way forward. Further, gradually the government can lower subsidy and divert it towards setting up of drip irrigation and sprinkler irrigation systems can be done.

In order to make agriculture a revenue-generating model, it is necessary to reduce its crop dependence nature. Agriculture in India is majorly rainfed, and this brings in high chances of crop failure due to less rain. Sources of non-crop incomes are dairy, poultry, sericulture, agriculture, aquaculture, jatropha plantation, sea-weed cultivation, etc. The government has been productive in introducing a number of initiatives like Apiary on wheels to train farmers in beekeeping, but a regular and sustained approach is required. Recently, the government has introduced

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Shaphari Scheme to make shrimp production regulated and antibiotic-free. Such initiatives to check the quality, ensure pricing, and preventing farmers from being exploited are required to be carried on a large scale.

Further, a biogas plant can be set up by aggregating 2-3 villages with the help of the government to utilize the agriculture residue, get biogas as a cleaner fuel, and use the residue cultured as manure. India is 2nd largest producer of sugarcane in the world. To prevent distress selling and revive the sugar industry, ethanol production from it should be encouraged. This will further supplement the trending of the fuel program of the government.

Lastly, training farmers to adopt such practices and making them understand the benefits holds the key to bring change. Regional languages should be used to communicate with farmers through local newspapers, community radios, street plays, mobile apps, etc. NGOs, student groups from agriculture and science backgrounds can be referred to spread information.

Revival of rural income will help to improve the socio-economic conditions of people residing in rural areas (majority). It will keep a check on urban migration, open opportunities for better access to health and education, and improve the country's social fabric. The dream of economic and social justice in Preamble should keep the rural area in focus. In this way, we will realize the dream of Atmanirbhar Bharat through Atmanirbhar Villages.

►GDP CENTRIC GROWTH SHOULD ENABLE ECONOMIC INCLUSION AND CREATE WELLNESS

ECONOMY

Happiness: Towards a Holistic approach to development was the title of Bhutan sponsored resolution approved by the United Nations. The resolution declared that "happiness is Fundamental human good and universal aspiration, that GDP by nature does not reflect the good, that unsustainable pattern of production and consumption impede sustainable development, and that a more inclusive, equitable and balanced approach is needed to promote sustainability, eradicate poverty and enhance well-being and profound happiness.

Gross domestic product (GDP) is the total value of goods and services produced in a nation in a given year. Since 1930s at the time of great depression, the GDP has been a valuable tool for measuring how well or poorly an economy is doing at a certain point of time. GDP has remained a reliable indicator of economic health of a country. However, it measures only one thing and that is money. Some people believe that money is all important as it determines the health of an economy. But some think that there is much more to be considered such as happiness.

A country is considered prosperous when it has strong consolidated economy. However, having a strong economy is just a necessary condition but not a sufficient condition. Economic well-being of a country does not guarantee social well-being of a country. A country with high economic rise but without fundamental facilities such as sanitation, drinking water, education, health, security cannot be called a perfect place to live. Money is worthless in an atmosphere of anxiety, grief and agony.

This is the reason that some economists started to think about the 'Happiness' aspect of the development. The term `Gross Domestic Happiness' came to be first used in Bhutan; a small royal kingdom in the south Asia. In the year 1972, Bhutan fourth dragon king, Jigme Singye Wangchuk, started the age of modernization of Bhutan. He used the phrase for the first time to indicate that he was committed to build an economy that would serve Bhutan's unique culture based on Buddhism. The Buddhist ideology suggests that human society can benefit from development only when material and spiritual development occur side by side to compliment and reinforce each other. Promotion of sustainable development, preservation and promotion of cultural values, conservation of natural environment and establishment of good governance are the four pillars of development. This has been further elaborated into eight contributors of happiness i.e. Education, living standards, physical, mental and spiritual health, time balance, social and community vitality, cultural vitality, good governance and ecological vitality.

Growing GDP in lack of sustainable development cannot help a country in long term, because GDP is measured without taking into account the destruction it causes to the 'natural environment', which is the common property of human beings. It is a source of subsistence for millions of people. The main problem

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is the inefficiency of governments which has failed in delivering the goods and services to its people. If GDP is the sum total of all the goods and services produced within a country, it should not be the final yardstick for measuring the wellbeing of people of a country. As per the latest data, India is the third largest economy in terms of purchasing Power Party. But it is an irony that 30 percent of Indian people fall below poverty line. India is a home for nearly one third of world's poor. In perspective of GDP, India has no precedents in this world but when we see the poor, India is the dweller of largest poor in the world. Discrimination based on caste, honour killing, injustice and delay in justice, red tapism, corruption, nepotism, crisis in rule of law are the general features of a growing India which affects all the common citizens. These are the ingredients that make the lives of commoners cumbersome and clumsy. If we can overcome these root causes of crisis, then only can we get the right indices to judge the well-being of the people in a society.

How can GDP measure development in a country like India which has one of the world's dismal records in Human Development? How astonishing it becomes when we come to know that even Bangladesh and many third world countries score better than India in infant mortality? The levels of malnutrition among children are highest in India. The learning achievements of primary schools in India are no better than West Africa. In India nearly one third of newborns are underweight in comparison to one-sixth in Sub-Sahara Africa. On the other side, Bhutan is a tiny country in the north of India. It has a very low GDP. But it is the eighth happiest place in the world. It is the only country among the top 20 happiest country having such a low GDP. There is no proper quantitative definition of GDH but it has elements which facilitate its quantifying measurement. If we take an example of mortality rate in a country, we can directly co-relate it with the quantitative aspect of happiness. A society with low mortality rate would mean that the quantitative aspect of happiness is high.

GDH acts just like a genuine progress indicator which indicates quantitative measurement of happiness and well-being. Its supporters think that the concept of GDH is motivated by the notion that happiness and well-being are more important and relevant than the concept of income and consumption. It cannot be measured directly but through the elements which facilitate its measurement. For measuring GDP some metric can be used. **Economic wellness** is one of the important metric proposed, Economic metrics such as consumer price index ratio and income distribution are some of the metrics which can be used. Direct survey and statistics measurements can be conducted to measure it. The next very important metric is Environmental wellness of a country. We can conduct survey for checking pollution levels, noise, traffic etc. These are hindrances in the way of leading a healthy and peaceful life. Cities must be well planned and environmental friendly. Then only people dwell there and lead a healthy life.

One the major metric is **physical wellness** of the people. If people are suffering from severe illnesses and diseases despite having high GDP, we can't say that they-are happy. **Mental wellness** is as important as physical wellness. If Surveys and statistic surveys indicate that if people are mentally sound, are not suffering from any psychological disorders, they are happy. Consuming too much anti depression pills indicate Psychological illness. If persons are physically and mentally well, but they do not have a suitable and affordable environment at their place of work, they cannot enjoy their work. So **workplace wellness** is as important as other two i.e. physical and mental.

Wellness at social front is very important Discrimination, safety; divorce rates, domestic violence, family lawsuits, crime rates etc. indicate the state of **social wellness** of a country wellness. The quality of local democracy, governance, individual freedom, foreign conflicts etc. indicate at the health of **political wellness** of a nation.

GDP was intended to be a yardstick to measure economic growth of a country. The theory of GDP makes the statement that economic growth enhances social well-being. This may be true in many cases but researches have "shown that GDP has been an imperfect measure at it does not include environmental and social degradation that accompany economic growth.

All this led to an overwhelming support to GDH across the world from all quarters of the society. The reason for this overwhelming support and encouragement is that people all over the world are dissatisfied with the way societies are progressing. They are concerned with the degradation of overall quality of life where GDP is the only yardstick to measure social and economic well-being of a country. People have started demanding more sustainable and complete approach to development. They want dimensions such as social, environment and culture to be taken into account while making policy framework.

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GDH has evolved as a serious challenge to GDP which is a one sided measure of social and economic progress. Its supporters argue that GDP is simply a measure of currency that changes hands and doesn't take care of growing social problems. Its only focus is on economy. It does not consider the factors such as natural disasters which can contribute to the GDP growth as it encourages economic activities such as reconstruction. In measuring GDP there is a fear of statistic errors and the pollution factors are overlooked. GDP fails to measure quality development as it only measures the price as value. Gross Domestic Happiness aims to evaluate sustainability, well- being and quality of life. It measures total household income, the level of education, value of voluntary work and unpaid work of wives at home, natural capital such as energy, air water, sustainable transportation, levels of health, crime, pollution etc. But measuring love and happiness has to own limitations. Different people have different perceptions and opinions about love and happiness.

At present, GDP has been a measure used to evaluate the economy in India. Due to the flaws in the GDP, the government agencies have been trying hard to device techniques to strengthen GDP so that it can be made a comprehensive indicator. GDP indicate the' economic health of a country. It represents a sum of a country's production which consists of all purchases of goods and services produced by a country and services used by individuals firms, foreigners etc. GDP is considered important because it guides governments by indicating how much planning is needed and which policies are to be made.

India has made a phenomenal growth when we look at the growth in GDP. In terms of GDP, the economy is galloping to new heights. But does GDP reflect true picture of India? If we look more closely we come to see that the benefit of growth has reached to a small part of society. In India the gap between poor and the rich has been growing wide. Money has been restricted into a few hands. They are reaping the benefits of growing economy. They are the persons who are enjoying the luxuries of life. Poor are not able to fulfil even the bare necessities of life. Then there is a middle class which has now more money at their disposal but rising inflation in the prices of food and general items is leaving little money in their hands. They are not able to save for their future.

The real cause of unemployment is lacuna in our education system. The rise in GDP does not say anything about the state of education in the country. Moreover, education is not within the reach of everyone. The dropout rate in India is very high. It is true that the government has been trying hard to bring reforms in education but there is a lot needed to be done. Education must enable a person to become gainfully employed.

Vocational education must be incorporated into general education. The dismal picture of education sector does not match with the picture being depicted through growing GDP. Health sector in India is also very backward. Treatment is beyond common people's reach. There is lack of proper infrastructure in health services people have to long distance to get proper treatment.

Nearby dispensaries do not have adequate staff, and medicines. Private health care is very expensive. Only rich can afford such costly medical treatment. Transportation system is not up to the mark. Roads are not properly maintained in rural areas. In urban areas also we witness roads which are a clear invitation to accidents. Our railways are also in a primitive state. When most of the developed countries have introduced high speed bullet trams, we are still struggling to maintain whatever railways we have. People have to suffer a lot during journey.

The idea of measuring a country's performance through GDH is brilliant. It works in fairly small countries such as Bhutan but when it comes to larger countries such as India, China, U.S.A, Germany etc. it is difficult to rely totally on GDH. However, focusing only on GDP leads to stress, overworking suicides and unhappiness. Therefore, there must be a mixture of GDP and GDH while measuring a countries progress. It will surely cover all aspects of human development.

►GDP (GROSS DOMESTIC PRODUCT) ALONG WITH GDH (GROSS DOMESTIC HAPPINESS) WOULD BE THE RIGHT INDICES FOR JUDGING THE WELLBEING OF A COUNTRY

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Majority of farmers being small and marginal, they can be organized in the **Joint Liability Group (JLG).** The concept is similar to that of self-help groups, where like-minded people come together to progress together. Such JLGs would enhance the credit procurement power of the group, machines lent can be used effectively, and ultimately it will help in better bargaining power while selling in the market. Collective sharing of the loans and the liability to pay will keep all members accountable and reduce the excessive burden on one. The timely repayment of loans will lead to better credit trust among the banks and farmers. There has been a rise of 38% NPAs in agricultural loans; this problem will be effectively tackled. Further, once JLGs are successfully operating, they can be formally registered with State Governments and upgraded to farmer producer groups or companies.

A major cause of distress among the farmers is the repayment of loans taken from informal sources. Farmer's land in a debt trap due to no document availability and spiralling interest rate. There are only 48,000 rural bank branches for 6 lakh plus villages in India. Further, the branches are skewed-greater presence in green revolution success areas. To make formal credit accessible, bank branches, especially of Small Finance Banks (SFBs) should be opened. SFBs have a 75% priority lending commitment to agriculture. Furthermore, microfinance institutions and post office banks should be encouraged. In areas that are far off, mobile banking should be adopted. This will also benefit farmers who cannot visit the branches often. PMGDISHA is a scheme of government by which it aims to train members from rural households to use the internet, including basic banking features. To enhance the coverage, bank applications should have regional language options. Further, the group of youth in the villages can be trained as Bank Mitras and act as a linking pin in the model. This will enhance rural employment generation as well.

Further, **research and development** by agricultural universities in terms of seeds, practices, and crop protection should be encouraged. A gradual shift to organic inputs like bio pesticides and bio fertilizers should be encouraged. Under the Soil Health Card Scheme of the government, at least twice a year, testing of soil should be done. Farmers should be explained about the condition of their soil and ways to enhance production. Continuous research in the development of superior quality seeds will help to make agriculture a more sustainable option. In West Bengal, 'Muktoshri' arsenic-resistant variety of paddy was grown. This will help to tackle bioaccumulation. Such seeds should be available to farmers efficiently and effectively. For this community seed banks can be set up. Such banks can be maintained at Panchayat Level, and agro-climatic suitable crop seeds can be made available. Women SHGs can be roped to take charge. Further pooling of good-quality seeds by farmers can also be a solution.

Agriculture in India accounts for maximum use of water, accounting for 75% of water used both from underground and surface water. Further, the subsidized electricity and diesel pump sets worsen the exploitation. Subsidy of the government here is a huge burden on the exchequer as well. For this, a **community partnership for managing water resources**, especially by raving traditional sources-baolis, tanks, ponds, should be undertaken. MGNREGA has reaped success stories in various pockets of the country to make villages sustainable in water consumption by building infrastructure. Rainwater harvesting, agroforestry (Har Medh Par Ped) and sustaining water use is the effective way forward. Further, gradually the government can lower subsidy and divert it towards setting up of drip irrigation and sprinkler irrigation systems can be done.

In order to make agriculture a revenue-generating model, it is necessary to reduce its crop dependence nature. Agriculture in India is majorly rainfed, and this brings in high chances of crop failure due to less rain. Sources of non-crop incomes are dairy, poultry, sericulture, agriculture, aquaculture, jatropha plantation, sea-weed cultivation, etc. The government has been productive in introducing a number of initiatives like Apiary on wheels to train farmers in beekeeping, but a regular and sustained approach is required. Recently, the government has introduced Shaphari Scheme to make shrimp production regulated and antibiotic-free. Such initiatives to check the quality ensure pricing, and preventing farmers from being exploited are required to be carried on a large scale.

Further, a **biogas plant** can be set up by aggregating 2-3 villages with the help of the government to utilize the agriculture residue, get biogas as a cleaner fuel, and use the residue cultured as manure. India is 2nd largest producer of sugarcane in the world. To prevent distress selling and revive the sugar industry, ethanol production from it should be encouraged.

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This will further supplement the trending of the fuel program of the government.

Lastly, training farmers to adopt such practices and making them understand the benefits holds the key to bring change. Regional languages should be used to communicate with farmers through local newspapers, community radios, street plays, mobile apps, etc. NGOs, student groups from agriculture and science backgrounds can be referred to spread information.

Revival of rural income will help to improve the socio-economic conditions of people residing in rural areas (majority). It will keep a check on urban migration, open opportunities for better access to health and education, and improve the country's social fabric. The dream of economic and social justice in Preamble should keep the rural area in focus. In this way, we will realize the dream of Atmanirbhar Bharat through Atmanirbhar Villages.

►UNIVERSAL BASIC INCOME (UBI): INCOME SUPPORT OR MAKING PEOPLE DEPENDENT

#INCLUSIVE ECONOMY

A referendum was carried out in Switzerland in 2016 where in the people were asked to give their opinion on the implementation of Universal Basic Income (UBI). The proposal included the UBI of 2,500 Swiss francs to be provided to all the adults living in Switzerland. The result of the referendum was quite surprising given the fact that more than 75% of the population rejected the idea of UBI. Despite its rejection, the idea of UBI has caught the imagination of the world. A large number of countries such as US, Canada, Kenya, Finland, Namibia, Netherlands, and India etc. are implementing UBI through a pilot program in order to study its impact on the society.

UBI has its advocates as well as opponents. On one hand, the advocates have pitched for UBI as an answer to solve the problems of poverty and unemployment while, on the other hand, the opponents have argued that UBI would not be economically feasible and impose additional social costs in the form of inducing laziness and increased demand for temptation goods such as alcohol, cigarettes etc. Against this backdrop, questions which can be raised here is whether India is ready for UBI?

A Universal Basic Income (UBI) is a regular fixed cash transfer payment provided by the government to every citizen or resident regardless of their socio-economic status to ensure that they are at least able to meet their basic needs. The idea of a basic income is founded on the three following characteristics: **Universality**: UBI should be given to the entire population without taking into account the socio-economic status; **Un-conditionality**: UBI should be unconditional i.e. UBI should be given without any conditionality; **Agency**: UBI should be in the form of cash transfers without dictating the choices i.e. the recipients should have complete freedom to use the UBI in whatever way they deem fit.

The capitalists argue that growing automation would lead to loss of jobs and hence can have an adverse impact on the demand in the economy. Under such circumstances, the UBI would enable the economies to keep the demand intact and consequently the future economic growth would not be jeopardised. Further, the capitalists argue that UBI would not induce laziness among people. It is based upon the assumption that all the individuals are utility maximisers and would strive for higher quality of life once they are assured of basic needs through the UBI.

On the other hand, the socialists argue that implementation of UBI would reduce the growing socio-economic disparities across the world and would go a long way in taking forward the idea of modern welfare state.

Thus, it is argued that UBI is neither right (Capitalist) nor left (Socialist), rather it should be way forward for all the countries.

There are some advantages of UBI in India such as:

Freedom and Justice: It is often said that the greatness of a nation can be judged by how it treats its weakest member. In this regard, the UBI would enable the government to realise its vision of social and economic justice as enshrined in the Preamble of the Indian Constitution.

It is to be noted that Article 21 of the Indian constitution includes the Right to Life. The right to life is not confined to mere animal existence and it means more than physical survival. It includes the right to live with human dignity by being able to meet the basic necessities such as food, clothing, shelter, education, healthcare etc. Thus, the state is required to play a facilitative role in ensuring human dignity and

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enabling the individuals to reach their optimum potential. Hence, the implementation of UBI would promote the basic values such as freedom, justice, equality, fairness in a country.

Poverty Reduction: The Government has launched a large number of schemes and programmes aimed at poverty eradication. However, it has not had intended benefits. In this regard, the UBI can be considered to be a much better tool for poverty eradication for number of reasons. **Firstly**, if we look at the BPL population in India, it has got reduced from almost 70% in 1950s to 22% in 2011-12. However, in spite of this huge achievement, a large section of Indian society is even today unable to meet their basic needs.

Secondly, the BPL list in India is characterised by inclusion and exclusion errors due to which we have been unable to ensure basic needs for the poorest and most vulnerable sections of Indian society. In this regard, since the UBI is designed to be universal, it would be most appropriate tool to ensure basic rights of the poor and the downtrodden.

Thirdly, reasons for the poverty in India vary across the families. In some families, lack of basic education could be reason for poverty whereas in other families, lack of unemployment opportunities or poor health conditions could be reasons. Due to which, "One size fits all approach" to eradicate poverty does not work. Hence, it is the family and not the government that is in the best position to decide as to what actions should be taken in order to come out of the vicious cycle of poverty. The UBI would empower the families to take this important decision and hence can be considered to be a much better tool for poverty eradication.

Reducing Income Inequality: The UBI could also be considered as a solution to address the growing inequality in India for number of reasons. **Firstly**, 1/3 of jobs in developing countries could face immense pressure due to growing technological advancements and automation. Hence, the UBI would provide the people with the necessary security net in order to withstand any potential job losses in future.

Secondly, the UBI would be financed through the progressive income tax leading to redistribution of income from the richer class to the poor people.

Thirdly, provision of income security through the UBI would have positive spill-over effects such as increased levels of entrepreneurship among the poor families. This would promote inclusive growth and reduce the gap in the income levels between the households.

Promote Women Empowerment: Even though, women contribute significantly for the growth of our economy, their contribution is hardly recognised since majority of the women are involved in "unpaid" household work. Hence, in this regard, the feminists argue that the implementation of UBI would lead to change in the outlook of the society towards women and promote gender equality. This becomes extremely important in India where the women are regarded as burden on the families leading to their low social status.

UBI and Mental Health: Normally, the poor people across the world are burdened with the "psychology of scarcity" characterised by anxiety, distress and depression leading to poor mental health condition. This significantly affects their decision making ability and hence they fall into the vicious cycle of poverty and poor mental health condition.

The UBI could, therefore, help people free themselves of the mental burden and preoccupations and move towards a healthier life.

The motivation behind most universal basic income is laudable. However, some of the economists have argued that the UBI may not have intended benefits on the economy. In this regard, let us understand some of the problems and challenges in implementation of UBI in India.

Economic cost of UBI: Many opponents of the UBI argue that providing an income transfer to the entire population would result in very high expenditure. For example, if India has to provide UBI to all its citizens, it would be required to pay Rs 1190 per person per month (This is based on the Poverty line estimates of 2011-12 according to Tendulkar committee estimates). This expenditure would amount to around 12.5% of its GDP.

Social Cost of UBI: Work plays a central role in the life of the people. Apart from enabling them to earn their livelihood, working has certain social benefits. It contributes to feelings of self-worth and personal satisfaction, facilitates social interaction and enables the people to fulfil social needs and establish their role and identity in the society. In this regard, some economists have opposed UBI on the grounds that it would disincentive work and lead to negative social cost on the society.

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Apart from that, modern societies are necessarily based upon the principle of reciprocity i.e. the people's rights must be commensurate with their duties and obligations. The UBI would violate this principle of reciprocity since people would receive the money as matter of right without the imposing any economic or social obligation.

Political Cost of UBI: In order to implement UBI, the government would be required to do away with all the subsidies, which presently account for around 4.24% of the GDP. However, doing away with the subsidies has always been Achilles heels for India since it imposes political cost in the form of loss of vote bank.

Further, it has to be noted that the UBI may have to be revised periodically taking into account the rate of inflation and standard of living. Hence, competitive and vote bank politics may play a major role in the revision of UBI leading to unnecessary increase in the UBI amount.

Besides the above, there are other questions of concern about UBI such as: - **Does UBI discourages work and make people lazy?** It has been argued that UBI would discourage work and make people lazy since they are assured of minimum income for meeting their basic needs. On the other hand, this criticism against the UBI has been countered by some of the economists on number of grounds.

Firstly, the amount of money to be given under the UBI is meant to cover only the basic needs of the people. This means that the UBI cannot be considered to be sole means of survival for the large chunk of India's population. People would still have to work in order to meet their higher order needs. This can be explained through Maslow's Theory of Motivation.

Secondly, the argument that UBI would discourage work is based upon erroneous assumption that people work only in order to meet their basic needs. However, such an assumption demeans human dignity and labour and portrays the human beings in negative manner.

Thirdly, it can also be argued that the UBI would lead to increase in the productivity level of the workers. UBI would enable the workers to increase their bargaining power and negotiate on better terms of employment such as increased wages, better working conditions, access to social security benefits such as pension, insurance etc. Further, assurance of UBI would enable the workers to spend the money on development of their skills leading to increase in their productivity.

Hence, it can be argued that, contrary to the claims that UBI would discourage work, implementation of the UBI would actually improve the status of the workers, improve their bargaining power and more importantly, lead to higher productivity.

Does UBI lead to increase in demand for Temptation Goods? It has been argued that the implementation of the UBI would lead to increase in the demand for temptation goods such as Alcohol, Tobacco, Gambling etc. leading to moral hazard. However, this criticism against UBI may be countered on number of grounds.

Firstly, it is to be noted that both alcohol and Tobacco are inferior goods and not normal goods i.e. their demand reduces as the income level of the people increases due to the substitution effect (Law of Demand).

Hence, it is expected that as the income levels of the people increases through the implementation of UBI, the people would spend less money on the temptation goods and instead substitute this wasteful expenditure with some productive expenditure such as education, healthcare etc. So the assumption that the UBI would lead to increase in the temptation goods goes against the empirical evidence.

Secondly, there is also evidence that as the poor people are provided with UBI, they are willing to start small businesses and pull themselves out of poverty trap.

UBI has now entered policy debate in India ever since UBI was proposed by the Economic Survey 2016-17 as a social welfare scheme suitable for India. Further, recently, the Sikkim government has declared that it would be implementing the UBI from 2022. But the question here is does India has sufficient financial resources to implement UBI? From where should we generate revenue to fund UBI? The Economic survey has given answers to these questions.

The Economic survey proposes that the UBI should target only 75% of the population rather than being universal. It is of the opinion that the top 25% of the India's population can be easily excluded from the purview of UBI through automatic exclusion criteria such as payment of income Tax, ownership of movable and immovable property etc. Hence, in order to provide the UBI for 75% of the population in India, we would be required to spend around 5-6% of the GDP in order to implement the UBI.

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The Economic survey has proposed that the UBI can be implemented by doing away all the subsidies presently given by the government. However, financial resources alone would not guarantee the success of UBI in India. There are host of other factors which should have to be considered.

Firstly, it is observed that the success of the UBI initiative would depend upon the Political will and administrative efficiency.

Secondly, there is a need to recognise that the success of the UBI would depend upon providing information and enhancing the awareness levels of the people in India.

Thirdly, lack of Financial Inclusion may create a significant impediment to UBI implementation. According to the WB, there are only around 20 ATMs for every 100,000 adults in India. Hence, under circumstances, it may become quite difficult for the people living in remote areas to access the UBI. Hence, there is need to make the optimum use of JAM (Jan Dhan, Aadhaar and Mobile) trinity solution for making cash transfers. Apart from that, we need to improve the last-mile connectivity before implementing UBI. In this regard, there is a need to give further boost to differentiated banks such as Payment Banks and Small Finance Banks along with enhancing the presence of Banking correspondents (BCs) in the rural areas.

Fourthly, being a large and diverse country, India has to implement the UBI in an incremental and phased manner. Such an approach would enable us to keep learning from the challenges and problems which would be encountered in the implementation of the UBI.

Lastly, the government has to realise that the implementation of UBI is just one facet of welfare state and its implementation should not deter the government from undertaking other welfare measures. The Government needs to continue to invest in the creation of welfare state such as provision of Education, Healthcare, Housing, Sanitation etc. Provision of such basic infrastructure is equally critical for the success of the UBI.

It can be construed that the option of UBI has been floated as a panacea to promote welfare but it should be accompanied with more focus and weightage towards education, generating awareness, skilling, creativity, productivity, employability, employment and health of the people. Major budgetary investment is desired in all these areas which make people capable rather than dependent, make them citizens rather than subjects.

"Lending hands to someone is better than giving a dole."

►DIGITAL ECONOMY CAN BECOME AN ENABLER BY BRIDGING DIGITAL DIVIDE

INCLUSIVE ECONOMY

Click on the Zomato app and you will have your pizza delivered at your doorstep, one click on the Uber will make you reach the airport in time and with just a single click, you can actually plan your vacation in Mauritius. Thereby, going digital is no longer an option, it is the default.

Technology has evolved so much in today's time that everyone has become tech savvy. A student with access to internet can learn more than a child with no internet connectivity. A trader can buy his work and sell it online on higher prices. A farmer can stay updated with real time advisory. Not just this, a young man or woman with internet skills is more likely to be hired at a departmental store. One swipe of the ATM card resolves the issue of carrying cash and the list goes on. It's this digital world which has made every impossible thing possible.

Digital economy is a term coined in the mid-1990s which is considered as the by-product of internet revolution. The digital economy is the worldwide network of economic activities, commercial transactions and professional interactions that are enabled by information and communication technologies. Naming one thing where technology is not present is difficult.

Digital economy has evolved tremendously. Apart from the basic applications, many new features and new areas have emerged such as Internet of things, 5G, data analytics robotics, 3D printing, automatic vehicles, cloud computing, artificial intelligence, etc. It finds application in education, entertainment, banking, science, healthcare, financial services, space, medicine, agriculture and so on.

Digital technologies provide a level playing field, easy accessibility, affordability and services to all. It's a saying that in 21st century one cannot completely switch off!

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Digital Economy as a leveller: Was not man apprehensive when computers had first arrived? Was not joblessness provoked as a fear at that time? Similarly, with the fast pacing and globalised world, man is again doubtful about the possibility of these technologies replacing men or brushing gender equality.

Starting from our own households, digitisation has shaped our lives such as smart electricity, LED TVs, smartphones, ipads, automatic cars and what not. The problem of cash transactions during availing banking services, health care services, payment of fees, shopping etc. has been eradicated through digital payment modes like net banking, credit/debit cards, Paytm, Phone Pe etc.

Technology finds numerous applications outside of the households such as in the production sector where digitization has seen spur in innovation which is engine of growth. Many e-commerce companies, cloud computing, ITES, smart grid etc. have availed these technological advancement opportunities for producers and sellers.

B2B e-commerce between industries and many retail giants like Amazon, Flipkart etc. have increased production efficiency and high output. Thereby, improving India's ranking in Ease of Doing Business Report published by World Bank from 77 in 2018 to 63 in 2019.

The Govt. of India's **'Digital India' program** has been instrumental in bringing change towards paperless transactions. Most of the e-commerce companies monitor consumer behaviour and provide desired shopping material at their fingertips, reducing travel time and increasing affordability for customers that today customers prefer online shopping than traditional shopping methods.

Artificial Intelligence has started to make its way in the field of health care and medicine. India faces shortage of qualified doctors i.e. 0.76 doctors/1000 population, non-uniform accessibility and affordability issues. Artificial intelligence in combination with internet of medical things (IOMT) will serve as new nervous system for healthcare. Machine learning in assisting pathologists will guide in quality and precise diagnosis of diseases like cancer.

Today's farmer also will be engaged in 'climate smart agriculture' where with the help of digital technology she will be aided in real-time advisory regarding weather forecast, monitoring soil health, condition of micro nutrients, predictability of monsoons etc. Certain technologies involve the use of AI in monitoring soil health such as the Plantix App by the Berlin – based Germany which examines images of soil and uses whether there is any kind of pest or disease and offers remedial step for action. There is also an AI sowing app which predicts apt sowing time for beautiful harvest.

USA and China account for 75% of all patents in digital technologies and 50% of global spending or Internet of things (IOT). 4th industrial Revolution is known to transform existing technologies towards a brighter and improved quality of life.

Govt. in planning to establish 100 smart cities under the 'Smart India' mission which will incorporate the use of smart and advanced technology towards the creation of smart parks. Smart homes, crowd management, AI driven service delivery etc.

Change of such a kind requires change of people's attitudes because it's very hard to transform the culture and workforce to the digital world if all of the processes are stuck in the traditional world. If people do no adapt themselves to the fast changing world, then they will log behind most others and will not be able to compete.

Technology is sometimes also treated as a driver of economic inequality due to globalization, organizational and situational factors. Many inequalities are observed such as in terms of income difference which eventually breeds inequalities among people.

Large firms are in concentrated markets where executives are paid exorbitantly compared to the rest of the areas. But, these are exceptions and are not so always. There are some differences among the gender usage of technology such as per the Digital Economy Report of 2019, in around 2/3rd of countries women using internet are less than men.

Some disparities remain but to eradicate them UNCTAD recommends enhancing e-commerce radius in which firms and people create value through digital economy.

First step would be formulation of appropriate strategy through establishment of a leading ministry to enhance focus on digital technology, awareness generation towards importance of digital empowerment, engagement into public-private partnership dialogues. Just as PPP model has been proved to be effective in the construction of highways,

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bridges etc. similar model can be applied in the digital technology as well.

Second, creations of ICT infrastructure such as fast, affordable, reliable internet services and last mile connectivity especially connecting the rural population those in inaccessible hinterlands. PPP model can serve as national backbone infrastructure for access to internet bandwidth.

Third step would involve creation of legal and regulatory framework to regulate the e-commerce firms and digital economy and laws aimed at consumer protection, data protection, Intellectual property right etc. This would also include stringent provisions in ease of violation of laws and rules.

Fourth, would include development of skills i.e. making the workforce eligible for high-skilled or expertise requiring tasks through reskilling and upskilling. This can take place through vocational training by providing incentives such tax holidays, tax breaks/grants to employer. Recognition of training provided by informal training institutes such as in various diploma courses or distance education courses. One such initiative is of Ministry of Tribal Affairs to import training to tribal girls (5000) by mentoring them on weekly basis in collaboration with Facebook.

Empowering women in the digital economy is a pre-requisite for upward mobility of women and making them financially empowered. Wireless women for entrepreneurship and empowerment are a program in India which is women driven ICT based micro social enterprises.

Haiti, has also started a program called Radikal to empower women with tools such as internet, social media, mobile technology etc. to tackle poverty and handle micro-enterprises.

At the end, fostering digital entrepreneurship and innovation through large scale 'talk-shop' conferences such as i4 Policy initiative in Africa incorporates hub managers for policy dialogues.

Many such initiatives like these will help in making digital economy as a leveller and not as a source of economic inequality.

Times are changing and are bound to change, it depends on us how we adjust ourselves to the changing times.

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5 THEME SOCIAL ISSUES AND SOCIAL JUSTICE

ABOUT THE THEME:

UPSC topics related with Society are based on the desire to convert our society into a more democratic and egalitarian society. Here the major elements for achieving a just society are evolved education system, giving respect and recognition to all irrespective of caste, religion, gender and region.

In this regards, the topics in this theme are based on the above thought process.

►POVERTY ANYWHERE IS A THREAT TO PROSPERITY ANYWHERE

#SOCIAL ISSUES

"The good of the individual is contained in the good of All"- Mahatma Gandhi

If we look at Earth from a Cosmopolitan perspective, what the earth reflects is not an egalitarian humanity, but an amalgamation of rich nations concentrated in one hemisphere and underdeveloped nations elsewhere. Earth as a whole cannot be called prosperous as the Global North is composed of people with high per capita income, high standard of living whereas the Global South, that of poorer nations- example Africa, South Asia, which are placed low on Human Development Index, multidimensional poverty index, hunger index etc.

This image of the earth is not what reflects justice- social economic and political, equality or fraternity. The interconnected globalised world is highly prone to negative entropy, irregularities like poverty, climate change, wars, etc. which may arise from any country. Thus, poverty anywhere threatens the idea of prosperity anywhere.

The idea of a prosperous, egalitarian society based on ideals of social justice, equality, and dignity for all stems from various books of reverence. The Constitution of India envisions justice (social, economic, political) as fundamental rights and DPSPs, where the India State in under obligation to ensure this to its citizens. Goal One of Sustainable Development Goals envisions a world of ' no poverty'. Universal Declaration of Human Rights seeks to promote equality, economic prosperity equally.

Poverty implies a state of inadequacy of resources or capacities, where an individual is unable to fulfill his/her basic needs. It may be calculated quantitatively as done by the Rangarajan formula for poverty line estimation, or it may be understood qualitative like intellectual, relative, ethical poverty.

If we look at historical developments, the incidence of poverty has been due to many reasons -- lack of resources or their access, exploitation, colonization, etc. The sub-Saharan African Nations have been marred by the lack of natural resources, infertile land, etc. which are not conducive for development. On the other hand, European Nations, with temperate climate and plentiful resources have flourished.

Colonisation's impact on increasing poverty can be seen by analysing India. India, which was an ancient land of wealth, gold, spices, culture, etc., was a prosperous country. The British colonization appropriate India's wealth which has been called 'Drain of Wealth' by historians. This drain of wealth led to immiseration of masses, impoverishment of agricultural workers and exploitation of its rich resources. This has been duly brought out in various works like 'Poverty and Unbritish rule in India', by Dadabhai Naoroji.

The industrial revolution related to deepening of economic disparity between Global North and South. A 'zero Sum game' was created. The ideas of mercantilism saw the way to getting rich by making others poor, thus, developed countries flourished at the cost of poorer countries.

So why is the debate on poverty so important? How will it threaten prosperity as a whole?

If we take India as a case, in the social sphere, the presence of caste inequalities and hierarchy has threatened our ideals of social justice and empowerment. Poverty leads to deepening of the caste inequalities and create greater economic and

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social inequalities. Poverty reduces dignity of an individual, their autonomy and freedom and thus compromises their human rights. For e.g. - Safai Karamchari, Prostitution, etc, are often the results of impoverishment. Danish Institute on Human Rights has reported that countries with poor economic growth and high incidence of poverty also score very poorly on safeguarding human rights of their citizens. Thus, poverty is like a missing pearl in a necklace. It threatens the whole aesthetic.

ASER report has highlighted about learning poverty. This reflects poorly on our education system where even class five students are unable to understand basic class 2 texts and mathematical problems. This threatens the future generation of education with reduced chances of employment and lack of development of potential of our children.

Poverty has been linked with anti-social elements of society- unethical immoral acts like theft, robbery, murder, etc. have, many times, been a result of poverty. It is said "The rich can afford to be honest". However, the poor are often forced to indulge in criminal activities because of their basic needs. This results in weak social capital, lack off mutual trust, disharmony and law and order problems in society.

The Scandinavian countries like Norway and Finland, etc. usually top the human development and happiness parameters, because of high per capita income, high standard of living, ethical society, and overall harmony.

In the economic sphere, large poverty will force the government to provide subsidies, universal basic income, etc., which may strain public finances making it unsustainable for countries to invest in education, health, and future growth opportunities such as R&D and innovation. Higher subsidies also lead to high fiscal deficits, which can lead to ratings downgrades making it unattractive to foreign capital.

In the political arena, poverty deepens communal rifts. Rising inequality and poverty leads more left-wing extremism. Poor people are more susceptible to political populism, vote bank politics and political corruption. Poverty creates demands for reservations on the lines of caste, religions etc. this leads to increased fragmentation of society and deepens identity politics.

In the environmental sphere, poverty with respect to natural resources that is environmental poverty is a result of unchecked exploitation. Poor people often are dependent on nature for their survival. They consume coal-based power, use timber for fuel, their animals often graze grasslands. Thus, in a way, environmental poverty can lead to climate change global warming which affects the earth.

From the gender perspective, women are more illiterate, unemployed and face adverse effects of poverty more than men. When women are not empowered, the society is underpowered.

"I measure the progress of a nation by the degree of progress its women have achieved"- BR Ambedkar.

"If you empower a man, you empower himself. If you empower women, you empower the entire generation." - Gandhi

Thus, poverty of women will affect the future generation.

An especially important dimension of poverty is ethical poverty i.e., lack of moral values in individuals and society. Lack of ethics has resulted in major catastrophic events in human history- the Holocaust of Jews by Nazis, Atom Bomb explosions on Hiroshima and Nagasaki etc.

Poverty also leads to corruption. Since corruption is like a ball of snow, once it starts, it keeps increasing. Corruption has a bandwagon effect. Therefore, even small acts of corruption have potential impact society gravely.

►DIGITAL EDUCATION: THE FUTURE OF LEARNING

#EDUCATION

Paragi, school topper in class XII was upset about her chance to study abroad due to pandemic induced lockdown and restrictions. But she not only applied but successfully pursued her higher education in a prestigious college due to online education. Sanjay, who studied only till class 10 due to poor economic condition of his family now completed his graduation through distance learning. Similarly, hundreds of tribal students from a sleepy Hamlet in Odisha passed class XII board examination with flying colours, all thanks to NGO aided digital classes. Digital Education has truly been the future of learning by combining the best of both worlds: knowledge and technology.

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Digital education implies the delivery of education through Internet and digital aided systems. The courses can be pursued in live online manner and even provide the flexibility of recorded lectures for self-paced learning. This revolutionary turn in the field of learning offers varied advantages overcoming the human potential of reaching at a particular place. It not only offers students to build their careers but also aid the professionals with mid-term training, workshops and help them fulfil their dream of adding additional qualification.

Internet has revolutionized the way we shop, buy, sell, entertain ourselves and interact with fellow beings. This one click away technology now aids the potential of making education more accessible. Digital education can truly be seen as a way of making education more inclusive and thereby supplementing the fulfilment of sustainable development goals. This can also help us fulfil the dream of Right to Education (Article 2A) of the nation. In earlier times, education was considered as a privilege of few, especially in India. Only brahmins and kshatriyas were allowed to get access. This manifested in serious social inequalities which we experience even today. With digital learning even the most vulnerable section, Schedule Castes, Scheduled Tribes, girls especially from economically weak background, transgenders, elderly, migrant worker children, children in urban slums and rural areas can get an opportunity to learn. This will not only improve their chances of social mobility and better job prospects but will also make India more literate.

The NCRB data over the years has highlighted the issue of increased student suicides in India. The reasons are varied: from parents pressurising their wards, lack of self-paced learning, low scores, lack of securing admission in good college etc. Digital education with the supplement of artificial intelligence can help the students in self-paced learning. Quality assignments and continuous comprehensive tests can be conducted to make students aware about where they stand. Further, these applications provide an idea about areas of strength and improvement which can be utilised by a student to prepare smartly. Further, students can be provided enrichment of the explanation through use of immersive technologies. Videos of the method of working aided by sound improve cognitive ability of the child to retain better.

Digital education also provides an opportunity for meaningful collaboration with schools and institutions: regionally, nationally, and internationally. We all are aware of the scarcity of well qualified teachers at all the levels of education system. Digitally connecting the classrooms will help the knowledge and method of the well qualified teacher reach hundreds of students. Further, prominent technology, medical and management institutes can reach out to students who cannot economically afford to stay on campus or pay fees.

Government's vision of improving the quality rankings of Indian universities so that they find the place in top 50 and 100 institutions of the world can be fulfilled by learning best practices from their institutions (top 100 global universities).

India can surely take a step forward and invite students from neighbouring countries, poor countries from Africa and Latin America to get education digitally from renowned Indian institutions. This will surely make a huge impact and reassert India's soft power influence. Furthermore, India can strengthen its image globally and shape its idea of knowledge economy.

However, looking at the other side, the concept of digital education is a tightrope to walk on. The idea though promising and revolutionary is marred with challenges the most basic one being providing infrastructure. Digital education can only be effective if- electricity, internet and gadgets are present. The NFHS 2014- 15 the survey has highlighted the dismal picture where less than 20% of rural households own a device specially computer compared to 75%+ proportion of households in urban areas. ASER 2020 reports highlight that only 33% of students in India could have access to digital learning; 11% off which only could attend live classes. Rural electrification is still a dream, forget about a stable internet connection. Further, we have only seen gender inequality angle thereby male own smartphones in a greater proportion as compared to females. Also, a family having a single phone- then the male child is given preference.

Another grave concern which doctors and child psychologist have highlighted is the issue of addiction. Students must spend hours before a gadget exposing them to radiation, stress on eyes and almost negligible physical activity. Being given the screens have become a new normal and nowadays youngsters refuse to just take efforts. This causes mental stress and chances of increase in obesity among students. Digital learning is also limited in its application, there is still no method as to how

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students would learn practical subjects like chemistry, fashion technology, beauty and wellness, hospitality, etc. as these require hands-on learning and practice. The outcome of learning can also be questioned as being separated by a screen makes students often disinterested and open opportunities to duplicate/cheat in examination.

Digital education not only impacts the students but also the educators/teachers in several ways. Firstly, the teachers had to themselves learn about using online learning and lecture application. Some of them were literally pushed into the framework and given no prior training. This not only impacts the teaching but also reduces the confidence of the faculty. Further, many teachers are at the receiving end from the parents of children who attend classes with them and interrupt in the pedagogy in several ways. Teachers are stopped from delivering lectures due to parental influence where they correct them even for slightest of error. Further, managing home with school has been a daunting task for many. Our teachers mostly females have been doubly burdened by household duties along with online lectures. Students often play pranks, disrupting the classes instead of helping the teachers with technology.

Even though, digital education poses several challenges, but they can be effectively tackled through societal and political will. Government needs to increase its expenditure on education to 6% from current 4% and provide the required infrastructure and training to the stakeholders. Further, CSR funding can be utilised to provide required devices to students along with internet connection. Bharatnet project needs to be completed on war footing so that villages are covered effectively. Further, economically well-endowed educational institutions should voluntarily come forward to collaborate with other less well-endowed schools and colleges. This will help us to curb the problem in areas where schools have to shut due to faculty availability.

Furthermore, as Einstein emphasized that education should teach children about how to think rather than what to think, should be adopted. Education has the power to change the world and therefore the curriculum and execution should be well planned. A hybrid form of learning can be adopted as the rich and lifelong lessons in a classroom cannot be negated. Social interactions teach students a teamwork, tolerance, ability to disagree but be respectful, embracing the diversity, gender sensitivity and parity. Social interaction opens our mind and are stress busters in many ways. Further, the bond between the teacher and disciple gets strengthened in classroom setting. As Aristotle said, education of mind without education of heart is no education at all.

Digital education though disruptive offers numerous opportunities. It depends on a nation to make it a leveller for differentiator. A more inclusive and educated society would help us fulfil our social and economic justice aims as enshrined in the Preamble. Educated population is a key human resource which can be effectively used for Atmanirbhar Bharat and in becoming a true democracy.

►AN ALL-INCLUSIVE PUBLIC HEALTH SYSTEM

SCIENCE

The current public health situation in India is a sad story of deprivation. Unless one is eye-washed by displays of hi-tech medical care and use of state-of-the-art medical technologies in five star deluxe facilities of a few select urban centres, the tale of utter helplessness and callous carelessness is so apparent that it is now frequently taken as a matter of course. The blatantly paradoxical spectacle of buying and selling of health improvements as a consumer goods by the well-off minority in the metros on the one hand and the denial of basic health facilities to the vast majority of the population along the length and breadth of the country on the other hardly evokes any comment.

On daily basis, bleak picture of health services emerge from different parts of the country. In this regard, let us understand the importance of healthy public health system.

Public Health is the science and art of promoting health, preventing disease, and prolonging life through the organized efforts of society (WHO). It is a social and political concept aimed at improving health, quality of life among whole population through health promotion, disease prevention and other forms of health interventions. Public Health approach is a holistic approach which encompasses all elements required for healthy living. It controls disease through health promotion, specific protection and by restoration and rehabilitation. In addition, disease surveillance which informs about ongoing as well as emerging public health issues is a core public health function. Other important functions are developing partnerships, formulation of

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regulations/laws, planning/policies and Human Resources Development.

Directive Principles of State Policy considers that the State shall regard raising of the level of nutrition and standard of living of its people and improvement of public health as among its primary duties under **Article 47**. In addition, **Article 42,** the State shall make provisions for securing just and humane conditions of work and for maternity relief. The health system in India is expected to perform with objectives based on these principles and evolve its spirit and structure to achieve these objectives.

The most comprehensive health policy and plan document ever prepared in India was on the eve of Independence in 1946. This was the 'Health Survey and Development Committee Report' popularly referred to as the **'Bhore Committee'**. This Committee prepared a detailed plan of a National Health Service for the country, which would provide a universal coverage to the entire population free of charges through a comprehensive state run salaried health service. Later, many other committees reviewed the existing health infrastructure/situation in the country and made recommendations needed to prevent and control diseases including communicable, non-communicable and emerging diseases.

Later, the 'Expert Committee on Public Health system (1996)', the 'National Commission on Macroeconomics and Health (2005)', National Five Year Plans, 'National Health Policy (1983, 2002)', and many international initiatives such 'UN Millennium Development Goals (2000)', have also provided strong policy directives for the development of health care delivery system to control/prevent diseases.

Broadly, the healthcare services are divided under **State list and Concurrent list** in India. While some items such as public health and hospitals fall in the State list, others such as population control and family welfare, medical education, and quality control of drugs are included in the Concurrent list. The Union Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (UMHFW) is the central authority responsible for implementation of various programmes and schemes in areas of family welfare, prevention, and control of major diseases.

The public sector ownership is divided between central and state governments, and municipal and panchayat local governments. The facilities include hospitals, secondary level hospitals, first level referral hospitals (community health centres [CHCs] or rural hospitals), dispensaries, primary health centres (PHCs) and sub centres, and health posts.

The major weaknesses in the Public Health system in India have emanated from -Issues related to quality and functioning of Public Health Services. 'Quality of public health services' is defined by the extent of their **availability and coverage, economic affordability and social accessibility** to all sections of society, efficacy, safety and epidemiological rationale, and attitudes of the personnel. This, in turn, is dependent upon the 'culture of health services', which consists of the organizational principles, motivations of personnel at all levels and their interactions among themselves as well as with those to whom they provide services.

The factors that have contributed towards dilution in the quality and reach of Public Health Services are given hereunder:

Public health has effectively remained a **low priority** for the Indian state in terms of financing and political attention in successive five-year plans. The overall system of health planning and decision making remained highly centralized and top-down with minimal accountability, giving little scope for genuine community initiatives.

It may be noted that until 1983 India had no formal health policy. Although, significant expansion of healthcare infrastructure did take place after 'National Health Policy-1983' yet this remained grossly underutilized because of poor facilities and low attendance by medical staff, inadequate supplies, insufficient hours, lack of community involvement and lack of proper monitoring mechanisms. The Primary Healthcare Approach was never implemented in its full form, and selective vertical programmes were pushed as a substitute for comprehensive health system development.

This already unsatisfactory situation seriously worsened with the onset of liberalisation era from 1990s onwards. This phase has witnessed staggering health inequities, resurgence of communicable diseases and an even more unregulated drug industry with drug prices shooting up, adding up to the current crisis in public health. Along with the retreat from the goal of universal access, special health needs of women, children and other sections of society with special needs have become further sidelined or are inadequately addressed.

Closely related to this, and compounding this situation has been a **Techno-managerial model of**

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healthcare inspired by the West, with an inability to evolve effective indigenous models and appropriate technologies, or to effectively integrate modern and indigenous systems of medicine.

Consequently, emphasis is on more curative services and with inadequate lab capacity in the system and poor participation of private sector in public health activities. As per NFHS, the pattern of health care expenditure in India shows that more than 70% of expenditure is from out of pocket by households. Estimates suggests that in India the total health expenditure is around 6% of GDP, and is dominated by out of pocket spending i.e. around 5%. The government/public expenditure on health care is around 1.4% of GDP. Due to this low public expenditure the reach and quality of public health services are below the desired level.

By considering the above, rejuvenating the Public Health System in India should be provided utmost priority. Making **right to health care a fundamental right** is an important step to initiate changes in the public health delivery mechanism. The other major steps that may be taken for rejuvenation are:

First, a considerably strengthened, accountable and reoriented public health system needs to be nurtured. Such a rejuvenation of the public health system would require changes at levels of policy, structure, programmes, and processes. Such strengthening should ensure adequate infrastructure, human power, services and supplies at various levels, restoring the basic functionality of the system and rebuilding public confidence.

Second, the base of strengthened public health would need to be a framework of comprehensive Primary Health Care including Community health workers in every habitation; much more functional and accountable Primary health centres (PHCs) and First referral units (FRUs), combined with a range of appropriate preventive and promotive activities.

Third, to institutionalize accountability would require a legal and constitutional framework to assure health services as a Right. Once right to health care is considered, the task of the health movement would be to make sure the range of services is as comprehensive as possible, and to ensure that the services required by various marginalized sections and groups with special needs are definitely included.

Fourth, substantially raising public finances for the public health system, through general taxation along with various forms of special taxation and cesses for health security. Ending subsidization of the private medical sector and effectively taxing this sector, especially its upper end; a special health security cess on all financial transactions above a certain level; and preferential taxation of industries with negative health impacts are some other measures that may be considered.

Fifth, specific health care requirements of various groups with special needs – such as women, children, and elderly persons – would need to be met through sets of special measures, sensitively delivered by the general health system.

Sixth, specific major health problems, both communicable diseases such as TB and HIV-AIDS, and non-communicable health issues such as mental health would need to be addressed through programmes closely integrated with a robust comprehensive health system.

Seventh, progressively bringing the private medical sector under social regulation would be essential for realization of health rights in meaningful manner. A first step in this direction would consist of legally and organizationally ensuring that this sector meets minimum standards -follows standard treatment guidelines, and observes ceilings on prices of essential health services.

Eighth, much more effective public health support to indigenous healing systems is required, including active research on areas such as community based evaluation of indigenous healing methods and synergistic combination with modern medicine.

Ninth, ensuring access to essential drugs in rights based framework, both in form of ensuring availability of the range of essential drugs free of cost in public health facilities, and stringent price control.

Tenth, operationalising accountability and redressal mechanisms to ensure regular civil society monitoring and inputs at various levels.

Besides above, for realization of 'Public Health for All', in its fullest and most humane sense, coordination and synchronization with other conditions such as- comprehensive nutritional and food security (linked to livelihood security), universal access to safe drinking water and sanitation, provision of healthy housing and local environments, universal healthy working conditions and a safe general environment, access to health related education and information

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for all, and an equitable, gender-just social milieu, free from violence are required.

►THE LONG ROAD TO REAL WOMEN EMPOWERMENT

WOMEN EMPOWERMENT #SOCIAL JUSTICE

The core of empowerment lies in the ability of a woman to control her own destiny. This implies that to be empowered women must not only have equal capabilities (such as education and health) and equal access to resources and opportunities (such as land and employment), they must also have the agency to use those rights, capabilities, resources, and opportunities to make strategic choices and decisions (such as are provided through leadership opportunities and participation in political institutions) and to exercise agency, women must live without the fear of coercion and violence.

In terms of Indian women, the women empowerment is very essential, because of the male dominated patriarchal society. It is very difficult to achieve social, political, economic and other development of the nation without empowerment of women community. There are many practical steps that can reduce inequalities based on gender, inequalities that constrain the potential to reduce poverty and achieve high levels of well-being in society. There are also many positive actions that can be taken to empower women. Without leadership and political will, however, the world will fall short of taking these practical steps and meeting the goal.

In the Indian society gender inequality is deeply rooted in entrenched attitudes, societal institutions, and market forces. Political commitment at the highest international and national levels is essential to institute the policies that can trigger social change and to allocate the resources necessary to achieve gender equality and women's empowerment. The women should be empowered, and then only India can overtake its challenges to achieve the desired growth.

Like race and ethnicity, gender is a social construct. It defines and differentiates the roles, rights, responsibilities, and obligations of women and men. The innate biological differences between females and males form the basis of social norms that define appropriate behaviours for women and men and that determine women's and men's differential social, economic, and political power. The concept of empowerment is related to gender equality in the distinct from. Inclusion of gender equality and women's empowerment need an operational framework within three dimensions:

The **Capabilities Domain**, which refers to basic human abilities as measured by education, health, and nutrition. These capabilities are fundamental to individual well-being and are the means through which individuals access other forms of well-being.

The Access to Resources and Opportunities Domain, which refers primarily to equality in the opportunity to use or apply basic capabilities through access to economic assets (such as land or housing) and resources (such as income and employment), as well as political opportunity (such as representation in parliaments and other political bodies). Without access to resources and opportunities, both political and economic, women will be unable to employ their capabilities for their well-being and that of their families, communities, and societies.

The **Security Domain**, which is defined to mean reduced vulnerability to violence and conflict. Violence and conflict result in physical and psychological harm and lessen the ability of individuals, households, and communities to fulfil their potential. Violence directed specifically at women and girls often aims at keeping them in "their place" through fear.

These three domains are interrelated. Change in all three is critical to achieve empowerment. Building capacities means enhancing the role of participation in the society. The dimension security refers to violence and crimes arising against women and the other social evils such or the crimes against women, female infanticide. Women are also more susceptible to cheating and exploitation. Child marriage and dowry system see women as trade goods.

From the gender perspective reservation policy is implemented for equity and equality of the women and access to resources and opportunity for empowerment. The recommendation to include 33 percent women in the decision-making level of political parties should be made compulsory as implementing steps to ensure that women propose their own views in the decision-making of the administration, judiciary, non-government organisations and private sector. It is also recommended increasing political position of the ministry of Women and Children Affairs with provision of required resources.

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The Indian government conducts multidimensional programs for empowering women. To empower women further, the bare minimum necessities are: Strengthen opportunities for post-primary education for girls while simultaneously meeting commitments to universal primary education. **Schooling is the first step** toward gender equality in education. However, the world is still far from achieving gender parity in enrolment and completion rates, particularly at the secondary school level. A number of interventions that have proven effective for increasing girls' participation in primary school may also apply to post-primary education. These include making schooling more affordable by reducing costs and offering targeted scholarships, building secondary schools close to girls' homes, and making schools girl-friendly. To make all schools feminine friendly in terms of toilet and campus. Education must serve as the vehicle for transforming attitudes, beliefs, and entrenched social norms that perpetuate discrimination and inequality and promotes empowerment. All interventions taken to promote gender equality in education must, therefore, be transformational in nature

Guarantee of sexual and reproductive health and rights cannot be achieved without empowerment of girls and women. A large body of evidence shows that sexual and reproductive health and rights are central to women's ability to build their capabilities, take advantage of economic and political opportunities, and control their destinies. Conversely, gender inequality that restricts women's access to economic resources compromises their sexual and reproductive autonomy. Interventions to improve sexual and reproductive health and rights must therefore be a priority and should occur both within and outside the health system. At a minimum, national public health systems must provide quality family planning services, emergency obstetric care, safe abortion (where legal), post-abortion care, prevention and treatment of sexually transmitted infections (including HIV), and interventions to reduce malnutrition and anaemia.

Invest in infrastructure to reduce women's and girls' time burdens. Increasing women's participation in the design and implementation of infrastructure projects can help to overcome obstacles to access and affordability. This is best illustrated in the sanitation and water sector, where women play key roles as users and managers. There is strong evidence from community water and sanitation projects that projects designed and run with the full participation of women are more sustainable and effective than those that ignore women. Adapting modern science and technology to meet the infrastructure needs of poor people in a way that builds on the knowledge and experience of women and is accessible and affordable to all is therefore a development priority.

Guarantee women's and girls' **property and inheritance rights**. Eliminate gender inequality in employment by closing gender gaps in earnings, and reducing occupational segregation. Women's work, both paid and unpaid, is critical to the survival and security of poor households and an important route through which households escape poverty. Recognizing the value of early education, especially targeted to poor children, governments in India, also support childcare and early education services. Yet, no single country provides the investment in care services that is required to fully meet the needs of women and their children. Filling this gap is essential for empowerment. To improve the nature and conditions of work, employment-enhancing economic growth is a prerequisite for low-income countries, coupled with social policy that eliminates discriminatory employment.

Increase women's share of seats in national parliament, assemblies and local governmental bodies. Increasing women's representation in political office is now a widely accepted Indicator of empowerment for tracking progress. Indeed, the bench mark recommended a target of 33 percent of seats for women in national parliaments. There are three reasons why the task force has selected political participation as a strategic priority. Countries where women's share of seats in political bodies is less than 30 percent are less inclusive, less egalitarian, and less democratic. Equality of opportunity in politics is a human right. Evidence also suggests that women's interests often differ from men's and those women who participate directly in decision making bodies press for different priorities than those emphasized by men. Finally, women's participation in political decision making bodies improves the quality of governance.

Combat violence against girls and women. Although no single intervention will eliminate violence against women, a combination of infrastructure, legal, judicial, enforcement, education, health, and other service-related actions can significantly reduce such violence and ameliorate its negative con- sequences. Throughout countries around the world adopted new legislation on intimate partner violence, reformed laws on rape and against domestic violence.

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Information, Education and Communication: The key step for overall empowerment of women is to educate them. Education is the greatest and primary way to empower women society, and giving awareness about their right especially in rural women. The parents have the prime duty that is to educate children. Education provides another important entry point for combating or preventing gender-based violence. Educational interventions include both school-based programs and broader communications campaigns aimed at raising community awareness about the damaging effects of violence. Communications media such as pamphlets, radio, television, and theatre serve to educate and promote change, as they can reach large audiences, because violence often occurs in unsafe public spaces, interventions to improve public infrastructure can contribute to reducing violence against women. If any exception occurred the government should take immense and suitable action to educate them.

Gender inequalities exist among the rich and the poor, but they tend to be greater among the poor, especially for inequalities in capabilities and opportunities. Moreover, the wellbeing and survival of poor households depend on the productive and reproductive contributions of their female members. Also, an increasing number of poor households are headed or maintained by women. A **focus on poor women** is therefore central to reduce poverty and empower them. Women empowerment faces other challenges in this patriarchal society that are poverty, unemployment, dependence over male counterpart for safety, security and survival etc. The government should step in to include necessary measures in the upcoming Poverty Reduction Strategy to ensure empowerment of women in every sphere of society. Overall long term plan with strategic steps should be taken to empower Indian women community's socio-economic freedom, equality with male counterpart, right to own title and heir of property.

Situations of conflict have disproportionate impacts on women and children, who are typically the majority of displaced persons. Post conflict periods present a window of opportunity for reducing gender barriers and creating a gender-equitable society, which is more likely to occur if the reconstruction process fosters the full participation of women. Women in conflict and post conflict needs a damage management system to empower them.

All of the above transformation requires a critical mass of change agents committed to the vision of a gender equitable society. These change agents include leaders at all levels of government who control critical levers for change — financial and technical resources and set the priorities for actions affecting the lives of many. To be effective, government leaders must work in partnership with civil society institutions, especially organizations that represent women's interests. Simultaneously, there must be a critical mass of change agents at the international level in the institutions that provide support to national governments and civil society organizations in implementing changes necessary for a gender-equitable society.

Accountability and monitoring systems need to be in place to ensure that fundamental change is broad-based and lasting. The needed systems include a strong legal framework along with the mechanisms to enforce it within and outside government, and a strong women's movement along with the processes that enable women's groups to inform and influence government policies and resource allocations. The philosophy of women empowerment should identify indicators for measuring invisible contribution of women. At the same time, it should incorporate budget, National Women's Development Policy and Platform of Action in the meaningful planning of the future for the empowered women in society. The way is long for us to go, but with the sustained and collaborative steps, and implementation of favourable policies, the vision of empowered women will be achieved. Then only India can be a developed nation.

►RECOGNISING THE ROLE OF WOMEN IN AGRICULTURE BY ENABILING LAND ENTITLEMENTS

#WOMEN EMPOWERMENT #SOCIAL JUSTICE

"How wrong is it for a woman to expect the man to build the world she wants, rather than to create it herself?" ~ Anaïs Nin (Cuban activist)

What is the issue of land ownership for Women?

In many parts of the world, women's rights to land and property are systematically denied. Laws give women fewer or less secure rights than men, and discriminatory attitudes and practices undermine them. This leaves many women almost entirely dependent on the men in their lives for basic economic survival and vulnerable to violence,

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poverty, and food insecurity, particularly if widowed, divorced, single, or in marriages not formally recognized. As land resources are increasingly contested, these problems have worsened, particularly for rural women.

Women's access to, use of and control over land and other productive resources are essential to ensuring their right to equality and to an adequate standard of living. These resources help to ensure that women are able to provide for their day-to-day needs and those of their families, and to weather some of life's most difficult challenges. Women's access to land and other productive resources is integrally linked to discussions around food security, sustainable economic development, as well as the pressing fight against gender-based violence. Why have we not able to achieve that in India?

One of the foremost reasons is the patriarchal mindset of Indian society which identifies women's role with narrow outlook. The biggest manifestation of such outlook is the continuous land deprivation that women are subjected to. According to the estimates, about 90% of agricultural land is owned by men. Similarly, in urban regions, majority of property is owned by male counterparts where even the most liberal legislations related to property rights have not been able to make a difference. Families prefer to name their property and land in the name of male members and somehow get around with the laws.

The Indian society is, basically, more tied towards the theory of females being temporary members of the family, and once married would go to other family. This further leads to the mindset where sons are seen as the caretakers of parents during their old age. Such beliefs are not restricted only to the lower sections but continue to persist in the educated and advanced most sections of the society. On the contrary, it is lower sections where women enjoy more liberty in terms of working and ownership. However, such instances are not a norm. The other reasons for such deprivation is stereotyping that women's role is being confined to that of domestic and household works. In rural areas there is an emotional attachment to land and ancestral property. Families want these to remain in the family thus prefer to name it to male members.

The persisting land deprivation comes with its own set of perils. In rural areas agricultural land belonging to male members disempower women. The Indian government provides bank accounts and credit facilities in the name of land holders. This effectively means women are deprived of financial inclusion. Women would continue to be subjected to discrimination. This results in lesser say of women in decision making. It is proved that women are better managers of household income. They would judiciously spend in important works and save the rest. Such instances develop a financial cushion for the household. On the contrary male counterparts may spend in other tasks such as gambling and drinking. Drinking leads to deterioration of health and increase in domestic violence. Children are deprived of a better life and there are no savings for financial emergencies. Drinking is also related to other forms of crimes such as rapes and murders.

Additionally, when male members migrate to other places, it is the women who work on fields. However due to low level of financial awareness and absence of land titles they are not able to enjoy government welfare measures such as access to markets, subsidized inputs and loans as these are linked to landownership. Also, such deprivation makes them vulnerable to opportunists who may try to grab their land.

Land deprivation of women brings with it plethora of problems in urban areas also. The lower sections of people reside in slums and generally do not own any land. Even if they do own due to government housing allocations it is in the name of male counterparts. In the upper and middle urban sections conditions are slightly different. They have higher levels of education and income; women may be working in well-established enterprises and are more aware of their rights. The urban middle class is most developed in this sense where women share property and have higher societal status. Unfortunately, even in this section land and property deprivation of women is prevalent. Conspicuously, it is the rich business class where women are deprived the most. Preference to son is given in the continuity of business. Thus absence of women ownership leads to lesser role of women in decision making.

In this regard, the multi-dimensional advantages related with women ownership of land are given hereunder: -

Considering the labour input of women in agricultural land and also at home, justice demands that she has ownership in the land owned by the family; Land ownership establishes one's rootedness and belongingness to the community; Land ownership elevates woman's status in the family; Land provides social security for women; Land is a fall back option in case of widowhood, desertion and divorce; Land

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enhances the probability of being well looked after in the old age; Land ownership enhances the probability of being treated with respect within the family; Propertied women have greater role in household decision making; Ownership of land decreases the chances of Domestic Violence; Ownership of land aids women in walking out of an abusive marriage; Land ownership increases the bargaining power of women within the family; Ownership of land gives financial security to women- land is the least liquid asset and hence will not be easily appropriated by others; Ensures livelihood if properly utilised; Land ownership provides economic security and reduces poverty; Women's land ownership enhances the welfare and well-being of the family and money earned by women result in more equitable intra household distribution of resources than money earned by men in the family, which is evident through the following: When women own agricultural land, health of daughters improve; When women own land , education of children improve.

Further, land is collateral for availing loans; Women's access to credit increases. This enables timely purchase of inputs and this in turn enhances production; Women negotiate better with suppliers of credit when they are the owners than when the owner is another family member;

On the positive note, the government on its part has recognized the problem and has been taking steps to increase women's ownership. The Hindu Succession Act, 1956 was a breakthrough in this regard. An amendment to this Act in 2005 took the progressive step of making daughters coparceners (a person who shares equally with others in the inheritance of an undivided estate or in the rights to it) at par with sons, such that they receive an equal birth right to a share in the natal family's ancestral property, i.e., parents' property.

But, there are many **hindrances** in its implementation. They are: Hindu social practice allows the parents to absolve themselves from honouring the daughter's inheritance right at par with their sons with the alibi of paying dowry at the time of the daughter's marriage. Dowry as a substitute of land and other properties in inheritance is one key way the patriarchal beliefs are deeply anchored in social practice, denying the women social and economic equality within the family. The practice of dowry is so entrenched that women themselves do not feel that it is their moral or legal right to claim inheritance rights in their parents' property.

Women's understandings of the current inheritance law and of the claim processes are clearly rudimentary and fragmented. Land has historically been a male domain and it continues to be so. Even when the women do receive land in inheritance, it is invariably much less than an equal share. Women are likely to get more land as widows than as daughters.

The people and institutions that are mandated to enforce the law are prisoners of the same practice.

Even when women do get land in their own names by inheritance, through dowry, or through purchase by their marital family in their name (this is often done to take advantage of reduced stamp duty on property purchased in a woman's name), the ownership by women is only notional. The women are seldom in possession of the land, title and the Record of Rights (ROR) that make it a secured tenure. The decision making power on use of the land remains firmly in the grip of men – father, brother, husband or father-in-law.

There is a lack of political will on the part of the State governments to implement the law. Additionally, there are informal barriers as well, in the form of social and cultural barriers. Women are generally forced to give up their share of their parents' property in favour of their brothers for various reasons, such as the fear of breaking familial bonds.

Several other legal reforms and positive steps have taken place since independence in India on equality of women when it comes to property yet equal status remains elusive. The theoretical reforms so far have not been adequate to give women right to property on the same footing and terms as to men. It varies with states, region and religion. Though law has given equal rights it's the practices, customs and norms that stand as an obstacle in giving due recognition to the women.

Given these strong social customs that prevent women from getting a share of their parents' land, robust support systems are needed to help women stand up for their rights and begin to claim the land that is rightfully theirs. The government of India has started this by establishing women's self-help groups (the Mahila Samakhya Program). These village-level groups support women dealing with a variety of challenges, including alcoholic husbands, domestic violence, unfair labour practices, and disrespected property rights. It is in everyone's interest that women be recognized as the farmers that they are. Their continued lack of assets contributes to not only their

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individual vulnerability, but also country's stubborn poverty.

To some extent, women themselves are responsible for their present condition. They relinquish their rights as daughters, wives, daughters-in-law, mothers or sisters. This further gets accentuated when they lose the security of the family, as single women, divorced or separated or widow. Social awareness of the rights under law, attitudes of the individual and determination to bring change can ensure social justice and equality in our society and can improve the status of the women.

Finally, to quote Justice Sujata V. Manohar of Supreme Court of India "It is not easy to eradicate deep seated cultural values or to alter traditions that perpetuate discrimination. It is fashionable to denigrate the role of law reform in bringing about social change. Obviously law, by itself, may not be enough. Law is only an instrument. It must be effectively used. And this effective use depends as much on a supportive judiciary as on the social will to change. An active social reform movement, if accompanied by legal reform, properly enforced, can transform society."

"Woman must not accept; she must challenge. She must not be awed by that which has been built up around her; she must reverence that woman in her which struggles for expression." — Margaret Sanger (an American activist, educator, writer, and nurse)

►RECOGNISING THE VALUE OF HOUSEWORK

#WOMEN EMPOWERMENT #SOCIAL JUSTICE

Women everywhere carry a disproportionately higher burden of unpaid work, namely, unpaid domestic services as well as unpaid care of children, the old and the disabled for their respective households. Though this work contributes to overall well-being at the household level and collectively at the national level, it is invisible in the national database and particularly in national policies.

This work is repetitive, boring and frequently drudgery — a 24-hour job without remuneration, promotions or retirement benefits. It restricts opportunities for women in the economy and in life. Women do this job not necessarily because they like it or are efficient in it, but because it is imposed on them by patriarchal norms, which are the roots of all pervasive gender inequalities. This unequal division of unpaid work between women and men is unfair and unjust and it deprives women of equal opportunities as men.

Origins of the demand

The demand for 'wages for housework' arose in the context of struggle and consciousness-raising associated with the Second Wave of the women's movement in North America and Europe. Alongside other demands for social and political equality, women's rights campaigners made visible and also politicised women's everyday experience of housework and child care in the 'private' realm of the household. In doing this, they challenged the assumption that a 'natural' affinity for housework was rooted in the essential nature of women who were performing a 'labour of love'. For leading women's rights activists of the 1960s and 1970s, it was important to bust the myth that women's work at home was a personal service with no links to capitalist production. In a concrete sense, this meant linking the exploitation of the worker in the factory to women's work at home.

Despite the links between the 'housewife' and the factory worker, the unwaged status of the former accounted for crucial differences between them. As feminist scholar and writer **Silvia Federici wrote (in 1975),** in "Wages against housework", it was possible for wage-earners to bargain around the terms of their paid work and the quantity of the wage. 'Housework, on the other hand, had come to define the very nature of a woman. This disallowed women from seeing it as 'real work' or as a social contract. And, therefore, the women who sought to negotiate housework with their partners were seen as 'nagging' and not as workers in struggle'. For the advocates of 'wages for housework', the wage that the state ought to pay women would make them autonomous of the men on whom they were dependent. More fundamentally, the very demand for a wage was a repudiation of housework as an expression of women's nature. It was a revolt against the assigned social role of women. Therein lay the radical nature of the demand for wages, not in the money itself.

For political parties to recognise this work is a positive development and the demand for wages for housewives has emerged from this concern. However, its implementation may create problems such as affordability of the government and calculation of the amounts. Women may not be eager to enter the labour market. More important, these wages may confirm unpaid work as women's work

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only, which would deny opportunities to women in the wider world. Payment of pension to old women (60+ years) may be a better idea to compensate them for their unpaid work.

What the government could do?

What governments could do is recognise this unpaid work in the national database by a sound time-use survey and use the data in national policies. Also, they could **relieve women's burden of unpaid work by improving technology** (e.g. better fuel for cooking), better infrastructure (e.g. water at the doorstep), shifting some unpaid work to the mainstream economy (e.g. childcare, care of the disabled, and care of the chronically sick), and by making basic services (e.g. health and transportation) accessible to women.

Also, they could redistribute the work between men and women by providing different incentives and disincentives to men (e.g. mandatory training of men in housework, childcare, etc.) and financial incentives for sharing housework. These measures will give free time to women and open up new opportunities to them.

Unpaid work and the economy

What is critical is to understand the linkages between unpaid work and the economy. The household produces goods and services for its members, and if GDP is a measure of the total production and consumption of the economy, it has to incorporate this work by accepting the household as a sector of the economy.

At the macro level, unpaid work subsidises the private sector by providing it a generation of workers (human capital) and takes care of wear and tear of labour who are family members. The private sector would have paid much higher wages and earned lower profits in the absence of unpaid work. Unpaid work also subsidises the government by taking care of the old, sick and the disabled. The state would have spent huge amounts in the absence of unpaid work. Unpaid work is a privately produced public good which is critical for the sustenance of the mainstream economy. This work, therefore, needs to be integrated with the mainstream economy and policies. It will be up to public policies then to improve the productivity of unpaid workers, reduce their burden, and tap their potential in development, as the household could also be an important economic sector.

By excluding this work from the economy, macroeconomics shows a clear male bias. It is not surprising that many economists call economics "a wrongly conceived discipline" that is narrow, partial and truncated. There is an urgent need to expand the purview of economics not only for gender justice but mainly for moving towards a realistic economics.

►FULFILMENT OF NEW WOMEN IS A MYTH

#WOMEN ISSUES

In seven decades of its independence and enactment of the constitution, India has made huge strides in the political, economic and socio-cultural spheres. From an underdeveloped country that couldn't even be self-sufficient in its food grain productions, we are today the fifth largest economy in the world. India today, looks at becoming a global leader.

Despite these advancements made by our country, we fare poor on the **Gender Gap Index published by World Economic Forum** (ranked 104/44 countries). According to World Bank estimates women legislators in the Parliament occupy only 12% of the seats in 2018. On the economic indicators and participation India is ranked below our poorer neighbours. According to a recent study by Indian Council of Research on International Economic Relations, although participation of women in higher education has improved, it has not translated into higher labour force participation of women. These issues prompt one to ask how much of our development and economic growth is engendered and inclusive of the women folk who constitute this country?

Notwithstanding all the efforts made by the government through acts, legislations and programs for women empowerment, women in our country face discrimination even before they are born and till their death. A girl child continues to be seen as a "burden" on the family that has to be done away given all the expenses on her education, marriage, dowry and the concern on her safety. The feudal society of our rural areas still denies property rights to women despite the Hindu Succession Act and other legislations Women in our country are denied the right to choose their life partners and every year so many of them become victims of "honour killings". Muslim women are still waging the battle to do away with the talaq-e-biddat that deprives them of their marital rights and the economic cover in just three words.

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Literacy among women is far below the national average and that of men at approximately 65%. This shows how many of our women are empowered enough to at least read and write and do basic numeracy. Economically, women are burdened with the care responsibilities and workplace responsibilities especially in rural India given the feminisation of poverty and agriculture. More than 50% of our women are anaemic and a significant portion of them under nourished due to gender disparity in access too food. Streets and public spaces continue to be unsafe for our women with our national capital being infamous for it.

Thus, discrimination against women continues in social, economic, political, cultural and legal spheres despite all the efforts made.

Historically, women have been given a subordinate position in our society with various socio-cultural practices being prevalent even today that affects the way we have raised our children without gender sensitisation and upholding the gender stereotypes.

Ranging from the most heinous practices such as sati to the supposedly mild ones such as purdah system or regulating what our women wear to putting the onus of family honour on a girl, our society has ensured to "keep women in their right place" by denying them the basic human rights.

Despite being granted the right to vote over seven decades ago, the representatives of women in our legislatures are few, if not absent to voice the concerns and aspirations of women in our law-making bodies. As a result, most of our policies continue to be gender insensitive.

E.g., It took us over 70 years to do away with Section 497 of IPC that criminalises adultery by looking at women as objects possessed by men.

Although workforce participation of women has improved, it continues to be low as well as insignificant in most formal employment to give economic freedom to women. Financial independence of women still is a dream and hence leads to many of the disadvantages women face. The feudal society still denies women property rights.

The socio-cultural practices that demean and discriminate women operate spatially and are more prevalent in North India than in Southern India. Tribal women enjoy greater freedom and autonomy compared to others.

A major reason for the discrimination against woman persisting in our society despite all our efforts lies in the mindset of our people who still believe in the gender stereotypes and look at women as burden. A huge part of the problem lies in the way we up bring our children at home and in schools, continuing the cycle of discrimination we were born into.

Since independence, and even before that we have made efforts for the empowerment of women: Starting with the Bhakti/Sufi Movements that accorded equal dignity to women and the socio-cultural reforms initiated by visionaries such as Raja Rammohan Roy, Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar, Savitribai Phule, Jyotiba Phule etc., our freedom movement also saw some meaningful work, from leaders such as Sarojini Naidu, Kasturba Gandhi, etc. who emphasised on women's education and participation in economic sphere. The colonial government's effort at legally banning Sati (1829), Child Marriage (1856), Promoting Education of Women (e.g., Hunter Commission) ameliorated women's position in society.

Post independent India made the greatest stride towards empowerment of women by enacting our Constitution that guaranteed equal rights to women in the legal, political, economic and cultural spheres, upholding the ideals of justice and equality, the Constitution made provisions for positive discrimination for women for their upliftment. Various measures were taken for the same in the political, economic and social spheres including but not limited to 33% reservation in local self-governments, maternity benefits for women at workplace, equal pay for equal work, Dowry Prohibition Act, preventing Sexual Harassment at workplace, Hindu Succession Act, 2005, criminalising talaq-e-biddat (through ordinance) etc. Efforts are being made for promoting education of women (Beti Bachao Beti Padhao), improving their literacy (Sakshar Bharat), providing them party in health outcomes (Janani Suraksha Yojana, National Nutrition Mission) etc. are being taken with a lifecycle approach.

Despite having so many schemes, the progress has been slow because of the old mindsets of people that have not changed. All efforts at policy and implementation are bound to fail until and unless efforts are made through various Information, Education and Communication methods to influence the psyche of people. There needs to be sustained, comprehensive and rational information flow to

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people so that they are forced to change their way of thinking and become gender sensitive.

The effort must start from our schools and colleges by bringing in gender sensitive curriculum, teaching our children to break the shackles of the gender stereotypes rather than uphold it. More co-educational institutions need to be promoted so that there is greater interaction between different sexes and greater respect and understanding cultivated. Sports is a great way to ensure that our girls become self-confident, self-reliant, strong, independent and are thus able to compete with men with confidence.

Rural India needs a major transformation in terms of crack down on the extra constitutional Khap panchayats that are often detrimental to women's rights. The Gram Sabha must be empowered to become the voice of the people especially women by ensuring their greater participation. These Gram Sabhas can be an effective tool of IEC to change societal mindsets. The panchayats and urban local bodies and the women representatives in them must be used efficiently to ensure grass root level implementation of all schemes and programs of government for women empowerment.

The Self-Help Groups Movement must be sufficiently encouraged as it can be an effective tool for economic empowerment of women. Additionally, they can be used as IEC tools for promoting social empowerment of women through information on healthy practices, by acting as means to improve literacy among women etc.

Cinema and social media play a very significant role in transforming societal mindsets. The Censor Board needs to play a proactive role in ensuring the kind of portrayal of women that is made through our movies. Objectification of women through numerous derogatory songs and dance needs to be explicitly banned while at the same time ensuring that women's issues are properly reflected in our movies.

Community radio run by women and focussing on women's issues is yet another tool of changing mindsets while at the same time informing women of their rights.

Women empowerment is a long and sustained process and does not stop with merely women entering the workplaces or political spheres. It has to go beyond that to ensure women enjoy autonomy, freedom and basic rights they are entitled to as human beings. The fulfilment of the 'new empowered women' will become successful only when we teach our children to break free from the shackles of gender stereotypes and discrimination and respect every human for their values, achievements and personality irrespective of gender. As remarked by Kofi Annan, former U N Secretary General, there is no tool for development more effective than the empowerment of women. Thus, the future of our country and society lies in ensuring that the idea of 'new empowered woman' becomes a reality in the social, cultural, political, economic and legal spheres.

►NEED FOR A RENEWED PUBLIC HEALTH CARE SYSTEM

#HEALTH

The current public health situation in India is a sad story of deprivation. Unless one is eye-washed by displays of hi-tech medical care and use of state-of-the-art medical technologies in five star deluxe facilities of a few select urban centres, the tale of utter helplessness and callous carelessness is so apparent that it is now frequently taken as a matter of course. The blatantly paradoxical spectacle of buying and selling of health improvements as a consumer goods by the well-off minority in the metros on the one hand and the denial of basic health facilities to the vast majority of the population along the length and breadth of the country on the other hardly evokes any comment.

On daily basis, bleak picture of health services emerge from different parts of the country. In this regard, let us understand the importance of healthy public health system.

Public Health is the science and art of promoting health, preventing disease, and prolonging life through the organized efforts of society (WHO). It is a social and political concept aimed at improving health, quality of life among whole population through health promotion, disease prevention and other forms of health interventions. Public Health approach is a holistic approach which encompasses all elements required for healthy living. It controls disease through health promotion, specific protection and by restoration and rehabilitation. In addition, disease surveillance which informs about ongoing as well as emerging public health issues is a core public health function. Other important functions are developing partnerships, formulation of regulations/laws, planning/policies and Human Resources Development.

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Directive Principles of State Policy considers that the State shall regard raising of the level of nutrition and standard of living of its people and improvement of public health as among its primary duties under **Article 47**. In addition, **Article 42,** the State shall make provisions for securing just and humane conditions of work and for maternity relief. The health system in India is expected to perform with objectives based on these principles and evolve its spirit and structure to achieve these objectives.

The most comprehensive health policy and plan document ever prepared in India was on the eve of Independence in 1946. This was the 'Health Survey and Development Committee Report' popularly referred to as the **'Bhore Committee'**. This Committee prepared a detailed plan of a National Health Service for the country, which would provide a universal coverage to the entire population free of charges through a comprehensive state run salaried health service. Later, many other committees reviewed the existing health infrastructure/situation in the country and made recommendations needed to prevent and control diseases including communicable, non-communicable and emerging diseases.

Later, the 'Expert Committee on Public Health system (1996)', the 'National Commission on Macroeconomics and Health (2005)', National Five Year Plans, 'National Health Policy (1983, 2002)', and many international initiatives such 'UN Millennium Development Goals (2000)', have also provided strong policy directives for the development of health care delivery system to control/prevent diseases.

Broadly, the healthcare services are divided under **State list and Concurrent list** in India. While some items such as public health and hospitals fall in the State list, others such as population control and family welfare, medical education, and quality control of drugs are included in the Concurrent list. The Union Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (UMHFW) is the central authority responsible for implementation of various programmes and schemes in areas of family welfare, prevention, and control of major diseases.

The public sector ownership is divided between central and state governments, and municipal and panchayat local governments. The facilities include hospitals, secondary level hospitals, first level referral hospitals (community health centres [CHCs] or rural hospitals), dispensaries, primary health centres (PHCs) and sub centres, and health posts.

The major weaknesses in the Public Health system in India have emanated from -Issues related to quality and functioning of Public Health Services. 'Quality of public health services' is defined by the extent of their **availability and coverage, economic affordability and social accessibility** to all sections of society, efficacy, safety and epidemiological rationale, and attitudes of the personnel. This, in turn, is dependent upon the 'culture of health services', which consists of the organizational principles, motivations of personnel at all levels and their interactions among themselves as well as with those to whom they provide services.

The factors that have contributed towards dilution in the quality and reach of Public Health Services are given hereunder:

Public health has effectively remained a **low priority** for the Indian state in terms of financing and political attention in successive five-year plans. The overall system of health planning and decision making remained highly centralized and top-down with minimal accountability, giving little scope for genuine community initiatives.

It may be noted that until 1983 India had no formal health policy. Although, significant expansion of healthcare infrastructure did take place after 'National Health Policy-1983' yet this remained grossly underutilized because of poor facilities and low attendance by medical staff, inadequate supplies, insufficient hours, lack of community involvement and lack of proper monitoring mechanisms. The Primary Healthcare Approach was never implemented in its full form, and selective vertical programmes were pushed as a substitute for comprehensive health system development.

This already unsatisfactory situation seriously worsened with the onset of liberalisation era from 1990s onwards. This phase has witnessed staggering health inequities, resurgence of communicable diseases and an even more unregulated drug industry with drug prices shooting up, adding up to the current crisis in public health. Along with the retreat from the goal of universal access, special health needs of women, children and other sections of society with special needs have become further sidelined or are inadequately addressed.

Closely related to this, and compounding this situation has been a **Techno-managerial model of healthcare** inspired by the West, with an inability to evolve effective indigenous models and appropriate

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technologies, or to effectively integrate modern and indigenous systems of medicine.

Consequently, emphasis is on more curative services and with inadequate lab capacity in the system and poor participation of private sector in public health activities. As per NFHS, the pattern of health care expenditure in India shows that more than 70% of expenditure is from out of pocket by households. Estimates suggests that in India the total health expenditure is around 6% of GDP, and is dominated by out of pocket spending i.e. around 5%. The government/public expenditure on health care is around 1.4% of GDP. Due to this low public expenditure the reach and quality of public health services are below the desired level.

By considering the above, rejuvenating the Public Health System in India should be provided utmost priority. Making **right to health care a fundamental right** is an important step to initiate changes in the public health delivery mechanism. The other major steps that may be taken for rejuvenation are:

First, a considerably strengthened, accountable and reoriented public health system needs to be nurtured. Such a rejuvenation of the public health system would require changes at levels of policy, structure, programmes, and processes. Such strengthening should ensure adequate infrastructure, human power, services and supplies at various levels, restoring the basic functionality of the system and rebuilding public confidence.

Second, the base of strengthened public health would need to be a framework of comprehensive Primary Health Care including Community health workers in every habitation; much more functional and accountable Primary health centres (PHCs) and First referral units (FRUs), combined with a range of appropriate preventive and promotive activities.

Third, to institutionalize accountability would require a legal and constitutional framework to assure health services as a Right. Once right to health care is considered, the task of the health movement would be to make sure the range of services is as comprehensive as possible, and to ensure that the services required by various marginalized sections and groups with special needs are definitely included.

Fourth, substantially raising public finances for the public health system, through general taxation along with various forms of special taxation and cesses for health security. Ending subsidization of the private medical sector and effectively taxing this sector, especially its upper end; a special health security cess on all financial transactions above a certain level; and preferential taxation of industries with negative health impacts are some other measures that may be considered.

Fifth, specific health care requirements of various groups with special needs – such as women, children, and elderly persons – would need to be met through sets of special measures, sensitively delivered by the general health system.

Sixth, specific major health problems, both communicable diseases such as TB and HIV-AIDS, and non-communicable health issues such as mental health would need to be addressed through programmes closely integrated with a robust comprehensive health system.

Seventh, progressively bringing the private medical sector under social regulation would be essential for realization of health rights in meaningful manner. A first step in this direction would consist of legally and organizationally ensuring that this sector meets minimum standards -follows standard treatment guidelines, and observes ceilings on prices of essential health services.

Eighth, much more effective public health support to indigenous healing systems is required, including active research on areas such as community based evaluation of indigenous healing methods and synergistic combination with modern medicine.

Ninth, ensuring access to essential drugs in rights based framework, both in form of ensuring availability of the range of essential drugs free of cost in public health facilities, and stringent price control.

Tenth, operationalising accountability and redressal mechanisms to ensure regular civil society monitoring and inputs at various levels.

Besides above, for realization of 'Public Health for All', in its fullest and most humane sense, coordination and synchronization with other conditions such as- comprehensive nutritional and food security (linked to livelihood security), universal access to safe drinking water and sanitation, provision of healthy housing and local environments, universal healthy working conditions and a safe general environment, access to health related education and information for all, and an equitable, gender-just social milieu, free from violence are required.

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►TRUE EDUCATION IS COMPLETE EVOLUTION OF AN INDIVIDUAL

#EDUCATION

"Education is the most powerful tool that can change the world." These are the wise words of great South African leader, Nelson Mandela. This quote provides a very holistic view point to education. However, unfortunately in the contemporary times, education is viewed from a very materialistic and narrow perspective. It is considered merely as a source to earn a livelihood. So, is it really just a source of livelihood?

Levels of Education

There are primarily three levels of education. The **first level** begins the moment a child is born and becomes a part of a family. Family and especially the mother are the first teachers of a child. A new born child is like a clay-round. The child will take shape as s/he is moulded. This is especially important for child to imbibe good morals and values. Unfortunately, for some children when this level is disturbed due to either negligence or the fact that the child may be coming from a battered household, it leads to many issues, juvenile delinquency being one of them.

The **second level** begins with formal education. This level imparts both materialistic as well as immaterialistic education. Materialistic education gained at schools and colleges is important for shaping the career and professional life of a student. Along with that the morals and values taught to the child at home during early years are strengthened and cemented by teachers at school. This is crucial for the student to evolve into a responsible citizen. But much of the knowledge gained at the second level is the critical and needs to be tested practically.

So, the **third level** involves the practical tests of life. The world itself is a huge university with all people being students here. When the knowledge gained at the first and second level is tested at the third level it validates the educational attainment of the student. After all, education is not just about a piece of paper declaring a person to be literate, it is about the complex tests of life which any truly educated person must clear.

So, these three levels are crucial for completing the process of educating a person. However, now a days education is treated just a mean to a certain end and not end in itself and this has given rise to many prevailing socio economic and environmental problems. E.g. A few years back Supreme Court gave out strict guidelines regarding burning of crackers on the occasion of Diwali in Delhi due to the deteriorating air quality of the capital. Still many 'educated people' flouted the rules blatantly disregarding the air quality of the city. So, here one must ask a very pertinent question. Is the process of education for such people complete yet?

Historically, since the Vedic times, education had a very wider connotation. For a child to complete the education process, apart from learning basic skills moral and value education was also essential. However, this system changed gradually and eventually with coming of the Industrial Revolution, education for the society ended up just a means to earn a livelihood.

Considering this situation, Gandhiji and his associates, in the Wardha Scheme propounded the concept of 'Nai Taleem' (New Learning). Gandhiji's Nai taleem was a holistic view towards education which focused on mind, body and soul of the student. In the Wardha scheme of education, focus was not only laid on formal education but also on other aspects for the holistic development of the child. Handicraft activities were also part of the curriculum for the development of creative facilities in the mind of the student. Along with this, moral education was also focused upon.

So, such a holistic view towards education is currently the need of the hour, in order to create a class of youth who will propel our country forward towards the path of prosperity.

What needs to be done?

Going forward, there is a need to overhaul the education system of the country to shift focus from a mere materialistic view towards a more holistic view. Moral and value based education should be part of the curriculum right from the primary level. Students should be evaluated not only through written tests but also through situational viva based examinations. This would go a long way in instilling good morals and values in children and will create a morally upright generation. This can act as a panacea to all social ills that are prevailing in our society at present.

Apart from this, moral and value based education should also be part of the curriculum of higher education. Students of higher educational institutes today are future of our country and these students will be holding many public offices in future. So, moral and value based education is extremely crucial to

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tackle contemporary challenges such as corruption which are playing the system of our country.

So, there is a need to consider the importance of education from a broader perspective in order to tackle the contemporary socio-economic and environmental challenges.

Renowned Buddhist Religious leader Dalai Lama has said in the context of education that "while educating the minds of the youth, we must not forget to educate the hearts as well."

So, to sum it up, it can be pointed out the education is not just about acquisition of necessary skills in order to earn a livelihood, but it is about the holistic development of a human being, so that the life of a person can be given a certain meaning.

►DEMOGRAPHIC DIVIDEND CAN BE REAPED THROUGH CONSTRUCTIVE COMPETITION

#DEMOGRAPHIC DIVIDEND

The inherent quality of nature is to maintain an equilibrium condition. Anything disrupting this would result into something unwanted. The same can be applied to competition. The purpose of competition is to bring out the best in an individual. The indispensable components of competition are stress, hard work and talent. Rising competition in the current scenario is a debatable topic. Increased stress, high level of unemployment and in some cases death, cannot be ignored. At the same time, excellence and success are a result of undaunted perseverance provided by the platform of competition. Competition can be classified in mainly two categories: Healthy competition, which has become a rare phenomenon, integrated with the values of sportsmanship, contributing to social, moral and self-development. On the contrary, there is unhealthy competition which focuses on materialistic gains that may even compromise with social and ethical values.

Competitive exams like JEE and PMT, produce the best engineers and doctors who may go ahead to achieve global recognition. India's move to achieve the status of a superpower is taking its toll on the youth. The expectations are too high with the least sophisticated support mechanisms. While affirmative action makes the competition stiffer for many; there remains a large number who study under street lights and in much more adverse conditions.

The basic theory of Economics which is the demand-supply mismatch tends to explain the rise in competition. Consider a rubber band being pulled at the extremities-one end by demand and the other by supply. As the tension increases, the band elongates to the point where its elasticity equals its resilience. The band snaps if the tension is increased further. The same applies to human beings. People undergo a lot of stress. Once snapped, they adopt to suicides or other unethical practices to get relief from the stress. This essay will describe the various effects of competition and how to mitigate its negatives.

The history of competition clearly depicts its importance. Competition is so ingrained in the living world. Starting from our birth, we compete with a million sperm cells to come to life, start walking, talking and reading in the blink of an eye. In the primordial period of human development, competition to gather food and hunt were the key to stay alive. Competition drives the society on the path of development. Sports competitions like wrestling, jousting as well as many Olympian Games were the main source of entertainment for the people.

India is a young country with an average age of 29. Being considered as a major upcoming nation, it is important for the country to guide the youth and assimilate it into the workforce. Though competitions pick the best, however, it discourages or rejects a large number of young determined people. Striking a balance to make the competition fair and providing opportunities can do well. The Government of India adopted "The Competition Act 2002" to bring out the best among different companies and preserve competitive attitude. The small enterprises were supported till they became self-sufficient. This is evident from the fact, how small scale industries are giving tough competition to foreign and domestic companies. Innovation and optimization are a result of strong and healthy competition.

The theory of Charles Darwin presents the same view. As man is a social animal, it tends to adhere to the needs of society. These needs though dynamic in nature remain overall static. For example, the need 20 years ago was to have a scooter, while currently the same is to have a four wheeler. Thus evolution along different epochs has modified such needs. 'Social Darwinism' refers to the survival of the fittest in a society which is fuelled by competition.

But it should be borne in mind that competition alone will not suffice the purpose. This is where ethics

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comes into play. Competition must not in any way compromise the universal ethical values of an individual. The amalgam of ethics and competition will turn the wheel of development and take humanity to the next level. What is ethics without competition? And what is competition without ethics? They are only self-satisfying ambitions catering to one's own interests. The world today is connected, thanks to globalization. We thank capitalism for bringing free market enterprises, giving rise to fair competition. Is it because of capitalism, where 10 percent of the global population controls 80 percent of the riches? While still many countries remain impoverished, people die of hunger regardless of the fact that we are in the 21st century.

It cannot be forgotten that competition brings a lot to the table. It forces the youth to work and train hard. This leads to excellence and recognition of world class talent. It makes them responsible and keeps them focused on their goal. Lionel Messi, currently the best soccer player said, "I start early, and I stay late, day after day after day, year after year. It took me 17 years and 114 days to become an overnight success." Life without competition will disable the thrills, ambitions and passion of individuals. It keeps them mentally and physically fit and vigilant. Competition makes them constructive. It is also responsible for the spread of education.

Competition moulds the youth into responsible citizens who have the capacity to take part in social change and improve the socio-economic condition. Satya Nadella- the current CEO of Microsoft, Sundar Pichai- current CEO of Alphabet and many such personalities are examples who made India proud. Outperforming every other candidate from different nations and achieving global recognition is the pioneer product of this growing competition. Theory of Darwinism suggests that competition will never end. It is a natural process which will drive the human race to different eras of evolution. If it wasn't for competition, ISRO would not have been able to accomplish its grand feat to Mars. Competition produced a wide variety of musicians ranging from Lata Mangeshkar to Yo Yo Honey Singh. At the same time, the ending of the hegemony of the Bretton Wood twins- The IMF and World Bank by establishing The BRICS Bank and Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank are the result of competition on global scale.

Although, there is a lot we receive from competition but its negative impacts cannot be sidelined. The problem with increasing competition is the lack of an adequate support system. For example, millions of children in the age 6-14 are out of school. Many work in unsafe or hazardous environment. The provision of urban amenities in rural areas (PURA) aims to provide latest infrastructure to rural parts of India. The absence of instant communication facilities like internet and telecommunications to keep up with high paced world keeps capable rural traders away from the share market. Share market businesses are completely dependent on telecommunication services which are still not an integral part of Rural India. With the growing competition, comes greater stress. The advancement of human race to the next level raised the aspirations and possibilities of the youth. One must notice with evolution, there came various types of health disorders. Prolonged mental pressure and stress leads to multiple psychological disorders. Anxiety, increased blood pressure and premature mortality are some examples. Recent studies reflect, increased pressure has detrimental effects on marriages and personal life.

The youth possess immense energy to achieve the impossible. Proper counselling from elders with strong emphasis on physical fitness and various stress relieving activities is the key to unlock the tremendous potential of the younger generation. Another such factor which causes the youth to take desperate measures is an unfriendly society. High amount of criticism is associated to people who try hard but fail to achieve success. This is a major factor for the unrequired mental pressure the youth accumulates. Although criticism is an integral part of this process but as long as it encourages people to perform better and not eliminate them from bonding socially. Competition is directly proportional to the number of candidates and indirectly to the number of vacancies for a particular job. Either way, competition skims the cream, leaving the huge lot of energetic, determined people behind and unemployed. They do not lack talent or labour. They lack opportunities. They are forced to settle for something meagre to make both ends meet. The stiff competition may lead to repeated failures, where the youth falls into the clutches of depression. Aggravated conditions may lead to identity crisis which can be fatal.

Creating more employment opportunities can go a great way in the development of a country. The youth are the most productive class of workers, hence must be preserved and guided. Modifying the education system to focus on practical learning rather than rote

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learning will develop a sense of perception and perspective among the young who wield the power of making a better tomorrow. Getting a score of 90 percent has lost its lustre. Why not 95? The one stereotypical statement which dreads the life of every 'Indian Youth', "Sharma jike bete se kuch seekho" meaning 'learn something from Mr. Sharma's son'. If we demand excellence, we should know that excellence is driven by passion and passion cannot be forced. It comes from within. Imagine if Sachin Tendulkar was forced to be a musician, Lionel Messi an engineer and Rahul Dravid a scientist. Wouldn't that be disastrous and complete waste of talent? The point is, people should be free to choose their career. Breaking the age old norms of being an engineer, doctor or a chartered accountant will not only diversify from the mainstream competition but also unfold many new talents to the world.

The major effect of growing competition with negligible opportunities is 'Hypocrisy'. It is quite ironical where I being an Engineer am preaching the exact opposite. Slowly and steadily hypocrisy firmly establishes itself in the society and drains it hollow like a weed. The pangs of unethical competition are biting us since childhood. It kills the honesty within us. Perhaps it is rightly said that honesty has too big a price to pay in this world. However, amongst these dark clouds of uncertainty, we do have a silver lining- The Youth. They are the catalyst for a social change. Achieving success with high level of moral development is the future we believe to see. This is indeed a colossal task but not impossible. The elders playing their roles as guardian angels with their blessings the youth will realize and redirect to the right path of development through constructive and healthy competition.

►CREATING A SAFE CHILDHOOD FOR OUR CHILDREN

#CHILD RIGHTS

Children are the supreme national assets of the nation and the future well-being of the nation itself depends upon how its children grow and develop. There are various rights guaranteed for the children at the national and international level but the reality that these all assurances intended to provide for their protection and safeguards are far from reality. It is well known fact to all that in this civilized society some children face hurdles and humiliation in the society as well as in their home.

Violence against children knows no boundaries. No country or region is immune. It occurs in homes, schools and streets, in places of work and entertainment, in care and detention centres. Perpetrators include parents, family members, teachers, caretakers, law enforcement authorities and other children itself. Some children are particularly vulnerable because of gender, race, ethnic origin, disability or social status. The consequences of violence can be devastating. Indeed, violence places at risk not on their health, but also to their ability to learn.

In every region, in contradiction to human rights obligations and children's developmental needs, violence against children is on the rise. Violence against children is multidimensional and calls for a multifaceted response. Protection of children from violence is a matter of urgency. Children have been suffering violence for centuries. Children must be provided with the effective prevention and protection to which they have right.

Violence against children is under-reported for various reasons. Very young children lack the capacity to report violence. Children often fear reprisals by perpetrators or interventions by authorities, both of which may worsen their overall situation. Sometimes Parents are perpetrators of violence against children, or parents may remain silent when violence is committed by other family members or by powerful members of the community or society. But it is the persistent social and legal acceptance of some forms of violence against children that too often leaves such violence unnoticed and unreported.

In many cases parents, who should protect their children, remain silent if the violence is perpetrated by a spouse or other family member, a more powerful member of Society such as an employer, a police officer, or a community leader.

Violence against children is never justifiable or acceptable. States are obligated to protect all children from all forms of violence. International human rights laws based on respect for every person's human dignity. Extreme forms of violence against children - including sexual exploitation and trafficking, genital mutilation/cutting the worst forms of child labour and the impact of armed conflict, child prostitution, child sex tourism, child pornography, incest, child marriages, infanticide etc. have provoked

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international outcry and achieved a consensus of condemnation, although there is still no rapid remedy.

Child sexual abuse has existed in all societies for centuries. The United Nation's has defined child sexual abuse as contacts or interactions between a child and an older or between child or adult when the child is being used as an object of gratification for the older child's or adult's sexual needs. These contacts or interactions are carried out against the child using force, trickery, bribes, threats or pressure.

The Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act, 2012 has been enacted to strengthen the legal provisions for the protection of children from sexual abuse and exploitation. For the first time, a special law has been passed to address the issue of sexual offences against children.

The Act defines a child as any person below the age of 18 years and provides protection to all children under the age of 18 years from the offences of sexual assault sexual harassment and pornography. This is the first time that an Act has listed aspects of touch as well as non-touch behaviour (e.g.: photographing a child in obscene manner) under the ambit of sexual offences.

The Act incorporates child friendly procedures for reporting, recording of evidence, investigation and trial of offences. The attempt to commit an offence under the Act has also been made liable for punishment for up to half the punishment prescribed for the commission of the offence. The Act also provides for punishment for abetment of the offence, which is the same as for the commission of the offence this would cover trafficking of children for sexual purposes.

Child pornography is the fastest growing crime against children. Child pornography refers to depicting sexually explicit activities involving a child. Children in contemporary world are growing up with an unprecedented exposure to sophisticated sexual and violent kinds of imagery. It has surpassed all generations in making available to the sexually explicit materials. They are exposed to every kind of harmful material through cable, magazines, phones, internet etc.

Indian Penal code provides for the sections 292, 293 and 294 which prohibits the sale distribution, publications, export, import etc. of obscene books etc. other materials and also provides for the punishments for that. It also prohibits the sale of obscene material to young persons. Section 294 also prohibits the obscene acts and songs to the annoyance of others or in the public place.

Child labour means that when work is done by children under the age of 18 years which is considered as danger to his physical and mental being. Poverty and lack of social security are the main causes of child labour. The increasing gap between the rich and the poor, privatization of basic services and the neo-liberal economic policies are causes major sections of the population out of employment and without basic needs.

Article 24 the constitution of India prohibits the employment or recruitment of children below 14 years in any factory or mine or heavy and harmful industries to the health and growth of children.

The Factories Act of 1948 prohibits the employment of children below the age of 14 years in any factory. The law also placed rules on whom, when and how long can pre-adults aged 15-18 years be employed in any factory.

The Mines Act of 1952 prohibits the employment of children below 18 years of age in a mine.

The Child Labour (Prohibition and Regulation) Act of 1986 prohibits the employment of children below the age of 14 years in hazardous occupations identified in a list by the law. The list was expanded in 2006, and again in 2008.

Further in July 2016, the Parliament passed the Child Labour (Prohibition and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2016. This act amends the Child Labour (Prohibition and Regulation) Act, 1986 by widening its scope against child labour and provides for stricter punishments for violations.

Child marriage in India has been practiced for centuries. The problem of child marriage in India remains rooted in a complex matrix of religious traditions, social practices, economic factors and deeply rooted prejudices. Regardless of its roots, child marriage constitutes a gross violation of human rights, leaving physical, psychological and emotional scars for life. Sexual activity starts soon after marriage, and pregnancy and childbirth at an early age can lead to maternal as well as infant mortality. Moreover, women who marry younger are more likely to experience domestic violence within the home.

Child marriage affects both boys and girls, but statistics show that girls are far more likely to be forced into a child marriage than boys; however, the

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percentage of girls forced into child marriage in India has declined in recent years. Child marriage tradition in India has social reasons too. Indians performed child marriages to get their girls protected against rapes and abductions by foreign rulers.

The Prohibition of Child Marriage Act, 2006, put into place to address and fix the shortcomings of the Child Marriage Restraint Act 1929. In the act of 2006, Boys and girls forced into child marriages as minors have the option of voiding their marriage up to two years after reaching adulthood, and in certain circumstances, marriages of minors can be null and void before they reach adulthood.

Prostitution of children or child prostitution is the commercial sexual exploitation of children in which a child performs the services of prostitution for financial benefit. The term normally refers to prostitution by a minor, or person under the legal age of maturity. A customer may negotiate an exchange directly with a prostituted child in order to receive sexual gratification, or through an intermediary who controls or oversees the child's activities for profit.

Immoral Traffic (prevention) Act 1987 has been passed in India to control the situation. Under the act detention of women for the purposes of prostitution is a punishable offence.

According to UNICEF, **child trafficking** is defined as "any person under 18 who is recruited, transported, transferred, harboured or received for the purpose of exploitation, either within or outside a country" There are many contributing factors to child trafficking, which include economic deprivation, conditions lack of employment opportunities, social status, and political uprisings. Many of the families in India are unable to afford the basic necessities of life, which forces the parents to sell their children off to gangs, and the gangs to exploit them.

The consequences of violence against children vary according to its nature and severity. But the short- and long-term repercussions of violence can be devastating. Exposure to violence in early childhood can affect the maturing brain. Prolonged exposure of children, whether as victims of or witnesses to violence, can disrupt nervous and immune systems and lead to social, emotional and cognitive impairments as well as behaviours that cause disease, injury and social problems. Violence can result in health-risk behaviours such as substance abuse and early sexual activity. Related mental health and social problems include anxiety and depressive disorders, impaired work performance, memory disturbances and aggressive behaviour. Early exposure to violence is associated with later lung, heart and liver disease, sexually transmitted diseases and foetal death during pregnancy, as well as later intimate partner violence and suicide attempts.

Children, who witness violence in their homes or community show excessive irritability, immature behaviour, sleep disturbances, emotional distress, fears of being alone, and regression in toileting and language. In extreme cases of exposure to chronic community violence, school-age children may also exhibit symptoms akin to post-traumatic stress disorder. Exposure to violence can have significant effects on children during their development.

Hence, the **Constitution of India** prohibits every kind of discrimination against individuals, including children. The major provisions of rights that are relating to the rights of children are:

Article 14 recognizes the equality before law and equal protection of laws for every individual which includes the children also. Article 15 (3) It empowers the State to make special provisions for the development of women and children. Article 21a provides for compulsory education to all children of age 6-14 years. Article 23 prohibits traffic human beings and abolishes bonded labour. Article 24 prohibits the employment or recruitment of children below 14 years in any factory or mine or heavy and harmful industries to the health and growth of children.

Articles 32 and 226 of the constitution it confers the remedial measures through judiciary for the violation of any of the rights conferred on its citizens through judicial intervention through.

Under the constitution of India, the State is to make necessary policy formulations and legal enactments, through the Directive Principles of State Policy. The relevant provisions of Directive Principles of State Policy, which deal with children, are: Article 39 clause (e) directs the state to evolve policy formulations not to abuse the tender age of children, and economic incapacity should not adversely result in their employment in any avocation, especially below the age of fourteen years in no circumstances.

Article 39 clause (f) imposes an obligation on the state to provide opportunities and facilities for children to

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develop in a healthy environment. It further directs the state that life, liberty, and childhood be protected from any kind of exploitation, which includes moral or material negligence.

Article 45 provides for care of early childhood, and compulsory education for all children until the child attains the age of six years.

Article 46 further directs the state to take special efforts to promote the rights and interests of children belonging to social, educationally backward classes. In no way their economic and social status, adversely affect their rights.

Article 47 imposes an obligation to raise the nutritional standards of living and provide easy public access to health facilities.

Article 51 (c) imposes a duty on the state to promote and respect international commitments and obligations. As signatory to number of conventions, covenants and other documents on international human rights law, it is the duty of the state to discharge its obligations in the promotion of children's rights through national legal framework.

According to Article 51 (A) (k) imposes the fundamental duty on the parents or wards to provide education to their children between the age group of six to fourteen years compulsorily.

All States should develop a multifaceted and systematic framework to respond to violence against children which is integrated into national planning processes. It is the duty of the States to prohibit all forms of violence against children, in all settings, including all corporal punishment, harmful traditional practices. Health, criminal justice and social service systems should be designed to meet the special needs of children. Governments at various levels should promote and support programmes and campaigns to educate the public and parents on child rights generally and in particular on maintaining positive, non-violent relationships with children in families. Here, the media can also play a key role.

For the growth of the society, the welfare of the children is very important. So it becomes essential that for the welfare and growth of a nation, the children are to be protected from all kinds of discrimination and violence and must be brought up in a secured atmosphere. It is important that society in a collective manner must take all the relevant steps to secure the rights of the children which will enable them to develop and progress in the society.

►ARE WE PAYING ENOUGH ATTENTION TO THE NEEDS OF THE EXPANDING ELEDERLY POPULATION?

#ELDERLY ISSUES

A large number of people enter 'old age' with little, or no, awareness of what this entails. While demographically, we acknowledge that a person is considered to be old when (s)he attains the age of 60 years, there is no such clear indicator available to the individual. For each person, there is a turning point after which (s)he feels physiologically or functionally 'old'. This event could take place at any age before or after the age of 60. Unfortunately, in India, there is almost no formal awareness program – even at higher level institutions or organizations – for people to prepare for old age. For the vast majority of people, old age sets in quietly, but suddenly, and few are prepared to deal with its issues. Most people living busy lives during the young and middle age periods may prefer to turn away from, and not consider, the possible realities of their own impending old age.

Thus, the majority of Indians are unaware of the problems, rights and entitlements of older persons. Let us analyse the common problems to get prepared in advance for 'old age'.

It has been said that **"we start dying the day we are born".** The aging process is synonymous with failing health. While death in young people in countries such as India is mainly due to infectious diseases, older people are mostly vulnerable to non-communicable diseases. Failing health due to advancing age is complicated by non-availability to good quality, age-sensitive, health care for a large proportion of older persons in the country. In addition, poor accessibility and reach, lack of information and knowledge and/or high costs of disease management make reasonable elder care beyond the reach of older persons, especially those who are poor and disadvantaged.

To address the issue of failing health, it is of prime importance that good quality health care be made available and accessible to the elderly in an age-sensitive manner. Health services should address preventive measures keeping in mind the diseases that affect – or are likely to affect – the communities

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in a particular geographical region. In addition, effective care and support is required for those elderly suffering from various diseases through primary, secondary and tertiary health care systems. The cost (to the affected elderly individual or family) of health has to be addressed so that no person is denied necessary health care for financial reasons. Rehabilitation, community or home based disability support and end-of-life care should also be provided where needed, in a holistic manner, to effectively address the issue to failing health among the elderly.

The problem of **economic insecurity** is faced by the elderly when they are unable to sustain themselves financially. Many older persons either lack the opportunity and/or the capacity to be as productive as they were. Increasing competition from younger people, individual, family and societal mind sets, chronic malnutrition and slowing physical and mental faculties, limited access to resources and lack of awareness of their rights and entitlements play significant roles in reducing the ability of the elderly to remain financially productive, and thereby, independent.

Economic security is as relevant for the elderly as it is for those of any other age group. Those who are unable to generate an adequate income should be facilitated to do so. As far as possible, elderly who are capable, should be encouraged, and if necessary, supported to be engaged in some economically productive manner. Others who are incapable of supporting themselves should be provided with partial or full social welfare grants that at least provide for their basic needs. Families and communities may be encouraged to support the elderly living with them through counseling and local self-governance.

Isolation, or a deep sense of loneliness, is a common complaint of many elderly is the feeling of being isolated. While there are a few who impose it on themselves, isolation is most often imposed purposefully or inadvertently by the families and/or communities where the elderly live. Isolation is a terrible feeling that, if not addressed, leads to tragic deterioration of the quality of life.

It is important that the elderly feel included in the goings-on around them, both in the family as well as in society. Those involved in elder care, especially NGOs in the field, can play a significant role in facilitating this through counseling of the individual, of families, sensitization of community leaders and group awareness or group counseling sessions. Activities centered on older persons that involve their time and skills help to inculcate a feeling of inclusion. Some of these could also be directly useful for the families and the communities.

The elderly, especially those who are weak and/or dependent, require physical, mental and emotional care and support. When this is not provided, they suffer from neglect, a problem that occurs when a person is left uncared for and that is often linked with isolation. Changing lifestyles and values, demanding jobs, distractions such as television, a shift to nuclear family structures and redefined priorities have led to increased neglect of the elderly by families and communities. This is worsened as the elderly are less likely to demand attention than those of other age groups.

The best way to address neglect of the elderly is to counsel families, sensitise community leaders and address the issue at all levels in different forums, including the print and audio-visual media. Schools and work places offer opportunities where younger generations can be addressed in groups. Government and non-government agencies need to take this issue up seriously at all these levels. In extreme situations, legal action and rehabilitation may be required to reduce or prevent the serious consequences of the problem.

The elderly are highly **vulnerable to abuse**, where a person is willfully or inadvertently harmed, usually by someone who is part of the family or otherwise close to the victim. It is very important that steps be taken, whenever and wherever possible, to protect people from abuse. Being relatively weak, elderly are vulnerable to physical abuse. Their resources, including finances ones are also often misused. In addition, the elderly may suffer from emotional and mental abuse for various reasons and in different ways.

The best form of protection from abuse is to prevent it. This should be carried out through awareness generation in families and in the communities. In most cases, abuse is carried out as a result of some frustration and the felt need to inflict pain and misery on others. It is also done to emphasize authority. Information and education of groups of people from younger generations is necessary to help prevent abuse. The elderly should also be made aware of their rights in this regard.

Where necessary, legal action needs be taken against those who willfully abuse elders, combined with counseling of such persons so as to rehabilitate them. Elderly who are abused also require to be counseled,

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and if necessary rehabilitated to ensure that they are able to recover with minimum negative impact.

Many older persons live in fear. Whether rational or irrational, this is a relevant problem face by the elderly that needs to be carefully and effectively addressed.

Elderly who suffer from fear need to be reassured. Those for whom the fear is considered to be irrational need to be counseled and, if necessary, may be treated as per their needs. In the case of those with real or rational fear, the cause and its preventive measures needs to be identified followed by appropriate action where and when possible.

Boredom is a result of being poorly motivated to be useful or productive and occurs when a person is unwilling or unable to do something meaningful with his/her time. The problem occurs due to forced inactivity, withdrawal from responsibilities and lack of personal goals. A person who is not usefully occupied tends to physically and mentally decline and this in turn has a negative emotional impact. Most people who have reached the age of 60 years or more have previously led productive lives and would have gained several skills during their life-time. Identifying these skills would be a relatively easy task. Motivating them and enabling them to use these skills is a far more challenging process that requires determination and consistent effort by dedicated people working in the same environment as the affected elders.

Many elderly can be trained to carry out **productive activities** that would be useful to them or benefit their families, communities or environment; activities that others would often be unable or unwilling to do. Being meaningfully occupied, many of the elderly can be taught to keep boredom away. For others, recreational activities can be devised and encouraged at little or no additional cost.

Lowered self-esteem among older persons has a complex etiology that includes isolation, neglect, reduced responsibilities and decrease in value or worth by one-self, family and/or the society.

To **restore self-confidence**, one needs to identify and address the cause and remove it. While isolation and neglect have been discussed above, self-worth and value can be improved by encouraging the elderly to take part in family and community activities, learning to use their skills, developing new ones or otherwise keeping themselves productively occupied. In serious situations, individuals – and their families – may require counseling and/or treatment.

This problem of older persons has many facets. While self-realization and the reality of the situation is acceptable to some, there are others for whom life becomes insecure when they begin to lose control of their resources – physical strength, body systems, finances (income), social or designated status and decision making powers.

Early intervention, through education and awareness generation, is needed to prevent a negative feeling to inevitable loss of control. It is also important for society – and individuals – to learn to respect people for what they are instead of who they are and how much they are worth. When the feeling is severe, individuals and their families may be counseled to deal with this. Improving the health of the elderly through various levels of health care can also help to improve control. Finally, motivating the elderly to use their skills and training them to be productive will help gain respect and appreciation.

The problem of not being prepared for old age can only be prevented. Awareness generation through the work place is a good beginning with HR departments taking an active role in preparing employees to face retirement and facing old age issues. For the majority who have unregulated occupations and for those who are self-employed, including farmers, awareness can be generated through the media and also through government offices and by NGOs in the field. Older people who have faced and addressed these issues can be 'recruited' to address groups at various forums to help people prepare for, or cope with, old age

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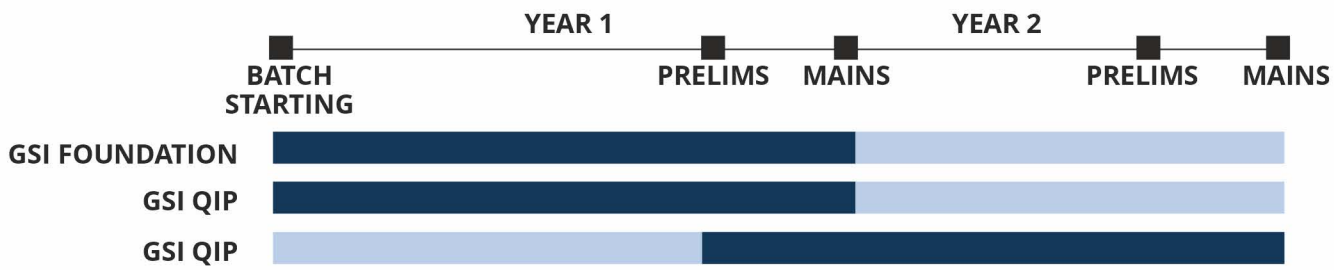
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